

SPHS 101

**POSTGRADUATE COURSE
M.A - HISTORICAL STUDIES**

FIRST YEAR

FIRST SEMESTER

PAPER - I

**CULTURAL HERITAGE OF INDIA
(EXCLUDING TAMIL NADU)**



**INSTITUTE OF DISTANCE EDUCATION
UNIVERSITY OF MADRAS**

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With best wishes from mind and heart,

DIRECTOR

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M.A - DEGREE COURSE
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FIRST SEMESTER
Paper - I
CULTURAL HERITAGE OF INDIA
(EXCLUDING TAMIL NADU)
SYLLABUS

UNIT I

Ancient Indian Culture – Harappan Civilization – Social and Cultural life of Early Vedic Age and Later Vedic Age.

UNIT II

Religious Ferment in the 6th Century B.C. – Jainism and Buddhism – Age of Mauryas – Social and Cultural Development – The Cultural Achievements of the Kushanas – Cultural Florescence of the Gupta Age.

UNIT III

Socio-Cultural life during the Delhi Sultanate period – Art and Architecture of Delhi Sultanate – Socio-Cultural life during the Mughal Rule – Art and Architecture of the Mughals – The rise and growth of Islamic Culture and its impact on Hindu Culture.

UNIT IV

The 19th Century Renaissance: Hindu and Muslim Reform Movements – The British Rule: Missionary Activities – Spread of Christianity – Impact of Christianity on the Society.

UNIT V

Western Education and its Impact on Indian Society – Development of Art and Architecture: Indo-Saracenic Style – Language and Literature – Fine Arts – Music and Dance.

Books for Reference:

1. Luniya. B.N – Evolution of Indian Culture
2. Rawlinson. H.G. – A Short Cultural History
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4. Gokhale. G – Ancient India – History and Culture
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8. Panikker. K.M. – A Survey of Indian History
9. Srinivasachari. C.S. – Social and Religious movements in India
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11. Tripathi. R.S. – History of Ancient India
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M.A - DEGREE COURSE

FIRST YEAR -

FIRST SEMESTER

Paper - I

**CULTURAL HERITAGE OF INDIA
(EXCLUDING TAMIL NADU)**

SCHEME OF LESSONS

Sl.No.	Title	Page
1.	Ancient Indian Culture – Unity in Diversity	001
2.	Harappan Civilization	012
3.	Social and Cultural Life of Early Vedic and Later Vedic Period	032
4.	Social and Cultural Life of Later Vedic Period	065
5.	Evolution of Social and Cultural Institutions Rise of Jainism and Buddhism	079
6.	Age of Mauryas - Social and Cultural Development	094
7.	The Cultural Achievements of the Kushans	122
8.	Cultural Florescence of The Gupta Age	140
9.	Socio - Cultural Life During Sultanate Period	165
10.	Art and Architecure Under Delhi Sultanate	184
11.	Socio - Cultural Life During Mughal Rule	193
12.	Art and Architecture Under The Mughals	216
13.	Indian Society In Transition – The 19 th Century Rennaissance Hindu and Muslim Reform Movements	245
14.	The British Rule: Missionary Activities Spread of Christianity Impact of Christianity on the Society	260
15.	Western Education and its Impact on Indian Society	274
16.	Development of Art, Architecture, Music and Dance	297

LESSON - 1

ANCIENT INDIAN CULTURE – UNITY IN DIVERSITY

Learning Objectives

After learning this Unit, you will be able to

- Appreciate the culture of India
- Understand the distinct and unique features of ancient Indian culture
- Comprehend the unity and diversity of India's culture
- Realize the splendour and grandeur of Ancient Indian culture and civilization, and the extent of the civilization
- Grasp the Intellectual growth of Vedic period

Structure

1.1 Introduction

1.2. Multiculturalism in India – Unity in Diversity

1.2.1. Geographical Unity

1.2.2. Political Unity

1.2.3. Religious Unity

1.2.4. Cultural Unity

1.2.5. Racial Unity

1.2.6. Unity of Language

1.2.7. Social Unity

1.2.8. Philosophical Unity

1.2.9. Promoters of this Unity

1.3. Answers to Check your Progress

1.1 Introduction

In the previous classes you have learnt the outlines of ancient Indian culture and civilization. This Unit will give you a vivid picture of distinct and unique culture of India, grandeur of protohistoric civilization and the supreme Vedic age. The culture of India is dynamic and is spanning back to the beginning of human civilization. Indian culture refers collectively to the thousands of diverse, distinct and unique cultures of all religions and communities present in India. India's languages, religions, dance, music, architecture, food, and customs differs from place to place within the country, often labelled as a unification of several cultures, spans across the Indian subcontinent and has been influenced by a history that is several millennia old. Many elements of India's diverse cultures, such as Indian religions, philosophy, cuisine, languages, martial arts, dance, and music have a profound impact across the world.

1.2. Multiculturalism in India – Unity in Diversity

India is a plural society. It is repository of multiplicity of cultures. Indian civilization, stretching over five thousand years, provides the most distinctive feature in the coexistence of unity in diversity. The idea of unity of India is inherent in all its historical and socio-cultural facts as well as in its cultural heritage. India has one Constitution providing guarantees for people belonging to diverse religious, cultures and languages. It covers people belonging to all socio-economic strata. Besides twenty two constitutionally recognized languages, there are several hundred dialects. There is diversity not only in regard to racial compositions, religious and linguistic distinctions but also in patterns of living, life styles, occupational pursuits, inheritance and succession of law and practices and rites related to birth, marriage, death etc. National unity and integrity have been maintained even though sharp economic and social inequalities have obstructed the emergence of equalitarian social relations. It is this synthesis which has made India a unique mosaic of cultures. India is, in fact, a panorama of its own types without a parallel in other continents. Foreign invasions, immigration from other parts of the world and the existence of diverse languages, cultures and religions have made India's culture tolerant, on the one hand, and a unique continuing and living culture with its specificity and historicity on the other. India possesses varieties of social, economic, geographical conditions. In India there is unity in apparent diversities of race, religion, language, custom etc. The distinctive feature of India in its unity and diversity is also reflected in the social ethos.

Meaning of “Unity in Diversity”

The term “**Unity in diversity**” refers to the state of togetherness or oneness in spite of presence of immense diversity. Unity in diversity means that we can live in communal harmony whilst also embracing each others’ differences. According to this principle, diverse cultures and diverse races can live together in total peace and happiness. We all have diverse origins, but no matter how diverse your background is from someone else’s you can live in harmony with them, united by a single thread of unity. It refers to the spirit of singleness or the feeling to totality when diverse sets of people, organisations or states are unified together.

“Unity in diversity” is a concept where diverse groups of people co-operating and working together as a single force, different areas or states being united as a single country, different people set aside their differences and look forward towards a common goal. It is a concept where the individual or social differences in physical attributes, skin colour, castes, creed, cultural and religious practices, etc. are not looked upon as a conflict. Rather, these differences are looked upon as varieties that enrich the society and the nation as a whole. Unity in diversity is a very important principle because we all live in a diverse world and it is crucial to respect each other and to support each other no matter what our culture, background, gender, orientation or other differences may be.

What does Unity in Diversity Teach Us?

Unity in Diversity teaches us that our differences do not need to keep us apart. We can be different to each other whilst still being firm friends with each other, supporting each other and working together for common goals.

Unity in diversity is a lesson that everyone should learn from their earliest years because it helps us to live together in a kinder and more loving way. This simple saying teaches us not to divide ourselves against each other into different camps, because this is where real conflicts can begin. Rather, the principle of unity in diversity teaches us that, fundamentally, we are all equal to each other and we all have equal rights.

What is the importance of this phrase?

1. **Peacemaking.** The idea that we are united, and that we should celebrate our differences rather than making them a cause for conflict is the cornerstone of peace.

2. **Social progress.** When we live together in harmony, we can learn from each other's diverse experiences and our societies will progress much better.
3. **Economic prosperity.** Economic prosperity thrives in an atmosphere of communal harmony.
4. **Law and order.** It is easier for us to all live together in a way that respects the law – and for the law to respect us too – if we all embrace the principle of 'unity in diversity', lawmakers included!
5. **Happiness.** Nothing makes us happier than an atmosphere of love, and sisterhood and brotherhood.

India being the largest democracy in the world with a civilization more than five thousand years old boasts of multiple cultural origins. The cultural origins of the Indian subcontinent can be traced back to the Indus Valley Civilizations, the remains of which are cherished even today. Since the late 16th century India was under the influence of the British Empire until 15th August 1947 the day when India gained independence. India is a land of diverse cultures, religions and communities. There is great diversity in our traditions, manners, habits, tastes and customs. Each and every region of the country portrays different customs and traditions. But though we speak different languages yet we are all Indians. 'Unity in Diversity' has been the distinctive feature of our culture. To live peacefully has been our motto and this motto has helped us to achieve independence. As history tells us that there has been active participation from people of different caste and religion. In our struggle for freedom people from different communities participated keeping one thing in mind that they all are Indians first. People from different background and culture participated in India's struggle for freedom. The national leaders, particularly Mahatma Gandhi, Nehru, Azad and Bose had coined the slogan unity in diversity. There are numerous others who were also involved. Be it Hindu, Muslim, Buddhist, Jain and Sikhs everybody had a single identity of being an Indian. It should be understood that all of us have multiple identities religious, linguistic, cultural, regional and caste identities. No one can claim single identity. One who demands single identity i.e. national identity does not recognize the reality but during India's struggle for freedom no one thought in that manner they just thought of India's independence. India remains one of the most ethnically diverse countries in the

world. Modern India presents a picture of unity in diversity where people of different faiths and beliefs live together in peace and harmony.

1.2.1. Geographical Unity:

Undoubtedly, down through the ages India has maintained geographical unity. Even, the seers of the past had visualized it. The geographical location of Bharatavarsha had been described in the Vishnu Purana.

“Uttaramyatsamudrasya
HimadreshchaivaDakshinam
Varsham tad Bharatamnoma
Bharati Yatra Santatih”

It means- “The country that lies to the north of the ocean and to the south of the snowy mountains is called Bharata where dwell the descendants of Bharat.” The kings of ancient India like Chandragupta Mourya, Asoka, Pushyamitra Sunga, Kanishka, Chandragupta II Vikramaditya, Harsavardhan and others considered India as one geographical unit. In the medieval period Akbar, Shahjahan and others considered this land as a single entity and ruled over it. The British authorities also did the same thing.

After independence, India maintained and still maintains that uninterrupted geographical entity. Thus goes the popular saying – ‘from Kashmir to Kanyakumari India is one’. The concept of ‘Bharatmata’ our national song ‘VandeMataram’ and national anthem ‘Jana-gana-mana’ clearly project India as one geographical unit. The poets, philosophers, prophets, reformers had conceived this geographical unit of this land and today the Indians are preserving that ideal with all its sanctity.

1.2.2. Political Unity:

Concept of Indivisible India

Since the ancient times, the powerful kings were inspired with the ideal of one, indivisible India. This prompted them to make conquests of lands stretching from the Himalayas to the seas. Chandragupta Maurya had tried to build one nation in Ancient time. Ancient India was known as ‘Bharatvarsha’.

Article 1 of the Indian constitution speaks, “India that is Bharat shall be a union of states”. This political unity is not recent. It had its origin in the long past. For the first time India was united under one umbrella by the redoubtable leadership of Chandragupta Maurya. Right from him, the concept of ‘Rajachkravartin’ or the Paramount Sovereign’ began to evolve and Asoka, Samudragupta, Chandragupta II Vikramaditya, Harsavardhan, RajarajaChola, Akbar, and many others maintained it.

Even after the British conquest of India, this political unity was maintained like today with uniform pattern of law, penal code, administrative works etc. everywhere inside the country. The concepts of ‘Dandasamata’ (uniformity of penalcode) and ‘vyavaharaSamata’ (uniformity in judicial procedure) invoked by Asoka became the ideal for all the rulers of India. No Mughal rule, British rule or the present democratic set up of India could escape it.

Even in modern times, we all celebrate our National festivals, viz. Independence Day, Republic Day and Gandhi Jayanti, etc. with a sense of unity. These festivals are widely celebrated at schools, colleges, universities, offices, societies across all the states of India. Every Indian watches the Flag Hoisting ceremony at Red Fort and listens to the speech of the Prime Minister. In every state, similar event takes place in which the Chief Minister of the state addresses to the audience through a speech. The unity or oneness that we display during these National festivals displays the indivisible character of India. India is said to be a synthesis of diverse social and cultural elements. A grand synthesis of cultures, religions and language of the people belonging to different castes and communities has upheld its unity and cohesiveness despite foreign invasions, and the Mughal and British rule. Thus, politically India remained one, remains one and will remain one in future.

1.2.3. Religious Unity:

In respect of religion in India, there is no end of its range. Hinduism, Jainism, Buddhism, Islam, Sikhism and Christianity are the major religions. Diverse religions found their ways in the Indian subcontinent. India is the place of reunion of many religions and languages of the world. People from around the world with different cultures are found living in a peaceful manner. Here, the Hindus, the Muslims, the Sikh, the Christians, the Jews, the Buddhists, the Jains and the Parsees (Parsi community) live abreast of each other. They all celebrate religious festivals

with great enthusiasm. Besides this, the aborigines living in the jungles or in the hill areas have various ancient religious customs which they carefully observe. Again, in different regions and among different races, social customs and usages assume different shape and character. Spiritualism became the most essential part in one's life. Many sects and creeds began to rise in this soil and gained momentum. Besides, the concept of moksha, nirvana, atma, paramatma etc. are well known by the people of different sects in India. Thus, an underlying unity amidst religious diversity exists in India. For this religious unity, India is famous in the world.

1.2.4. Cultural Unity:

There is a Sense of Unity among diverse Cultures and Society in India. Cultural unity amidst various diversities is found in India. In spite of differences in language, religion, dress and manners, Indian culture is homogeneous. In ancient time, the rock-cut architecture of the Mauryan period found its expression throughout India. The Gandhara School of art and Mathura School of art also flourished in this land. The Indo-Islamic art and architecture were alike in the nook and corner of India.

Several inscriptions found from different parts of the country bore uniformity in many respects though the events and narratives were different. Similarly, many festivals like Holi, Diwali, Dashahara, Rakshabandhan, Eid, Soharat, Christmas, Good Friday are observed throughout the country with their colourful lustre.

Further, the Kumbhmela at Allahabad, Hardwar and Ujjain are attended by people from different parts of the country. Similarly, many rites like birth-rite, funeral-rite etc. are observed throughout the country. The caste system, family sanctity, modes of offerings, several social ceremonies are celebrated almost in a similar manner in different parts of the country. Thus, the cultural unity in India amidst several diversities is a unique phenomenon.

The social customs and traditions which the Indians observe irrespective of caste, race and creed in all parts of the country contain within them a sense of Unity. It has kept alive a message of Unity in Diversity in India.

Following the different tradition and culture which diverse societies in India have developed, there lies a sense of unity which keeps the people of India bonded together. This fundamental unity can be observed among all the Indian tribes and races.

1.2.5. Racial Unity:

Various races have dwelt in India down through the ages. By circumstance, some Indian Hindus were converted to Islam and Christianity. However, they preserve the Indian identity. The Greeks, Sakas, Kushanas, Mongols, Turks and Mughals who came to India were absorbed in the Hindu way of life. With the gradual march of time they were termed as Hindustani irrespective of the state they belong to.

This identity as an Indian effaces all the racial discrimination. All the Indians belonging to any race feel pride in the name of India, their mother country. That is why Indian army accepts Indians without any inhibition of their caste or race. The racial difference is not at all found inside our country.

Diverse Races enriched the Indian Ethnicity and Culture. In India, there are a large number of ancient cultures prevailing or still practicing today. Though there are several numbers of diverse cultures in India, still it has unity in diversity.

The modern Indian civilization has been nourished and developed by multiracial contributions. From times immemorial, diverse races migrated into India by via land and sea routes and get themselves settled here. In course of time they are absolutely absorbed in India's social life.

The ancient ethno-linguistic groups, such as, the Aryans, the Austrics, the Negritos the Dravidians, the Alpines and the Mongoloids, had combined to constitute the modern Indian race.

In the historical period, diverse branches of the aforementioned unique ethnic groups – the Persians, the Pallavas, the Kushanas, the Greeks, the Sakas, the Huns, the Portuguese, the Arabs, the Turks, the English and the European races came to India, and enriched Indian ethnicity and culture by their contribution to the same.

1.2.6. Unity of Language:

Amidst diversity in language, unity is also maintained in the same sphere. During Asoka's period Prakrit became the vehicle of spreading the message of moral-ethical codes of conduct. Prof H.C. Raychaudhuri writes –

“Prakrit was the one single language sufficient to bring the message of a royal missionary to the doors of his humblest subject throughout this vast kingdom.”

With the advancement of time, Sanskrit took the place of Prakrit. During medieval period several languages including Tamil, Telugu, Kannada, Malayalam, Hindi, Bengali, Marathi, Gujarati, Oriya, and Urdu emerged as great languages to bring coherence among all other languages which do not have script.

However, English and regional languages are used for carrying on the official correspondence. Thus, diversity in language mingles bringing linguistic unity.

The Indian people composed of several racial elements have a range of languages among them. Official accounts confirm that more than two hundred languages are present in this country. Each region has its own language. The local people speak in their own language.

In North India, most people speak in Hindi language. While in South India, the languages for communication are the Dravidian languages such as Tamil, Malayalam, Telugu, Kannada, etc. Further, in West Bengal, there is prominence of Bengali language. The people of Odisha mainly speak in Oriya language. Besides, Hindi, Bengali, Urdu, Dravidian languages and other regional languages, many tribal groups have their own language. In modern times, English language has played an important role in unifying the people of the country. English is one of the most popular inter-languages among educated class.

In different regions, people use diverse languages, but Sanskrit is widely acknowledged and honoured as the language of spiritual scriptures and literature. It was through Sanskrit that the learned community of many of the provinces exchanged their ideas and thoughts. Different languages that are currently used in different provinces owe their origin to Sanskrit.

In spite of the fact that there are numerous languages among various races, there is a sense of national unity and oneness among all the Indians. It is this spirit of patriotism that binds us together as one nation.

1.2.7. Social Unity:

It is a well known fact that Indian society is diversified. In dress, food-habit and customs, the northern Indians are quite different from the southern Indian people. However, there are

certain common factors that guide all the societies of India. Treatment of guests, offering alms to beggars, to help others at the times of need, to show mercy to the poor, destitute and needy etc. are certain common practices found in every Indian society. The magnanimity of Indian society is well recognized by all the people of the world. For this greatness, the Indian society has received commendation from the tourists who came to visit India from abroad.

1.2.8. Philosophical Unity:

India is the birth place of many philosophical systems of the world. The Vedic philosophy, the philosophy of the Sankhyas, Yogas, Advaita Vedantins, Buddhists, Jainas, Saivas, Shaktas etc. vary in many respects from each other. Buddha, Mahavir, Sankaracharya, Ballavachaiya, Nimbarka, Kabir, Nanak, Sri Chaitanya, Nizamuddin Auliya, Eknath, Tukaram and many other saints preached their philosophy. Monotheism and polytheism have been preached in this subcontinent. However, the ultimate aim of every philosophy is to lead a life full of bliss and happiness, the concept of Nirvana, Moksha, Mukti etc. or the life in this world and the other are certain other aspects of each philosophical system. This unity in Indian philosophical system has allured the attention of the people of the world at large.

1.2.9. Promoters of this Unity:

There are several agencies which have promoted the unity amidst diversity. The sages, saints, reformers and pilgrims who have visited throughout India sing the glory of several places like Kurukshetra, Allahabad, Hardwar, Rishikesh, Dwaraka, Mathura, Kanchipuram so on and so forth. Their description makes Indians feel that they belong to a glorious land, their motherland, India.

In the past the conquerors like Chandragupta Maurya, Asoka, Chandragupta II and Akbar wanted the unity of this land which inspired the leaders of the past and inspires the present leaders too to maintain the unity and integrity of our country.

Among other factors, uniform administration, language and religion, modern means of transport and communication, common history and nationalism and the present democratic set up act as agencies for maintaining this fundamental unity of India amidst various diversities.

Unity in diversity is the basic postulate of Indian culture. It is a wonder that in spite of several diversities Indian culture preserves unity. That is quite unique and unparalleled in the chequered annals of history. That is why, perhaps Sir Herbert Hope Risley (British ethnographer, colonial administrator, and a member of the Indian Civil Service who conducted extensive studies on the tribes and castes in India) had rightly pointed out—

“Beneath the many-fold diversity of physical and social type, language, custom and religion which strikes the observer in India, there can still be discerned a certain underlying uniformity of life from the Himalayas to Cape Comorin.”

Conclusion

The geography of the various regions has influenced the ways of life of the people living in them. The economy, habitat, and settlements, dress patterns, food habits, and language of each region are, to an extent, affected by the ecology of the area. Constant arrivals of people from other areas added further to the diversity in terms of race, language, religion, and material culture. Thus, various factors have contributed to the cultural diversity of India and to its rich cultural heritage. India is a large country. Different regions observe variations in climate. The spoken language of one state is quite different from that of another. They wear different types of garments. They celebrate different festivals and perform varied religious rites. People belonging to diverse cultures belong to different religious faiths. In spite of these diversities, Indians feel a sense of unity and oneness among them. Thus, we conclude that India is a land of Unity in Diversity.

Check Your Progress -1

1. What is the meaning of unity in diversity?
2. Give an account of different aspects of Unity in Diversity.

1.3. Answers to Check your Progress -1

2. See Section 1.2.
3. See Sections 1.2.1. –1.2.9.

LESSON - 2

HARAPPAN CIVILIZATION

Learning Objectives

After learning this lesson you will be able to

- Learn about the discovery of a great civilization which is variously called as Indus Valley Civilization or Harappan Civilization or Harappan Culture
- Know about the name, extent, date, chronology and the important sites of the civilization
- Understand the social, economic and religious aspects, its arts, crafts and the town planning
- Appreciate the magnificence of this civilization

Structure

2.1. Introduction

2.2. Prelude

2.2.1. Discovery and Archaeological Excavations

2.2.2. Name of the Civilization

2.2.3. Extent

2.2.4. Date

2.3 Findings

2.3.1. Great Bath

2.3.2. Granaries

2.3.3. Town Planning

2.3.4. The Drainage System

2.3.5. The Assembly Hall

2.3.6. Seals

2.4 Religion

2.4.1. Worship of Cult Objects and Nature Worship**2.4.2. Faith in Magic, Charms and Sacrifices****2.4.3. Belief in Life after Death****2.5 ART****2.5.1. Sculpture in Stone****2.5.2. Sculpture in Metal – Dancing Girl****2.5.3. Sculpture in Terracotta****2.5.4. Pottery and Painting****2.6 Economic Activity****2.6.1. Agriculture****2.6.2. Domestication of Animals****2.6.3. Crafts****2.6.4. Trade****2.7 Social Life****2.7.1. Food****2.7.2. Dress****2.7.3. Ornaments****2.7.4. Cosmetics****2.7.5. Furniture and Utensils****2.7.6. Conveyance****2.7.7. Amusements and Recreation****2.8 Script****2.9 End of Civilization****2.10 Answers to Check your Progress****2.1 Introduction**

One of the earliest urban civilizations in the world was the Indus Valley Civilization. This civilization is also known as the Harappan Culture or Harappan Civilization. The end of the

Neolithic Period saw the use of metals of which copper was the first and a culture based on the use of stone and copper arrived. Such a culture is called Chalcolithic which means the stone-copper phase. The date of Chalcolithic Age is roughly between 3000 B.C. – 1500 B.C. The new technology of smelting metal ore and crafting metal artefacts is an important development in human civilization. But the use of stone tools was not given up. Some of the microlithic tools continued to be essential items. People began to travel for a long distance to obtain metal ores which led to a network of Chalcolithic cultures. The Chalcolithic cultures were found in many parts of India. Generally, Chalcolithic cultures had grown in river valleys. Harappan or Indus Valley Civilization belongs to this period. Gold was probably one of the earliest discoveries, but it served as a material for ornaments only.

2.2 Prelude

Prior to the study of various aspects of the Harappan culture, it would be essential to be acquainted with a few crucial and fundamental facts about its discovery, date and extent. The appropriateness of the name assigned to the Indus Valley Civilization, the period in history when it lasted and the extent of the over which it prevailed – all these are relevant for an accurate understanding of the subject, and therefore they are discussed below:

2.2.1. Discovery and Archaeological Excavations

In 1842, Charles Masson in his Narrative of Various Journeys in Balochistan, Afghanistan, the Punjab and Kalat described the ruins of Harappa. In 1856, when British engineers John and William Brunton were laying the East Indian Railway Company line connecting the cities of Karachi and Lahore, they faced a shortage of bricks. Their crew took bricks from the nearby village of Harappa where they found bricks from a 'ruined city'. These 4000-year old bricks were used for the railway track stretching to 93 miles (150 km). In 1912 John Faithfull Fleet discovered several seals at Harappa. The civilization was first discovered during an excavation campaign under Sir John Hubert Marshall in 1921–22 at Harappa. Harappan ruins were discovered by Marshall, Rai Bahadur Daya Ram Sahni and Madho Sarup Vats. Mohenjodaro ruins were excavated for the first time by R.D. Banerjee, E. J. H. MacKay and Sir John Hubert Marshall. As of 2008, over 1500 **Indus Valley Civilization sites** have been **discovered**.

2.2.2. Name of the Civilization

When it was discovered in 1921, this civilization was referred to as “Indo-Sumerian” because of its affinities with the Sumerian Civilization. But the newly discovered civilization had characteristics of its own, and historians named it the Indus Valley Civilization for the obvious reason that it flourished mostly in the Indus region. Nevertheless, the modern trend is to describe this civilization as “Harappan Culture” because archaeologists discovered for the first time the remnants of this civilization amidst the ruins of Harappa. Harappa in Sindhi means ‘Buried City’. The name Mohenjo-Daro means ‘Mound of the Dead’ in Sindhi. The Indus Valley Civilisation has also been called by some the “Sarasvati culture”, the “Sarasvati Civilisation”, the “Indus-Sarasvati Civilisation” or the “Sindhu-Saraswati Civilisation”, as the Ghaggar-Hakra River is identified by some with the mythological Sarasvati River suggesting that the Indus Valley Civilisation was the Vedic civilisation as perceived by traditional Hindu beliefs.

Meluha

The Mesopotamian (Sumerian) scribes in the Middle Bronze Age refer frequently to a place they call Meluhha. Meluhha was a prominent trading partner of the Sumerians and they imported timber and ebony in high volumes. Sesame oil and luxury items like lapis lazuli were also imported from Meluhha, which was in all probability, the Indus Valley Civilization.

2.2.3. Extent

Geographically, this civilization covered Punjab, Sindh, Baluchistan, Rajasthan, Gujarat and Western Uttar Pradesh. It extended from Sutkagendor (in Baluchistan) in the West to Alamgirpur (Western UP) in the East; and from Mandu (Jammu) in the North to Daimabad (Ahmednagar, Maharashtra) in the South. Some Indus Valley sites have also been found as far away as Afghanistan and Turkmenistan.

Important Sites

In India: Kalibangan (Rajasthan), Lothal, Dholavira, Rangpur, Surkotda (Gujarat), Banawali (Haryana), Ropar (Punjab).

In Pakistan: Harappa (on river Ravi), Mohenjodaro (on Indus River in Sindh), Chanhudaro (in Sindh).

Though a few archaeological artefacts similar to those excavated in the above places were found in hundreds of other sites as well, the Harappan culture is noticeable in its mature and flourishing stage especially in the above mentioned sites. The Harappan culture flourished in cities, and hence it is urban nature.

2.2.4. Date

The time span of mature Indus Valley Civilization (IVC) is estimated between BCE. 2700- BCE.1900 (for 800 years). But early Indus Valley Civilization had existed even before BCE.2700. The cities of the Indus Valley Civilisation had “social hierarchies, their writing system, their large planned cities and their long-distance trade [which] mark them to archaeologists as a full-fledged ‘civilisation.’” The mature phase of the Harappan civilisation lasted from c. 2600 to 1900 BCE. With the inclusion of the predecessor and successor cultures – Early Harappan and Late Harappan, respectively – the entire Indus Valley Civilisation may be taken to have lasted from the 33rd to the 14th centuries BCE. It is part of the Indus Valley Tradition, which also includes the pre-Harappan occupation of Mehrgarh, the earliest farming site of the Indus Valley.

Several periodisations are employed for the Indus Valley Civilisation or Harappan Culture. The most commonly used classifies the Indus Valley Civilisation into Early, Mature and Late Harappan Phase. An alternative approach by Shaffer divides the broader Indus Valley Tradition into four eras, the pre-Harappan “Early Food Producing Era,” and the Regionalisation, Integration, and Localisation eras, which correspond roughly with the Early Harappan, Mature Harappan, and Late Harappan phases.

Hakra Ware (pottery) has been found at Bhirrana, and is pre-Harappan, dating to the 8th–7th millennium BCE. Hakra Ware culture is a material culture which is contemporaneous with the early Harappan Ravi phase culture (3300–2800 BCE) of the Indus Valley. The estimation for the antiquity of Bhirrana as pre-Harappan is based on two calculations of charcoal samples, giving two dates of respectively 7570–7180 BCE, and 6689–6201 BCE.

Chronology

Dates	Main Phase	Mehrgarh phases	Harappan phases	Post-Harappan phases	Era
7000–5500 BCE	Pre-Harappan	Mehrgarh I (aceramic Neolithic)			Early Food Producing Era
5500–3300 BCE	Pre-Harappan/ Early Harappan (ceramic Neolithic)	Mehrgarh II-VI			Regionalisation Era c.4000-2500/ 2300 BCE (Shaffer)[57] c.5000–3200 BCE (Coningham & Young)[58]
3300–2800 BCE	Early Harappan c.3300–2800 BCE (Mughal)		Harappan 1 (Ravi Phase; Hakra Ware)		
2800–2600 BCE	c.5000–2800 BCE (Kenoyer)	Mehrgarh VII	Harappan 2 (KotDiji Phase, Nausharo I)		
2600–2450 BCE	Mature Harappan (Indus Valley Civilisation)		Harappan 3A (Nausharo II)		Integration Era
2450–2200 BCE			Harappan 3B		

2200–1900 BCE			Harappan 3C		
1900–1700 BCE	Late Harappan		Harappan 4 Ochre Coloured Pottery	Cemetery H	Localisation Era
1700–1300 BCE			Harappan 5		
1300–600 BCE	Post- Harappan Iron Age India			Painted Grey Ware (1200–600 BCE) Vedic period (c.1500–500 BCE)	Regionalisation c.1200–300 BCE (Kenoyer c.1500- 600 BCE (Coningham& Young)
600–300 BCE				Northern Black Polished Ware (Iron Age)(700– 200 BCE) Second urbanisation (c.500–200 BCE)	Integration

Pre-Harappan – Mehrgarh

Mehrgarh is a Neolithic (7000 BCE to c. 2500 BCE) site to the west of the Indus River valley, near the capital of the Kachi District in Pakistan, on the Kacchi Plain of Balochistan, near the Bolan Pass. The discovery of Mehrgarh “changed the entire concept of the Indus

civilization. There we have the whole sequence, right from the beginning of settled village life." Mehrgarh is one of the earliest sites with evidence of farming and herding in South Asia. Mehrgarh was influenced by the Near Eastern Neolithic, with similarities between "domesticated wheat varieties, early phases of farming, pottery, other archaeological artefacts, some domesticated plants and herd animals." "The earliest evidence of cattle herding in south Asia comes from the Indus River Valley site of Mehrgarh and is dated to 7,000 YBP." One can notice an initial local development of Mehrgarh, with continuity in cultural development but a change in population. While there is a strong continuity between the Neolithic and Chalcolithic (Copper Age) cultures of Mehrgarh, dental evidence shows that the chalcolithic population did not descend from the Neolithic population of Mehrgarh, which "suggests moderate levels of gene flow." A "new, possibly West Asian, body types are reported from the graves of Mehrgarh beginning in the Togau phase (3800 BCE)." The IVC-population likely resulted from a mixture of Iranian agriculturalists and South Asian hunter-gatherers, and came into being between ca. 4700–3000 BCE.

Early Harappan

The Early Harappan Ravi Phase, named after the nearby Ravi River, lasted from c. 3300 BCE until 2800 BCE. It is related to the Hakra Phase, identified in the Ghaggar-Hakra River Valley to the west, and predates the KotDiji Phase (2800–2600 BCE, Harappan 2), named after a site in northern Sindh, Pakistan, near Mohenjo-Daro. The earliest examples of the Indus script date to the 3rd millennium BCE. The mature phase of earlier village cultures is represented by Rehman Dheri and Amri in Pakistan. KotDiji represents the phase leading up to Mature Harappan, with the citadel representing centralised authority and an increasingly urban quality of life. Another town of this stage was found at Kalibangan in India on the Hakra River.

Trade networks linked this culture with related regional cultures and distant sources of raw materials, including lapis lazuli and other materials for bead-making. By this time, villagers had domesticated numerous crops, including peas, sesame seeds, dates, and cotton, as well as animals, including the water buffalo. Early Harappan communities turned to large urban centres by 2600 BCE, from where the mature Harappan phase started. The latest research shows that Indus Valley people migrated from villages to cities.

The final stages of the Early Harappan period are characterised by the building of large walled settlements, the expansion of trade networks, and the increasing integration of regional communities into a “relatively uniform” material culture in terms of pottery styles, ornaments, and stamp seals with Indus script, leading into the transition to the Mature Harappan phase.

Mature Harappan

The slow southward migration of the monsoons across Asia initially allowed the Indus Valley villages to develop by taming the floods of the Indus and its tributaries. Flood-supported farming led to large agricultural surpluses, which in turn supported the development of cities. The IVC residents did not develop irrigation capabilities, relying mainly on the seasonal monsoons leading to summer floods. The development of advanced cities coincides with a reduction in rainfall, which may have triggered reorganization into larger urban centers. The Mature Harappan Civilisation was “a fusion of the Bagor, Hakra, and KotDiji traditions or ‘ethnic groups’ in the Ghaggar-Hakra valley on the borders of India and Pakistan”.

By 2600 BCE, the Early Harappan communities turned into large urban centres. Such urban centres include Harappa, Ganeriwala, Mohenjo-Daro in modern-day Pakistan, and Dholavira, Kalibangan, Rakhigarhi, Rupar, and Lothal in modern-day India. In total, more than 1,052 cities and settlements have been found, mainly in the general region of the Indus Rivers and their tributaries.

Check Your Progress -1

1. Give an account of excavations at Harappan sites and its name.
2. Summarize about the extent of the Harappan culture.
3. Write a note on the date and chronology of Indus Valley Civilization.

2.3. Findings

Most cities had similar patterns. There were two parts:

1. A citadel and
2. The lower town

Most cities had a public water tank. There were also granaries, 2-storied houses made of burnt bricks, closed drainage lines, excellent storm water and waste water management system, weights for measurements, toys, pots, etc. A large number of seals have been discovered. Excellent pieces of red pottery designed in black have been excavated. Faience was used to make beads, bangles, earrings and vessels. The civilization also was advanced in making art works.

2.3.1. Great Bath

The **Great Bath** is the most fascinating structure of the metropolis of Mohenjo-Daro. It is found to contain a large, open space at the centre. Galleries and rooms lie on all sides. In the central space, there was the provision of a large swimming enclosure. There is a set of steps from all four sides that leads towards the pool. The pool was fed with water through a well. The water was discharged probably by a huge drain. Studies have suggested that every house had got a well-built bathroom and there were street water facilities. The presence of such a Great Bath indicates that there was some ceremonial occasion when people, in large numbers, used to go there to take bath. Utmost importance was given to the privacy of the bather. There were small rooms on the raised platform on all the sides. These rooms must have been used for changing clothes. There is a probability that there was arrangement for hot water as well.

Similar bathing pool is also found at Dholavira. This indicates that the people of this civilization attached importance to sanitation and cleanliness.

2.3.2. Granaries

Large granaries were located near each of the citadels, which suggest that the state stored grain for ceremonial purposes, times of shortage, and possibly the regulation of grain production and sale. Evidence of several granaries, massive buildings with solid brick foundations and sockets for wooden superstructures has been found in excavations of Harappa, Mohenjodaro, and Rakhigarhi. All the granaries were built close to the river bank so that with the help of boats, grains could be easily transported. The Great Granary at Harappa had a series of working platforms with circular bricks nearby that were probably used for threshing grains.

2.3.3. Town Planning

The excavations of the ruins showed a remarkable skill in town planning. The main streets and roads were set in a line, sometimes running straight for a mile, and were varying in width from 4 meters to 10 meters. Most of these roads and streets were paved with fire burnt bricks. On the either side of the street stood houses of various sizes which did not protrude into the streets. The main streets intersected at right angles, dividing the city into squares or rectangular blocks each of which was divided length wise and cross wise by lanes. Some buildings had a lamp post and a well. There was an elaborate drainage system which emptied into the river.

The Indus Valley cities and towns had a rectangular grid pattern. The main streets were along the North-South direction and the secondary streets were along the East-West direction. The well-planned streets and the elaborate drainage system hint that the occupants of these cities were skilled urban planners who gave importance to the management of water. Wells have also been found throughout the cities and nearly every house consisted of a bathing area and a covered drainage system.

At Harappa, Mohenjo-Daro and Kalibangan, the city was divided into two main parts. The higher and upper portion of the city was protected by a construction which looks like a fort. The ruling class of the towns perhaps lived in the protected area. The other part of the towns was lower in height than the former and common men lived in this area. The lower area of the towns generally spread over one square mile. The nature of the buildings at Harappa and Mohenjo-Daro shows that the town dwellers were divided into various social classes.

The rich and the ruling class lived in the multi-roomed spacious houses and the poorer section lived in small tenements. The public building and big houses were situated on the streets. The modest houses were situated on the lanes. Encroachment on public roads or lanes by building houses was not permitted.

The houses can be divided into three main groups viz.

- a. dwelling houses,
- b. larger buildings,
- c. public baths.

Smaller houses had two rooms, while larger houses had many rooms. There were courtyards attached to big buildings. There was little artistic touch in the architectural design of the buildings belonging either to the rich or the poor. They were plain, utilitarian and comfortable to live. Some of the buildings were probably multi-storied.

Most of the houses had baths, wells and covered drains connected with street drains. Ordinary buildings had little ventilation arrangements, as doors and windows were rarely fixed in the outer walls. Doors of entrance were fixed not on the front wall but on the side walls. One could enter a house by the door facing the side lanes of the house. The doors were made of wood. Large buildings had spacious doors.

Most of the houses were built of burnt bricks. But un-burnt sun-dried bricks were also used. Most of the bricks were of equal size. The staircases of big buildings were solid; the roofs were flat and were made of wood.

2.3.4. The Drainage System

The Drainage System of the Indus Valley Civilization was far advanced. The drains were covered with slabs. Water flowed from houses into the street drains. The street drains had manholes at regular intervals. Housewives were expected to use pits in which heavier part of the rubbish will settle down while only sewerage water was allowed to drain off. All soak pits and drains were occasionally cleaned by workmen. In every house there was a well-constructed sink, and water flowed from the sink into the underground sewers in the streets. This elaborate drainage system shows that the Indus Valley people were fully conversant with the principles of health and sanitation.

2.3.5. The Assembly Hall

An important feature of Mohen-jo-daro was its 24 square meters pillared hall. It had five rows of pillars, with four pillars in each row. Kiln baked bricks were used to construct these pillars. Probably, it was the Assembly Hall or the ruler's court. It is said that it also housed the municipal office which had the charge of town planning and sanitation.

2.3.6. Seals

Seals, more than 2000 in number, made of soapstone, terracotta and copper are discovered in various Indus sites. Some seals have human or animal figures on them. Most of the seals have the figures of real animals while a few bears the figure of mythical animals. The seals are rectangular, circular or even cylindrical in shape. The seals even have an inscription of a sort of pictorial writing. Most of the seals have a knob at the back through which runs a hole. It is said that these seals were used by different associations or merchants for stamping purposes. They were also worn round the neck or the arm. The seals show the culture and civilization of the Indus Valley people. In particular, they indicate: Dresses, ornaments, hair-styles of people, Skill of artists and sculptors, Trade contacts and commercial relations, Religious beliefs, Script.

Important Seals:

The Pasupati Seal: This seal was excavated in Mohenjo-daro and depicts a seated and possibly ithyphallic figure or yogi, probably God Siva., surrounded by animals. the three-faced male god is shown seated in a yogic posture, surrounded by a rhino and a buffalo on the right, and an elephant and a tiger on the left. Pair of horns crowns his head. He is surrounded by a rhino, a buffalo, an elephant and a tiger. Under his throne are two deer. This seal shows that Shiva was worshipped and he was considered as the Lord of animals (Pasupati).

The Unicorn Seal: The unicorn is a mythological animal. This seal shows that at a very early stage of civilization, humans had produced many creations of imagination in the shape of bird and animal motifs that survived in later art.

The Bull Seal: This seal depicts a humped bull of great vigour. The figure shows the artistic skill and a good knowledge of animal anatomy.

The use of these seals is uncertain. Many Indus Valley seals include the forms of animals, with some depicting them being carried in processions. Some scholars believe that animals played an important role in Indus Valley religions. One seal from Mohenjo-daro shows a half-human, half-buffalo monster attacking a tiger. This may be a reference to the Sumerian myth of a monster created by Aruru, the Sumerian earth and fertility goddess, to fight Gilgamesh, the hero of an ancient Mesopotamian epic poem. This is a further suggestion of international trade in Harappan culture.

Check your Progress -2

1. Give an account of the important findings of Indus Civilization.

2.4. Religion

The numerous seals and figurines discovered in the excavations carried out at various sites connected with the Harappan culture point out to the religious beliefs of the Indus Valley people.

2.4.1. Worship of Cult Objects and Nature Worship

Worship of Linga: Discovery of a large number of conical or cylindrical stones show that the people worshipped lingam, the symbol of Lord Shiva.

Worship of Mother Goddess: A large number of excavated terracotta figurines are those of a figure which is identified with some female energy or Shakti or Mother Goddess, who is the source of all creation. She is wearing numerous ornaments and a fan-shaped head dress.

Worship of Trees: The worship of trees was widespread. The Pipal tree was considered most sacred. One of the seals shows a god standing between the branches of a people tree and the god was being worshipped by a devotee on his knees. The discovery of a large number of seals with papal trees engraved on them suggests that this tree was considered sacred, same as some nowadays Hindu do.

Other Objects of Worship: People also worshipped animals such as the bull, buffalo and tiger. The worship of mythical animals is evident from the existence of a human figure with a bull's horns, hoofs and a tail. Besides animals, these people also worshipped the Sun, the Fire and the Water.

2.4.2. Faith in Magic, Charms and Sacrifices

The discovery of amulets suggests that the Indus valley people had belief in magic and charms. Some seals have figures of men and animals in act of sacrificing. This shows that sacrifices played some part in their religion.

2.4.3. Belief in Life after Death

The people of Indus Valley disposed of their dead either by burial or by cremation. They buried their dead together with household pottery, ornaments and other articles of daily use. Even when they cremated the dead, they preserved the ashes of the bodies in clay urns. Both these practices show that people believed in life after death.

The existence of public baths suggests that people believed in ritual bathing.

2.5. ART

2.5.1. Sculpture in Stone

Among the stone images found in Harappa two male statues are noteworthy. The first statue is that of a “**Yogi or Priest King**”, draped in a shawl worn over the left shoulder and under the right arm. His beard is well-kept and his eyes are half-closed. The other figure is a torso of a human male. It is beautiful piece of sculpture made of red stone. The head and arms of the figure were carved separately and socketed into holes drilled on the torso.

2.5.2. Sculpture in Metal – Dancing Girl

The Harappan artists knew the art of bronze casting. A figure of a female dancer was found at Mohen-jo-daro. Necklaces adorn her neck. One of her arms is fully covered with bangles made of bone or ivory. Her eyes are large, nose is flat and the lips are pendulous. Her hair is braided and her head is slightly thrown back. Her limbs suggest graceful lines. Besides the figurine, bronze figures of a buffalo and a humped bull are very artistically designed.

2.5.3. Sculpture in Terracotta

The Indus Valley people practiced sculpture in terracotta. The terracotta figure of the Mother Goddess was discovered in Mohen-jo-daro. The figure, with a punched nose and artistic ornamentation laid on the body and pressed on the figure, shows the Mother Goddess as the symbol of fertility and prosperity.

2.5.4. Pottery and Painting

Pottery found in large quantities shows that with the potter's wheel the craftsman produced pottery of various artistic shapes. The special clay for this purpose was baked and the different

designs on pots were painted. Figures of birds, animals and men were depicted on the pots. Paintings on the pots show, that these men were equally good at painting.

Check your Progress -3

1. Write about the religious practices of Indus people
2. Give an account of the art of the Harappan people

2.6. Economic Activity

2.6.1. Agriculture

Agriculture was the main occupation of the Indus Valley people. Crops such as wheat, barley, peas and bananas were raised. In the olden days, there was enough rain in that region and occasional floods brought a great deal of fertile soil to the area. People used to plough the land with wooden ploughshares drawn by men and oxen. From the existence of granaries, it is concluded that there were surplus food-grains.

2.6.2. Domestication of Animals

The people of Harappa domesticated animals like oxen, buffaloes, pigs, goats and sheep. Camels and asses were used as means of transport. Dogs and cats were kept as pets. The humped bull was considered a great asset in the farming community.

2.6.3. Crafts

The discovery of spindles at the sites of Harappan culture shows that the people used to spin and weave. Goldsmiths made jewellery of gold, silver and precious stones. People were also engaged in brick-laying and in the art of sculpture. The making of seals was developed during this period. Bronze-smiths made various types of weapons and tools such as knives, spears, saws and axes which were used in daily life.

2.6.4. Trade

Traders carried on trade in the country as well as with other countries like Egypt, Babylon and Afghanistan. Many seals of Harappa found in Mesopotamia show that trade existed between

the two countries. The seals were made of terracotta and were used by merchants to stamp their goods. The people of the Indus Valley used weights and measures in their business transactions.

2.7 Social Life

2.7.1. Food

Specimens of wheat and barley show that they were cultivated in that region. Rice was also probably grown. There is evidence to show that date palms were grown in the area. Besides these, the diet of the people consisted of fruits, vegetables, fish, milk and meat of animals i.e. beef, mutton and poultry.

2.7.2. Dress

From the sculptured figures it can be seen that the dress of men and women consisted of two pieces of cloth-one resembling a dhoti, covering the lower part, and the other worn over the left shoulder and under the right arm. Men had long hair designed differently. Women wore a fan shaped head dress covering their hair. The discovery of a large number of spindles showed that they knew weaving and spinning. Similarly, it was concluded, by the discovery of needles and buttons, that the people of this age knew the art of stitching.

2.7.3. Ornaments

Both men and women wore ornaments made of gold, silver, copper and other metals. Men wore necklaces, finger rings and armlets of various designs and shapes. The women wore a head dress, ear rings, bangles, girdles, bracelets and anklets. Rich people wore expensive ornaments made of gold while the poor had ornaments made of shell, bone or copper.

2.7.4. Cosmetics

The ladies of Mohen-jo-daro were not lagging behind in styles as used by the ladies of the present day, when it came to the use of cosmetics and the attainment of beauty. Materials made of ivory and metal for holding and applying cosmetics prove that they knew the use of face paint and collyrium. Bronze oval mirrors, ivory combs of various shapes, even small dressing

tables, have been found at Mohen-jo-daro and other sites. Women tied the hair into a bun and used hair pins made of ivory. Toilet jars, found at Mohen-jo-daro, show that women took interest in cosmetics.

2.7.5. Furniture and Utensils

The furniture and utensils found at Mohen-jo-daro show a high degree of civilization because of their variety in kind and design. The beautifully painted pottery, numerous vessels for the kitchen, chairs and beds made of wood, lamps of different material, toys for children, marbles, balls and dice, indicate what people manufactured in those days.

2.7.6. Conveyance

A copper specimen found at Harappa resembles the modern Ekka (cart) with a top-cover. Bullock carts with or without the roof was the chief means of conveyance.

2.7.7. Amusements and Recreation

The Indus Valley people liked more of indoor games than outdoor amusements. They were fond of gambling and playing dice. Dancing and singing were considered great arts. Boys played with toys made of terracotta, while girls played with dolls.

2.8. Script

Harappans are believed to have used a Script, consisting of symbols. A collection of written texts on clay and stone tablets unearthed at Harappa, which have been carbon dated 3300-3200 BCE, contain trident-shaped, plant-like markings. This Indus Script suggests that writing developed independently in the Indus River Valley Civilization from the script employed in Mesopotamia and Ancient Egypt. As many as 600 distinct Indus symbols have been found on seals, small tablets, ceramic pots, and more than a dozen other materials. Typical Indus inscriptions are no more than four or five characters in length, most of which are very small. The longest on a single surface, which is less than 1-inch (or 2.54 cm.) square, is 17 signs long. The characters are largely pictorial, but include many abstract signs that do not appear to have changed over time. The inscriptions are thought to have been primarily written from right to left, but it is unclear whether this script constitutes a complete language.

The characters are largely pictorial but include many abstract signs. The number of principal signs is about 400. Many linguists and archaeologists are trying to decipher this script. A board with symbols or letters over 30 cm in height in a wooden frame was discovered at Dholavira in 1999. Archaeologists believe this was the world's first signboard. It is thought to have been placed at the façade of the northern gate of the city's citadel.

2.9. End of Civilization

This civilization is said to have come to an abrupt end. The following reasons are put forward for its abrupt end:

- The neighbouring desert encroached on the fertile area and made it infertile.
- Regular floods destroyed the area.
- Invaders killed people and destroyed the Indus Valley Civilization. They did not have weapons to attack others or to defend themselves. So, they could not defend themselves against the invaders.
- The end was partly caused by changing river patterns. These changes included the drying up of the Hakra River and changes in the course of the Indus River. The river changes disrupted agricultural and economic systems, and many people left the cities of the Indus Valley region.
- Earthquakes and Epidemics caused destruction.

By 1700 B.C., the Indus civilization had gradually broken up into smaller cultures, called late Harappan cultures and post-Harappan cultures. However, some aspects of Indus art, agriculture, and possibly social organization continued in the smaller cultures. Some of these aspects became incorporated into a unified urban civilization that began developing throughout the region about 600 B.C.

The Indus Valley people gave to the world its earliest cities, its town planning, its architecture in stone and clay, and showed their concern for health and sanitation. They built a scientific drainage system in their cities.

Check your Progress - 4

1. Highlight the economic activities of the Indus people.
2. Focus on the social life of the Indus Valley Civilization
3. What do you know about the Indus script?
4. What are the reasons for the disappearance of Harappan Culture?

2.10. Answers to Check your Progress**Check your Progress –1**

1. See Sections 2.2.1. & 2.2.2.
2. See Section 2.2.3
3. See Sections 2.2.4.

Check your Progress –2

1. See Sections 2.3.-. 2.3.6.

Check your Progress –3

1. See Sections 2.4. -2.4.3.
2. See Sections 2.5.1. – 2.5.4

Check your Progress - 4

1. See Sections 2.6.1. – 2.6.4.
2. See Sections 2.7.1. – 2.7.7.
3. See Section 2.8.
4. See Section 2.9.

LESSON - 3

SOCIAL AND CULTURAL LIFE OF EARLY VEDIC AND LATER VEDIC PERIOD

Learning Objectives

After learning this lesson, you will be able to

- Describe the origin of the Aryans
- Explain the home of the Aryans
- Discuss about the Vedas, Samhitas and Vedangas
- Understand the Political Organisation and Administrative Divisions
- Comprehend the Social, Economic and religious conditions

Structure

3.1 Introduction

3.2 Learning Objectives

3.2 Origin

3.2.1. European Origin

3.2.2. Migration from Southern Russia

3.2.3. Indian Origin

3.2.4. Home of the Aryans in India

3.3 Vedic Literature

3.3.1. The Vedas

3.3.2. Samhitas

3.3.3. The Authorship of the Vedic Literature

3.4 Political Organisation during Rig Vedic Age

3.4.1. Administrative Divisions

3.4.2. Form of Government

3.4.3. The King**3.4.4. Officials****3.4.5. The Army****3.4.6. Popular Assemblies****3.5 Social Life****3.5.1. Family****3.5.2. Position of Women****3.5.3. Dress and Ornaments****3.5.4. Food and Drink****3.5.5. Amusements****3.5.6. Morality****3.5.7. Education****3.5.8. Caste System****3.6 Economic Life****3.6.1. The Village****3.6.2. Agriculture****3.6.3. Domestication of animals****3.6.4. Occupation****3.6.5. Trade and Commerce****3.6.6. Transport and Communication****3.7 Religious Life and Philosophy****3.8 Later Vedic Age****3.9 Political Organisation****3.9.1. Rise of Big States****3.9.2. Growth of Imperialism****3.9.3. Origin of Kingship****3.9.4. Growth of Royal Power****3.9.5. Administrative Machinery**

3.10. Social Condition**3.10.1. Caste System****3.10.2. Social Organization****3.10.3. Education****3.10.4. Position of women****3.10.5. Food and Dress:****3.11 Economic Condition****3.11.1. Agriculture****3.11.2. Trade and Commerce****3.11.3. Occupation****3.11.4. House Building and Transport****3.12 Religious Condition****3.12.1. New Gods****3.12.2. Rituals and Sacrifices****3.12.3. Morality and Duty****3.12.4. Religious Philosophy****3.12.5. Ascetic Life****3.13 Science****3.1 Introduction**

After the decline of the Indus Valley Civilization, another glorious civilization flourished in India. The people who were responsible for the evolution of this civilization called themselves Aryas or Aryans. 'Arya' literally means the man of 'noble character', and the "free-born". They belonged to the group of people known as Indo-Europeans. They entered into India from the north-west. India, as is well known, derives its name from the Sindhu (Indus) and the earliest civilisation of this country which was predominantly urban had its cradle in the valley of the same river, called the Indus civilisation. Far different is the picture of another civilisation which had its principal home higher up in the Indus valley called the Vedic or Rig Vedic culture. The people who evolved this culture called themselves Aryas or Aryans and were probably an

invading or immigrant people, whose first arrival in India is dated a little earlier than 1500 B.C. We do not find clear and definite archaeological traces of their advent. The Aryan migration to India was not a single concerted action, but one covering centuries and involving many tribes. The earliest life of the Aryans seems to have been mainly pastoral, agriculture being a secondary occupation. The Aryans did not lead a settled life, with the result that they could not leave behind any solid material remains. They spoke the Indo-European languages from which modern languages like Sanskrit, Persian, Latin, Greek, Celtic, Gothic have developed. Originally, the Aryans seem to have lived somewhere in the area east of the Alps, known as Eurasia. From the earliest Aryan language, classical languages as Sanskrit, Latin and Greek came into being. From these languages again, several other languages developed. They all form the Aryan family of languages.

The Vedic age spans almost a millennium of Indian history (1500-600 B.C.), a period which witnessed crucial changes in North India. These developments are evident in a number of spheres-social, economic, political and religious.

Dating the Vedic Civilization:

As regards the age of the Vedas, Jacobi's view was that the Vedic civilization flourished between 4500 and 2500 B.C. According to Dr. Winternitz "The available evidence merely proves that the Vedic period extends from an unknown past say X to 500 B.C., none of the dates 1200-500 B.C., 1500-500 B.C. and 2000-500 B.C., which are usually assumed, being justified by facts. Only it may be added, as a result of recent researches, that 800 B.C. should be substituted for 500 B.C. and that the unknown date more probably falls in the third rather than in second millennium before Christ."

3.2. Origin

Nobody can say exactly which place on earth was the earliest home of the Aryan people. The descendants of the ancient Aryan race spread over wide areas of Europe and Asia. To some Indian scholars, the Aryans were the original inhabitants of India and they did not come to this land from outside. On the other hand, some patriotic European scholars believe that the Aryans originally lived on the shores of the far-away Baltic Sea. Majority of historians, however,

believe that the early Aryans lived in that region of Europe which now comprises such places as Austria, Hungary and Bohemia.

From their original home the ancient Aryans spread away to different places. Going south and westward they divided themselves into several branches and entered into Greece, Italy, Germany, France, Spain and England. Coming in another direction, they entered into Iran and India.

The name Iran (Persia) comes from the word Aryanam which means the country of the Aryans. In India, the Aryans first settled in the area known as the Punjab. At first the name of that place was Saptanada or the Land of the Seven Rivers. Subsequently, it was called Panchanada or the Land of the Five Rivers. The word Punjab means the Land of the Five Rivers.

The fact that the Aryan tribes of Europe and Asia came from common ancestors is known from their earliest religious and social terms of use. From the original Aryan word Dyu, came the words Deva in Sanskrit, Deus in Latin, Zeus in Greek, Tiu in Saxon and Zio in German. The original Fire God of the ancient Aryans became Agni in India, Ignis in Italy, and Ogni in East European lands. The Usha or Dawn of the Indian Aryans was the same as the Eos of the Greeks and Aurora of the Italians.

Similarly, from the root family terms of the ancient Aryans came such words as Pitar, Matar, Bhratar and Duhitar in Sanskrit, and Father, Mother, Brother and Daughter in English. Many such words in Sanskrit and several European languages came from the same Aryan roots. Though they came from the same ancestors, the different branches of the Aryan people in course of time lived as separate races and developed their separate individualities.

Original Homeland:

The identification of the original home of the Aryans has been a very difficult riddle to solve with claims and counter-claims being made by several scholars. The word Aryan literally means of high birth, but generally refers to language, though some use it as race.

Max Muller, the great German Scholar declared emphatically that the term "Aryan, in scientific language, is utterly inapplicable to race. It means language and nothing but language".

Philological studies by Filippo Sasseti, (a Florentine) in the late 16th century led to the discovery of close affinities between Sanskrit and some of the principal languages of Europe such as Greek, Latin, Gothic, Celtic and also Persian.

These similarities could have been only when their ancestors must have lived together for a sufficiently long time. In 1786, Sir William Jones in his address to the Asiatic Society of Bengal tried to prove a definite relation between the Vedic Sanskrit and the principal European languages.

The scholars have given a common name 'Indo-European' to this group of languages and the people speaking them were known as Indo- Europeans. On this basis it has been surmised that this Indo-Europeans migrated or dispersed to the various parts of the world, including India. The Indo-Aryans in due course of time orally composed the Rigveda Samhita which on linguistic grounds is dated between 1500 and 1000 B.C.

The language of Zend Avesta, which is the oldest text in the Iranian language, is also similar to the Rig Vedic Sanskrit. The two texts use the same names for several gods and even for social classes suggesting that the Vedic culture and the ancient Aryan culture of Iran seem to have derived from one and the same Indo- Iranian culture.

There is archaeological evidence outside India to show that in Asia Minor and other countries of Western Asia there was some activity of the Aryans. Some inscriptions of about 1400 B.C. found at Boghaz-koi in Cilicia (Asia Minor), the capital of the ancient Hittites, mention some Aryan deities such as Indra, Varuna, Mitra and Nasatyas. On the evidence of Indian archaeological objects, it is assumed that the Aryans were the authors of the Painted Grey Ware Culture (1100-600 B.C.) with its epicentre located in the Ganga-Yamuna doab.

Originally the Aryans seem to have lived somewhere in the Steppes, stretching from southern Russia to Central Asia, bordering the Oxus and the Jaxartes, and the Aral and Caspian seas. From these base sections many of them may be presumed to have pushed up the highlands of Afghanistan, and then to have descended from this base into the plains of the Punjab.

In the opposite direction other Aryan tribes from the same region moved westwards into Iran. The main tribes known among the Aryan speaking people are the Hittites, Indo-Aryans, Iranians, Kassites, Mitannis and Greeks. While Hittites migrated to Cappadocia (Asia Minor) in about 1950 B.C., the Indo-Iranians came to the Pamirs and the Oxus and Jaxartes valleys in about 2000 B.C.

Then the Iranians went to Iran and the Indo-Aryans entered India in about 1500 B.C., but not earlier than 2000 B.C. Kassites occupied Babylonia in about 1760 B.C., while the Mitannis migrated to other parts of Mesopotamia around 1500 B.C. Finally the Greek Aryans went to Greece around 1200 B.C.

Many scholars like Ganganath Jha, D.S. Trivedi, L.D. Kalla, etc., tried to prove that the Vedic Aryans were the indigenous people, who regarded Sapta-Sindhu as their original home. This view, though highly favoured at one time, has not many supporters now. Had India been the original home of the Aryans they would have certainly tried to fully Aryanise the whole of the sub-continent.

Besides, the vast disparities between the Harappan and vedic cultures further prove that had the Aryans been the indigenous people these disparities would not have been noticed, particularly when the epicentre of both these cultures was the Indus region.

Bal Gangadhar Tilak was of the opinion that the original home of the Aryans was the Arctic region. This view was propounded by him in his book, 'The Arctic Home of Aryans.' According to Swami Dayanand Saraswati and Pargiter, the original home of the Aryans was Tibet. The view has been expounded by them in the 'Satyarth Prakash' and 'Ancient Indian Historical Traditions' respectively.

3.2.1. European Origin:

The descendants of the ancient Aryan race spread over wide areas of Europe and Asia. The early Aryans were familiar with certain animals such as goats, dogs, pigs, cows, horses etc. and also with the trees like pine, maple, oak, willow, birch etc. which are found in Europe. This led to Prof. Giles to suggest the European origin of the Aryans. It is generally believed that they migrated to India and other parts of Asia from Europe.

It is difficult to locate the exact part of Europe where the Aryans originally lived before they migrated elsewhere. According to Giles, Balkan countries were the original home of the Aryans. The flora and fauna and the animals with which the early Aryans were familiar could be found in the Balkan countries at that time.

Prof. Hist believes that the Aryans migrated from Lithuania Europe into Caucasus and from there they entered into Iran. Again, from Iran they entered into Punjab. This view is proved by the discovery of Boghaz Koi inscription and the Tel-EI- Amarna Letters in Western Asia.

3.2.2. Migration from Southern Russia:

Some historians held the view that the Aryans entered into India from the region of South Russia. Brandenstein has suggested that the Aryans migrated to India from Kirghizsteppes in Russia. The great Philologist, Schrader accepts South Russia as the original home of Russians from where they migrated to different areas.

3.2.3. Indian Origin:

Some historians held the view that Aryans belonged to India. In the Rigveda, the land where the Vedic Aryans lived is called by the name of Sapta-Sindhu or the 'land of the seven rivers' which included the Indus or Sindhu with its principal tributaries on the west and the river Saraswati on the east. The region of Sapta-Sindhu witnessed the composition of the sacred hymns which describe the early growth and development of the Vedic culture. Subsequently it was called "Panchanada" (land of five rivers) which was the name of Punjab. The flora and fauna with which the Aryans were familiar are not found in Punjab. Again, the fertility of Punjab must have attracted immigration. From the linguistic view point Greek and Latin belong to Aryan group of Languages. These considerations led the historians to believe that Aryans do not originally belong to India.

From linguistic study it is proved that the Aryans migrated from Europe or Asia to India. For example, 'Pider' and 'Mader' in Parsi, 'Pater' and 'Mater' of Latin, "Father" and 'Mother' of English resemble with 'Pitru' and 'Matru' of Sanskrit. So, the historians generally accepted the view that Aryans migrated from Europe or Asia to India.

The Aryans first appeared in Iran on their way to India, where the Indo-Iranians lived for a long time. From Rig Veda, which is the earliest specimen of Indo-European language we know about the Aryans. The Rig Veda consists of ten mandalas or books. It is a collection of prayers offered to Agni, Indra, Mitra, Varuna and other gods by various families of poets or sages.

Rig Veda has many things in common with 'Avesta' of Iran. The 'Rig Veda' and 'Avesta' use the same names for several gods and even for several classes. Some Aryan names engraved in the Kassite inscriptions of 1600 B.C. and the Mittani inscriptions of the fourteenth century B.C. found in Iraq proves that from Iran a branch of the Aryans moved towards the west.

Coming of the Aryans to India:

The time when the Aryans entered into India is yet a subject of debate. Attempts are made to know that time from Vedic literature. According to some learned Indians like Bal Gangadhar Tilak, the earliest Veda, famous as the Rig-Veda, was composed about 4,500 years before Christ. The Aryans must have come, therefore, several generations before that time.

According to the famous western scholar H.T. Colebrooke, who discovered the Vedas for the western people, the composition of all the Vedas was perhaps finished by 14th century B.C. For several centuries before that they must have settled in the Punjab. Max Muller believed that the Vedas were composed about 1500 years before Christ. Another western scholar, Whitney, believed that the hymns of the Rig-Veda were composed between 2,000 B.C. and 1,500 B.C. Most likely, the Aryans entered into India around 2,000 years before the birth of Christ. This opinion is held by the majority of historians.

Soon after their entry into India the Aryans began to compose the Vedas. Much about their early life in India is known from the descriptions in the Vedas. At first, they settled in the Punjab region where the rivers, Sindhu, Vitasta, Chandrabhaga, Iravati, Bipasa, Satadru and Saraswati flowed.

At that time, they had to fight against the primitive people of the land as well as, perhaps with the civilised Dravidians. The enemies were described in the Vedas as Dasyus and Asuras. In course of time, the Dravidians, migrated towards the south, and the primitives retired into mountains, hills and forests. The conquered or subjugated enemies were described as the Dasas.

From the Punjab, the Aryans moved eastward into the river valleys of the Ganges and Yamuna. They called that region Madhya Desa. Gradually, they spread over the whole of the Uttarapatha. The landmass between the Himalayas and the Vindhya and from the western seas to the east was named as the Aryavarta.

3.2.4. Home of the Aryans in India:

The Aryans appeared in India a little earlier than 1500 B.C. The earliest Aryans settled down in eastern Afghanistan, Punjab, and fringes of Uttar Pradesh. The Rig-Veda mentioned the names of some rivers of Afghanistan such as the river Kubha, and the river Indus and its five branches. The earliest settlements of Aryans were confined to the valleys of the river Sindh and its tributaries and of the Saraswati and the Drishadvati.

Though they were confined mainly in Punjab, yet their outer settlements reached to the banks of the Ganga and the Yamuna. They named that region Madhya Desa. Gradually they occupied the whole of Uttarapatha, the land between Himalayas and the Vindhya and from the western seas to the east were called as Aryavarta.

3.3. Vedic Literature

3.3.1. The Vedas:

The Vedas form the oldest literary works of the Aryans and occupy a very distinguished place in the history of the world literature. Because of its ancient character, it occupies a unique place in the history of the world literature. Vedas have been looked upon as the revealed words of God by millions of Hindus. In course of many centuries Vedas had grown up and was orally handed down from generation to generation. The word Veda means the supreme knowledge. The Aryans believed that the Vedas were the words of God. Heard from the voice of God they

were also called Shruti. The Vedas were transmitted from generation to generation orally and from memory. The Vedas were probably authored during 1800 BC and 600 BC. It consists of three successive classes of literary production. The Vedas were four in number. They were Rig Veda, Sama Veda, Yajur Veda and Atharva Veda. The earliest, namely, the Rig Veda was composed about 2000 B.C. It contained 1017 hymns which were divided into 10 Mandalas or parts. The total words numbered more than one lakh and fifty thousand.

These three classes are:

- (i) The Samhitas or Mantras—these are collections of hymns, prayers, charms, litanies, sacrificial formulas.
- (ii) The Brahmanas—a kind of Primitive theology and philosophy of Brahmanas.
- (iii) The Aranyakas and Upanishads—they are partly included in the Brahmanas or attached thereto and partly exist as separate work. They contain philosophical meditations of the hermits and ascetics on soul, God, world & man.

3.3.2. Samhitas

There are four Samhitas which are different from one another.

These are:

(i) The Rigveda Samhita:

A collection of hymns. It has ten mandalas with a total of 1028 'Suktas' or 'stutis' for the worship of gods like Indra, Surya, Agni, Yama, Varuna Ashwini, Usha etc.

(ii) Samaveda Samhita:

A collection of songs mostly taken from Rig Veda. It contained 1549 stutis. A special class of priests known as "Udgator" were to recite its hymns.

(iii) Yajur Veda Samhita:

A collection of sacrificial formula. It has 40 mandals. There are two distinct forms of Yajur Veda namely. "SuklaYajur Veda" and "Krishna Yajur Veda". The "SuklaYajur Veda" contains the genesis while the "Krishna Yajur Veda" describes the "Vasya" or the philosophy.

(iv) Atharva Veda Samhita:

A collection of songs and spells. It has twenty mandalas with 731 'stutis'. It deals with magic, hypnotism, enslavement through mantra. It is regarded on a lower level than the other three Vedas. These four samhitas formed the basis of four Vedas.

Every work belonging to the second and third classes of Vedic literature viz, the Brahmanas, the Aranyakas and the Upanishads, is attached to one or another of these samhitas and is said to belong to that particular Veda.

Vedangas:

Besides the Vedas, there is another class of works whose authorship is ascribed to human beings. They are known as Sutras or Vedangas. There are six vedangas. They are six subjects. These are siksha (pronunciation), chhandas (metre) Jyotisha (astronomy), Kalpa (ritual), Vyakarana (grammar), Ninukta (explanation of words).

3.3.3. The Authorship of the Vedic Literature:

The Hindus have a belief that the hymns were merely revealed to the sages and not composed by them. For this Vedas are called "apaurusheya" (not made by man) and "ritya" (existing in all eternity). The 'Rishis' to whom they are ascribed are known as Mantradrastra'. (Who received the mantra by sight directly from the Supreme Creator).

Rig Vedic Age:

Although the Rig Veda deals with devotional work of religious nature, yet it gives a vivid picture of the early Vedic civilization. The early Aryan civilisation is generally described as the Vedic Civilisation. It is said that the Rig-Vedic civilisation showed the zenith of Indian culture rather than its beginning. The Vedic Civilization is best understood from the a) political organisation, b) social life, c) economic life and d) religious beliefs.

Check your Progress – 1

1. Where was the original home of the Aryans?
2. Determine the date of the Vedas

3.4. Political Organisation during Rig Vedic Age

3.4.1. Administrative Divisions:

The lowest unit of the Rig-Vedic society was the patriarchal family. A number of families bound together by ties of blood formed a clan, several clans formed a district, and a number of districts composed a tribe, the highest political unit. From the Rig Veda we come to know about some administrative units termed as 'grama', 'vis', and the 'jana'.

The 'grama' consisted of several families. It was under a headman known as 'gramani'. During war or battle he used to lead the soldiers from his village. He attended the meetings of the 'Sabha' and 'Samiti'. Several villages formed a 'vis'. It was placed under a 'visapati'. He was a military leader.

A group of 'vishes' formed a 'jana'(tribe) whose members were bound together by real or supposed ties of kinship. 'Gopa' was the head of one 'jana'. Rig Veda mentions about various tribes such as Bharatas, Matsyas, Krivis, Tritsus. But the tribes which acquired great importance are the Purus, Trigwasas, Yadus, Aus and Drahyus. Several janas formed a 'janapada' or 'kingdom'. The 'Rajan' or the king was the head of the Janapada.

3.4.2. Form of Government:

Monarchy was the normal form of Government. Kingship was hereditary. But there was a sort of hierarchy in some states, several members of the royal family exercising the power in common. There were references of democratic form of government and their chiefs were elected by the assembled people.

3.4.3. The King:

The kingdom was small in extent. The king enjoyed a position of pre-eminence in the tribe. Kingship was hereditary. He was anointed by the priest as king in the 'Abhishka' Ceremony. He wore gorgeous robes and lived in a splendid palace, gaily decorated than a common building. The king had the duty to protect the life and property of his people. He was required to be 'Indra' in valour, 'Mitra' in kindness and 'varuna' in virtues.

The sacred duty of the king was the protection of the tribes and the territory and maintenance of priests for the performance of sacrifices. Maintenance of law and order was his principal duty. He maintained justice with the help of Purohitas. He collected tributes known as “Bali” in kind from his subjects.

3.4.4. Officials:

In the work of administration, the king was assisted by a number of functionaries like the Purohita (priest), the senani (general) the Gramani (village headman) and the spsa (spies). Purohita was the most important officer of the state.

3.4.5. The Army:

The army was mainly consisting of Patti (infantry) and Rathins (chariots). The weapons used by the soldiers were bows, arrows, swords, axes and spears. These weapons were made up of irons. The soldiers were organised into units known as Sardha, Vrata and gana.

3.4.6. Popular Assemblies:

The Rig Veda mentions the names of two popular assemblies known as Sabha and Samiti. Though the king enjoyed substantial power yet he was not an autocrat. In the work of administration, he consulted these two bodies and act according to their decision. Sabha was a select body of elders. The head of the sabha was known as ‘Sabhapati’.

The Sabha advised the king on administration. It also functioned as a court of law and tried the cases of criminals and punished them. The Samiti was the most popular assembly and included common people. The head of Samiti was known as ‘Pati’ The Samiti mainly dealt with the political business of the state. It also used to elect the king. In the early Vedic Age the Sabha and Samiti had a commendable role to play as the political organisation of the Aryans.

Check your Progress -2

1. Explain the position of king during early Vedic age.
2. What is the role of the Sabha and Samiti in Vedic administration?
3. Write a note on the officials of the king.

3.5. Social Life

3.5.1. Family:

The family was regarded as the social and political unit. It was the nucleus of the social life of the early Aryans. The father was the head of the family and he was known as “grihapati”. The Aryans had joint families. The father had great authority over the children. Though the father was kind and affectionate yet at times he became cruel towards his children. From Rig-Veda we come to know about a father who blinded his son for his extravagance.

3.5.2. Position of Women:

In the early Vedic age women enjoyed an honoured place in the society. The wife was the mistress of the household and authority over the slaves. In all religious ceremonies she participated with her husband. Prada system was not prevalent in the society. Sati system was also not prevalent in the Vedic society.

The education of girls was not neglected. The Rig-Veda mentions the names of some learned ladies like Viswavara, Apala and Ghosha who composed mantras and attained the rank of Rishis. The girls were married after attaining puberty. The practice of ‘Swayamvara’ was also prevalent in the society. Monogamy was the general Practice.

Polygamy was, of course, practiced and it was confined only to Kings and chiefs. Remarriage of widows was permitted. The women were not independent persons in the eye of the law. They had to remain under the protecting care of their male relations.

3.5.3. Dress and Ornaments:

The Aryans wore dresses made from cotton, wool and deer skin. The garments consisted of three parts—an undergarment called ‘nivi’, a garment called ‘Vasa’ or ‘Paridhan’ and a mantle known as ‘adhivasa’, ‘atka’ ‘dropi’. The garments were also embroidered with gold. Both men and women wore gold ornaments.

The women used ear-rings, neck-lace, bangles, anklets. These ornaments were sometimes studded with precious stones. Both men and women oiled and combed their hair which was plaited or braided. The men kept beard and moustache but sometimes also shaved them.

3.5.4. Food and Drink:

The Aryans ate both vegetable and animal foods. Rice, barley, bean and sesamum formed the staple food. They also ate bread, cake, milk, ghee, butter, and curd together with fruits. Fish, birds, goats, rams, bulls and horses were slaughtered for their food. Slaughter of cow was prohibited. They also drank intoxicating liquor, known as sura, a brandy made from corn and barley and the juice of soma plant.

3.5.5. Amusements:

Rig Vedic people spent their leisure time in various amusements like gambling, war—dancing, chariot racing, hunting, boxing, dancing and music. Women displayed their skill in dancing and music. Three types of musical instruments like percussion, string and wind were used by the singers.

3.5.6. Morality:

The morals of women were of high standard. But the standard of morality of men was not very praiseworthy. Polygamy was practiced by men. Great respect and affection was shown to guests. The people hated seduction and adultery. There was a class of women known as hetairai and dancing girls whose morality was probably not above reproach.

3.5.7. Education:

In the Rig-Vedic age great importance was given to education. There were Gurukulas which imparted education to the disciples after their sacred-thread ceremony. Entire instruction was given orally. The Vedic education aimed at proper development of mind and body. The disciples were taught about ethics, art of warfare, art of metal and concept of Brahma and philosophy, and basic sciences like agriculture, animal husbandry, and handicrafts.

3.5.8. Caste System:

In the early Vedic age there was no caste system. Member of same family took to different arts, crafts and trades. People could change their occupation according to their needs or talents. There was hardly any restriction in intermarriage, change of occupation. There, was no restriction on taking of food cooked by the sudras. A late hymn of the Rig-Veda known as Purushasukta

refers to four castes. But many scholars reject the theory that caste system existed in Rig Vedic age. According to them Purushasukta is a late hymn and caste system was never rigid and hereditary.

Check your Progress – 3

1. Elucidate the position of women in Vedic period
2. Give an account of food, drink, dress, ornaments, and amusements of Vedic people
3. Write about the morality and education during Vedic times
4. Write a note on the caste system during Vedic period

3.6. Economic Life:

3.6.1. The Village:

In the Rig Vedic Age people lived in villages. The houses were made of wood and bamboo. They had thatched roof and clay floors. The hymns of Rig-Veda refer to Pura. It seems that Puras were fortified places and served as places of refuge during danger of invasion.

There was absence of word nagara (city) in the hymns of Rig-Veda. Gramani was the chief of the village. He looked after the affairs of the village, both civil and military. There was another officer known as Vrajapati who led Kulapas or heads of families to battle.

3.6.2. Agriculture:

Reference in Rig-Veda shows, that agriculture was the principal occupation of the people. They ploughed the field by means of a pair of oxen. Rig-Veda even mentions that twenty-four oxen were attached to a plough share at the same time to plough the land. The ploughed land was known as Urvara or Kshetra. Water was supplied into the fields by means of irrigation canal. Use of manure was known to them. Barley and wheat were mainly cultivated. Cotton and oil seeds were also grown. Rice was perhaps not extensively cultivated. Agriculture was their main source of income.

3.6.3. Domestication of animals:

Besides agriculture, cattle breeding were another means of living. There are prayers in the Vedas for Gosu (cattle). Cows were held in great respect. Cows were symbols of wealth and prosperity of the Aryans. Sometimes cow was the medium of exchange. The Aryans had also domesticated animals like horse, draught OX, dog, goat, sheep, buffalo and donkey.

3.6.4. Occupation:

Apart from agriculture and animal husbandry Aryans had also other occupation. Weaving was the most important occupation. We learnt about weavers of wool and cotton together with the workers in the subsidiary industries of dying and embroidery. The carpenters built houses, chariots, wagons and supplied household utensils and furniture.

Then there were blacksmiths who supplied various necessities of life, from fine needles and razors to the sickles, ploughshares, spears and swords. The gold smiths made ornaments like ear-rings, bangles, necklaces, bands etc. The leather-workers made bow-strings and casks for holding liquor. The physicians cured diseases. The priests performed sacrifices and composed hymns and taught them to the disciples.

3.6.5. Trade and Commerce:

There were trade and maritime activity. Sometimes traders made journey to distant lands for larger profits in trade. There was probably commercial intercourse with Babylon and other countries in Western Asia. The principal media of trade was barter. Cow was used as unit of value. Gradually pieces of gold called "Nishka" were used as means of exchange. Trade and commerce were regulated and managed by a group of people called "Pani".

3.6.6. Transport and Communication:

The chief means of transport by land were rathas (Chariots) and wagons drawn by horses and oxen. Riding on horseback was also in vogue. Travelling was common though roads were haunted by taskara (highway men) and forests were infested by wild animals.

Check your Progress – 4

1. Write a note on the agriculture and domestication of animals during early Vedic period
2. Give an account of different occupations of the early Vedic people
3. What is Nishka?
4. What is the mode of transport for the early Vedic people.

3.7. Religious Life and Philosophy:

The religious life of the Aryans was simple and plain. They worshipped various manifestations of nature such as the sun, the moon, the sky, the Dawn, the thunder, the wind and the Air. Vedic hymns were composed in praise of nature. Rigveda mentions that thirty-three gods and goddesses were worshipped by the Aryans.

These divinities were placed under three categories namely:

- (1) the terrestrial gods such as Prithvi, Agni, Brihaspati (Prayer), and Soma,
- (2) The atmospheric gods, such as, Indra, Rudra (Probably lightning), Maruts, Vayu (wind) and Parjanya and
- (3) celestial gods such as Dyaus (the sky), Varuna (vault of Heaven), Ushas (dawn), Asvins (probably twilight and morning stars) and Surya, Mitra, Savitri and Vishnu all associated with the most glorious phenomenon of nature, viz., the sun.

Among the vedic gods, Indra occupied the chief place, was given the largest number of hymns—about one fourth of the total number of hymns in the Rig Veda Samhita. He was also known as Purandara and the destroyer of forts. He was also the god of rain. Varuna was regarded as the god of truth and moral order. He was conceived as the omniscient ruler of the cosmic waters. Maruta was the god of storm. He helped Indra in scattering away the demons. Usha was the goddess of dawn.

Prithvi was regarded as the goddess of grain and of procreation. Agni was second in importance only to Indra. He acted as the coordinator among all deities. He conveyed to the gods the oblations offered by the devotees. He received special homage by the people as no

sacrifice could be performed without offering to him. Vishnu was worshipped as the god of three worlds. Surya was regarded as the destroyer of darkness. Apart from these deities, others like Savitri, Saraswati, Brihaspati and Prajnya were also worshipped.

Mode of Worship:

The mode of worship was simple. The Vedic worship meant primarily only oblation and prayer. A great value was attached to the hymns. The Aryans chanted hymns to appease the various divinities. Yajna or sacrifice was another mode to appease the gods and goddesses. They offered milk, ghee, grains, wine, fruits etc. as offering into fire.

Animals like horses, buffaloes, rams, bulls, and even cows were also sometimes sacrificed. The process of sacrifice was simple. Every Aryan family took part in the offering of prayers and performing of fire-sacrifice. There was no priestly class for performing these religious sites. No shrine or temple was built. Image worship was unknown in those days.

The theory of reincarnation or rebirth was not completely formed. The Rig Vedic hymns had no consistent theory regarding life after death. The Rig Vedic idea of life after death was very vague. The soul departed to "Land of fathers", pitralok was received by Yama and rewarded or punished according to its deeds. So, the conception of rebirth was there.

The doctrine of transmigration of soul was not properly developed. In spite of worshipping various deities the Vedic age saw the prevalence of monotheism. The hymns of Rig-Veda, Mandal x, 82 express the belief that God is one although. He bears many names. The idea of single supreme power governing and controlling the universe seems to have emerged. The spiritual life of Vedic Aryans was simple. They worshipped nature through prayer and sacrifice which later on formed the basis of Hindu religion.

Check your Progress -5

1. Describe the religion and philosophy of the early Vedic people
2. Write a note on the mode of worship of the Aryans

3.8. Later Vedic Age

The period that followed Rig Vedic Age is known as Later Vedic Age.

This age witnessed the composition of three later Veda Samhitas namely, the Samveda Samhita, the Yajurveda Samhita, the Atharvaveda Samhita as well as Brahmanas and the Upanishads of all the four Vedas and later on the two great epics—the Ramayana and the Mahabharata.

All these later Vedic texts were compiled in the Upper Gangetic basin in 1000—600 B.C. During the period represented by Later Samhitas the Aryans covered the whole of Northern India, from the Himalayas to the Vindhya.

“The Aryans of Vedic age had reached the highest stage of civilization. This age had excelled in every walks of life. All the valuable things in man’s life—philosophy, religion, science and code of conduct were all developed in the Vedic age.”

The spread of Aryans over the whole of India completed before 400 B.C. Of the new kingdoms in the east, the most important were Kurus, Panchalas, Kasis, Kosalas and Videhas.

Gradually the Aryans moved towards South India. It is believed that their southern movement began during the period of Brahmana literature, about 1000 B.C. and went on steadily till they reached the southernmost extremity of the Peninsula in or sometime before fourth century B.C.

The great grammarian Katyana who flourished in the fourth century B.C. had knowledge about the countries of south such as Pandya, Chola and Kerala. But the Aryan colonization in the South was not as complete as in the north. With the progress of the Aryans in Northern India, their centre of civilization was shifted towards east. The territory between Saraswati and Ganga was the seat of Aryan civilization.

3.9. Political Organisation:

3.9.1. Rise of Big States:

With the progress of Aryan settlements in the eastern and southern part of India, the small tribal states of Rig Vedic period replaced by powerful states. Many famous tribes of Rig

Vedic period like Bharatas, Parus, Tritsus and Turvasas passed into oblivion and new tribes like the Kurus and Panchalas rose into prominence. The land of the Yamuna and Ganga in the east which became the new home of the Aryans rose into prominence.

3.9.2. Growth of Imperialism:

With the emergence of big kingdoms in the Later Vedic Age the struggle for supremacy among different states was of frequent occurrence. The ideal of Sarbabhauma or universal empire loomed large in the political horizon of ancient India. The sacrifices like Rajasuya and Asvamedha were performed to signify the imperial sway of monarchs over the rivals. These rituals impressed the people with the increasing power and prestige of the king. The Rig Vedic title of “Rajan” was replaced by the impressive titles like Samrat, Ektrat, Virat, Bhoja etc. These titles marked the growth of imperialism and feudal ideas.

3.9.3. Origin of Kingship:

There were two theories regarding the origin of kingship. The Aitareya Brahmana explained the rational theory of election by common consent of origin of kingship. Side by side the Taittiriya Brahman explained the divine origin of kingship. It explained how Indra, “though occupying a low rank among the gods, was created their king by Prajapati.”

3.9.4. Growth of Royal Power:

The king had absolute power. He became the master of all subjects. He realized taxes like “bali”, “sulka” and “bhaga”. The Satapatha Brahmana described the king to be infallible and immune from all punishment. The sabha of the Rig Vedic Period died. The king sought the aid and support of the Samiti on matters like war, peace and fiscal policies. There are references to the Samiti sometimes electing or re-electing a king.

The authority of the government in the later Vedic period was perhaps more democratic in the sense that the authority of the leaders of Aryan tribes was recognized by the king. However in spite of the existence of the popular assemblies the powers of the king went on increasing due to the growth of large territorial states and the evolution of an official hierarchy.

3.9.5. Administrative Machinery:

The growth of the royal power was largely reflected in the enlarged entourage of the king. In the work of administration, the king was assisted by a group of officers who were known as Ratnins (Jewels). They included the Bhagadugha (collector of taxes), the Suta (charioteer), the Akshavapa (superintendent of gambling), the kshattri (chamberlain), the Govikartana (king's companion in the chase), the Palogala (courtier) the Takshan (Carpenter), the Rathakara (Chariot marker) in addition to the ecclesiastical and military officials like the Purohita (chaplain) the senani (general), and the Gramani (leader of host or of the village).

In the Later Vedic Period Gramani was both a civil and military officer. Gramani was the medium through which the royal power was exercised in the village. According to the Upanishads, Adhikrita was the village officer and was lowest in the rank. The king administered justice. Occasionally he delegated his judicial power to Adhyakshas. In the villages, Gramyavadin (Village judge) and Sabha (court) decided the cases. Punishments for crimes were severe.

The father was the head of the property of the family. In case of inheritance of property the law of primogeniture was applied. By this rule the eldest son would inherit the property of the deceased father. Neither the women nor the sudras had any right to property.

3.10. Social Condition:

Changes of far greater significance were gradually taking place in their society.

3.10.1. Caste System:

Most important change was the evolution of caste system. Aryanization promoted social differentiation. In the later Vedic texts the term arya encapsulates brahmana, Kshatriya, vaishya, and shudra. Thus, it was the Vedic Aryans who introduced the Varna system. The later Vedic society came to be divided into four varnas called the brahmana, rajanya or Kshatriya, vaishya, and shudra. The growing cult of sacrifices enormously added to the power of the brahmanas. Initially the brahmanas were only one of the sixteen classes of priests, but they gradually overshadowed the other priestly groups and emerged as the most important class.

Various sub castes evolved in addition to the traditional four-castes. The Brahmanas and Kshatriyas emerged as the two leading castes out of the general mass of population, known as vaisyas. The vaisyas were superior to the sudras but their position was steadily deteriorating. The Aitaraya Brahmana clearly indicates the absolute dependence of vaisyas on the two higher classes. The Sudras were held in great contempt.

The Brahmanas of the later Vedic age were the intellectual and priestly class. The Brahmanas retained a high standard of excellence and knew the details of the rituals. The kshatriyas were the fighting class in the society. War, conquest, administration of the kingdom was the principal duties of this class. By their superior learning some kshatriyas raised themselves to the status of a Brahmana. They composed hymns and performed sacrifices and also challenged the supremacy of Brahmanas.

Two Kshatriya kings Janak and Viswamitra attained the status of Rishi. For a long time the kshatriyas resisted the supremacy of the Brahmanas and claimed that the priest was only a follower of the king. Vaisyas were engaged in trade, industry and agriculture, and animal husbandry. They are debarred from the privileges which were enjoyed by the Brahmanas and kshatriyas. However the richer people among the vaisyas known as Sresthin were highly honored in the royal court.

The condition of the Sudras was very miserable. They had to serve the other three castes. They were untouchables. They had no right to approach the sacred fire, i.e., perform sacrifice, or to read the sacred texts. They were further denied the rite of burning the dead body. The structure of the caste system became hereditary.

3.10.2. Social Organization:

The rise of the brahmanas is a peculiar development that did not occur in Aryan societies outside India. It appears that non-Aryan elements had some role to play in the formation of the brahmana Varna. They conducted rituals and sacrifices for their clients and for themselves, and also officiated at the festivals associated with agricultural operations.

They prayed for the success of their patron in war, and, in return, the king pledged not to do anything to harm them. Sometimes the brahmanas came into conflict with the rajanyas,

who represented the order of the warrior nobles, for positions of supremacy. However, whenever the two upper orders had to deal with the lower orders, they put aside their differences. From the end of the later Vedic period onwards, it began to be emphasized that the two upper orders should cooperate to rule over the rest of society.

The vaishyas constituted the common people, and they were assigned producing functions such as agriculture, cattle-breeding, and the like; some of them also worked as artisans. Towards the end of the Vedic period they began to engage in trade. The vaishyas appear to have been the only tribute payers in later Vedic times, and the brahmanas and kshatriyas are represented as living on the tributes collected from the vaishyas.

The process of subjugating the mass of the tribesmen to the position of tribute payers was long and protracted. Several rituals were prescribed for making the refractory elements (vis or vaishya) submissive to the prince (raja) and to his close kinsmen called the rajanyas. This was achieved with the assistance of the priests who also fattened themselves at the cost of the people or the vaishyas.

All the three higher varnas shared one common feature: they were entitled to upanayana or investiture with the sacred thread according to the Vedic mantras. Upanayana heralded the beginning of education in the Vedas. The fourth Varna was deprived of the sacred thread ceremony and the recitation of the gayatri mantra.

The gayatri was a Vedic mantra that could not be recited by a shudra, thereby depriving him of Vedic education. Similarly, women were also denied both the gayatri and upanayana. Thus, the imposition of disabilities on the shudras and women began towards the end of the Vedic period.

The prince, who represented the rajanya order, sought to assert his authority over all the three other varnas. The Aitareya Brahmana, a text of the later Vedic period, represents the brahmana as a seeker of livelihood and an acceptor of gifts from the prince but also removable by him. A vaishya is called tribute-paying, meant to be beaten and oppressed at will. The worst position is reserved for the shudra. He is called the servant of another, to be made to work at will by another, and to be beaten at will.

Generally, the later Vedic texts draw a line of demarcation between the three higher orders, on the one hand, and the shudras, on the other. Nevertheless, several public rituals associated with the coronation of the king in which the shudras participated, were presumably survivors of the original Aryan community.

Certain sections of artisans, such as the rathakara or chariot maker, enjoyed a high status and were entitled to the sacred thread ceremony. Thus, in later Vedic times, Varna distinctions had not advanced very far.

The family shows the increasing power of the father, who could even disinherit his son. In princely families, the right of primogeniture was getting stronger. Male ancestors came to be worshipped. Women were generally given a lower position. Although some women theologians took part in philosophical discussions and some queens participated in coronation rituals, ordinarily women were thought to be inferior and subordinate to men.

The institution of gotra appeared in later Vedic times. Literally, it means the cow pen or the place where cattle belonging to the entire clan are kept, but in course of time, it signified a descent from a common ancestor. People began to practise gotra exogamy. No marriage could take place between persons belonging to the same gotra or having the same lineage.

Ashramas or the four stages of life were not well established in Vedic times. The post-Vedic texts speak of four ashramas: that of brahmachari or student, grihastha or householder, vanaprastha or hermit, and sannyasin or ascetic who completely renounced the worldly life. Only the first three are clearly defined in the later Vedic texts; the last or the fourth stage was not well established, though ascetic life was not unknown. Even in post-Vedic times, only the stage of the householder was commonly practised by all the varnas.

3.10.3. Education:

A vast mass of Vedic literature as well as a highly developed intellectual life speaks abundantly about a well-planned system of education in the later Vedic Period. The students had to learn Vedas, Upanishad, grammar prosody, law, arithmetic and language.

After the Upanayana or sacred thread ceremony and initiation to studies the students were sent to the Gurukula for their education. They had to live in the house of the teacher

(guru) and lead the chaste life of a Brahmacharin whose principal duties were study and service to the teacher. The students received free boarding and lodging at the house of the Guru. At the completion of their study they paid fees (guru-dakshina) to the teachers.

3.10.4. Position of women:

The women lost their high position which they had in the Rig Vedic Age. They were deprived of their right to the Upanayana ceremony and all their sacraments, excluding marriage, were performed without recitation of Vedic mantras. Polygamy prevailed in the society. Many of the religious ceremonies, formerly practiced by the wife, were now performed by the priests. She was not allowed to attend the political assemblies. Birth of a daughter became undesirable—for she was regarded as a source of misery. The custom of child marriage and dowry crept in. The women lost their honored position in the society.

3.10.5. Food and Dress:

In the later Vedic age rice became staple food of the people. Gradually the practice of eating meat was declined. Killing of cow was looked with disfavor. Wool was used in addition to cotton.

3.11. Economic Condition:

Like political and social conditions, the economic condition of the Aryans of the later Vedic period also underwent significant changes. Due to the emergence of caste system various occupations also appeared.

3.11.1. Agriculture:

The Aryans of the later Vedic period lived in the villages. In the villages small peasant owners of land were replaced by big landlords who secured possession of entire villages. Agriculture was the principal occupation of the people. Improved method of tilling the land by deep ploughing, manuring and sowing with better seeds were known to the Aryans. More lands were brought under cultivation.

The cultivator yielded two harvests a year. Varieties of crops like rice, barley, wheat, maize and oil seeds were raised. But the cultivator was not free from trouble. Dangers of insects and damage of crops through hail-storm very badly affected the land of kurus and compelled many people to migrate.

3.11.2. Trade and Commerce:

With the growth of civilization, the volume of trade and commerce had increased by leaps and bounds. Both inland and overseas trades were developed. Inland trade was carried on with the Kiratas inhabiting the mountains. They exchanged the herbs for clothes, nattresses and skins. The people became familiar with the navigation of the seas. Regular coinage was not started.

The coins which were in circulation were “Nishka”, “Satamana” and “Krishnala”. The unit value of goods was a gold bar called “nishka” weighing three hundred and twenty ratis, which was also the weight of a satamana. A ‘Krishnala’ weighed one rati, i.e. 1.8 grams. There was a class of merchants called ‘Pani’ who controlled the trade. References to “ganas” or corporations and the “sreshthins” clearly speak of the formation of guilds or corporations for facilitating trade and commerce. Usuary and money lending was also practiced in this period.

3.11.3. Occupation:

The emergence of caste system brought varieties of means of livelihood. There are references about money lenders, chariot makers, dyers, weavers, barbers, goldsmiths, iron smiths, washer men, bow makers, carpenters, musicians etc. The art of writing probably developed in this period. The use of silver was increased and ornaments were made out of it.

3.11.4. House Building and Transport:

The house had many rooms with a special place for ‘Grahapatha’ fire which was kept continuously burning. Houses were made of wood. The TaittiriyaAranyakas refer about a special type of house known as ‘Dhandhani’ (treasure house). The Atharvaveda mentions about ‘PatninamSadana’ (women’s apartment).

The means of transport and communication developed with the growth of trade and commerce. Regarding means of transport mention may be made of wagons drawn by oxen, chariots for war and sport and rough vehicle known as 'bipatha' for transport of goods. Elephants and horses were also used. Ships and boats were also used as means of transport.

3.12. Religious Condition:

During the later Vedic period the religious spirit underwent a great change. Religion was overshadowed with rites and rituals. New gods and goddesses emerged during this period.

3.12.1. New Gods:

The Rig Vedic gods, Varun, Indra, Agni, Surya, Usha etc. lost their charm. The people worshipped them with less zeal. New gods like Siva, Rupa, Vishnu, Brahma etc. appeared in the religious firmament of the Later Vedic Period. The grandeur of the Rigvedic gods passed into oblivion, though we find in Atharvaveda the omniscience of Varuna or the beneficence of the Earth goddess.

Certain less important duties of the Rigvedic Period now became popular with the Common People. One of them was Rudra who already bore the epithet of Siva. Very soon Rudra came to be worshipped as 'Mahadeva' (great god) and the lord of animate beings (Pasupati).

Vishnu, the preserver rose into Prominence during this period. He occupied the place of Varuna, as the most sublime among the celestials. To attain his "Paramapada" (highest step) became the goal of the rishis. The worship of vasudeva was also started. He was regarded as Krishna Vasudev, the incarnation of Vishnu. Semi divinities like Apsara, Nagas, Gandharbas, Vidyadharas etc. also came into being. This age also witnessed the beginning of the worship of Durga and Ganesh.

3.12.2. Rituals and Sacrifices:

During this period the rites and ceremonies of Vedic religion were elaborated and became complex. In the Rig Vedic age Yanjas were a simple affair which every householder could do. But in the later Vedic age sacrifice became an important thing in worship. Now the priestly class devoted their energy to find out the hidden and mystic meaning of the rites and ceremonies.

People had a firm belief that gods must submit to the sacrifice if properly performed. Vedic hymns were regarded as charms to be used in sacrifice. The belief that gods were satisfied by Yanjas led to a rise in the number, variety of sacrifices which were prescribed for every householder. In fact every Aryan performed a number of sacrifices under the supervision of the Brahmana priest.

3.12.3. Morality and Duty:

The Later Vedic Period prescribed a code of righteous conduct. The Brahmins had spread the belief that, “man is born with certain runas or debts” which he must repay in his life. He has to repay the debts to his gods, to the rishis, to the munis, to men, to the ancestors and to the lower creatures. And he redeems himself from these debts, if he worships the gods and performs Yajnas study Vedas, performs funeral ceremonies and Sraddha, etc. One should perform all these duties with selflessness. The first requisite of a good life were prayers and good works. One should restrain himself from the sins like theft, adultery, and murder.

3.12.4. Religious Philosophy:

The Later Vedic age witnessed the emergence of a new intellectual thought. The people thought deeply about the problems of creation, life and death and arrived at the conclusion that there is one ‘Brahma’ (one Unchanging Principle) beyond the universe—the creator and controller of the whole order.

It is the universal soul or the Absolute “that dwelleth in everything that guideth all beings within, the Inward guide, Immortal.” After the death of a person his soul passes into another body and again into another and this process continues till it can be liberated from all its imperfections and merged in the Universal Soul. This is the doctrine of transmigration of souls.

The Aryans had also faith in the doctrine of Karma. It lays down that all actions, good or bad, reap their proper fruits. Souls have to be born again and again and bear the fruits of the actions (Karma) of their previous lives. There is also doctrine of ‘Moksha’. It is a state of birthlessness and deathlessness at a point when a soul is liberated from the cycle of births and deaths and mingled into the universal soul.” It was essential for a man to attain moksha. All these are embodied in the Upanishad which were composed in the Later Vedic Period.

3.12.5. Ascetic Life:

The later Vedic Aryans developed the concept of ascetic ideal of life as the rites and ceremonies were not the only means of attaining success in this world or bliss in heaven. So there developed the ideas of Tapas and Brahmacharya (celibacy) leading to the same or even more important results. Tapa means meditation, accompanying by physical tortures.

An ascetic person renounced the worldly life and retired to the solitude and exercised all the ascetic practices with the belief that they would not only obtain heaven, but also develop, “mystic, extra-ordinary and superhuman faculties.” This asceticism was widely practiced in the Epic age.

3.13. Science

The first recorded forms of Ayurveda as medical texts evolved from the Vedas. Ayurveda is a discipline of the upaveda or “auxiliary knowledge” in Vedic tradition. The origins of Ayurveda are also found in Atharvaveda, which contains 114 hymns and incantations described as magical cures for disease. There are various legendary accounts of the origin of Ayurveda, e.g. that it was received by Dhanvantari (or Divodasa) from Brahma. Tradition also holds that the writings of Ayurveda were influenced by a lost text by the sage Agnivesa.

Some cosmological concepts are present in the Vedas, as are notions of the movement of heavenly bodies and the course of the year. As in other traditions, there is a close association of astronomy and religion during the early history of the science, astronomical observation being necessitated by spatial and temporal requirements of correct performance of religious ritual. Thus, the Shulba Sutras, texts dedicated to Altar construction, discusses advanced mathematics and basic astronomy. VedangaJyotishadated to 1400–1200 BCE is another of the earliest known Indian texts on astronomy, it includes the details about the sun, moon, stars, lunisolar calendar. VedangaJyotishadetails several astronomical attributes generally applied for timing social and religious events. The VedāngaJyoticha also details astronomical calculations, calendrical studies, and establishes rules for empirical observation. Since the texts written by 1200 BCE were largely religious compositions the VedāngaJyoticha has connections with Indian astrology and details several important aspects

of the time and seasons, including lunar months, solar months, and their adjustment by a lunar leap month of *Adhikamāsa*. Ritus are also described as ((yugams)). Tripathi holds that ‘Twenty-seven constellations, eclipses, seven planets, and twelve signs of the zodiac were also known at that time.’

The religious texts of the Vedic Period provide evidence for the use of large numbers. By the time of the *YajurvedasaChitā*- (1200–900 BCE), numbers as high as 10^{12} were being included in the texts. The solution to partial fraction was known to the Rigvedic People as states in the *Purusha Sukta*.

The Aryans of Vedic age had reached the highest stage of civilization. This age had excelled in every walks of life. All the valuable things in man’s life—philosophy, religion, science and code of conduct were all developed in the Vedic age.

Check your Progress – 6

1. Write a note on the social and cultural conditions during later Vedic period
2. Explain about the concept of science during Vedic age

Answers to Check your Progress

Check your Progress –1

1. See Sections 3.2.- 3.2.4.
2. See Section 3.3.1.

Check your Progress –2

1. See Section 4.4.3
2. See Section4.4.4
3. See Section 4.4.6.

Check your Progress –3

1. **See Section 3.5.2.**
2. **See Sections 3.5.3 – 3.5.5.**
3. **See Sections 3.5.6. – 3.5.7.**
4. **See Section 3.5.8.**

Check your Progress –4

1. See Sections 3.6.2 – 3.6.3
2. See Section 3.6.4.
3. See Section 3.6.5.
4. See Section 3.6.6.

LESSON - 4

SOCIAL AND CULTURAL LIFE OF LATER VEDIC PERIOD

Learning Objectives

After learning this lesson, you will be able to

- Understand the Political Organisation and Growth of Imperialism
- Comprehend the Social, Economic and religious conditions

Structure

4.1 Introduction

4.2 Later Vedic Age

4.3 Political Organisation

4.3.1. Rise of Big States

4.3.2. Growth of Imperialism

4.3.3. Origin of Kingship

4.3.4. Growth of Royal Power

4.3.5. Administrative Machinery

4.4 Social Condition

4.4.1. Caste System

4.4.2. Social Organization

4.4.3. Education

4.4.4. Position of women

4.4.5. Food and Dress:

4.5 Economic Condition

4.5.1. Agriculture

4.5.2. Trade and Commerce

4.5.3. Occupation

4.5.4. House Building and Transport

4.6 Religious Condition

4.6.1. New Gods

4.6.2. Rituals and Sacrifices

4.6.3. Morality and Duty

4.6.4. Religious Philosophy

4.6.5. Ascetic Life

4.7 Science

4.1 Introduction

The period between B.C. 1000 and B.C. 600 is generally known as Later Vedic period. This age is also called as the Epic Age because the two great epics Ramayana and Mahabharata were written during this period. The Aryans during this period moved to the Gangetic Valley.

Sources

The Sama, Yajur, Atharva Vedas, Brahmanas, Upanishads, Aranyakas and the two epics are the sources of information for this period.

4.2. Later Vedic Age

The period that followed Rig Vedic Age is known as Later Vedic Age.

This age witnessed the composition of three later Veda Samhitas namely, the Samaveda Samhita, the Yajurveda Samhita, the Atharvaveda Samhita as well as Brahmanas and the Upanishads of all the four Vedas and later on the two great epics—the Ramayana and the Mahabharata.

All these later Vedic texts were compiled in the Upper Gangetic basin in 1000—600 B.C. During the period represented by Later Samhitas the Aryans covered the whole of Northern India, from the Himalayas to the Vindhya.

“The Aryans of Vedic age had reached the highest stage of civilization. This age had excelled in every walks of life. All the valuable things in man’s life—philosophy, religion, science and code of conduct were all developed in the Vedic age.”

The spread of Aryans over the whole of India completed before 400 B.C. Of the new kingdoms in the east, the most important were Kurus, Panchalas, Kasis, Kosalas and Videhas.

Gradually the Aryans moved towards South India. It is believed that their southern movement began during the period of Brahmana literature, about 1000 B.C. and went on steadily till they reached the southernmost extremity of the Peninsula in or sometime before fourth century B.C.

The great grammarian Katya Yana who flourished in the fourth century B.C had knowledge about the countries of south such as Pandya, Chola and Kerala. But the Aryan colonization in the South was not as complete as in the north. With the progress of the Aryans in Northern India, their centre of civilization was shifted towards east. The territory between Saraswati and Ganga was the seat of Aryan civilization.

4.3. Political Organisation:

4.3.1. Rise of Big States:

With the progress of Aryan settlements in the eastern and southern part of India, the small tribal states of Rig Vedic period replaced by powerful states. Many famous tribes of Rig Vedic period like Bharatas, Parus, Tritsus and Turvasas passed into oblivion and new tribes like the Kurus and Panchalas rose into prominence. The land of the Yamuna and Ganga in the east which became the new home of the Aryans rose into prominence.

4.3.2. Growth of Imperialism:

With the emergence of big kingdoms in the Later Vedic Age the struggle for supremacy among different states was of frequent occurrence. The ideal of Sarbabhauma or universal empire loomed large in the political horizon of ancient India. The sacrifices like Rajasuya and Asvamedha were performed to signify the imperial sway of monarchs over the rivals. These

rituals impressed the people with the increasing power and prestige of the king. The Rig Vedic title of “Rajan” was replaced by the impressive titles like Samrat, Ekkrat, Virat, Bhoja etc. These titles marked the growth of imperialism and feudal ideas.

4.3.3. Origin of Kingship:

There were two theories regarding the origin of kingship. The Aitareya Brahmana explained the rational theory of election by common consent of origin of kingship. Side by side the Taittiriya Brahman explained the divine origin of kingship. It explained how Indra, “though occupying a low rank among the gods, was created their king by Prajapati.”

4.3.4. Growth of Royal Power:

The king had absolute power. He became the master of all subjects. He realized taxes like “bali”, “sulka” and “bhaga”. The Satapatha Brahmana described the king to be infallible and immune from all punishment. The sabha of the Rig Vedic Period died. The king sought the aid and support of the Samiti on matters like war, peace and fiscal policies. There are references to the Samiti sometimes electing or re-electing a king.

The authority of the government in the later Vedic period was perhaps more democratic in the sense that the authority of the leaders of Aryan tribes was recognized by the king. However in spite of the existence of the popular assemblies the powers of the king went on increasing due to the growth of large territorial states and the evolution of an official hierarchy.

4.3.5. Administrative Machinery:

The growth of the royal power was largely reflected in the enlarged outrage of the king. In the work of administration, the king was assisted by a group of officers who were known as Ratnins (Jewels). They included the Bhagadugha (collector of taxes), the Suta (charioteer), the Akshavapa (superintendent of gambling), the kshattri (chamberlain), the Govikartana (king’s companion in the chase), the Palogala (courtier) the Takshan (Carpenter), the Rathakara (Chariot marker) in addition to the ecclesiastical and military officials like the Purohita (chaplain) the senani (general), and the Gramani (leader of host or of the village).

In the Later Vedic Period Gramani was both a civil and military officer. Gramani was the medium through which the royal power was exercised in the village. According to the *Frashna Upanishad*, Adhikrita was the village officer and was lowest in the rank. The king administered justice. Occasionally he delegated his judicial power to Adhyakshas. In the villages, Gramyavadin (Village judge) and Sabha (court) decided the cases. Punishments for crimes were severe.

The father was the head of the property of the family. In case of inheritance of property the law of primogeniture was applied. By this rule the eldest son would inherit the property of the deceased father. Neither the women nor the sudras had any right to property.

4.4. Social Condition:

Changes of far greater significance were gradually taking place in their society.

4.4.1. Caste System:

Most important change was the evolution of caste system. Aryanization promoted social differentiation. In the later Vedic texts the term *arya* encapsulates *brahmana*, *Kshatriya*, *vaishya*, and *shudra*. Thus, it was the Vedic Aryans who introduced the Varna system. The later Vedic society came to be divided into four varnas called the *brahmana*, *rajanya* or *Kshatriya*, *vaishya*, and *shudra*. The growing cult of sacrifices enormously added to the power of the *brahmanas*. Initially the *brahmanas* were only one of the sixteen classes of priests, but they gradually overshadowed the other priestly groups and emerged as the most important class.

Various sub castes evolved in addition to the traditional four-castes. The *Brahmanas* and *Kshatriyas* emerged as the two leading castes out of the general mass of population, known as *vaisyas*. The *vaisyas* were superior to the *sudras* but their position was steadily deteriorating. The *Aitaraya Brahmana* clearly indicates the absolute dependence of *vaisyas* on the two higher classes. The *Sudras* were held in great contempt.

The *Brahmanas* of the later Vedic age were the intellectual and priestly class. The *Brahmanas* retained a high standard of excellence and knew the details of the rituals. The *kshatriyas* were the fighting class in the society. War, conquest, administration of the kingdom

was the principal duties of this class. By their superior learning some kshatriyas raised themselves to the status of a Brahmana. They composed hymns and performed sacrifices and also challenged the supremacy of Brahmanas.

Two Kshatriya kings Janak and Viswamitra attained the status of Rishi. For a long time, the kshatriyas resisted the supremacy of the Brahmanas and claimed that the priest was only a follower of the king. Vaisyas were engaged in trade, industry and agriculture, and animal husbandry. They are debarred from the privileges which were enjoyed by the Brahmanas and kshatriyas. However, the richer people among the vaisyas known as Sresthin were highly honored in the royal court.

The condition of the Sudras was very miserable. They had to serve the other three castes. They were untouchables. They had no right to approach the sacred fire, i.e., perform sacrifice, or to read the sacred texts. They were further denied the rite of burning the dead body. The structure of the caste system became hereditary.

4.4.2. Social Organization:

The rise of the brahmanas is a peculiar development that did not occur in Aryan societies outside India. It appears that non-Aryan elements had some role to play in the formation of the brahmana Varna. They conducted rituals and sacrifices for their clients and for themselves, and also officiated at the festivals associated with agricultural operations.

They prayed for the success of their patron in war, and, in return, the king pledged not to do anything to harm them. Sometimes the brahmanas came into conflict with the rajanyas, who represented the order of the warrior nobles, for positions of supremacy. However, whenever the two upper orders had to deal with the lower orders, they put aside their differences. From the end of the later Vedic period onwards, it began to be emphasized that the two upper orders should cooperate to rule over the rest of society.

The vaishyas constituted the common people, and they were assigned producing functions such as agriculture, cattle-breeding, and the like; some of them also worked as artisans. Towards the end of the Vedic period they began to engage in trade. The vaishyas appear to have been

the only tribute payers in later Vedic times, and the brahmanas and kshatriyas are represented as living on the tributes collected from the vaishyas.

The process of subjugating the mass of the tribesmen to the position of tribute payers was long and protracted. Several rituals were prescribed for making the refractory elements (vis or vaishya) submissive to the prince (raja) and to his close kinsmen called the rajanyas. This was achieved with the assistance of the priests who also fattened themselves at the cost of the people or the vaishyas.

All the three higher varnas shared one common feature: they were entitled to upanayana or investiture with the sacred thread according to the Vedic mantras. Upanayana heralded the beginning of education in the Vedas. The fourth Varna was deprived of the sacred thread ceremony and the recitation of the gayatri mantra.

The gayatri was a Vedic mantra that could not be recited by a shudra, thereby depriving him of Vedic education. Similarly, women were also denied both the gayatri and upanayana. Thus, the imposition of disabilities on the shudras and women began towards the end of the Vedic period.

The prince, who represented the rajanya order, sought to assert his authority over all the three other varnas. The Aitareya Brahmana, a text of the later Vedic period, represents the brahmana as a seeker of livelihood and an acceptor of gifts from the prince but also removable by him. A vaishya is called tribute-paying, meant to be beaten and oppressed at will. The worst position is reserved for the shudra. He is called the servant of another, to be made to work at will by another, and to be beaten at will.

Generally, the later Vedic texts draw a line of demarcation between the three higher orders, on the one hand, and the shudras, on the other. Nevertheless, several public rituals associated with the coronation of the king in which the shudras participated, were presumably survivors of the original Aryan community.

Certain sections of artisans, such as the rathakara or chariot maker, enjoyed a high status and were entitled to the sacred thread ceremony. Thus, in later Vedic times, Varna distinctions had not advanced very far.

The family shows the increasing power of the father, who could even disinherit his son. In princely families, the right of primogeniture was getting stronger. Male ancestors came to be worshipped. Women were generally given a lower position. Although some women theologians took part in philosophical discussions and some queens participated in coronation rituals, ordinarily women were thought to be inferior and subordinate to men.

The institution of gotra appeared in later Vedic times. Literally, it means the cow pen or the place where cattle belonging to the entire clan are kept, but in course of time, it signified a descent from a common ancestor. People began to practise gotra exogamy. No marriage could take place between persons belonging to the same gotra or having the same lineage.

Ashramas or the four stages of life were not well established in Vedic times. The post-Vedic texts speak of four ashramas: that of brahmachari or student, grihastha or householder, vanaprastha or hermit, and sannyasin or ascetic who completely renounced the worldly life. Only the first three are clearly defined in the later Vedic texts; the last or the fourth stage was not well established, though ascetic life was not unknown. Even in post-Vedic times, only the stage of the householder was commonly practised by all the varnas.

4.4.3. Education:

A vast mass of Vedic literature as well as a highly developed intellectual life speaks abundantly about a well-planned system of education in the later Vedic Period. The students had to learn Vedas, Upanishad, grammar prosody, law, arithmetic and language.

After the Upanayana or sacred thread ceremony and initiation to studies the students were sent to the Gurukula for their education. They had to live in the house of the teacher (guru) and lead the chaste life of a Brahmacharin whose principal duties were study and service to the teacher. The students received free boarding and lodging at the house of the Guru. At the completion of their study they paid fees (guru-dakshina) to the teachers.

4.4.4. Position of women:

The women lost their high position which they had in the Rig Vedic Age. They were deprived of their right to the Upanayana ceremony and all their sacraments, excluding marriage,

were performed without recitation of Vedic mantras. Polygamy prevailed in the society. Many of the religious ceremonies, formerly practiced by the wife, were now performed by the priests. She was not allowed to attend the political assemblies. Birth of a daughter became undesirable—for she was regarded as a source of misery. The custom of child marriage and dowry crept in. The women lost their honored position in the society.

4.4.5. Food and Dress:

In the later Vedic age rice became staple food of the people. Gradually the practice of eating meat was declined. Killing of cow was looked with disfavor. Wool was used in addition to cotton.

4.5. Economic Condition

Like political and social conditions, the economic condition of the Aryans of the later Vedic period also underwent significant changes. Due to the emergence of caste system various occupations also appeared.

4.5.1. Agriculture

The Aryans of the later Vedic period lived in the villages. In the villages small peasant owners of land were replaced by big landlords who secured possession of entire villages. Agriculture was the principal occupation of the people. Improved method of tilling the land by deep ploughing, manuring and sowing with better seeds were known to the Aryans. More lands were brought under cultivation.

The cultivator yielded two harvests a year. Varieties of crops like rice, barley, wheat, maize and oil seeds were raised. But the cultivator was not free from trouble. Dangers of insects and damage of crops through hail-storm very badly affected the land of kurus and compelled many people to migrate.

4.5.2. Trade and Commerce

With the growth of civilization, the volume of trade and commerce had increased by leaps and bounds. Both inland and overseas trades were developed. Inland trade was carried

on with the Kiratas inhabiting the mountains. They exchanged the herbs for clothes, nattresses and skins. The people became familiar with the navigation of the seas. Regular coinage was not started.

The coins which were in circulation were “Nishka”, “Satamana” and “Krishnala”. The unit value of goods was a gold bar called “nishka” weighing three hundred and twenty ratis, which was also the weight of a satamana. A ‘Krishnala’ weighed one rati, i.e. 1.8 grams. There was a class of merchants called ‘Pani’ who controlled the trade. References to “ganas” or corporations and the “sreshthins” clearly speak of the formation of guilds or corporations for facilitating trade and commerce. Usuary and money lending was also practiced in this period.

4.5.3. Occupation

The emergence of caste system brought varieties of means of livelihood. There are references about money lenders, chariot makers, dyers, weavers, barbers, goldsmiths, iron smiths, washer men, bow makers, carpenters, musicians etc. The art of writing probably developed in this period. The use of silver was increased and ornaments were made out of it.

4.5.4. House Building and Transport

The house had many rooms with a special place for ‘Grahapatha’ fire which was kept continuously burning. Houses were made of wood. The TaittiriyaAranyakas refer about a special type of house known as ‘Dhandhani’ (treasure house). The Atharvaveda mentions about ‘PatninamSadan’ (women’s apartment).

The means of transport and communication developed with the growth of trade and commerce. Regarding means of transport mention may be made of wagons drawn by oxen, chariots for war and sport and rough vehicle known as ‘bipatha’ for transport of goods. Elephants and horses were also used. Ships and boats were also used as means of transport.

4.6. Religious Condition

During the later Vedic period the religious spirit underwent a great change. Religion was overshadowed with rites and rituals. New gods and goddesses emerged during this period.

4.6.1. New Gods

The Rig Vedic gods, Varun, Indra, Agni, Surya, Usha etc. lost their charm. The people worshipped them with less zeal. New gods like Siva, Rupa, Vishnu, Brahma etc. appeared in the religious firmament of the Later Vedic Period. The grandeur of the Rigvedic gods passed into oblivion, though we find in Atharvaveda the omniscience of Varuna or the beneficence of the Earth goddess.

Certain less important duties of the Rigvedic Period now became popular with the Common People. One of them was Rudra who already bore the epithet of Siva. Very soon Rudra came to be worshipped as 'Mahadeva' (great god) and the lord of animate beings (Pasupati).

Vishnu, the preserver rose into Prominence during this period. He occupied the place of Varuna, as the most sublime among the celestials. To attain his "Paramapada" (highest step) became the goal of the rishis. The worship of vasudeva was also started. He was regarded as Krishna Vasudev, the incarnation of Vishnu. Semi divinities like Apsara, Nagas, Gandharbas, Vidyadharas etc. also came into being. This age also witnessed the beginning of the worship of Durga and Ganesh.

4.6.2. Rituals and Sacrifices

During this period the rites and ceremonies of Vedic religion were elaborated and became complex. In the Rig Vedic age Yanjas were a simple affair which every householder could do. But in the later Vedic age sacrifice became an important thing in worship. Now the priestly class devoted their energy to find out the hidden and mystic meaning of the rites and ceremonies.

People had a firm belief that gods must submit to the sacrifice if properly performed. Vedic hymns were regarded as charms to be used in sacrifice. The belief that gods were satisfied by Yanjas led to a rise in the number, variety of sacrifices which were prescribed for every householder. In fact every Aryan performed a number of sacrifices under the supervision of the Brahmana priest.

4.6.3. Morality and Duty

The Later Vedic Period prescribed a code of righteous conduct. The Brahmins had spread the belief that, "man is born with certain runas or debts" which he must repay in his life. He has

to repay the debts to his gods, to the rishis, to the munis, to men, to the ancestors and to the lower creatures. And he redeems himself from these debts, if he worships the gods and performs Yajnas study Vedas, performs funeral ceremonies and Sraddha, etc. One should perform all these duties with selflessness. The first requisite of a good life were prayers and good works. One should restrain himself from the sins like theft, adultery, and murder.

4.6.4. Religious Philosophy

The Later Vedic age witnessed the emergence of a new intellectual thought. The people thought deeply about the problems of creation, life and death and arrived at the conclusion that there is one 'Brahma' (one Unchanging Principle) beyond the universe—the creator and controller of the whole order.

It is the universal soul or the Absolute "that dwelleth in everything that guideth all beings within, the Inward guide, Immortal." After the death of a person his soul passes into another body and again into another and this process continues till it can be liberated from all its imperfections and merged in the Universal Soul. This is the doctrine of transmigration of souls.

The Aryans had also faith in the doctrine of Karma. It lays down that all actions, good or bad, reap their proper fruits. Souls have to be born again and again and bear the fruits of the actions (Karma) of their previous lives. There is also doctrine of 'Moksha'. It is a state of birthlessness and deathlessness at a point when a soul is liberated from the cycle of births and deaths and mingled into the universal soul." It was essential for a man to attain moksha. All these are embodied in the Upanishad which were composed in the Later Vedic Period.

4.6.5. Ascetic Life

The later Vedic Aryans developed the concept of ascetic ideal of life as the rites and ceremonies were not the only means of attaining success in this world or bliss in heaven. So there developed the ideas of Tapas and Brahmacharya (celibacy) leading to the same or even more important results. Tapa means meditation, accompanying by physical tortures.

An ascetic person renounced the worldly life and retired to the solitude and exercised all the ascetic practices with the belief that they would not only obtain heaven, but also develop,

“mystic, extra-ordinary and superhuman faculties.” This asceticism was widely practiced in the Epic age.

4.7. Science

The first recorded forms of Ayurveda as medical texts evolved from the Vedas. Ayurveda is a discipline of the upaveda or “auxiliary knowledge” in Vedic tradition. The origins of Ayurveda are also found in Atharvaveda, which contains 114 hymns and incantations described as magical cures for disease. There are various legendary accounts of the origin of Ayurveda, e.g. that it was received by Dhanvantari (or Divodasa) from Brahma. Tradition also holds that the writings of Ayurveda were influenced by a lost text by the sage Agnivesa.

Some cosmological concepts are present in the Vedas, as are notions of the movement of heavenly bodies and the course of the year. As in other traditions, there is a close association of astronomy and religion during the early history of the science, astronomical observation being necessitated by spatial and temporal requirements of correct performance of religious ritual. Thus, the Shulba Sutras, texts dedicated to Altar construction, discusses advanced mathematics and basic astronomy. VedangaJyotishadated to 1400–1200 BCE is another of the earliest known Indian texts on astronomy, it includes the details about the sun, moon, stars, lunisolar calendar. VedangaJyotishadetails several astronomical attributes generally applied for timing social and religious events. The VedāngaJyoticha also details astronomical calculations, calendrical studies, and establishes rules for empirical observation. Since the texts written by 1200 BCE were largely religious compositions the VedāngaJyoticha has connections with Indian astrology and details several important aspects of the time and seasons, including lunar months, solar months, and their adjustment by a lunar leap month of Adhikamāsa. Ritus are also described as ((yugams)). Tripathi holds that ‘Twenty-seven constellations, eclipses, seven planets, and twelve signs of the zodiac were also known at that time.’

The religious texts of the Vedic Period provide evidence for the use of large numbers. By the time of the YajurvedasaChitā- (1200–900 BCE), numbers as high as 10^{12} were being included in the texts. The solution to partial fraction was known to the Rigvedic People as states in the Purusha Sukta.

The Aryans of Vedic age had reached the highest stage of civilization. This age had excelled in every walks of life. All the valuable things in man's life—philosophy, religion, science and code of conduct were all developed in the Vedic age.

Check your Progress –1

3. Write a note on the social and cultural conditions during later Vedic period
4. Explain about the concept of science during Vedic age

LESSON - 5

EVOLUTION OF SOCIAL AND CULTURAL INSTITUTIONS RISE OF JAINISM AND BUDDHISM

5.1. Learning Objectives

After going through this lesson, you will be able to

- Focus on the religious significance of the 6th century B.C.
- Evaluate the reasons for the rise of Jainism and Buddhism in India.
- Assess the life and teachings of Vardhamana Mahavira
- Estimate the life and teachings of Goutama Buddha
- Analyse the success of these religions
- Examine how they spread in India and abroad, and
- Judge the effects of these religious movements.

Structure

5.1 Introduction

5.2 Religious Significance of the 6th century B.C.

5.3 Religious Upheaval in the 6th century B.C.

5.4 Causes for the rise of Jainism and Buddhism

5.5 Life and teachings of Vardhamana Mahavira

5.5.1. Life

5.5.2. Teaching

5.5.3. Exodus to the South

5.5.4. Royal patronage

5.6 Life and teaching of Gautama Buddha

5.6.1. Life

5.6.2. Teaching

5.6.3. Monks and Nuns**5.6.4. Upasakas and upasikas****5.7 Causes for the spread of Buddhism****5.8 Royal patronage****5.9 Repolarisation of Society****5.10 Let us sum up****5.11 Answers to check your progress.****5.1 Introduction**

The 6th Century B.C.E. was a period of great tumult in India. The kingdom of Magadha, one of the 16 great Janapadas had become paramount over other kingdoms of the Ganges Valley. This period also saw the emergence of various heterodox sects in India. This was the time when Buddhism and Jainism emerged as popular protestant movements to pose a serious challenge to Brahmanical orthodoxy. Jainism and Buddhism are among the greatest gifts of India to world civilization. They are not only religions which have survived the test of time, but stand for a way of life where good human conduct is urged. They won over to their side millions of Hindus, and opened new chapters in literature, art and architecture, education and philosophy. Jainism and Buddhism shook orthodoxy to its roots, and encouraged 'a grand religious inquest' on religion and God. They may be said to have laid the foundations of a new social order where one can see more liberalism, more equality, and more freedom.

Jainism and Buddhism have come to stay, continue to influence the life and thinking of millions of people, and need to be cherished by the learners of history. The aims of this lesson are to make you comprehend the life and teachings of Vardhamana Mahavira and Goutama Buddha who changed the path of the history of India, and of territories beyond India.

5.2. Religious Significance of the 6th century B.C.

The sixth century B.C. was a period of religious quest, of search and speculation in India and also other parts of the world. The Mahavira and the Buddha lived and preached in India in the 6th century B.C, it was more or less in the same century, Heraclitus, Isaiah, Confucius, Lao

Tse and Zoroaster lived and preached their doctrines. Heraclitus (535 to 495 B.C.) was a Greek philosopher, Isaiah (4th Century B.C.), and old Testament prophet, Confucius (551 to 479 B.C.) a Chinese philosopher, Lao Tse, a sage and recluse and an older contemporary of Confucius, and Zoroaster (628 to 551 B.C.), an Iranian prophet and founder of the Parsee religion worked for the salvation of mankind in their own countries; it is almost certain that they did not know or influence each other. The fact that so many reformers lived and taught their ideas more or less at the same time has made a Historian to describe the 6th century B.C. 'a wonderful century'. Further, so far as India is concerned, the period witnessed political integration of northern India.

5.3. Religious Upheaval in the 6th century B.C.

The sixth century BC was a period of religious turmoil. The Indian movement was kindled in the Magadha and its neighbouring areas. This period witnessed the rise of numerous religious sects in India. 'We hear of as 62 religious sects ... of these Jainism and Buddhism were the most important'. The prevalence of the Brahmanical system based on complicated sacrifices and ceremonies created unrest among the common folks. The formalities of the sacrificial rites which were simple during the Vedic age proved expensive and unfeasible among the Kshatriyas, Vaisyas and Sudras. The Brahmanas who now adorned the status of being the highest in the society provoked religious propagators to preach a new philosophy of life and death. Opinions about God and soul was diverse. Looking into the facts of that period it can be summed up that the the Saisunagas, the Licchavis and other ruling clans or families being not Indo- Aryans evoked and encourage the growth of independent views on philosophy and religion. Thus, many sects arose advocating diverse opinions about God and ways of attaining Moksha. The most common of the several sects was Jainism and Buddhism. Both Jainism and Buddhism originated in the Magadha or the territories adjoining it during the reigns of Bimbisara and Ajatasatru. The Jain and Buddhist records speak of six other teachers leading people and held in esteem by them. They were Kassappa, Kaccayana, Gosala, Ajita, Sanjaya and Nataputa. Of these Gosala was the most well known. His followers, known as the Ajvikas, practiced severe austerities; a Tamil classic called the Nilakesi describes their moral observances. The Ajivikas enjoyed several gifts from emperor Asoka, and were patronised by his grandson king Dasaratha. The Tamil philosophical work, Sivajana Siittiyar describes the set and its creed.

A study of the teachings of these Sramanas makes one thing clear. Jainism and Buddhism were not entirely new in their approaches and attitudes, but were indebted to the multitudinous theories that existed in their time.

5.4. Causes for the rise of Jainism and Buddhism

The divisions of society into four **Varnas**- brahmanas, kshatriyas, vaisyas, and sudras - and the enjoyment of certain privileges by the first three denying the same to the fourth may have generated social tensions. The revolt in the sixth century B.C. seems to have been directed against the brahmanas who described themselves as messengers of god and trustees of spiritual power. There does not seem to be much substance in this argument, because the kshatriyas too enjoyed immense power and privilege; they were called vajanyas. The Mahavira was a kshatriya; the Buddha too was a kshatriya; the kshatriyas may not have suffered at the hands of the brahmanas, and there was no need to resort to any revolt against brahmanical ascendancy. Therefore, the cause may be something other than social.

R.S. Sharma would propound an economic origin for Jainism and Buddhism. The development of agricultural economy required the use of oxen, but the Vedic religion followed the practice of slaughtering cattle in sacrifices. 'the cattle wealth slowly if the new agrarian economy had to be stable, this killing had to be stopped. The Vaisyas had a special reason to hope for a religion which would promote trade and commerce by Dharmasastras of the Vedic age which did not approve of money lending; they looked forward to a new religion which would promote trade and commerce by discouraging war between kingdoms. Further, the vaisyas stood to lose by following the Dharmasastras of the Vedic age which did not approve of money lending; they looked forward to a new religion which would facilitate their mercantile activities. R.S. Sharma would also say that people detested the comforts and luxuries of the post-vedic and 'yearned to return to primitive life'- a simple and disciplined life free from vices. When Jainism and Buddhism promised such a plain life, the people welcomed the new sects.

R. Santhianathair would not agree with either social or economic reasons but would insist that the real cause was religious. The Vedic religion's adherence to 'the soulless sacrificial system' and the shedding of innocent animal blood must have troubled the conscience of people. Many a Vedic ritual should have appeared to them meaningless; they were not prepared

to accept the authority of the Vedas, nor were they willing to look upon the brahmanas as their spiritual guides. The views of the Mahavira and the Buddha fell on fertile ground; an ethical code was substituted for 'arid ritualism and metaphysical subtlety'

H. C. Raychaudhuri has summed up the situation in North India on the eve of the emergence of Jainism and Buddhism in the following words- 'old ideas changed. New ones sprang into vigorous life.... humanitarian and historic movements gathered force and momentum as popular faith in animal sacrifice and barren ritual tended to diminish.... spiritual leadership passed from the hands of priestly theologians and sacrifices to ascetics and wanderers....'

Check your progress-1

1. Show the significance of the 6th century B.C. in the history of the world, and the history of India in Particular.
2. Mention why the 6th century B.C. in India has been called a century of 'religious Upheaval'?
3. Describe the causes for the rise of Jainism and Buddhism.

5.5. Life and teachings of Vardhamana Mahavira

There is an abundance of material on the life and teachings of the Mahavira; but they were not composed in his own life time. Jain religious texts known as the **Angas**, and reduced to writing in the fifth or sixth century A.D., are especially useful to understand religion and philosophy, but the life of Vardhamana is gleaned mostly from oral tradition where one has to sift history from mythology and legend.

5.5.1. Life

Jain tradition would consider Rishabhadeva as the earliest of their prophets and founder of their order; however, the order appears to have gained strength in the eight century B.C. under Parsvanatha, the twenty-third **tirthankara**. Vardhamana Mahavera is treated as the twenty-fourth and last of the **tirthankars**. The absence of references in the records of the age to the career and religious ideas of these early teachers suggest that their existence was more legendary than historical.

Vardhamana Mahavira is treated more as a reformer of an existing religion than as a founder of a new one. Different scholars hold different views on the dates of Vardhamana's

birth and death. The most satisfactory theory fixes his birth in 539 B.C; and his death in 467 B.C. his date of birth, the lesser known date, has been worked out from the date of his death, the better-known date, taking into account that he lived for 72 years. Vardhamana was born at Kundagrama, a suburb of Vaisali he was the son of Siddhartha, who was the head of a well connected with influential royal families. He married Yasodha and had a daughter. After the death of his parents he turned away from 'profane things', began the life of an ascetic, and did penance for 12 years seeking truth. During his wanderings in Eastern India, he is said to have lived with Gosala who parted ways with him to become the leader of the Ajivikas. Vardhamana attained omniscience- **kaivalya**-in his forty- second year on the banks of the river Rajupalika. Because he conquered happiness and misery, he came to be known as the jina or Mahavira or the great conqueror; his followers were called **Nirgranthas**, 'free from fetters'. Thereafter, Vardhamana began his career as a teacher and preacher, and for thirty years he visited the chief centres of civilization in northern India, where even princes became his followers. He organized a Jain Sangha to which he admitted people regardless of caste or sex, and 'inaugurated a system of peaceful proselytization'

5.5.2. Teaching

Jainism taught the householder five doctrines known as **anuvratas**. A householder shall not do violence to other living beings, shall speak the truth, shall not commit theft, shall not indulge in adultery, shall not be greedy. Because a householder is not an ascetic, and has a family, and occupation and responsibility, some concessions are allowed to him. For example, in the matter of violence, accidental, occupational, and protective injury may be excusable but not intentional injury and killing.

Jainism taught the monks the same ethical code of abstaining from violence, untruth, theft, adultery, and greed, but expected them to observe the vows in their strictest form; in the case of the monks the vows become **mahavratas** (major vows) no kind of concession or relaxation is permissible, for example a monk under no circumstances may injure any living being in thought, word or deed. A monk should condition his mind and body in such a manner that a beautiful or an ugly sight, a charming note or jarring sound, a fragrant or foul smell, a flavory or tasteless dish, and a tender or rough touch should arouse no feelings of joy or hatred, attraction or repulsion.

The **Triratna** or three gems of Jainism that are described as moksha- marga or path to salvation are right faith, right knowledge and right conduct. Right faith is faith in the infallibility of

Mahavira, right knowledge is knowledge of the theory that there is no God, that the doctrine of **karma** is true and that asceticism could deliver people from the after effects of **karma**; Right conduct is, as already described, not to injure life, not to lie, not to steal, not to be adulterer or adulteress, and not to be greedy. Jainism commands its clergy to follow in addition to the above conduct, positive conduct that would promote self-discipline, confession, humility, obedience, meditation and study. Likewise, it commands the laymen to protect all living creatures, to be careful in choosing an occupation, practice charity, and take to starvation. In the midst of all these teachings it is necessary to remember that **ahimsa** or non-violence is the core of Jainism; no other religions in the world is known to carry **ahimsa** to such an extreme as to prohibit agriculture since it involves injury to the earth worms and animals.

5.5.3. Exodus to the South

There is a Jain tradition which speaks of a migration of 12,000 Jain monks to Karnataka when there was a famine in North India which lasted for 12 years. Bhadrabahu, the Jain pontiff is said to have led them; and Chandra Gupta Maurya is believed to have abdicated and accompanied Bhadrabahu. The migrant Jain's settled at Sravanabelgola from where they spread Jainism in South India. When the followers of Bhadrabahu, on their return to the north, found that those who remained at Pataliputra had convened a council and codified the canon, disagreed with them, accused them of violating the rules, and called them Svetambaras (dressed in white), those who followed scrupulously the teachings of Mahavira regarding nudity came to be called Digambaras (sky clad). The divisions of the Jain church into two sects – Svetambaras and Digambaras is said to be as old as the first century A.D. Though legends have grown on the migration from Magadha to Mysore, the incident may be taken as Historical. A very old rock inscription at Sravanabelgola commemorates his (Chandragupta Maurya's) visit to the South; a cave is dedicated to him, and the hill on which it exists is known as Chandragiri.

5.5.4. Royal patronage

The fortunes of Jainism increased due to royal patronage. Vardhamana himself came into contact with the Nanda kings, Bimbisara and Ajalsatru. King Kharavela of Kalinga (176-163 B.C.) was a great patron of Jainism. This Hathigumpha inscription refers to his donations to Jain monks, summoning an assembly of ascetics and causing the Angas to be compiled; he has been described as an undoubted Jain King. Many royal dynasties of the South like the

Gangas, Kadambas, Chalukyas, and Rashtrakutas patronised Jainism. His teacher-in-chief Jinasena was a Jain. He is even said to have become a Jain monk late in his life.

Check your progress-2

1. Sketch the life of Vardhamana Mahavira.
2. Mention the five vows prescribed for householders.
3. Describe the three jewels of Jainism.
4. Write about the cause and effects of Jain migration from the North to South.
5. Show the extent of royal patronage to Jainism.

5.6. Life and teaching of Gautama Buddha

The Pali canon throws light on the life, the teachings and the order of the Buddha. The **Tripitakas** of the canon—the Vinaya Pitaka, the Sutta Pitaka and the Abidamma Pitaka are a veritable source of information on the Buddha and Buddhism. The Ceylonese Chronicles **Dipavamsa** (4th century A.D.) and the **Mahavamsa** (6th century A.D.) are not monkish inventions but are based on historical accounts of the master and his teachings. But everywhere there is a fusion of history and legend. The Buddhist Councils that met at Rajagriha (487 B.C.), Vaisali (387 B.C.), Pataliputra (240 B.C.), and Srinagar (A.D.100) compiled Buddhist literature, and published commentaries on them for the benefit of future generations.

5.6.1. Life

A few scholars regard the Buddha as a mythological figure and not as a historical person who lived and moved in the midst of men and women. An Asokan inscription says: “Here was born the Buddha Sakyamuni”. Another inscription on an urn containing the ashes of the Buddha state. “This is the relic treasury of the Lord Buddha of the Sakyas” Therefore, there is no doubt about the historicity of the Buddha.

As in the case of Vardhamana, the dates of Gautama’s birth and death have been worked out in the reverse direction. The largely supported dates are 567 B.C. for his birth and 487 B.C. for his death. Drawing evidence from Indian events like Chandragupta Maurya’s accession and Asoka’s coronation, and foreign sources like the Ceylonese chronicles and the dotted

record of Canton, Gautama's date of death has been fixed at 487 B.C. and since he is said to have lived for 80 years, his date of birth at 567 B.C.

Siddhartha Gauthama was the son of Raja Suddhodhana and princess Mayadevi. Siddhartha was his name, and Gautama his **gotra**. Raja Suddhodana was the of a republic-Kapilavastu- and Gautama naturally inherited republican sentiments. He was born in Lumbini in Nepal. His birth place is marked by a pillar inscription of Asoka. The infant Gautama lost his mother a few days after his birth, and the little prince was brought up by Mahaprajapathi, his mother's sister. When he was sixteen, he married his cousin Yasodara and lived a princely life. But sights of old age, disease, and death turned his attention to the troubles and bondage of human life. The news of the birth of a son was received by him with the remark that he has been bound by another chain when he was about 30, he gave up the comforts of the palace and wandered as an ascetic from place to place. He lived with teachers, moved with Gosala who later became the leader of the Ajivikas, and practiced penance. He sat under a Bodhi tree and meditated and attained supreme knowledge at Bodh-Gaya. He became the Buddha or the enlightened one. He proceeded to Sarnath near Benares where he delivered his first sermon which is known as Dharma Chakra Pravartana or turning the wheel of the law. From Benaras he proceeded to Rajagriha where he refused the doctrines of many Brahmanical and non-Brahmanical teachers. He also visited places like Gaya, Nalanda and Pataliputra where he succeeded in making a large number of conversions.

Though the Buddha laid the foundations of his religions in Magada, its development is said to have taken place in Kosala where he delivered the largest number of discourses. The merchant-prince Anathapindika who became his convert bought the Jetavahana park for the Buddha. Ambapali, the famous courtesan of Vaisali, also became a convert and offered her mango grove to his order. After spreading his religion for forty years, he passed away at Kusinagara (Uttar Pradesh) after a fatal illness.

5.6.2. Teachings

The Sutta Pitaka is the best source for the Buddha's teachings. But so many additions and alterations have taken place in it that what we have today is not the original. Rhys Davids believes that it contains the teachings of the Buddha as well as those of his disciples. The Buddha was anxious that his followers should pursue practical methods to arrive at the Truth, and should not indulge in academic speculations.

Four Noble Truths

The essence of Buddhism is contained in the four noble truths called the **Arya Satyas**. They are misery, cause, suppression, and path. The first truth is that life is full of misery and unhappiness. The human tears are more abundant than the waters of the ocean. The evils of life are old age, sickness, death, submission to hateful things, and separation from beloved objects. The second truth is that desire- thirst for worldly possessions- causes unhappiness. The third truth is destruction of desire. The fourth truth is that there is a path for the destruction of thirst or desire. The path is known as the eightfold path – **ashtanga marga**.

- The truth of suffering (**Dukkha**)
- The truth of the origin of suffering (**Samudâya**)
- The truth of the cessation of suffering (**Nirodha**)
- The truth of the path to the cessation of suffering (**Magga**)

It was these four principles that the Buddha came to understand during his meditation under the bodhi tree.

Eight- fold Path – Ashtanga Marga

The eight-fold path consist of 1. Right Speech 2. Right Action 3. Right Livelihood 4. Right Exertion 5. Right Mindfulness 6. Right Meditation 7. Right Resolution 8. Right views. Right speech is speaking truth and avoiding slander. Right action is refraining from killing, stealing and immorality. Right livelihood is not causing injury to any living being a man or beast, fish or fowl. Right exertion is keeping the mind receptive to noble thoughts. Right Mindfulness is possessing self-control. Right meditation is concentration or **Samadhi**. Right resolution is right aspiration- the resolve to give up pleasure, the resolve to eschew violence. Right views are knowledge of four truths.

‘the eight-fold path has been called Middle path as it is midway between the two extremes of sensual pleasure and bodily torture’. He (the Buddha) learnt the lessons of moderation from his own experiences’. It has been said of the eight-fold path that this was the path that ‘opened the eyes, bestowed understanding, led to peace of mind, to the higher wisdom, to full enlightenment, to Nirvana’. The eight-fold path makes it clear that Buddhism is a moral code and not a metaphysical religion.

Nirvana

The Buddha's conception of nirvana is subtle and incommunicable; it has been translated as 'blowing out', as annihilation. However, one thing is clear. The goal of Buddhism is Nirvana. 'Nirvana is the final result of the extinction of the desire or thirst for rebirth... it is the blissful reward of a long course of exertion a haven of peace and rest'. When a man has relinquished all worldly ties, all worldly desires, all worldly attachment, he is said to have attained nirvana; such a person is called **arhat**, and in the opinion of many he is even superior to god.

5.6.3. Monks and Nuns

Buddhist monk and nuns who led a wandering life in the early years- living in caves, subsisting on alms, dressed in rags, later started living in monasteries and accepted food and clothing offered by the faithful. The Buddha framed regulations for the members of his Sangha – regulations relating to their ordination, layout of monasteries, food and dress and drugs. Fortnightly assemblies etc. The Vinaya Pitaka deals with all these rules. A monk is asked to observe ten principles. They are avoiding of 1. Killig. 2. Theft. 3. Untruth 4. Intoxicating 5. Adultery 6. Eating at improper times 7. Dancing and music 8. Garland and perfumes 9. Broad beds 10. And accepting gold and silver. The Buddhist monk and nuns were sannyasins and not priests. The rules meant for the monks were also applicable to the nuns. The Buddha had great confidence in their competence. The Therigatta is a collection of poems by nuns, these poems reveal what reasons made women to become nuns. Among the famous monks Sariputta, Moggallana, and Ananda (the last described as the boswell of the Buddha), and among the famous nun Khema, Uppalavanna, and Patichara deserve special mention.

5.6.4. Upasakas and Upasikas

The lay disciples of the Buddha, known as the Upasakas and Upasikas, did not belong to the Sangha. However, they expressed their faith in the Buddha, the Dhamma, and the Sangha. The Buddha advocated domestic and social virtues in their case and described their duties towards parents, teachers, wife and children, friends, servants and monks. The Buddha wanted them to practice 'liberality, courtesy, benevolence, unselfishness, under all circumstances and towards all men. The rich Ananthapindika and Visaka of Sravasti were the most celebrated lay disciples of the Master.

5.7. Causes for the spread of Buddhism

Buddhism spread rapidly in the north, making Maghada its cradle. Several reasons are attributed for the success. The founder's charisma and character, the sincerity with which he practiced what he preached, the grace and ease with which he moved with all kinds of people- listening to their tale of sorrow, consoling them, offering them hope- contributed in a large measure to the success and spread of Buddhism. His magnetic appearance and magnificent personality and at the same time, his simple and serene ways won tens of thousands of followers.

His repudiation of the caste system- treating people of all **varnas** alike- was a revolution, the like of which India had not seen earlier. Men and women whom the Vedas did not consider worthy of their blessing and benediction, found a safe harbour in Buddhism. The Buddha non-violence, his condemnation of slaughter and sacrifice of the animals, his compassion to all living beings won the admiration of many, and made them follow his footsteps. Again, instead of talking about God and metaphysics in which the common man had no interest, he talked about ethics, truth, honesty, morality, kindness which he understood and appreciated. The master spoke to them in Pali- the language of the common people. He did not require any translation. His parables, his anecdotes, his smiles made an impression on their imagination. No wonder Edwin Arnold called the Buddha the light of Asia. Rhy Davids went a step further and described him the light of the world.

5.8. Royal patronage

Many a famous king of ancient India admired Buddhism became its followers, and assured its survival and success in India and beyond, Asoka became its best patron, published edicts to popularise the teachings of the Buddha, organised missions to spread his message abroad, made administrative arrangements to ensure its success, and set Buddhist Council to heal the schism in the Buddhist church. The greatest of the Kushana kings, Kanishka, was also a patron of Buddhism. Epigraphic and numismatic evidence support this view. He is said to have built a monastery at Peshawar. He also convened a Buddhist council in Kashmir where Buddhist monks wrote commentaries on Buddhist texts. Yet another king who is honoured guest. He held a religious Assembly at Kanauj where a statue of the Buddha was enthroned and the pilgrim honoured. Therefore, there is no doubt that Buddhism flourished due to royal patronage of kings like Asoka, Kanishka, Harsha, and a host of others.

Check yours progress-3

1. Trace the career of the Buddha
2. What are the four Aryan truths?
3. Describe the Eight-fold path of the Buddha
4. Mention the Ten Commandments prescribed by the Buddha for the monks and nuns.
5. Describe the causes responsible for the spread of Buddhism
6. Show how the kings of ancient India patronised Buddhism.

5.9. Repolarization of Society

The social organisation of the Vedic period continued in the time of the Mahavira and the Buddha but with some changes. The sutras and the sastras of the age throw some light on these changes. The four castes became formalised; they gradually became rigid and fixed. The Dharma **sutras** laid down the duties of each of the four varnas, and even the civil and criminal law came to be based on the varna division. The literature of the age would assign the highest position to the brahmanas; their duties included study, worship and making gifts; at the same time society expected him to possess superior knowledge and qualifications. But the sudras suffered many disabilities. They had few privileges and many obligations. They were treated like slaves, and were ineligible for sacraments.

The Buddhist Jataka stories would refer to a fifth class called the Chandalas. They were probably tribals, and were treated as untouchables. Their very sight was regarded as impure and therefore they had to live outside the village or city.

An interesting feature of the age of the Mahavira and the Buddha is the emergence of the challenge to the supremacy of the Brahmanas. The name of the Kshatriyas appears at the top of the four castes. The king was almost always a Kshatriya, fought the wars on behalf of his people, and ensured that they lived in peace and prosperity.

The four asramas also came to stay. The first asrama is that of brahmachari- a student. Through most of them studied for a short period. Some remained as students for the whole of their lives and pursued learning. The second is that of a **grihastha** who had manifold duties. He found a home, brings up a family, and discharges his duty to the gods, ancestors, and **rishis**. The third asrama is that of a bhikshu who lives a life of restraint and denial. This may be said to

be a preparation for the final stage. The fourth and final asrama is that of a **sannyasi**. He abandons truth and falsehood, pleasure and pain, the Vedas, this world and the next. A Greek writer speaks of a sannyasi who refused to go and see the mighty Alexander and asked him to come and see him. The saint Dandamis (Dandi or Dandi Swami) was “the only antagonist in whom he the conqueror of many nations had found more than his match”. **Dandamis** was a philosopher, whom Alexander encountered in the woods near Taxila, when he invaded the subcontinent in 4th century B.C. Dandamis was the name mentioned by the Greeks but his real name was **Dandi** or **Dandi-Swami**. He is also referred to as **Mandanes**. The conversation that followed between them is recorded by Greeks as Alexander-Dandamis colloquy.

We notice a retrograde movement in the position and status of women during the period under review. With the lowering of the marriageable age of women and extreme emphasis laid on physical chastity of women and unquestioned obedience to her husband led to progressive deterioration of her status and position. The customs in the earlier age was to give away women in marriage at a mature age. But pre- puberty marriages became the order of day during the period under study. This affected their position because such early marriages arrested the progress of their education. Spiritually too the women were reduced to an inferior position. She was excluded from performing Vedic sacrifices and the upanayana ceremony. This change has been described as the spiritual disenfranchisement of women. Gone were the days when Indian women participated in highly philosophical subjects and even composed verses and entered into disputations on Sastras. The marginalization of women is an unfortunate trend of this period.

Check your progress-4

1. Describe the changes in the varna system during the sixth century B.C.
2. Mention the four asramas and indicate the respect shown to the sannyasis.
3. Show how women came to occupy a subordinate position in an otherwise progressive century.

5.10. Let us sum up

The sixth century B.C. ushered in far- reaching changes. Jainism and Buddhism are largely responsible for these changes. The changes were not only reformatting but evolutionary in character. Every aspect of Indian life –religion, society, economy, culture-came under the

spell of these changes; but it has to be remembered that the break in the past was never complete or total life continued to flow like a stream, the old and the new mixing, creating a new texture of society, new norms, new patterns, new ideas at with roots in the old.

4.10 Answers to check your progress.

Check your progress-1

1. See 5.2.
2. See 5.3.
3. See 5.4.

Check your progress -2

1. See 5.5.1
2. See 5.5.2. Paragraph (1)
3. See 5.5.2. Paragraph (2)
4. See 5.5.3
5. See 5.5.4

Check your progress-3

1. See 5.6.1
2. See 5.6.2 Paragraph (2)
3. See 5.6.2 Paragraph (3) and (4)
4. See 5.6.3.
5. See 5.7-
6. See 5.8

Check your progress-4

1. See 5.9 Paragraph (1), (2), and (3)
2. See 5.9. Paragraph (4)
3. See 5. 9. Paragraph (5)

LESSON - 6

AGE OF MAURYAS - SOCIAL AND CULTURAL DEVELOPMENT

Learning Objectives

After learning this lesson, you will be able to

- Explain the details of Mauryan administration
- Describe the social structure under Mauryas
- Narrate the economic activities of people, like agricultural, industries, and trade
- Comment on their religious conditions
- Write on their achievements in arts and letters

Structure

6.1 Introduction

6.2 Administration

6.2.1. The King

6.2.2. Officers

6.2.3. Income and Expenditure

6.2.4. Census

6.2.5. Armed Forces

6.2.6. Provinces

6.2.7. Municipal Administration

6.3 Social life

6.3.1. Castes

6.3.2. Asramas

6.3.3. Positions of Women

6.3.4. Marriages

6.1 Introduction

It was in the Mauryan Age that India became the cultural ambassador of the world, sending out missionaries to spread out India's civilisation and religion to distant parts of the globe. India under the Mauryas sought to build a new world based on peace, brotherhood and cultural unity. This lesson describes cultural developments under the Mauryas between 321 B.C. and 187 B.C. Mauryan Kings like Chandragupta and Asoka were largely responsible for developments in administration, society, economic, religion, and cultural during this period. Mauryas ruled for more than hundred and thirty years, and ruled well; though there were wars now and then, their period was one of peace and prosperity.

6.2 Administration

The Mauryas are given credit for organizing an almost perfect administration – Central, Provincial, and Local. Kautilya's Arthashastra, the Indica of Megasthenes, the edicts of Asoka, and the Smritis like that of Manu constitute the main source of information for understanding the Mauryan polity. The political institutions of the Mauryas were so well organized that even the Greeks, who made so many experiments in the art of government, admired them.

6.2.1. The King

The Mauryan empire, more extensive than the Roman Empire and the British India was a morally controlled monarchy. The king assisted by ministers and provincial governors, innumerable officers including spies, and infantry, and cavalry, succeeded in providing a good government to the millions of his people living in a vast empire stretching from the Hindukush to the valleys of the Godavari and the Krishna. In the early days king was treated as a human being- 'humble and-modest, versed in sacred and secular lore'

The Mauryan rulers, and those who succeeded them, are known for their never ceasing activities to protect their people and promote their welfare. Chandragupta Maurya, Asoka, Kharavela, and Gautamiputra led their armies in person to the battle field. Manu would want the king to encourage agriculture, improve the highways, exploit the mines, clear the forest, colonise barren lands, tame elephants, build forts and bridges' the kings were far from despots; they look upon the people as 'Prajā' – children. Kautilya said. 'in the happiness of his subjects lies his happiness; in their welfare, his welfare'.

6.2.2. Officers

The king was assisted by a council of ministers called the 'Mantri parishad'. The prime minister, the Purohita, the Senapati, and the Yuvaraja were among the members of the Parishad who advised the king on all important matters concerning the state. The inscriptions of Asoka refer to Rajukas and Pradesikas; the former was in charge of country parts, and the latter, districts. The Mahamatras were charged with the administrations of cities. Kautilya mentions two classes of officials called Sannidhata and the Samaharta. The Sannidhata took care of the Treasury, and the Samaharta, collection of revenue. He also mentions the different departments of the government like finance, public work, royal correspondence, agriculture, weights and measures, mines and metals, passport, stores, excise, weaving ships, slaughter- houses, salt etc these departments were administered by superintendents known as adhyakshas. Public assistance was offered to orphans, the poor, widows, the handicapped, etc. These multifarious types of work should have demanded the employment of thousands of dedicated workers. There were the inevitable spies too. Kautilya describes how the spies were to be recruited, and how they were to be trained. Public servants were recruited from all classes of people irrespective of caste creed or nationality; even allies like Yavanas were recruited to government service. The king was the fountain of justice as well; he headed the judiciary. The Rajukas enjoyed considerable freedom in administering justice; 'the emperor or his viceroys sent forth in rotation every five or three such officers as were of mild and temperate disposition and regardful of the sanctity of life' to check abuses and malpractices in the administration of justice. Greek writers speak of the severity of its penal code. Man slaughter, maiming an artisan, destroying a dam, theft of 40 panas and more were treated as capital crimes. The punishments awarded were fines, whipping, mutilation, and death. Those who were guilty of murdering brahmanas, women, and children were punished with death; fine were collected from those who destroyed bridges.

6.2.3. Income and Expenditure

The sources of revenue and the items of expenditure were fixed on consideration of the income of the people and the needs of the state. The taxes were collected in such a manner – as the calf and the bee collect their food little by little- that the people did not find them burdensome. Brahmanas were exempted from taxation. The most important source of revenue was the land tax; the rate of the tax was normally one- sixth of the produce. Traders paid

duties; all those who lived by buying and selling goods had to pay one-twentieth of the value of goods as tax. Those who evaded tax were permitted with confiscation of their property. The Sudras and the artisans who lived by manual labour worked for the kings for a day each month. Manu permitted the king to collect one –sixth of “tree-meat, butter, perfumes, herbs, ... flowers, roots and fruits, ... objects made of cane, skins, of earthen vessels”. Those who crossed ferries with an empty cart paid a pana and with a head load, half a pana.

Treasure- trove was another source of income. If they were discovered by the brahmanas, they belonged entirely to them; if they were discovered by others, they were shared between the discoverers, the state, and the brahmanas. The king was entitled to at least one twelfth of the property lost and found afterwards, the fines collected by court of law were yet another important source of income. The entire produce of the mines and income from sale of salt went to the king's treasury. Income thus earned from several sources met the cost of civil and military administration. Items of expenditure included the king and his household, government employees, armed forces, public works, poor relief, religious activities etc. The exercise of spreading Buddhism, especially during the reign of Asoka, should have cost the government a great deal.

6.2.4. Census

The Mauryan census introduced in the 4th century B.C. is the first of its kind in India. The census was meant to assess the resources to the empire, the basis for taxation, the number of people- Indians as well as foreigners, and to know far the state was stable and healthy. ‘the village officials were to number the people according to their caste and occupation, the slaves and freemen, the young and old, men and women, record their character, and income tax expenditure. They were also to count the animals in each house. It is interesting to be informed that the Mauryan census was ordered every year, and not once in ten years as in modern days.

6.2.5. Armed Forces

The Mauryan army consisted of the traditional four wings; corps of elephants, cavalry, chariot, and foot soldiers. Megasthenes makes a note of a governing body of thirty members that looked after military administration. The body was divided in to six boards of five members

each: 1. The elephants, 2. The cavalry, 3. The chariots, 4. The infantry, 5. The navy, and 6. Transport and commissariat. The last department looked after the movement of men and materials, and provided supplies and services- like food, servants, and equipment. Megasthenes would say that the Mauryan army consisted of 600,000-foot soldiers, 30,000 cavalry, and 9,00 elephants. The soldiers were paid by the state, and provided with menials to look after their comfort, maintain their animals, and keep their weapons in shape. Foot soldiers carried bows and arrows; there was hardly a shield which their arrows would not penetrate. They wielded swords to kill their enemies in close- quarter battles, 'the ethical side of the military code.... produced a good impression on the Greeks' in the battle field the wounded and disarmed were decently treated and those who had given up their arms were saved from butchery; the civil population's and the agriculturists were not molested. Forts were constructed for defence, and mining and counter- mining were practiced. 'in short the Indians possessed the art of war'.

6.2.6. Provinces

The Mauryan empire was divided in to four provinces. Each province was governed by a number of the royal family, preferably a prince. Before his accession the throne, Asoka ruled as governor of Taxila and Malwa. Chandragupta Maurya's empire was divided in to four provinces. The home province consisting of the Madhyadesa, which the king himself ruled from Pataliputra, the North- western or Taxila, the western or Malwa, and the Gujarat and Kathiawar. The provincial governors seem to have governed with the title 'raja' whatever happened even in the distant provinces were immediately reported to the emperor wherever he was- 'while he was eating, in the harem, in the inner apartment, at the cow-pen, in the palanquin or in the park.

6.2.7. Municipal Administration

Like the governing body of the armed forces, a commission of thirty members conducted the affairs of Pataliputra. The commission was divided in to five committees each consisting of five members. The committees looked after six different subjects like, industries, foreigners, census, trade, manufacture and their sale, and collection of sales' tax. The 'Nagarika' was the town perfect. Self-governing cities like Pataliputra were admired by Greek writers. The needs of the village were served by village officials known as Gramanis, who were advised by a panchayat; five to ten such villages were looked after by officers called Gopas; larger areas were entrusted to the care of Sthanikas.

Check your progress-1

1. Mention the officers of the Mauryan empire and their duties?
2. Point out the acts that were treated as crimes and the usual punishments.
3. What were the sources of income for the Mauryan empire?
4. Is it true to say that the Indians possessed the art of war in the Mauryan age?
5. Describe the municipal administration of Pataliputra.

6.3. Social life

The Mauryan Empire was a composite one where people of different races, religions, languages, castes, and creeds lived under a single rule. Yet the rulers succeeded in welding together, people with so many diversities, and ensuring that there was a social and communal harmony. Old customs and habits lingered, and a social order with new customs and habits came to be followed side by side with the old.

6.3.1. Castes

The four varnas and four asramas continued to be a dominant feature of the Mauryan society. The Arthasasthra describes the four castes and duties. Adhyana or study, yajana or worship, dana or making gifts are duties common for the three higher castes- the brahmanas, the Kshatriyas, and the Sudras. In addition to the above three, the Brahmanas were required to perform Adhyapana or teaching, yajana or officiating at workshop, and pratigraha or accepting gifts, the kshatriyas to practice Sastrajiva or professions of arms and bhutarakshana or protection of living beings, and the vaisyas to carry on krishi or agriculture, pasupalaya or cattle rearing, and vanijya or trad. The sudras who formed fourth caste were assigned menial service, and produced arts and crafts. The Manu Samhita gives the pride of place to the Brahmana; he claimed the highest supremacy in every field of life; he was prime minister, high priest, member of the Mantriparishad, teacher, and judge, kings sought their advice on important matters, whatever he did, he was exempted from capital punishment. They were not taxed; it was thought that the Brahmanas would deserve their status by superior knowledge and qualifications; they must observe the vows prescribed for them, and cultivate love towards all men and women; otherwise they would lose their status. But the Jain and the Buddhist texts challenged the

supremacy of the Brahmanas and named the Kshatriyas as first among the four castes. 'the whole political organization was behind the king (who was a kshatriya) ... the king dictated and the priest obeyed'.

Megasthenes refers to the existence of as many as seven castes during the time of Chandragupta Maurya. He confused the occupations with the castes. For example, he speaks of spies as a caste; it is obvious that all the soies of the empire could not have belonged to a single caste. The Sudras continued to suffer; they had' few privileges and many obligations' they were treated more or less like slaves.

6.3.2. Asramas

The earlier fourfold division of life in to four asramas continued in the Mauryan age as well. During the first stage- the Brahmachari left the home of his parents, lived with a teacher, and studied; during the second stage- the Grihastha set up a home, reared a family, and discharged his debts to gods, ancestors, and rishis, during the third stage- the vanaprastha lived the life of a bhikshu, a life of restraint and denial; during the fourth stage- the forest, the sannyasi lived the forest, survived on roots and fruits, abandoned pleasure and pain, and sought only the Ataman. One did not always follow all the four stages. A few remained as students for the whole of their lives, and pursued learning. The Sannyasis were held in great esteem, and they were known for their plain living and high thinking. The Greeks were impressed by their discipline and wisdom; they did not care for material rewards and were not afraid of even death.

6.3.3. Positions of Women

Women appear to have been treated well in the Mauryan age- at least in its earlier part. 'there were highly educated women, holding an honourable position in society and household'. Women who were life- long students of sacred texts were known as Brahnavadini; those who look to teaching were called Upadhyayi. Buddhist and Jain texts refer to women who renounced the world for the service of god. Jayanti, daughter of the king of Kausambi, became a jain nun, and devoted her life to religion and philosophy. Megasthenes speaks of women bodyguards following the king when he went out for hunting. He says 'some are in chariots, some on horses, and some even on elephants, and they were equipped with weapons of every kind'.

On the other hand, women also suffered from a few disabilities. The Upanayana ceremony fell into disuse in the case of women; they were barred from reciting Vedic mantras. But to say that women were reduced to the status of the sudra is an exaggeration.

6.3.4. Marriages

Like the Manu Samhita, the Arthashastra mentions eight forms of marriage: Brahma, gift of a girl to a learned man of good conduct; Daiva, marriage to a priest who officiates at a sacrifice; Arsha, exchange of a girl for a couple of cows from the bridegroom; Prajapatya, marriage for the performance of sacred duties together; Asura, where the bridegroom buys a bride; Gandharva, man and woman marrying after loving each other; Rakshasa, marrying a woman after forcible abduction; Paisacha, where a man carries a woman when she is asleep, intoxicated, or mentally disordered. Society approved the first four forms of marriage; even the last four forms of marriage were held valid if approved by the father and the mother.

Divorces also were known. According to Kautilya, a husband may be divorced if he is of 'bad character, or is long gone abroad, or has become a traitor to his king or is likely to endanger the life of his wife, or has fallen from his caste, or has lost virility'. Divorce due to ill feeling was also permissible provided both the parties agreed. Other authorities refer to grounds of a husband divorcing his wife; they included wasteful expenditure, procuring abortion, adultery, or attempts on the husband's life.

Re-marriages of widows though discouraged was not unknown. The Dharmasutras permitted remarriage of a woman whose husband is dead has become an ascetic, or has gone abroad such a remarried woman was called Punarbhi. Widows usually remarried the brother of their deceased husbands. Greek writers have left references to the practice of sati. The practice of widows burning themselves was probably confined to the warrior class it looks that women were not compelled to commit sati but adopted it as a matter of choice. It is likely that widows resorted to this practice because they were treated with so much contempt that they must have thought it was better to die than to face hardships.

6.3.5. Courtesans / Ganikas

Courtesans enjoyed 'a social standing not accorded to them anywhere else in the world'. Amrapali, a rich courtesan of Vaisali and accomplished in all the sixty-four arts, is said to have

visited the Buddha, heard his discourse, and presented a park to him. Kautilya informs us that the courtesans learnt singing, dancing, acting, painting, making perfumes. etc. A prostitute noted for beauty, youth, and accomplishment was to be appointed superintendent of prostitutes on a salary of 1,000 panas per annum. The company of courtesans was sought by all classes in society; they were not held in contempt or ridicule. Further, they made themselves useful to the state by working as spies.

6.3.6. Slaves

Megasthenes would say that 'all the Indians are free and not one of them is a slave. Nothing can be far from truth. Literature is full of references to the institution of slavery. Slaves could be acquired by birth in the master's house, by purchase, by gifts, by inheritance, by maintenance, during famines, by release from a heavy debt, by capture, by gain in wages, by voluntary surrender of freedom, by apostasy from asceticism, by connection with a female slave' Rhys David remarks 'we were nothing of hear misery and oppression. For the most part the slave where household servants and not badly treated. A slave who saved his master's life would be released from slavery and gain freedom.

6.3.7. Food

People in the Mauryan empire ate rice, barley and wheat. The rich ate rice mixed with meat. Not a day passed without consuming milk and its products; ghee was a favourite article of food as it was found to be 'substantial and nourishing' the Jains and the Buddhists cultivated the spirit of non-violence among the people. Emperors like Asoka worked to persuade people not to take animal food. Yet 'various kinds of fish and meat were exclusively taken by the people'. Kautilya would say that the state even maintained a slaughter house.

Manufacture of liquor was a state monopoly. Its sale was regulated by the state. Manu treated drinking liquor as a mahapataka or great sin, and still people drank freely; the habit was particularly common among 'kshatriyas, the nobility and kings.

6.3.8. Dress and Ornaments

The dress of the people consisted of two garments- an under garments and an upper garment. Their dress resembled the dress of the people in the modern Bengal, Orissa, and

Tamil Nadu. The higher classes wore a turban especially on formal occasions. Dress materials were generally made from cotton; but the women and the rich preferred silk, linen, and wool. The Mauryan sculpture shows women's upper part of the body bare; descriptions in Sanskrit literature support sculptural representation. The Mauryans loved ornaments. Every part of the body from head to foot had its appropriate ornaments made of gold, silver, pearls, gems and precious stones'. Even the Buddhist monks are said to have worn ear-rings, strings of beads, bangles, bracelets, necklaces, rings etc, people protected their feet by wearing foot wear made of leather; shoes and slippers were made in a variety of colours black, red, white, etc, the shoes of the rich were decorated with gold, silver and pearls, and even peacock feathers.

Check your progress -2

1. Describe the position of the Brahmanas and the Sudras in the Mauryan age.
2. Mention the types of marriages described in the Arthashastra
3. Show how the courtesans were treated during the age of the Mauryas?
4. Write what you know about the condition of slaves?
5. Describe the dress and ornaments of the people;

6.4 Economic Condition

The Mauryan economy prospered due to agriculture, industries, and trade. The care taken by the state and the initiative of the people resulted in a stable and healthy economy. We do not hear of people dying due to hunger and famine or that they suffered due to want of basic needs.

6.4.1. Agriculture

Agriculture was the main occupation of the people. The arable land, known as grama-kshetra lay beyond the village, it was protected by fences. Land was distributed among villagers, and was cultivated by the owners. There were also large estates- estates of 1000 acres and cultivated using 500 ploughs. Beyond the farms and fields lay the pastures for grazing of cattle. A cowherd called Gopalaka kept the cattle in pens during nights and returned them to the owners. Beyond the pastures there were groves.

Different varieties of rice, pulses, pepper, sesamum, mustard, and saffron were grown. Fruits like plantains and grapes and vegetables like pumpkins and gourds and even sugarcane were raised. Agriculture depended on cattle and livestock, and therefore cows, buffaloes, goats, sheep, asses, camels, pigs and dogs were kept. Before agriculture became popular, cattle lifting (of the enemies) was often resorted to, and cow-boys were employed to take charge of cattle breeding. Land revenue was the chief source of income for the state, and it varied from one sixth to one twelfth. The state also collected special levies during emergencies like war or famine. Kautilya refers to agriculture taxes like *bali* and *bhaga*; the former is state share of the produce, and the latter has not been defined.

The importance of forests was known and different kinds of forests are mentioned in the literature of the age. There were reserved forests meant for royal hunt. There were ordinary forests where all kinds of animals freely roamed; there were also forests which may be called plantations which yielded timber, bamboo, cane, fibre, herbs, roots, flowers and palm leaf. A conservator of forests called '*Nagavanaadhyaksha*' was in charge of forests.

6.4.2. Industries

Literature, epigraphs and sculpture show how various arts and crafts flourished in the Mauryan times. The Jatakas speak of 18 kinds of industries which included weaving, wood-work, pottery, jewellery, making of bows and arrows. Etc. The aborigines followed hunting, fishing, snake –charming and weaving. Particular industries seem to have been localised in particular areas. There were villages which specialised in making pots, iron goods like axes, and leather goods. There were separate markets outside towns to sell perishable goods. There was a market outside Sravasti selling fish, another outside Uttana Panchala selling green groceries yet another outside Banaras selling venison. Prices of goods were not fixed or controlled by the State. 'A vagrant buys a meet from a forester with his gold pin. A dog is bought for a clock or coin'.

6.4.3. Guilds

Persons following the same trade organised themselves into corporations known as '*sreni*' or guilds. The *srenis* even functioned as banks, accepted deposits, and spent the interest on charities. Some of the guilds even maintained private armies. The king could deploy them

whenever he needed their services. When merchants moved from place to place with their goods, they did so under a caption 'who gave them directions as to halts, watering routes, fording and danger spots.

6.4.4. Trade

Internal and external trade increased the prosperity of the empire. The roman empire was the principal buyer of Mauryan goods. Mounds of Roman coins have been found in several places in south Indian coast. There was a great demand in the west for articles of luxury made in India. Spices, perfumes, diamond and sapphire, ivory, silk, sandalwood, muslin, iron and steel, porcelain, and tortoise shell were the chief items of export; imports included gold, silver, coral, linen, and glass. People prospered enormously due to trade and industry. Ananthapindika, a millionaire bought the Jetavana Park covered its surface with gold coin, and gifted it to the Buddha. Likewise, the cost of constructing the great Chaitya cave at Karle (in Maharashtra) was met by an affluent person.

Many trades and industries were held as state monopolies. Mines- diamond mines, gold mines, silver mines, copper mines- were nationalised; even ocean mines from which pearls, conch, and coral could be harvested were held as state monopolies. Manufacture of salt and liquor, building boats and ships, and the making of ornaments were all state-owned industries. The state managed spinning houses as well, and employed helpless and Purdha women for spinning yarn. Traders were requested to obtain licences; in addition to this, foreign traders had to obtain passports. Smuggling and adulteration of goods were frowned upon, and were punished. 'Trade was taxed all along its way by export and import duties, octroi, and excise'. At the same time the state gave necessary protection to traders and their losses were compensated.

Trade and travel were facilitated by wide laid roads and water ways. 'The old Grand Trunk Road leading from Rajagriha through Banaras, Saketa and Sravasti towards Taxila and the frontiers, linking India with central and western Asia is worth mentioning. Megasthenes mentions another Royal Road covering a distance of 1156 miles and linking the North- West frontier with Pataliputra. The roadside was dotted with amenities like milestones, shady trees, rest houses, and wells. The wealthy rode on elephants, and ordinary people used horses, camels and asses. Rivers were crossed by boats and seas by ships.

6.4.5. Coinage

The advent of coins is a special feature of the Mauryan economy. The Mauryan coins are known as Punch-Marked Coins because they were punched with dots or devices, and were either circular or rectangular in shape. Thousands of silver and copper coins have been discovered. The standard gold coin weighed 80ratis, but its specimens have not been come across. Coins were issued not only by rulers, but also by merchants and corporations, and they bore signs and symbols of the authority issuing coins. More than three hundred such signs and symbols have been noticed so far.

6.4.6. Punch-marked coins are a type of early Coinage of India, dating to between about the 6th and 2nd centuries BC. It was of irregular shape. Punch-marked coins are a type of early coinage of India, dating to between about the 6th and 2nd centuries BCE. There are uncertainties regarding the actual time punch-marked coinage started in India, with proposals ranging from 1000 BCE to 500 BCE. However, the study of the relative chronology of these coins has successfully established that the first punch-marked coins initially only had one or two punches, with the number of punches increasing over time. The first coins in India may have been minted around the 6th century BCE by the Mahajanapadas of the Indo-Gangetic Plain, and certainly before the invasion of Alexander the Great in the 4th century BCE. However, according to Joe Cribb, Indian punch-marked coins may only go back to the mid-4th century BCE or slightly earlier, and actually started with the punch-marked coinage of the Achaemenids in the Kabul/ Gandhara area. The coins of this period were punch-marked coins called Puranas, Karshapanas or Pana. Several of these coins had a single symbol, for example, Saurashtra had a humped bull, and Dakshin Panchala had a Swastika, others, like Magadha, had several symbols. These coins were made of silver of a standard weight but with an irregular shape. This was gained by cutting up silver bars and then making the correct weight by cutting the edges of the coin. They are mentioned in the Manu, Panini, and Buddhist Jataka stories and lasted three centuries longer in the south than the north (600 BCE – 300 CE).

During the Mauryan period, punch-marked coins continued to be issued in large quantities. Similarly, the coinage of the Mauryan Empire was a of the punch-marked coinage of Magadha. Each coin contained on average 50–54 grains of silver depending on wear and 32 rattis in weight Manusmriti, and earlier coins are flatter than later coins. Punches on these coins count

to 450 different types with the most common the sun and six-armed symbols, and various forms of geometrical patterns, circles, wheels, human figures, various animals, bows and arrows, hills and trees etc. Many are barely discernible for what they could be. The basic coin is called the Karshapana (pana) in numismatic terms but the Arthashastra stated there are at least 4 denominations of silver coins in pana, ardhapana (half pana), pada (quarter pana) and ashtabhaga, or arshapadika (one-eighth pana). But only the Karshapana is found. There are no issues found of the other denominations even though cut coins are found.

The coins of foreign rulers like the Bactrian Greeks seem to have influenced Indian coins. The Graeco-Bactrian coins and the Roman coins influenced the coins of the Sakas, the Parthians, and the Kushanas, and the coins of the Sakas, the Parthians, and the Kushanas influenced the coins of Indian rulers. It may be noted in this context that though the coins of foreign rulers carried the names of rulers who issued them, the Mauryan coins continued to be of the punch –marked variety with no names or figures of kings.

Check your progress-3

1. Describe the progress of agriculture in the Mauryan age.
2. Show how the guild functioned.
3. Mention the exports and imports in the Mauryan period.
4. Describe the nature of Mauryan coinage.
5. Write a note on Punch Marked Coins.

6.5 Religion

The Mauryan age was an age when different religions existed side by side in India, some of them were orthodox, and some heterodox. Asoka espousing Buddhism and Kharavea supporting Jainism did not result in Vedic Hinduism disappearing. The worship of Indira and Varuna continued, and the performance of sacrifices went on; still there is no doubt that Hinduism had to face the challenges posed by Jainism and Buddhism. The Ajivikas too had their own followers. The Hinduism of the Vedic times transformed itself into Vaishnavism and Saivism. Therefore, people in the Mauryan age may be said to have followed Jainism, Buddhism, Vaishnavism, and Saivism, though there were a few minor sects as well.

6.5.1. Jainism

When a famine ravaged north India, Bhadrabahu and his followers migrated into the south, and those who remained at home convened a council at Pataliputhra and collected the sacred texts of the Jains. The migrants, when they returned home after twelve years, disapproved this exercise, and formed a separate sect calling themselves 'Digambaras' or sky-clad. They argued that the Mahavira desired and taught this. The Jains who remained at home called themselves 'Svethambaras' or clad in white. This split seems to have originated in the third century B.C., and assumed its final shape in the third century A.D.

Kharavela of Kalinga (176-163 B.C) occupies a prominent place in the growth of Jainism. This Hattigumpha inscription says how he humbled Brihaspatimitra, the king of Magadha and brought home certain Jain images once carried away from Kalinga by a king of Nanda dynasty. Kharavela was a devout Jain who excavated a number of caves in Khandagiri hill, and not far from the caves, a monastery also, he further claims to have summoned an assembly of ascetics, and caused a compilation of Jain canon Samprati; the grandson of Asoka, become a convert to Jainism, and established viharas for Brahmanas even in non-Aryan countries. Samprati is even said have initiated his grandfather 'in sending religious missionaries to the countries of Andhras and Dramilas to propagate the religion'. Rudrasinha too who ruled in the second century AD also provided caves to Jain monks.

6.5.2. Buddhism

Emperor Asoka's pro-Buddhist policy was mainly responsible for the spread of Buddhism in India and abroad. He took unprecedented pains to propagate the religion far and wide. Asoka sent missionaries to Syria, Egypt, Cyrene, Epirus, and Macedonia, and to the Cholas and the Pandyas. He published edicts- commands –on rocks and pillars to persuade people to accept Buddhism. He made administrative arrangements to promote his religion; officers called Dharmamahamatras and Dharmayuktas were appointed to preach and enforce the Dharma. He convened the third Buddhist council at Pataliputra to heal the schism in the Buddhist church. He, by his conduct set an example to others by his 'unceasing benevolent activity for man and beast'. An Indian religion became an international religion thanks to Asoka's efforts.

6.5.3. Vaishnavism

The Mauryan age also witnessed the rise of Vaishnavism which is worship of Vishnu as the supreme god. Panni's 'Ashtadhyayi' defines Vaishnavism for the first time as bhakti or devotion to Vasudeva. Megarthenes, writing two centuries later, states how the people of Mathura held Vasudeva in honour. What was known as Bhagavatism to begin with, came to be called as Vaishnavism later on. Vasudeva, the founder of Bhagavatism is said to have been a historical character who actually lived; he was a hero of the Yadava clan. The Bhagavata religion which originated in the Mathura region, spread over western India and northern Deccan. A second century B.C. inscription found at Besnagar 'refers to a garuda-dhvaja (column surmounted by the figure of Garuda conceived as the emblem or vahana of Vishnu) raised at Vidisa in honour of Vasudeva. The deva-deva (the greatest god), by his yavana or Greek devotee Haliodorus, an inhabitant of Takshasila in Gandhara, who calls himself a Bhagavata. i.e. a worshipper of Bhagava (Vasudeva- Vishnu)'

The Bhagavadgita contains the essence of Bhagavatism. It is in the form of a dialogue between Arjuna and Krishna. The Gita emphasizes devotion to Karman; action should be an end in itself, and not means to an end; one should do his duty without going in to the question of its result. Performance of one's duties with an eye on its fruits is the root of all evil. The Gita advocates detachment in action. A karma –yogi may choose either jnana or bhakti; the former leads to self –realisation, and the latter to communion with god.

6.5.4. Saivism

The beginnings of Saivism can be traced to the Indus valley civilization; siva was worshipped as Rudra in the Vedic period; a few Upanishads described him as Mahadeva or the Great God. But it became organized as a religion only in the beginning of the Christian era. Saivism in its early stage was known as pasupatha, and it is believed that a person called Nakulin was the earliest person who taught pasupatha; Nakulin is considered to be the author of panchartha vidya to expound the pasupatha system. The pasupathas believed that the jiva could be released from its bond through five categories; karyam or effect, karana or cause, yoga or path, vidhi or rule, duktanta or the end of misery. Theism, bordering on healthy asceticism, is said to be the essence of the pasupata system.

Saivasim was a popular cult even in the days of Megasthenes; he describes siva as Dionysus. Patanjali writing the second century B.C. speaks of the images of siva and Skanda being sold to raise money. 'some of the Kushana kings became ardent saivas and caused their coins to be minted with the images of siva and of his emblems like the trident and the sacred bull on them'. The santi parvan of the Mahabharata sees divinity equally in Siva and Vishnu; Hari addresses Mahadeva in the following words: 'He who knows thee knows me; he who loves thee loves me. There is no distinction between us'. In the same Mahabharata in one place Siva speaks of Vishnu as the greatest god; while in another Krishna praises Mahadeva as the one to whom there is nothing superior'.

6.5.5. Other sects

Along with Jainism, Buddhism, Vaishnavism, and Saivism, there existed a few more religious sects though not so well known. Among them the Ajivikas deserve mention. The order of the Ajivikas was founded by Nanda Vachcha, and became strong under Gosala. They spread from Avanti to Anga, and even enjoyed the patronage of Asoka and his grandson Dasaratha. The Ajivikas were called Ekandandins as they carried the single staff. They believed that things gain perfection even through non-performance of actions, and ceaseless rounds of birth and death naturally lead to perfection. Still they were known for their 'extreme asceticism, love of solitude, disdain of comfort and even of decencies'. The Ajivikas had a long history of about 2000 years and disappeared in the fourteenth century A.D.

6.5.6. Minor Gods

The sun has been an object of worship right from the Vedic age. This worship did not rise to high position nor did it descend to a low level; it was steady throughout history. The sect which practices Sun worship is known as the Sauras. The cult of sun worship may have been very popular when Kanishka was on the throne'. That Kanishka should have coins struck with the image of Mithra... proves that the Persian solar cult infiltrated into Brahmanical belief by the first century A.D.' it was the usual practice in ancient sculptures to show Surya riding on chariots, drawn by four horses.

The worship of Skanda and Ganesa was also practiced. Skanda was treated as war-god, and therefore warlike princes and tribes adored him. Ganesa became the god of wisdom,

and giver of success. The worship of Sri or Lakshmi is also noticed in the Mauryan period. She was considered as a goddess of wealth, and, therefore, became an object of adoration. When kings too worshiped Lakshmi, she came to be known as Rajalakshmi. Naga or serpent worship deserves an honourable mention. The Nagas are supposed to represent Baladeva or Krishna. In the sculptures the Nagas are shown with one, three, five or seven hoods. They are also shown as mermaid figures- half human and half serpentine.

Check your progress-4

1. Explain the circumstances leading to the split of Jainism into two sects.
2. Describe how Asoka spread Buddhism.
3. Recollect what you know about Mahayanism.
4. Show how Vaishnavism prospered in the age of the Mauryas.
5. Describe the worship of the sun and the serpent in the Mauryan period.

6.6. Literature and Arts

The Mauryas excelled in all kinds of arts. They have left indelible impressions in literature- both secular and sacred, architecture, sculpture, etc. The Arthashastra is encyclopaedic in its range, and is treated even today as an authoritative text of polity. The pillars of Asoka continue to be admired for their engineering skill. The stupas contain graphic pictures of day to day life as lived in Mauryan India, Examples like this can be multiplied.

6.6.1. Language and Literature

The language of the Vedas had become obsolete, cultivated only by the priests before Panini. A new form of it had come into existence, by the incorporation of dialectal elements which had already crept into the language.

This was Sanskrit, described by Panini as *bhasha* which, though an artificial vehicle of expression, became the polished language of intercourse and instruction in the brahmanical institutions.

This development, however, did not interfere with the evolution of the dialects which are grouped under the name Middle Indo-Aryan. This had different stages of evolution. The earliest commenced before the Mauryas and continued upto AD 200. It is represented in the inscriptions of Maurya and Kushana periods, early Buddhist and Jaina canonical works and the dialects used in Saripatra Prakarana of Asvaghosha and the plays of Bhasa.

These dialects had by this time attained normalised forms suitable for literary purposes. The second stage commenced from about the third century AD and is represented by the literary Prakrits used in the plays by the grammarians of the later times. These Prakrits were: Magadhi, Sauraseni, Maharashtri, Avanti and Paisachi, the first three being the most important.

The early Buddhist texts were written in Magadhi whereas the early Jaina texts were written in Ardha- Magadhi. In the post-Ashokan period, Pali came to be used as an important literary language (Ceylonese tradition identify it with Magadhi).

Later on, when the centre of Jainism shifted to the west, the language came to be regarded, as a form of Maharashtri. In some Buddhist texts such as the Mahavastu and the Lalitavistara, mixed Sanskrit is used. The Brihatkatha of Gunadhya has been written in a dialect called Paisachi.

Classical Sanskrit was also establishing itself slowly in some regions. Katyayana (Mauryan) and Patanjali (Shunga) tried to maintain the high standard set by Panini. The impact of the Middle- Indo-Aryan led to the simplification of the grammar and the vocabulary by the inclusion of dialectal words in Sanskritized forms. Words were also borrowed from the non-Aryan languages - Austric and Dravidian. Sanskrit began to be used as the medium of a new literature from the beginning of the Christian era.

Asvaghosa was probably the first to use Sanskrit for the composition of plays and a new type of epic, which strictly belongs to what is known as classical Sanskrit literature. Sarvastivada and Mula-Sarvastivada schools of Buddhist philosophy adopted it and wrote their canonical literature in it.

From the middle of the second century AD the Sakas of western India became great patrons of this language. They were the first to introduce Sanskrit in inscriptions. The rulers of

this dynasty used titles like svamin, bhadramukha, sugrihitanaman and rastriya for the first time.

Since these titles are not found in earlier literature, it is possible that it was under the patronage of these foreign rulers that Sanskrit drama originated and the classical Sanskrit shaped for fine literary works.

These foreign adventurers were also responsible for propagating Sanskrit in foreign lands. The Sakas were the first Sanskritic colonists in Indo-China and Indonesia where Sanskrit was adopted in the initial charters.

The Buddhist scholars and monks carried Sanskrit to eastern Turkestan (Khotan, Kucha etc.). Thus, during the first three centuries of the Christian era classical Sanskrit firmly established itself in India and also in new lands of the Far-East and Central Asia.

Very little is known regarding the Literature of that time. However, the little that has survived is sufficient to give an idea of the literary and artistic development of the age. Indian literature had advanced considerably by that time as Vedic literature including the Samhitas, the Brahmanas and the Upanishads and the six Vedangas have been mentioned by Kautilya.

The literature of the Maurya period was composed either in Sanskrit or Prakrit or Pali languages. Only few works can be assigned to this period due to lack of evidence. Chanakya was a well-known author of this age who was also the minister of Chandragupta Maurya. He was well versed in Buddhist, Jain as well as Hindu works. He received his education at Taxila. He was a great man of his age.

Arthashastra was the famous work of Chanakya. The work is considered as a genuine composition of the Maurya age. This claim is supported by the fact that the main features of the government set forth here agree with the description of Megasthenes. Several early writers refer to Chanakya as a writer on statecraft, and Dandin, while referring to the work of Chanakya, mentions even its size which agrees exactly with the size, mentioned in the Arthashastra itself.

The Arthashastra is a book on political economy and the art of government. It is a prose work written in the form of a sutra and bhasya, divided into fifteen adhikaranas each subdivided into numerous chapters. It deals with the duties of kings, administration of public affairs, civil

and criminal law and judiciary, education and discipline of princes, military campaigns, corporations and guilds, and even natural calamities like floods and fire, relation with foreign powers, methods of warfare, and secret means to injure an enemy. In regard to slavery, Kautilya's attitude stands apart as a glowing light of liberalism and humanity in a barbaric age. He boldly enunciated that among Aryas (freeborn) none should be unfree or enslaved. His views on other social matters are also commendable. Some even doubt whether "one man (Kautilya) could have possessed so much knowledge and wisdom".

Chanakya also authored a collection of witty aphorisms, and a book entitled the Chanakya-sataka that is based on ethical poetry. He is also known to have written on medicine, and in this capacity is known to Arabic writers as Sanaqa.

The field of medicine also was well developed in the age of the Mauryas. Charaka's Samita is said to be the earliest medical treatise in India. It describes eight principal diseases and remedies for them. His work was so popular that it was translated into Persian and Arabic. Susruta was equally famous for his contribution to medical sciences; he surprises us by describing surgeries and surgical instruments.

Bhadrabahu was the greatest Prakrit author of the age, the Jain pontiff. He was the disciple of Yasobhadra who lived and wrote during the reign of Chandragupta. He has composed many Jain Prakrit works. Kalpasutra is a prominent composition of Bhadrabahu. It has been divided into three sections: Jina charitra (lives of Jinas) Sthaviravali (list of Sthaviras) and Samachari (rules for Yatis). However, it is doubtful if the whole book is the work of Bhadrabahu.

The only Pali work of the Mauryan period was the Buddhist Kathavatthu that has been ascribed to Maudgaliputra Tishya. It was composed in the reign of Ashoka. The reign of Chandragupta was not devoid of literary achievements. During the reign of Ashoka across the empire Buddhist literature was published.

6.6.2. Architecture and Sculpture

The Mauryan period is a great Landmark in the history of the Indian Art. In fact, the history of Indian Art begins with the advent of the Mauryas. The stone monuments of Aśoka have defied the ravages of time and they form the earliest artistic record of Indian civilisation

yet discovered. The perfection which the art of sculpture attained during this period suggests that it had a long period of continuous and steady developments. Tradition credits Asoka with building 84,000 stupas all over India and Afghanistan.

The monolithic pillars set up by Asoka furnish, perhaps, the finest, the most beautiful and characteristic specimens of the remains of the Mauryan art. These Asokan pillars are a triumph of engineering, architecture and sculpture. The capital of the Sarnath Pillar is undoubtedly the most magnificent and has been declared the finest piece of sculpture.

Dr. V.A. Smith makes the following observation of the Sarnath capital, which is our national emblem. "it would be difficult to find in any country an example of ancient sculpture or even equal to this beautiful work of art, which successfully combines realistic modelling with ideal dignity and is finished in every detail with perfect accuracy".

It would be an exaggeration if we call the Mauryan age a brilliant period in Indian history. The world owes a huge debt to one of the Mauryan kings – Asoka. He is the only King in the history of world who gave up war after victory and attempted to banish war entirely from the world. He not only gave to the world the lessons of religious toleration but placed before the world the model of an ideal king. The century and a half of Mauryan rule witnessed a growth of civilisation, art and culture which entitled India to rank among the greatest countries of the time.

The stone pillars of Asoka, the stupas, the chaityas, the viharas that covered the country may be cited as illustrations of Mauryan architecture. The pillars which carry the emperor's edicts are monolithic columns with animal capitals. Great engineering and technical skill were shown in cutting, chiselling and removing these pillars hundreds of miles from the quarry. 'the Capital of the Sarnath Pillar is undoubtedly the best of the series. The figures of four lions standing back to back show a highly advanced form of art'- V.A. Smith is all admiration for the animal sculpture.

Stupas were erected over the relics of the Buddha –a tooth, a nail, ashes-on sites held sacred by the Buddhists. The stupa is a domical structure of brick or stone; it is surrounded by a railing with ornamental gateways. Asoka is believed to have built 84,000 stupas all over India

and Afghanistan. The stupa at Sanchi fortunately still exists; its diameter is 121.5feet, and height 77.5feet; the railing which enclosed it is 11feet high. The railing and gateways contain life-like sculptures; similar sculptures may be seen in Bharhut, Bodh Gaya, Mathura, Amaravathi, and Nagarjunakonda. The famous Mathura sculptures represent Buddha as a human being; the convention of showing Buddha in the form of symbols- a lotus, a wheel, a couple of foot prints, and umbrella yielded place to images. All Mathura sculptures were made of red sand stone from Sikri.

6.6.3. Cities

Foreigners were tremendously impressed by cities in Mauryan India. The Greek ruler Menander describes an Indian city as 'fine and regular, measured out into quarters, with excavated moats and ramparts about it, with stout gate houses and towers, with market places, cross roads, street corners, and public squares, with parks, gardens, lakes, lotus ponds and wells, adorned with many kinds of temples of the gods, free from every fault and standing in all its glory; 'this description may be taken as the standard scheme for all Mauryan cities. Magnificent buildings were not lacking. Classical writers have compared the palace buildings at Pataliputra with those of Susa and Ecbatana. Excavations around Patna prove that this view is right.

6.7. Ashokan Edicts

The Ashokan rock edicts were deciphered by James Prinsep in 1837. As these scripts were inscribed on rocks and pillars, they are known as rock edicts or pillar edicts. These edicts were installed in all prominent places like major travel routes, near towns and religious places to catch the attention of the people.

In course of time many of the pillars were moved from their original places. For example, Topra and Meerut pillars were shifted to Delhi by Firoz Shah Tuglaq, Pillar at Kausambi was shifted to Allahabad and Bairat pillar was shifted to Calcutta by Cunningham.

These edicts were commonly in Prakrit language and Brahmi script. But in North West the script was Kharosthi whereas in Extreme west the script was Greek and Aramaic. The Edicts of Ashoka generally provide information on Administration, Religion, Ethics, Foreign and domestic policies and also about the extent of Mauryan Empire.

Major Rock Edicts

The Major rock edicts are total fourteen in number. They are called so as they are inscribed on large boulders. Major rock edicts represent the exposition of Ashoka's government and ethical system. These edicts define the nature, scope and application of dhamma. The original location of the major rock edicts is given in the below table:

Major rock edict	Location
Kalsi	Dehradun
Girnar	Gujarat
Yerragudi	Andhra Pradesh
Mansehar	Pakistan
Sopara	Mumbai
Dhauili and Jaugada	Odisha
Shahbazgarhi	Pakistan

In Kalinga, two separate edicts called Edicts XV and Edicts XVI are located. They are substitute for the three edicts namely,

- * Edict XI on charity and kinship of mankind
- * Edict XII on religious tolerance
- * Edict XIII on Kalinga war and change of heart

Minor Rock Edicts

The minor edicts are concentrated in south and central parts of the Mauryan Empire. They are called so as they are inscribed on smaller boulders. These edicts highlight the activities of Ashoka as a Buddhist and also about Dhamma. The following table gives the information about the location of Minor rock edicts.

Minor rock edict	Location
Bairat	Rajasthan
Jatinga-Rameshwaram	Karnataka
Sahsaram	Bihar
Rupanath	Madhya Pradesh
Gavimath	Mysore (Karnataka)
Bramhagiri	Karnataka
Maski	Karnataka
Gujjara	Madhya Pradesh
Palkigundu	Karnataka
Rajula-Mandagiri	Andhra Pradesh
Siddapur	Karnataka
Suvarnagiri	Karnataka
Yerragudi	Andhra Pradesh
Nittur	Karnataka
Udegolam	Karnataka
Kandahar	Afghanistan

The minor rock edict found at Kandahar is bilingual and is inscribed in Greek and Aramaic scripts. The name Ashoka is clearly mentioned in the rock edicts at Maski, Gujjara, Nittur and Udegolam. The title most commonly adopted by Ashoka in his edicts is Devanampiya Piyadasi (Beloved gods). The latest discovery of three minor edicts is made from Sannati village, Karnataka.

Pillar Edicts

Originally there could have been many Pillar edicts but, only nineteen survive with inscriptions and seven survive with capitals. The stone of these pillars was transported from either Mathura or Chunar hills to different parts of the Empire. The pillar edict VII is considered to be the last edict issued by Ashoka. The following is the table giving information about few important pillar Edicts,

Topra-Delhi Pillar Edict

Delhi-Meerut Pillar Edict

Rampurva Pillar Edict

Lauriya-Araraj Pillar Edict

Lauria-Nandangarh Pillar Edict

Allahabad-Kosam Pillar Edict

Check your progress -5

1. Write a note on Manu-Smriti.
2. Point out the merits of Arthasastra.
3. Explain the purpose for which Stupas were erected.
4. Show the layout of a Mauryan city.
5. Explain about the Asokan Edicts

6.8. Let us sum up

Whatever Mauryas did, they did it with a thoroughness that is commendable. Their devotion to perfection has elicited the admiration of foreigners like the Greeks. Their political institutions, social Cohesion, economic enterprises, religious experiments, and artistic achievements will be remembered forever.

6.9. Answers to check your progress

Check your progress -1

1. See 6.2.2 (except paragraph 2)
2. See 6.2.2 Paragraph 2
3. See 6.2.3
4. See 6.2.5
5. See 6.2.7

Check your progress -2

1. See 6.3.1
2. See 6.3.4 Paragraph 1
3. See 6.3.5
4. See 6.3.6
5. See 6.3.8

Check your progress -3

1. See 6.4.1
2. See 6.4.3
3. See 6.4.4- Paragraph 1
4. See 6.4.5
5. See 6.4.6

Check your progress -4

1. See 6.5.1-Paragraph 1
2. See 6.5.2
3. See 6.5.3
4. See 6.5.4
5. See 6.5.4- Paragraph 2 and 3.

Check your progress -5

1. See 6.6.1 Paragraph 2
2. See 6.6.1 Paragraph 5
3. See 6.6.2 Paragraph 2
4. See 6.6.3
5. See 6.7.

LESSON - 7

THE CULTURAL ACHIEVEMENTS OF THE KUSHANS

Learning Objectives

After learning this lesson, you will be able to

- Explain the details of administration under Kushanas
- Describe the social structure under Kushans
- Narrate the economic activities of people, like agricultural, industries, and trade
- Comment on their religion, especially Mahayanism and
- Write on their achievements in arts and letters

Structure

7.1 Introduction

7.2 Administration

7.2.1. Officials

7.2.2. Administrative Divisions

7.3 Society Under the Kushanas

7.4 Literature

7.5 Economic Condition

7.5.1. Kushana Coinage

7.6 Religion

7.6.1. Buddhist Council

7.6.2. Mahayanism

7.7 Art, Sculpture and Architecture

7.7.1. Gandhara Sculpture

7.7.2. Mathura Art

7.8 Let us sum up

7.9 Answers to check your progress

7.0. Introduction

The abundance of coins and inscription as well as of literary evidence make it somewhat easy to have an idea of the overall condition of India under the Kushanas and to estimate the achievements of the period.

The dark age that commenced upon the downfall of the Maurya Empire and the political unity which the labours of Chandragupta and Asoka gave to India, was broken by the intruding Indo-Greek Parthian and the Scythians ended with the triumph of the Kushanas. The darkness was lifted and lost political unity was re-established. The Kushana Empire embraced most of northern India, north-western India and beyond, up to Central Asia. The Kushana empire was the second great Indian empire, the first being that of the Mauryas.

7.2. Administration

Kanishka's empire comprised vast tracts of land extending from Afghanistan, and Khotan, Yarkhand, Kashgarh, etc. in Central Asia to Benares, and perhaps to parts of Bengal. His empire included Gandhara, Peshawar, Oudh, Pataliputra, Mathura. Inclusion of Kashmir is borne out by both the Chinese and Buddhist evidences. The western Satrapies seem to have been under his suzerainty.

According to Hiuen Tsang Kanishka Raja of Gandhara in old days having subdued all the neighbouring provinces and brought into obedience the people of distant countries, governed by his army a wide territory even to the east of the Tsung-ling mountains. All this proves that Kanishka's sway extended beyond the borders of India.

The Buddhist tradition and Kanishka's own inscriptions are ample testimony to the vast expanse of his dominions within India. Selection of Purushapura, i.e. Peshawar, proves that Kanishka's imperial possessions spread far towards the west and north.

7.2.1. Officials

The Kushanas were foreigners who got Indianized. The administrative system under them was, therefore, a mixture of both foreign and Indian elements. Government by the system of Satrapies was the foreign elements in the Kushana administration and the use of the names

like Satraps for Governors and Viceroys, Strategos for the military governors, Meridarch for district officers, while manifested it, the use of the names such as Mahasenapati, Amatyas, etc. showed the Indian element in the administration.

It is of interest to note that the areas in the north-west which were under the Bactrians, Parthians and Scythians before coming under the sway of the Kushanas were placed under officers with foreign designations whereas officers with Indian designations were placed in charge of territories in the interior.

The Indo-Greek system of conjoint rule was also followed as we understand from Kanishka II and Huvishka's joint rule. The Satraps—senior and junior—were called Mahakshatrapas and Kshatrapas. The Kushana kings assumed titles Mahisvara, Devaputra, Kaisar, Shahnu Shah, etc.

7.2.2. Administrative Divisions

Kanishka was a mighty conqueror, but no less was his ability as an administrator and he was even mightier in peaceful pursuits and in his solicitousness of the welfare of the people. For an effective and efficient rule of the empire he resorted to the system of Satrapies and appointed Mahakshatrapa Kharapallana and Kshatrapa Vanaspara in the eastern part of the empire.

The northern part was ruled by General Lala as Mahakshatrapa with Vaspasi and Laika as Kshatrapas. The seat of the Central Government was at Purushpura or Peshawar. This practice of rule through Great Satraps and Satraps was the continuation of the system followed by the Sakas and the Pahlavas.

For administrative purposes the empire was divided into Rashtra, Ahara, Janapada, Desa or Vishaya. There appears to have been no Assembly or Council of Ministers. The king appears to have been the supreme head of the state in all matters, religious and secular. Under the Kushanas there was a spirit of toleration prevalent all over the country.

Check your progress-1

6. What do you know about the administration under Kushanas?

7.3. Society Under the Kushanas

Although the society, generally speaking, retained the original fourfold division into Brahmanas, Kshatriyas, Vaisyas and Sudras, but the rigidity of the caste-system under the Kushanas does not seem to be so exclusive as to preclude foreigners from entering the Hindu Society. The Kushanas, an outlandish race, gradually became thoroughly Hindus. This shows the basic virility of the Hindu Society and culture.

7.4. Literature

The Kushana period witnessed a remarkable development of literature and Sanskrit language. Under the patronage enjoyed by the scholars and Buddhist philosophers of the time a massive development in secular and religious literature took place. A large number of standard works in Sanskrit language were written during the period.

Asvaghosha's Buddhacharita, Saudarananda Kavya, Vajrasuchi, Sariputta Prakarana, Vasumitra's Mahabibhasa—regarded as the Buddhist encyclopaedia, Nagarjuna's Madhyamika-Sutra in which the theory of relativity was propounded, Charaka's work on medicine, etc. contributed to the fund of human knowledge. Under the Kushanas the royal court became a seat of luminaries mentioned above as also of the Political Scientist Mathara, Greek engineer Agesilaus, etc.

Kanishka's patronage of art and learning marked the beginning of a cultural renaissance which was to reach its peak and flower under the Guptas. A large volume of Sanskrit literary works both religious and secular, was produced during the period. Asvaghosha, the great-est Buddha Philosopher, saint and literary figure of the time adorned the court of Kanishka.

He was a versatile genius whose contributions to the cultural life of the time centred round poetry, philosophy, drama, music. Buddhacharita and Sutralankar are his two most famous works. Buddhacharita on the life of Gautama Buddha in Sanskrit verse has been regarded as a Buddhist epic. Another great Buddhist writer of fame who adorned the court of Kanishka was Nagarjuna. He was the greatest exponent of Mahayana Buddhism.

Charaka, the celebrated master of the science of medicine, was the court physician of Kanishka. Mathara, a politician of great acumen, was a minister of Kanishka. Besides these

worthies, the Greek engineer Agesilaus and many others played a leading part in the religious, literary, scientific, philosophical and artistic activities of the reign. It is of great interest to know that Nagarjuna in his celebrated work *Madhyamikasutra* expounded the theory of relativity in its preliminary form.

Another celebrity that adorned the court of Kanishka was Vasu-mitra who presided over the Fourth Buddhist Council held during the reign of Kanishka.

Check your progress -2

1. Write a note on the growth of literature under Kushanas

7.5. Economic Condition

The Kushana period saw an all-round development. In the field of economy, the peace and tranquility ensured by the efficient rule of the early Kushana rulers, absence of internal revolt and external in-vasion conducted to an unprecedented economic prosperity. Commercial relations with Eastern and Western countries led to an in-flux of gold.

India had a brisk trade with Rome and China where- from gold poured in due to the balance of trade that India had. Such was the huge amount of gold that came from Rome into India for the export of spices, silk, muslin, gems, etc. to that country that Pliny lamented over the drainage of gold to India.

Historian Momsen also refers to the heavy drainage of Roman gold to India for imports from India. The Roman government ultimately had to ban imports from India by passing a law. Sea-borne trade used to be conducted through ports in the Western and South Indian coasts, particularly from Broach.

The coins of the Kushana were mostly of gold and to some extent of copper. The coins depict the foreign influence—Roman—on the currency system. The eclecticism of the Kushana kings can as well be understood from the representation of deities—Iranian, Elamite, etc. on the coins. The Kushana coins also had representations of Brahmanical deities on them.

7.5.1. Kushana Coinage

The coins of foreign rulers like the Bactrian Greeks seem to have influenced Indian coins. The Graeco-Bactrian coins and the Roman coins influenced the coins of the Sakas, the Parthians, and the Kushanas, and the coins of the Sakas, the Parthians, and the Kushanas influenced the coins of Indian rulers.

The empire of the Kushanas experienced much prosperity due to the trading activities of the merchants. They carried out their trade mainly in silk with the Roman Empire. Their commercial activities generated huge amount of wealth; part of which find its way into the Kushana treasury. The prosperity of the Kushana Empire is well reflected in their coins.

The first two Kushana kings, Kujula and Vima issued gold coins. Archaeologists and Numismatists have also found their copper coins. The Kushana coins are excellent examples of artistic excellence and sophistication. The coins were die-struck and produced in large numbers to facilitate growing trade and commerce. They resembled a great similarity to the earlier Indo-Greek coins as these coins also depicted the portrait of the issuing monarch in a great detail. The Kushanas also closely followed the Indo-Greek weight standard in minting their coins. Some of the coins of Vima Kadphises were minted following the Roman aureus. The early gold coins of the Kushanas weigh around 8 gm. We have also some specimens of silver coins issued by Vima. The silver coins were mainly circulated in the area of lower Indus region.

Another main characteristic of the Kushana coins are the depiction of various deities on the reverse of the coins. Various Greek, Iranian, Bactrian and Indian deities were featured in the Kushana coins. We found the Indo-Iranian deities like Mazda, Mao, Athsho, etc. inscribed on the coins of the Kushanas. This is significant because it showed the syncretism nurtured by the Kushana rulers.

Another significant example of the syncretism of the Kushanas is evident from their issue of bilingual coins. The obverse of the coins carries Greek inscriptions and the reverse Kharosthi inscriptions using the Prakrit language which was the lingua franca of northern India during the early centuries of Christian era.

The greatest of the Kushana rulers is Kanishka I. He expanded the Kushana rule to many far-flung areas of central and eastern India. He also reformed the currency system and issued new variety of coins. The martial character of the king is well depicted in the coins. He can be seen carrying a spear in his left hand in many of the coins. The Greek and Indian gods and goddesses continued to feature in the Kushana coins. The prominence of the Indian god Shiva in the coins of Kanishka and later Kushanas is regarded by numismatists as a proof of their conversion to Saivism in later days. Buddhism also had a profound effect on the Kushanas. It is well documented in the archaeological remains. Buddha is also represented in various forms in their coins. Buddha is regarded as Boddo and Sakamano Boddo in these coins. These corroborate the literary texts which described the great patronage provided by Kanishka to Buddhism. Kanishka is still much revered as one of the greatest patrons of Buddhism. However, the policies of issuing bilingual coins were discontinued in favor of Greek or Bactrian legends.

The later Kushana rulers such as Vasudeva, Huvishka, etc. continued to issue highly sophisticated gold coins. The portrait of Huvishka in the coins is highly appreciated for its artistic excellence and exact depiction of the.

Due to the abundance of the gold coins of the Kushanas, they are considered as the worthy predecessors of the Guptas by some scholars.

Kadphises-II opened up path of commercial intercourse with China and Rome. It was he who had sent an embassy to the Roman emperor Trajan. He issued gold coins of Roman weight and standard besides an extensive number of copper coins. Some gold coins of Kadphises-II were issued in imitation of the Greek coins.

The great influx of Roman gold through commerce accounted for the economic prosperity under Kadphises-II. Indian spices, silk, gems were much in demand in Rome. Pliny bitterly complained against drainage of Roman gold to India. In order to stop the drainage of Roman gold to India, import of Indian goods was banned in Rome by legislation.

Kadphises-II became a zealous convert to Pasupata or Mahesvara creed. He is supposed to have been converted to Saivism some time before his formal accession. This is presumed

from the fact that the reverse device of his coins almost invariably consists of Siva with a long trident and sometimes accompanied by a bull. His coins not only indicate his religious belief but also accession to great power for the obverse of his coins depicts him as the Lord of the Worlds, the Great King, King of Kings, etc.

The practice of issuing bilingual and by scriptural coins introduced by the Indo-Greek kings was continued throughout the Saka-Pahlava period upto the time of Kadphises. The continuity of the practice without break till the time of Wima Kadphises was broken only at the time of Kanishka who gave up the practice of issuing bilingual coins. The legend of his coins was Greek but most of them were not, however, in Greek. Hurishka and Vasudeva followed the practice of Kanishka. Thus, we find that while there was a continuity in the method of the striking coins followed up to Wima Kadphises from the line of the Indo-Greeks a different method was followed and continued by Kanishka and his successors.

We find a conscious emulation of the methods of Asoka by the Kushana king Kanishka. He pursued the policy of propagating Bud-dhism both within India and outside India. It was in connection with his missionary activities that he established close relationship, religious cultural and commercial, not only with China, Tibet and Central Asia but also with Rome and influx of gold from China and Rome in parti-cular. The prosperity of the empire attested by the fine gold coins struck by Kadphises I appears to have increased under Kanishka. The unmistakable influence of Rome on the Indian coinage of the time could be noticed.

From the Periplus we know that gold and silver specie constituted one of the imports of Barygaza, i.e., Borach, a port on the eastern sea board of India. Swell has also mentioned to huge hoard of Roman coins of the first five Roman emperors discovered in the Madras Presidency. The very name dinara of gold coins seems to have close affinity with the Roman denarius and drama for silver coins has been adopted from the Greek drachma.

Kanishka assumed epithet like Shaonau Shoo, as found on his coins, was an adaptation of the Parthian title Basileos Basileon. From Shaonau Shoo the word Shaahan Sha was derived.

Check your progress-3

6. Summarize about the Kushana Coinage.

7.6. Religion

The Kushanas followed a policy of toleration and Brahmanical Hinduism, Jainism and Buddhism flourished side by side under their rule.

The Kushanas were of the Yue-chi origin and were foreigners who were eclectic in their religious belief to begin with as we understand from the numismatic evidence. But they later became either Buddhists or worshippers of Siva or Vishnu. While Kaniska became an ardent follower of Buddhism, took measures for propagation of the religion even in foreign countries like China, Tibet, Japan etc. some of the Kushana kings, it seems from their coins, honoured Greek, Sumerian, Elamite, Zoroastrian and Mithraic deities. Some again, for instance, Kadphises II was a Saiva and Vasudeva perhaps a follower of both Vishnu and Siva.

Kanishka as a Buddhist emulated his royal predecessor Asoka of the Maurya Dynasty and not only sent missionaries to outside countries but also took steps to resolve the disputes among the followers of Buddhism with regard to Buddhist doctrines. He summoned the Fourth Buddhist Council which thoroughly examined the whole Buddhist literature and prepared voluminous commentaries on the three Buddhist Pitakas. The commentaries were collected in Mahavibhasha, regarded as the Buddhist encyclopaedia. Mahayanism now became the dominant form of Buddhism.

As it is customary for the Buddhist writers to depict a person wicked before conversion and turned into saint after conversion to Buddhism. Kanishka has been described by them to be devoid of the sense of right or wrong before his conversion. This view of the Buddhist writers has not been accepted by most of the scholars who think that it is an attempt on the part of the Buddhist writers to glorify Buddhism.

Before conversion to Buddhism Kanishka was a believer in many gods, Persian, Greek, Hindu, etc. This is proved by the figures imprinted on his coins. The exact date of conversion of Kanishka is, however, not known. The conversion is supposed to have taken place after some

years he had been on the throne. It is supposed that after his association with the Buddhist philosopher and Saint Asvaghosha, he must have come under his influence.

Asvaghosha must have won the heart of Kanishka so completely that the latter gave up his allegiance to his previous gods and got converted to Buddhism. Here is a second instance of a great conqueror and emperor being converted to Buddhism and taken to the policy of peace and brotherliness in place of the policy of military conquests.

Kanishka was a close copy of Asoka. What is especially noteworthy about Kanishka is that he was the only foreigner who became a convert to an Indian religion and turned into zealous missionary. In his missionary activities we find him to be an emulator of Asoka whose foot-steps he tried to follow closely.

We renovated the old monasteries which were in a state of disrepair and built many a new one. He endowed the monasteries with liberal money grants for the maintenance of the monks who dwelt in them. Kanishka caused the construction of a number of stupas in the memory of Sakyamuni.

He also sent missionaries for the propagation of Buddhism to China, Tibet, Japan and Central Asia. The sculptors, painters, as well as the architects of his time also became active propagandists of Buddhism. The celebrated Chaitya at Peshawar constructed under his orders excited the wonder and appreciation of travellers down to a late period and famous sculptures therein included a life-size statue of himself.

During his time there arose disputes about Buddhism, among 18 schools of Buddhism prevalent at that time, as we know from the Tibetan historian Taranath. It became necessary to restore the disputes and to that end Kanishka convoked the Fourth Buddhist Council to which was attended by 500 monks.

There is a controversy with regard to the venue of the Council. According to some it was held at Kundavana in Kashmir but others hold that it met at Jullundur in the Punjab. In the Council the entire Buddhist literature was thoroughly examined and commentaries on the three Pitakas were prepared, which were compiled in Mahavibhasha which is the greatest work on Buddhist Philosophy.

This voluminous work is considered to be the encyclopaedia of Buddhism. The decisions of the Council were inscribed in copper plates and deposited in a stupa built for the purpose, packed in stone chests. Vasumitra acted as the President and Asvaghosha as the Vice-President of the Council.

7.6.1. Buddhist Council

The period of Kanishka saw the transformation of the Hinayana form of Buddhism into Mahayana form. In the Hinayana form the worship of Buddha was only by relics like footprint of Buddha, an empty seat of Buddha, that is, some sort of symbol used to be placed in front of the worshipper.

There used to be no figure or image of Buddha to worship. This needed great concentration of mind on the part of the worshipper and the method was very subtle and could be followed by persons of great self-control, and of deepest religious bent of mind. This method of proceeding along the Path of Buddhist religion was called Hina-Yana, i.e., lesser vehicle, i.e., subtle mode of transport in the path of religion.

But during Kanishka's time worship of the image of Buddha came into use. It became easy to concentrate by keeping as visible representation of Buddha in form. This was a greater and easier method hence called Mahayana Buddhism. In the Hinayana form of worship emphasis was laid on good action but in Mahayana system worship of Buddha and Bodhisattvas was emphasised. The use of Pali as the language of the Buddhist religious books was now replaced by Sanskrit.

7.6.2. Mahayanism

Buddhism of Kanishka differed from that of Asoka. It is known as Mahayanism- the great Path, and its origin is traced to the fourth Buddhist council convened by Kanishka around A.D.100. the Mahayanists treated Buddha as a God, and started worshipping him with garlands and perfumes. They made pilgrimages 'to the four places sanctified by the Buddha's birth, his attainment of Bodhi, his first promulgation of the Dhamma, and his entry into Nirvana'. In the early days the Buddha was venerated as a man, as a great man; but from the beginning of the Christian era he became to be treated as a Deva, as a Devati Deva. Images and shrines came

to be created for the Buddha. Buddhism ceased to be simple and became more complex, and came to be dominated by ritual. The devotees found in Mahayanism a means for expressing their devotion.

Mahayanism is said to have blossomed into full glory under savants like Nagarjuna, Aryadeva, Asana, and Vasubandhu. Nagarjuna, the chief abbot of Nalanda, was the earliest exponent of Mahayanism. Mahayana form of Buddhism became a popular cult all over India, and even beyond its frontiers. Kanishka is said to have convened a council of 500 monks at Kundalavana monastery near Srinagar. The council, presided over by Vasumitra, wrote on copper plates a commentary on the Tripitaka; the plates were enclosed in stone boxes, and a stupa erected over them, Kanishka also issued coins bearing the Buddha's image.

Check your progress-4

6. Explain about the contribution of Kanishka for the growth of Buddhism
7. Recollect what you know about Mahayanism.

7.7. Art, Sculpture and Architecture

7.7.1. Gandhara Sculpture

The Kushana period witnessed a remarkable development in art, sculpture and architecture. The Gandhara School of Art and Sculpture marked a happy blending of the Greco-Romano-Buddhist style and techniques. The distinguishing features of the Gandhara Sculpture owed their origin to Greek and Roman styles yet the art essentially was Indian in spirit. The Gandhara artists had the hand of a Greek but the heart of an India.

The most remarkable contribution of the Gandhara School of art is to be seen in the evolution of the image of Buddha, perhaps in imitation of the Greek God Apollo. Images of Buddha and Bodhisatva illustrating the past and present lives of Buddha were executed in black stone. The figures show an excellent idea of human anatomy that swayed the artists.

These works of art offer a striking contrast to similar art that we witness elsewhere in India. The smooth round features of the idealised human figures, draped in transparent and semi-transparent cloth closely fitting to the body and revealing its outline were due to the influence of the Hellenistic art of Asia Minor and the Roman Empire.

The images of Buddha pertaining to the Gandhara school centres of which were Gandhara, Jalalabad, Hadda and Baniyan in Afghanistan, Peshawar and Swat Valley, were more animated and anatomically perfect than those found in other parts of India. While the former are more beautiful physically and accurate in anatomical details as such more realistic, the Indian art and sculpture which produced the images of Buddha were more idealistic giving a spiritual and sublime expression to the images.

The technique of the Gandhara School of art of the Kushana period spread through China to the Far East and influenced the art of China and Japan. The Gandhara art, according to V. A. Smith, was based on the cosmopolitan art of the Asia Minor and the Roman Empire.

There were also purely Indian schools of art in India during the period of the Kushanas. There were the schools of art at Amaravati, Jagayyapeta and Nagarjunikonda. In the Amaravati human figures are characterised by slim, blithe features and have been represented in most difficult poses and curves. The technique of art reached a high standard of development. Plants and flowers, particularly lotuses, have been represented in the most perfect, lifelike manner.

Two Chaityas and a Stupa discovered at Nagarjunikonda are the relics of the indigenous school of art and show a high standard of development. The limestone panel of figures depicting the nativity of Buddha is an excellent piece of sculpture of the Kushana period which was entirely indigenous.

Architecture of the Kushana period was not so remarkable as the sculpture of the period. There were beautiful temples, monasteries, Stupas which indicate considerable development during the period although the technique of architecture did not attain the standard of excellence of sculpture. The famous tower of Kanishka at Purushapura (Peshawar) was one of the wonders of the world. Much of the architectural specimens of the period perished with time.

Caves hewn in solid rock with pillars and sculptures, hundreds of which have been found in different parts of the Kushana Empire show a great improvement upon the technique of excavation that was in use during the time of Asoka. A Chaitya with rows of columns on two sides was a fine work of art of sculpture and architecture. The Chaitya at Karle is an excellent illustration.

Fa-hien who visited India during the rule of Chandragupta II (5th century) was struck with wonder to find a large number of Stupas, dagobas (small stupa), Chaityas and images of Buddha carved out of stone during the Kushana period.

There has been a sharp difference of opinion about the celebrity, and the extent of influence of the Gandhara art upon the Indian art during the reign of the Kushanas. Modern scholars think that the Gandhara School of sculpture has attained a celebrity perhaps beyond its merits.

According to some European scholars, the Gandhara School of art was the only school in Ancient India which can claim a place in the domain of art. There are others who are of the opinion that the source of subsequent development of Indian art as well as of the Far East was the Gandhara School of art which developed as a result of a happy blending of the Graco-Romano-Buddhist art.

But despite the foreign influence upon the school of Gandhara art, scholars like Havell, Will Durant, R. C. Majumdar and others are of the opinion that the influence, Hellenistic and Roman, upon the Indian art which was the Gandhara School of art was technical but spirit and the subject matter of the art was purely Indian.

R. D. Banerjee's view that the Gandhara art influenced the Indian art for nearly five centuries to follow is untenable on the ground that there were indigenous schools of art at Amaravati, Nagarjunkonda, etc. where there was no influence of Gandhara School of art. The influence of the Gandhara art failed to penetrate into the interior of India and had no influence on the later development of the Indian art. But the Gandhara School of art achieved a grand success in becoming the parent of the Buddhist art of Eastern and Chinese Turkestan, Mongolia, China, Korea and Japan.

The Gandhara art flourished in its best style during the time of Kanishka. The figures of the Buddha made as Gandhara shown with rustic strength and dressed in folded drapery which is almost transparent. As the influence of Greek sculpture is unmistakable on these images of Buddha, the art is known Graeco-Buddhist. The Gandhara artists moulded the human body in a realistic manner, and great attention to physical details. It is said that the technique may be Greek but the spirit was Indian. 'The Gandhara artist had the hand of a Greek but the heart of an Indian'.

Kanishka was also a great builder and a patron of art and architecture. The works of architecture, art of sculpture of his time are found in Mathura, Peshawar, Taxila and Amaravati. The Sirsukh city in Taxila with its hall, buildings and monasteries was built by him. Statues, sculptures, monasteries added to the beauty of the city.

The Gandhara School of art was the product of Graeco-Roman-Buddhist school of art and sculpture. Totally indigenous art also flourished during his reign at Amaravati. The ornamental sculpture depicted in the Amaravati medallion bear testimony to the excellence of purely Indian style uninfluenced by any foreign art. At Mathura find of Kanishka's headless statue is an example of the massive sculptural art of the time.

7.7.2. Mathura Art

Mathurā art, style of Buddhist visual art that flourished in the trading and pilgrimage centre of Mathura, Uttar Pradesh, India, from the 2nd century BC to the 12th century AD; its most distinctive contributions were made during the Kushān and Gupta periods (1st–6th century AD). Images in the mottled red sandstone from the nearby Sīkri quarries are found widely distributed over north central India, attesting to Mathurā's importance as an exporter of sculpture.

The Mathurā school was contemporaneous with a second important school of Kushān art, that of Gandhāra in the northwest, which shows strong Greco-Roman influence. About the 1st century AD each area appears to have evolved separately its own representations of the Buddha. The Mathurā images are related to the earlier yakṣa (male nature deity) figures, a resemblance particularly evident in the colossal standing Buddha images of the early Kushān period. In these, and in the more representative seated Buddhas, the overall effect is one of enormous energy. The shoulders are broad, the chest swells, and the legs are firmly planted with feet spaced apart. Other characteristics are the shaven head; the *ushnisha* (protuberance on the top of the head) indicated by a tiered spiral; a round smiling face; the right arm raised in *abhaya-mudrā* (gesture of reassurance); the left arm *akimbo* or resting on the thigh; the drapery closely moulding the body and arranged in folds over the left arm, leaving the right shoulder bare; and the presence of the lion throne rather than the lotus throne. Later, the hair began to be treated as a series of short flat spirals lying close to the head, the type that came to be the standard representation throughout the Buddhist world.

Jaina and Hindu images of the period are carved in the same style, and the images of the Jaina TīrthaEkaras, or saints, are difficult to distinguish from contemporary images of the Buddha, except by reference to iconography. The dynastic portraits produced by the Mathurā workshops are of special interest. These rigidly frontal figures of Kushān kings are dressed in Central Asian fashion, with belted tunic, high boots, and conical cap, a style of dress also used for representations of the Hindu sun god, Sūrya.

The female figures at Mathura, carved in high relief on the pillars and gateways of both Buddhist and Jaina monuments, are frankly sensuous in their appeal. These delightful nudes or semi-nude figures are shown in a variety of toilet scenes or in association with trees, indicating their continuance of the yakcī (female nature deity) tradition seen also at other Buddhist sites, such as Bhārhut and Sānchi. As auspicious emblems of fertility and abundance they commanded a popular appeal that persisted with the rise of Buddhism.

Check your progress -5

1. Appreciate the exquisiteness of Gandhara Art
2. Highlight the marvellous features of Mathura Art

7.8. Let us sum up

From the cultural point of view the Kushana period marked the beginning of a renaissance which was to reach its peak and flower under the Guptas. The cultural renaissance which saw its beginning under the Kushana rulers was the result of the impact of diverse foreign influences, Hellenic, Roman, Parthian, and Scythian on the Indian cul-ture.

The happy blending of these diverse influences gave a new life to the Indian culture which was for a time became somewhat disturbed by foreign invasions. These diverse influences found op-portunities to settle down during the peaceful rule of the Kushanas and led to the beginning of a cultural renaissance.

Kanishka happens to be one of the few kings in history who came in as a conqueror and won an empire but was conquered by the religion, language and culture of the country of his conquest. He was an intrepid warrior, a mighty conqueror but what was more he was equally

great as an administrator. If he was great in war and administration, he was greater still in the arts of peace.

He was a great patron of art and literature. He built a vast empire which extended from Central Asia to Mathura, Benares and probably to parts of Bengal but he gave it an administration which brought peace and prosperity to the country and the people, which conduced to pursuit of religion, art, architecture and literature. Before his conversion to Buddhism he was eclectic in his religious belief and was a polytheist.

After becoming a Buddhist, he became an ardent missionary of the Mahayanism. He rendered a great service to Buddhism by convening the Fourth Buddhist Council which resolved the disputes that arose among the Buddhists about Buddhist religion. He was a great patron of Buddhism as his predecessor of the Maurya Dynasty Asoka. Like Asoka he sent missions for propagation of Buddhism in China, Japan, Tibet, Central Asia, etc.

He patronized the Buddhist philosophers like Asvaghosha, Basumitra, Nagarjuna, Political scientist like Mathara, medical scientist like Charaka, and engineer like Greek Agesilaus.

He was a great patron of art and architecture. The city of Purushapura, his capital, Taxila, Mathura were beautified by monasteries, stupas, etc. The tall Chaitya at his capital with its sculpture forced the admiration of visitors even after long time.

The beneficence of his rule was seemed in the prosperity of the people resulting from the influx of huge quantity of gold by way of trade with foreign countries like China, Rome, etc.

Kanishka has been likened to Asoka as a conqueror, preacher. But although he was definitely a lesser personality than Great Asoka, he was the nearest emulator of Asoka in his spirit of toleration of other religions, patronage of Buddhism, and missionary zeal. He, however, was not an apostle of non-violence as Asoka had been yet he had initiated a cultural renaissance which reached its zenith under the Guptas.

Kanishka's reign constituted a brilliant epoch in the history of ancient India and the darkness that descended on the Indian History after the fall of the Mauryas was lifted during his reign. Kanishka rightly deserves a place among the best rulers of the ancient history of

India. The Kushanas who had be-come totally Indianized, adopted Indian social customs, religion and culture.

7.9. Answers to check your progress

Check your progress -1

6. See 7.2. – 7.2.2.

Check your progress -2

6. See 7.4.

Check your progress -3

6. See 7.5.1.

Check your progress -4

6. See 7.6 & 7.6.1.
7. See 7.6.2.

Check your progress -5

6. See 7.7.1
7. See 7.7.2.

LESSON – 8

CULTURAL FLORESCENCE OF THE GUPTA AGE

Learning Objectives

After learning this lesson, you will be able to

- Explain the administrative institutions of the Guptas
- Describe their society, especially their castes, position of women and education
- Highlight the progress in agriculture, industries, trade and commerce,
- Trace the high position reached by Vaishnavism, besides the condition of other religions.
- Narrate the development of literature under the Guptas
- Investigate the blossoming of manifold arts.

Structure

8.1 Introduction

8.2 Administration

8.2.1. King

8.2.2 Officers

8.2.3. Provincial and District Administration

8.2.4. Fahien's Record

8.3 Social Life

8.3.1. Castes

8.3.2. Marriages

8.3.3. Position of Women

8.3.4. Food

8.3.5. City Life

8.3.6. Education

8.4 Economic Condition

8.4.1. Agriculture**8.4.2. Industries****8.4.3. Trade****8.4.4. Guilds****8.5 Religion****8.5.1. Buddhism****8.5.2. Jainism****8.5.3. Vaishnavism****8.5.4. Saivism****8.6 Literature****8.6.1. Kalidasa and other Writers****8.7 Arts****8.7.1 Architecture****8.7.2. Sculpture****8.7.3. Painting****8.7.4. Coins****8.8 Let us sum up****8.9 Answers to check your progress****8.0. Introduction**

The Gupta Empire, founded by Maharaja Sri Gupta, was an ancient Indian realm existing from the mid-to-late 3rd century CE to 590 CE. At its zenith, from approximately 319 to 550 CE, it covered much of the Indian subcontinent. Gupta rule, while solidified by territorial expansion through war, began a period of peace and prosperity marked by advancements in science, technology, engineering, art, dialectics, literature, logic, mathematics, astronomy, religion, and philosophy. The three hundred years of Gupta rule (A.D.300 to 600) witnessed a Golden Age, and blessed India with a cultural efflorescence not known either before or after. Samudragupta (A.D. 335/350-375) acclaimed as Indian Napoleon by V.A. Smith (though Samudragupta's date is earlier to Napoleon), and Chandragupta II (380-415) who assumed the title 'Vikramaditya'

gave this country blessing of peace and prosperity and promoted arts and letters. Samudragupta possessed a vast military machine, conquered many parts of the country, performed an 'asvamedha sacrifice', and found time to promote liberal arts like poetry. His son and successor Chandragupta II removed the last trace of foreign rule from India, presided over a court famous for its 'nine gems' and revived memories of the legendary Vikramaditya in the minds of his people.

8.2. Administration

The credit of maintaining law and order and providing the benefits of a good administration goes to the Guptas- especially to Chandragupta I (A.D. 320-335/350) Samudragupta (A.D. 335/350-375), Chandragupta II (A.D. 380-415), Kumaragupta (A.D. 415 to 455) and Skandagupta (A.D. 455-467). The Gupta empire, in its best days, extended from sea – the Bay of Bengal in the East and the Arabian Sea in the West. Pilgrims like Fahien, the inscriptions and coins of the age, and the vast literature of the period describe the excellent way in which such a far-flung empire was administered. Through the political institutions of the Mauryan times continued to function, new institutions were devised to meet the new demands of the empire with the result that the king's writ was accepted everywhere in the empire.

8.2.1. King

From the very beginning of their rule, the Gupta monarchs called themselves Maharajadhirajas- great kings. They deserved such titles, because they were not merely kings but kings of kings, mighty kings who controlled a multitude of kings. They claimed superhuman qualities, and considered themselves as gods. The Allahabad Pillar inscription describes Samudragupta as 'a god dwelling on the earth'. The inscription says that he is equal to Kubera, Varuna, Indira, and Yama, the presiding deities of the four quarters of the earth. The king in spite of his divine regent never forget the welfare of the people. The Chinese pilgrim Fahien bears testimony to this fact.

Kingship was almost always hereditary, at time the king was nominated by his predecessor. According to the Allahabad prasasti, Chandragupta I publicly announced Samudragupta as his successor to the throne. There may have been other princess, their claims may have been

ignored, and Samudra Gupta deliberately chosen. Whatever may have been the mode of selection, one thing seems to be certain. The selection was made in the presence of royal blood, nobles, Brahmanas and councillors, called sabhyas.

8.2.2 Officers

The Mantri of the Gupta Ministers enjoyed proximity to the king and ranked as head of the civil administration. The sandhivigrahika was an imperial officer of high position. He may have functioned as Minister for war and peace. Harisena, who composed the Allahabad pillar Inscription, bore the designation sandhivigrahika. Such officers are known, to have wielded tremendous influence among the Maitnakas of Valabhi and the chalukyas of Badami. Though we here of the sandhivigrahikas for the first time in the Gupta records, we have come across a definition of their functions. The other important officers were the 'mahabaladhikrita' 'mahadandanayaka' and 'mahaprathihara'. The Mahabaladhikrita was the commander-in-chief, the Mahadandanayaka, a general and the Mahaprathihara, the chief of palace guards.

The 'kumara amatyas' served as link between the central and provincial governments. We come to know of these offices for the first time from the Gupta epigraphs. They seem to have functioned as Ministers, high imperial officers, personal staff of the emperor, feudatories, generals and district officers. R.S. Sharma would say that 'the most important officers in the Gupta Empire were the Kumara Amatyas'.

8.2.3. Provincial and District Administration

The empire was divided into provinces called 'bhuktis'. These Bhuktis were governed by officers known as Uparikas. Princes of the royal blood were appointed as uparikas. They carried with them the title 'maharajaputra devabhattacharaka' the provinces were divided into districts called 'Vishayas'. These vishayas were governed by officers known as Vishayapatis. Sometimes they were under the care of ayuktakas. A few inscriptions of North Bengal inform provincial governors instead of the king nominated us that the district officers.

Officers like vishayapatis or Kummaramatyas or ayuktakas seem to have entered into land deals in north Bengal with the consent of local boards like 'adhishtanadhi karanas', 'vishayadhikaranas'. And 'ashtakuladhi karanas'. The Municipal Board known as adhishtanadhi

karanas consisted of four members, namely the Guild President, the principal merchant, the chief artisan and the chief scribe. There is reason to believe that the members, except the scribe, were people's representatives. Such boards probably functioned in North Bihar as well. Seals discovered in places like Vaisali attest this fact.

8.2.4. Fahien's Record

Fahien travelled in India during the time of Chandragupta II. He has left a brief record of what he saw and heard in this country. He would say that the people were numerous and happy and that they enjoyed the benefits of 'Gupta peace'. Peace and order prevailed throughout the empire, and a lonely pilgrim from abroad could travel without any fear of robbery. Fahien would further observe 'they have not to register their households or attend to an magistrate and their ruler. If they want to go. If they want to stay, they stay.

Fahien's observations on land revenues are interesting. He would say that only those who cultivated the king's land paid land revenue. It is rather difficult to believe this statement. He has recorded 'the king governs without decapitation or other corporal punishment. Criminals are simply fined lightly or heavily according to the circumstances of each case.' U.N. Ghoshal remarks that viewed in the context of "immemorial traditions of espionage and deterrent punishments." The Gupta age marked 'a new era of humanitarian reform in the penal law of ancient India'. Fahien records that the king's bodyguards and attendants had all fixed and regular salaries. It was a healthy Mauryan practice which the Guptas followed. According to R.S. Sharma the Gupta rulers did not require as many officials as the Mauryas did. 'The Guptas neither needed nor possessed the elaborate administrative machinery of Maurya times.'

Check your progress-1

1. Describe the position of the king in the Gupta age.
2. Give short notes on Sandhivigraha and Kumaramatyā.
3. State how provinces and districts were governed in the Gupta empire
4. Show how Fahien records the efficiency of Gupta administration.

8.3. Social Life

The social trends of the previous Mauryan age continued in the age of the Guptas. At the same time, new tendencies gave momentum to society. Jainism and Buddhism ceased to inspire people and Brahmanism became a force to reckon with. U.N. Ghoshal speaks of a 'Brahmanical Counter- Reformation' resulting in the ascendancy of the Brahmanas. The migration of foreigners into the north western and western parts of the empire added a new dimension to society. They adapted the faith and languages as well as the manners and customs of the indigenous population. As a result of the influx of foreigners sub-castes. Generally speaking, people became richer than before, their standard of life improved, and developed a taste for the ease and comforts of town life. These were changes, and changes were inevitable in a developing society.

8.3.1. Castes

The castes continued to be four in number. Varahamitira in his Brihad- samhita states that the Brahmanas lived in the northern, the Kshatriyas in the eastern, the Vaisyas in the southern, and the Sudras in the western quarters of the city. But there were also authentic instances of the Brahmanas and the Kshatriyas adopting the occupations of the classes below them, and of the Vaisyas and the Sudras. A Brahmana used to plough the land and a fifth century inscription refers to a couple of Kshatriya merchants. We have also classic example of silk weavers from Gujarat taking to miscellaneous occupations in Malwa during the reign of Kumaragupta. Also, inter-caste marriages, though not common, were known especially among royal families. Therefore, it may be stated that there was some flexibility in the caste system of the Gupta age. However, one thing is certain; the Brahmanas continued to retain their ascendancy in the social hierarchy of the period. The smritis and the travel accounts of the foreigners agree on this issue. The smriti law would declare that the Brahmanas enjoyed exemptions from capital punishment and confiscation of property, and it would say that the Brahmanas were regarded as the most honourable. Fahien has recorded that the people of the higher castes in the Madhya Desa did not kill any living creature, not drink intoxicating liquor nor eat onions garlic. This appears to be an exaggerated statement. The last days of the Gupta period witnessed many foreign people settling in India. They mixed with the indigenous population and became mostly Kshatriyas.

The Chandalas were kept outside the four varnas. They occupied the lowest rank in the society. They performed the meanest work life carrying unclaimed corpses and executing criminals. They were treated as untouchables. In the words of Itsing 'anyone touching them by mistake washed himself and his garments'. They lived outside the village, and they were required to strike a piece of wood whenever they walked into villages and towns to warn others of their movement. They were scavengers, the hunters, the butchers, and the executioners and society heaped on them all kinds of disgusting work.

There were slaves too in the Gupta Empire. It was a natural sequence of the life of ease and luxury lived by the people of the age. However, the Brahmanas would never become slaves. Katayana says that a Brahmana could never be a slave. Similarly, the sale and purchase of a Brahmana woman was invalid in the eyes of law. The age knew of self –sold slaves as well. The Michchhakatika speaks of a gambler who sold himself to discharged his gambling debt. Different masters and mistress seem to have treated their slaves differently. Some were treated as friends and some were beaten. It all depended on the temperament of the owners.

8.3.2. Marriages

The Gupta age witnessed a trend of lowering the age of girls given in marriage. At the same time, it was desired that the bride should be younger than the bridegroom by three years or more. Though prepuberty marriages seems to have been preferred, the maturity of the brides indicated in the literature shows that post – puberty marriages were also followed. Marriage within the same caste. Vatsyayana would also say that the Gandharva marriage was the best; as it is attended with happiness and is the result of mutual desire'. there are repeated references in the literature of the age to such type of gandharva marriages –Sakuntala marrying Dushyanta, Urvasi marrying Purunavas, Vasavadatta marrying Udayana. But in actual practice, on the whole, marriage was arranged by the parents of both the parties.

8.3.3. Position of Women

Women in the Gupta age were given opportunities to acquire proficiency in general learning. Vatsyayana says that women should learn sixty-four branches of knowledge known as anga vidya. They are said to have read history and legend, and composed verses. They

were trained in singing, dancing, and acting. There were even regular institutions where women received instruction. But it seems that such education and training was restricted to princesses and daughters of the nobles of the realm.

Vatsyayana draws the picture of an ideal wife. His account may be taken not just an ideal, but a reflection of real life. A good wife would treat her husband like a god, share his joys and sorrows, attend sacrifices and social functions with his consent, honour his relatives and friends, engage servants in their work, lived a life of total restraint when her husband had gone abroad and during his absence even gave up wearing all ornaments 'excepting the marks of her married state'. She was in complete charge of the household. She kept the house neat and clean, decorated it with flowers, worshiped the family gods, and took care of the garden. She attended to farms, spinning and weaving and even look after her husband's pets. The ideal wife frames the ideal budget, maintained the daily accounts, increased the income, and diminished the expenditure. The smritis too confirm Vatsyayana's expectations of a devoted wife.

8.3.4. Food

Food habits of people do not change easily and true to this belief, people in the Gupta age continued to eat rice, wheat, barley, butter, oil and sugar. Eating meat and fish, and drinking liquor too, was quite common. Fahien's observations 'that killing animals, drinking wine, and eating onions and garlic was unknown throughout Madhyadesa' is obviously an exaggeration. No doubt that fish, flesh of goats and sheep were occasionally eaten. But all the Chinese authorities agree that onions and garlic were forbidden items. 'Eating onions was visited with loss of caste. People seem to have freely indulged in drinking. Even queens and high-born ladies drank wine without any inhibition. The Brahmanas and the Buddhists drank syrup of grapes. The Kshatriyas took wine from sugarcane and the Vaisyas distilled spirits.

8.3.5. Nagaraka (City Life)

Vatsyayana describes in detail the life led by the fashionable young man of the town called the Nagarika. The man finishes his education, he comes to the town, builds a house furnishes it with elegance and taste, provides it with a garden and sewing, covers it with carpets

and couches, boards chess and dice, and perfumes of all kinds. He makes himself presentable by frequent massages, baths, and shaves. He eats twice a day, and after his noon meal starts amusing himself, listens to his parrots talking, watches the fights of cocks and roams, enjoys music, attends social gatherings and sends for his beloved ones. He attends samajas with his friends once a fortnight or a month in a temple and presents gifts to actors. He meets other Nagarakas of the same age, wealth, learning and temperament, has pleasant talk and enjoys in poetical and other artistic contests. He has also garden parties and water sports. For a nagaraka, life is one round of pleasure after pleasure. The Nagaraka surrounded himself with toilets and cosmetics. He painted his nails, scented his body with perfumes, powders, and pastes, and arranged his hair in curls and coiffures, beautifying the body was raised to the level of a fine art- a lalitakala.

8.3.6. Education

The Guptas rulers were devoted to learning. Samudragupta called himself 'kaviraja'- king among poets. Chandragupta II loved the company of learned scholars. The traditional method of gurugula continued. There were also regular schools attended by pupils. **Mayurasarman** (A.D. 345-370), the founder of the Kadamba dynasty, and a contemporary of Samudragupta, is known to have studied the Vedas in a **ghatika** at Kanchi. Moral discipline was as much a part of instructions as the sacred lore. The Brahmanas excelled in studies.

The Nalanda monastery was the most famous centre of learning in the Gupta period. It owed its existence to the munificence of six generations of Gupta kings. Thousands of students enrolled themselves in the Nalanda. It was supported by the revenues of a hundred or more villages. The monks who studied in the University were held in high esteem for their high character and were looked up to as models all over India.

The Nalanda was mainly a Mahayanist University, but other subjects like the eighteen schools of Hinayanism, logic, grammar, sankhya –yoga, medicine, Astronomy, art, and Iconography were also taught. Even Brahmanical subjects like the Vedas, the Vedangas, the Purana and Dharmasastras were taught there. Nalanda provided primary, secondary and higher educations. The first between 8 and 20, the second between 13 and 20 and the third for those above 20. Admissions were made through an entrance examination which was so difficult that

not more than thirty percent of the candidates were successful. According to Itsing there were eight halls and three hundred class rooms. The university possessed an observatory and a library housed in three building.

Apart from Nalanda, great strides were made in the empire in education –both sacred and secular. Branches of learning were counted as eighteen in number. Brhaspathi would count subjects like acting, painting, politics, mathematics, and grammar occupied the pride of place. The study of Panini's sutras in 8000 slokas seems to have been a must in those days. Though the studies mentioned so far were meant for the intellectual classes, the education of the agricultural and mercantile classes was not ignored. The Vaisyas were instructed in precious stones and metals, weights and measures, agriculture and cattle rearing.

Check your progress -2

1. Describe the miseries of the Chandalas
2. How, according to Vastyaana, should an ideal wife conduct herself?
3. Describe the life led by a Nagaraka
4. Mention the special features of the Nalanda University.

8.4. Economic Condition

Fahien who travelled in the Gupta empire for six years, says that the people were happy and prosperous. Magadha had the largest cities and towns. Its people were rich and thriving. He refers to the well –to –do instituting free hospitals. Distributing food and medicine to the poor and the helpless. The conquest of almost the whole of the Gangetic valley by Samudragupta, and that of Malwa, Gujarat and Kathiawar by Chandragupta II resulted in enormous flow of wealth with the coffers of the empire with the result that agriculture, industry, and trade flourished as never before.

8.4.1. Agriculture

The rulers ensured that lakes and tanks were maintained in good condition. The Junagarh. Rock inscription of Skandagupta mentions to breach of lake Sudarsana in A.D,455, and its repair and restoration in the next year by the local governor and his son. The Brihatsamhita

contains frequent references to rains and rainfall, and suggests ways and means of their forecast –when rainfall would be too much or too little or adequate.

The popular crops raised were paddy, wheat, barley, oil seeds, sugar cane, pepper and other spices, ginger, and herbs. A variety of paddy ripened in the course of sixty days. Like a seasoned farmer, Varahamitra prescribes rules for preparing the soil, treating the seeds, grafting of trees, watering them, curing the diseases, and promoting the yield of fruits and flowers. The literature of the age reveals that saffron was grown in Kashmir, Sandalwood, Pepper and Cardamom in the Western Ghats, and fruits like mango, melons, jackfruit, plantain, and pomegranate all over the country.

The State rewarded persons who promoted agriculture and punished those who caused damage. Those who indulged in activities like destroying dams were fined hundred panas, and those who obstructed free flow of water were fined a lesser amount. Persons covering fallow fields into arable land were allowed to enjoy its produce for seven or eight.

8.4.2. Industries

Trade prospered due to a variety of reasons. There was an abundance of raw materials. There were enterprising entrepreneurs. There were also people skilled in arts and crafts. Among the many industries that flourished in the empire, textile industry was the principle one. Clothes were made of cotton, silk, wool, and linen. There were fine as well as coarse varieties. They were either bleached or unbleached. They were made with or without flowers and figures. The ascetics were content with wearing barks of trees. Benares produced the best silk garments and Mathura, with four different techniques of weaving. Princesses wore silk woven with gold or silver brocade.

Leather industry too was popular. People used leather fans, leather bottles, and leather shoes. Sculptures and paintings of the age show gods and human figures wearing shoes. Ivory was used for a variety of purposes. Ivory seals have been discovered at Bhita near Allahabad. The Raghuvamsa speaks of ivory throne used at the king's coronations. Mines yielded metals like gold, silver, copper, and irons. Indian gold was supplemented by the gold coins of the Roman Empire given in exchange for Indian goods. Brass was produced in large quantities.

After the Guptas a colossal copper image of the Buddha and a brass temple was raised by Harsha at Nalanda. The image of the Buddha was more than 80 feet in height, and the temple 100 feet. A gigantic copper statue of the Buddha, discovered at Sultanganj, is now kept in the Birmingham museum, it reaches a height of 7-1/2 feet and weights a ton. The Delhi iron pillar of Chandra (Chandragupta I or II) is yet another monument in metal. It is 23'8" in height and 16.4 inches in diameter at the base and 12.05 inches at the top. The pillar is free from rust though exposed to the weather for more than 1500 years. The copper and bronze images of the Buddha and the iron pillar prove the great progress made in metallurgy.

The jeweller made ornaments from gold and silver, and inlaid them with diamond, sapphire, emerald, ruby, pearl, and coral. The jewellers were trained in the selection of precious stones, and the selection was based on ratna –pariksha or the testing of gems. According to Varahamihira, Indian mines supplied diamonds. Pearls were obtained from Persia and the Pandyan country. Pearl industry was carried on with great success. There were pearl necklaces ranging from one string to one thousand and eight strings. Even seven handles were inlaid with pearls.

8.4.3. Trade

The peace and order established by the Gupta rulers, and the gold and silver coins of high quality issued by them facilitated trade and commerce in the empire. Cosmos, an Alexandrine Greek, writing in the sixth century, has given a list of important trading stations in India. Tamaralipiti, with Gangetic delta has been described as the emporium of the vast trade of Eastern India across the seas; Also it was the port of call for ships from China, Indonesia, and Ceylon to Eastern India. The Raghuvamsam and the Dasakumara Charita contain references to the trade from Tamralipiti as a result of which its merchants became rich.

According to Katyayana prices of goods were fixed by the knowledgeable and honest body of neighbours (and not by the king and his officers) he continues to say that what is more or less than this price is considered improper, and the deal could be annulled even after a hundred years if found to have been transacted at an improper price. Another novel practice was to allow a period of examination to the buyer and the seller for returning or taking back the article if he repents of the transaction.

Trade with overseas countries too was carried on. Cosmas speaks of ships from China reaching Indonesia to east coast of India, from the east coast Ceylon from Ceylon the west coast, and from the west coast Persia and other places. Apart from oceanic routes, there were land routes connecting China and India, the difficult route connecting these countries passed through the Karakoram ranges and Kashmir.

A variety of articles were exported to the countries beyond the seas, pepper, Cardamoms, Cinnamon, aromatics saffron, and sandalwood were exported to the Roman empire besides other places. There was so much demand for pepper that it is said to have been sent from fine ports of Malabar. Rudravarman, king of Cambodia, sent a mission to the Chinese emperor in A.D. 519 with gift of an image of Buddha made of Indian pearls gathered in the funelions of river Tamraparni with the sea were very much sought after in the west. Kalidasa agrees on the excellence of pearls exported from the Pandyan country. The Gupta Empire imported best breeds of horses from countries like Arabia and Afghanistan, and ivory from Ethiopia as Ethiopian elements had larger tusks than Indian elements. India obtained copper from the Mediterranean countries, and saplings from Ceylon.

Loans were of different kinds. Loans without security, with security and with pledge. The smrutis of the age described in detail about the different types of loans. Creditors collected interested from their debtors. No interest was charged on loans given for the sake of friendship. The rate of interest was 11/4% per month for loans with security and 2% for loans without security. The general rule was that the interest should not exceed the capital, but it was allowed to exceed in the case of a few selected items. In the case of gold, grain, cloth and fluids, the interest could be as much as 2,3,4 and 8 times as the principal.

8.4.4. Guilds

Artisans and traders were organised into associations called **srenis**. The **smritis** describe their constitution. They were administered by officers known as adhyakshaas. These officers were assisted by committees of advisers called samuhahitavadins. The rules to be followed by the srenis were put into documents known as stutripatras the members are bound to follow the conventions failing which even their property could be confiscated the smritis demanded that each member should discharge his duties and have his share of the profits earned by the sreni.

The *sreni* functioned as banks as well, and carried out the instructions of their clients. A copper plate of Skandagupta refers to a donor making a gift of money to the local guild of oilmen for providing every day oil for a sun temple. The guild invested the sum in business, and from the income earned, met the expenditure stipulated by the donor. Many princes and private individuals in the Gupta age created such endowments for performing acts of piety or charity.

The Mandasor stone inscription of Kumaragupta I refer to the migration of a group of people from Lata to Dasapura. They were renowned in the world for their skill in weaving. They were treated honourably by the king. Adopted different professions, and settled happily in the new place. It is interesting to note that 'they came in a band, together with their children and kinsmen'.

Check your progress-3

1. Describe how agriculture was carried on in the age of the Guptas?
2. State what you know of the growth of industries during the 4th, 5th and 6th centuries of the Christian era?
3. Show how trade prospered in the Gupta period.
4. Explain the role of guilds in the economic development of the empire.

8.5. Religion

The age of Guptas was an age of change in the field religion. R.C. Majumdar says; "the Vedic pantheon and the sacrificial form of worship gradually recedes in to the background and the lineament of Vedic gods become dimmer and dimmer". Vedic gods like Indra are shown to be seeking the mercy of Vishnu and Siva to protect themselves against demons. The Puranas are full of praises of Vishnu and Siva. The age of the Guptas saw a shift from the abstract to the concrete. Instead of conceiving god as an idea, gods began to be worshipped in the form of images in temples. The Vishnudharmotra stated that worship and meditation (of the Supreme Being) are possible (only when he is endowed with forms). The age is also remembered for the spirit of tolerations among the different religions. The conception of Trinity combining Brahma, Vishnu and Siva illustrate this unity. It was not unusual for different members of royal families to follow different religions. The Gupta kings may have followed one sect, but that did not

prevent them from patronising other sects. Thus religious tolerance emerged as an important characteristic of the age of the Guptas. As in the days of Akbar, ministers and officers were appointed from all religions.

8.5.1. Buddhism

Hinayana Buddhism, which was divided into as many as 18 schools in the Mauryan period presented different picture in the age of the Guptas. Most of the schools disappeared and only four or five survived. Among them, the Sarvastivadins, the Sammitiyas and the Stavnavadins may be noted as important sects. Even these sects exerted themselves more to develop monasteries and educational centres and rituals and ceremonies than to the propagation of doctrines. R.C. Majumdar says that “there appeared during the Gupta period a number of distinguished writers whose contributions to Indian exegesis and philosophy can be regarded as landmarks in the history of Indian literature”.

But it was Mahayana which captured the imagination of the people. Mahayanism insisted that one dedicate one's life to the service of others. A Mahayanist was expected to fulfil six paramitas or virtues – dana or liberality, sila or moral precepts, kshanti or forbearance, virya or mental strength, dhyana or concentration and prajna or truth. Since it is not possible to acquire all the paramitas in one has to be born again and again to acquire them. Even Gautama, according to the jataka tales, was born several times to fulfil them. Fahien records that stupas were erected to honour the memory of the Buddha's immediate disciples, and also the three pitakas. The nuns are said to have worshipped at the stupa of Ananda. It was he who persuaded the Buddha to admit women in his Sangha. Fahien reports seeing the processions of images, 'on a four-wheel chariot is seated in the centre the image of the Buddha with two Bodhisattvas on the sides. The king prostrated himself before the image while the queen and other ladies scattered. The king prostrated himself before the image while the queen and other ladies scattered flowers.

Buddhism was divided into four philosophical schools. They were called Vaibhashika, Sautrantiku, madhyamika and yogachure. The first two belongs to hinayanism and the next two to Mahayanism. Those who accepted the vibhushus or commentaries or the principal. Abhidamma text, were known as vaibha shikyas. Vasubandhyu made a special study of the

vibhasbas, and composed the Abhidammakosa summarising the vibhasharas. The Abhidamma kosa is studied even today in China and Japan. The text of this classic was translated into Chinese by Hiuen Tsang. Those who considered that sutras alone (and not commentaries) could be treated as authoritative came to be called Jautrantikas. Unlike the Vaibhashikas who believed in realism, the Sautrantukas insisted that nothing is real, nothing exists. There is no substance, no duration and no bliss. Kumaralabadhra of Takshasila founded this school of philosophy, he was a renowned teacher and was counted among the four nuns of India. The next school, the Madhyamika, was founded by Nagarjuna. He expounded his philosophy in the Mulamadhyamkarika, he held that the only reality is sunyata, Aryadeva, Rahulabhadra-served with distinction as abbots of the Nalanda monastery. Maitreyanatta founded the yogachara school of thought. His philosophy was also known as Viganavada. Maitreyanantha and detailed the practices to be undertaken by a yogachara adept.

Among the many scholars of yogachara philosophy mention may be made of Dharmapala of Kanchi. He was a disciple of the distinguished Disnaga, and held position as abbot of Nalanda. He was known for his prodigious memory and prolific works of yogachara.

8.5.2. Jainism

Jainism lost its hold over the masses during the Gupta period. It ceased to be popular even in Magadha, the land of its origin. 'the paucity of epigraphic records about Jainism in this period and lack of literary evidence from the side of Jain writers, clearly indicate that Jainism was not prosperous in those days. Thus, decline was primarily due to the lack of royal patronage'. Jainism survived mostly due to the support of merchant communities and middle classes. The monks wandered from place to place, preached their tenets of their religion and kept it alive.

The second council (of Jainism) which met at Valabhi yielded fruitful results. The Jain cannon took its present stage in this council. The contents of the canons had been in existence for a long time, but their arrangement and classic fiction was the work of the council at Valabhi, the sacred texts were divided into six groups, Anga the first group, and Upanga, the second group are treated as the most important. The exercise of writing commentaries was also pursued with vigour. This resulted in the production of a vast and rich literature of considerable merit'. The names of scholars like Sanghadasas, Jinadassa, and Siddhasena are mentioned in this

context. The tradition of writing commentaries in prakrit slowly disappeared and the practice of publishing in Sanskrit started. Haribhadra was an important writer of Sanskrit commentaries. Jains, like others, took to building temples, establishing monasteries, worshipping prophets, and celebrating festivals. The monks and the laity also believed and practiced fasting unto death, and retired to holy places towards the end of their life.

8.5.3. Vaishnavism

What started as Bhagavatism in the age of the Mauryas came to be known as Vaishnavism in the age of the Guptas. Thanks to the extensive patronage of Gupta kings, it spread rapidly and became very popular all over the empire. The facts that Chandragupta II assumed the title of Purana Bhagavata and issued nine types of copper coins with Garuda on the reverse and that his father Samudragupta adopted the emblem of Garudadhvaja go to prove that they were ardent followers of Vaishnavism. Vishnu was worshipped in his ten avatars. Matsya, Kurma, Varaha, Vamana, Narasimha, Parasurama, Rama, Buddha Krishna, and Kalki. Vishnu is said to have incarnated himself from time to time 'in human or animal form in order to maintain the standard of righteousness in the world. The worship of Sri or Lakshmi continued in this age. What new was the conception of Lakshmi as Vishnu's wife. The Gaja Lakshmi figure was adopted as an emblem by a few royal families. There is also a view that the Indo- Greeks introduced Lakshmi worship in this country. It is believed that the Greek goddess Pollus Athene was behind the worship of worshipped in three forms- Sthanak or Standing, asana or seated and sayana or recumbent. The incarnations of Vishnu were also worshipped. Vishnu's images were shown carrying in his four hands lotus, club, wheel and conch. Vishnu was also shown with Sridevi and Bhudevi attending on him.

8.5.4. Saivism

Though the Gupta emperors worshiped Vishnu, Saivism, the other branch of Hinduism did not suffer neglect. Kumaragupta's introduction of the peacock type of coins showing on the observe the king feeding a peacock, and on the reverse God Kumara riding a peacock is a proof of his devotion to Saivism. The king naming his son Skanda confirms his Saivism, Again, his son Sandragupta not only continued the peacock type of coins of his father, but introduced a new type with siva's bull. Among the puranas, the Vayu purana and the Matsya Purana glorify

Siva. The Vayupurana praises Siva so much that Sivapurana became its second name. The great Sanskrit poet Kalidasa was a devotee of Siva. His epic Kumarasambhava commemorate the birth of Skanda. Bana too, another poet of eminence, was a Siva bhaktha and this is seen from his Kiratarjuniya, a Mahakavya. Siva was worshipped both in human and linga forms. An image of Siva assigned to Skandagupta's period shows Siva and Uma standing side by side. Ellora contains a few sculptures showing the god and goddess seated together. This relief is called Uma- Mahasvara. Siva was also worshipped as Ardhanarisvara-Siva in right half and Uma in the left in the same stone. A Gupta seal discovered near Allahabad contains the figure of Arthanariswara. At Badami a cave contains a panel showing Hari Hara, Hara in the right, and Hari in the left attended by their respective consorts and vahanas.

Check your progress- 4

1. Show the position of Mahayanism in the age of the Guptas.
2. Point out the rise and fall of Jainism.
3. Describe how the Guptas promoted Vaishnavism.
4. State how Siva was worshipped in the Gupta period.

8.6. Literature

Sanskrit literature prospered in all its branches in the age of the Guptas. Writers may be said to have touched the frontiers of literature, especially secular literature. Drama, poetry, prose, grammar, and sciences like Astronomy and mathematics in fact every field of knowledge flourished in this age. Cultural historians rightly call this period the Golden age of Sanskrit literature. Generations of men and women have delighted reading the works created during this period and there can be no doubt that coming generations too will continue to read and admire the literature of the period, historians describe the literary output of the age as an efflorescence of Sanskrit literature.

8.6.1. Kalidasa and other Writers

Tradition associates Kalidasa with the reign of Chandragupta II. He was the most brilliant luminary in the literary firmament of the Gupta age who shed lustre on the whole of Sanskrit

literature. Sakuntala, the Malavikagnimitra, and the Vikramorvasiya are his dramas. The Raghuvamsa and the Kumarasambava and his epics. The Meghduta and the Ritusamhara are his lyrics. The best-known work of Kalidasa is the Sakuntala - one of the best in the literature of the world. G.V.Devasthali writes, 'this charming and graceful diction, the refinement of his language and sentiments his minute observations of man and nature, his elevation of thought and suggestiveness of expression have immortalised him, and his works will endure so long as human beings retain a taste for great literature'.

Bana wrote the Kiratarjuniya which describes a battle between Arjuna and Siva. This Mahakavya has been praised for its 'vigour of thought and language and lofty eloquence of expression'. But his attempts at Chitrakavya have not been successful. Dandin's Dasakumaracharita is a romance describing the adventures of ten princes. The work introduces us to all kinds of people-rogues, ragabonds, thieves, gamblers and courtisans. We meet a cross section of the Gupta society in the Dasakumaracharita, the Vasavadatta of Subandhu is a fine story. It is full of descriptions ling compounds and poems. They are considered as defects of his work, and they constitute difficult reading. **Visakhadatta's, Mudraraksha** and **Sudraka's Mrichchakatika** are the other notable plays of the period.

The **Panchatantra** has been hailed as a great treasure house of stories. They were means to educate people in morals. It was composed in prose and verse. It has been translated in most languages of the world. Macdonald would observe that; probably no book except the bible has been translated into so many languages' **Amanasimha's Amarskosa** is a lexicon. It gives synonyms of personal and common names. Many commentaries have been written on Amarakosa.

8.6.2. Sciences

Vagbhatta, the third of the medical trio of ancient India is remembered for his Ashtangasangraha which is a summary of sections of medicine. There were manuals on the diseases of animals too. Hasti ayurveda deals with the diseases of elephants. Asvasastra describes the diseases of horses. Aryabhata was a great mathematician and astronomer of the age. He is said to have invented the decimal systems and revolutionised mathematics he was the first to hold that the earth was a sphere and rotated on its own axis, and offered a scientific explanation of solar and lunar eclipses. Further, he gave the correct ratio of the diameter to the circumference of the earth. Varahamihira's Panchasiddhantika is an authoritative

work on astronomy. The work is said to show the influence of Greek astronomy, especially the second and the third Siddhantas known as Romaka and Paulisa. Varahamihira was well versed in astronomy as well. His Brihatsamhita has been described as 'a veritable encyclopaedia of ancient Indian learning and superstition, dealing with astronomy, astrology, geography, weather, animals, women, marriage, the haven, etc. His Brihajataka is treated as a standard work on astrology.

8.6.3. Puranas and Dharmasastras

Among the 18 puranas known to Sanskrit literature, the Vayu, the Matsya, and the Vishnu puranas were composed during the Gupta period. None of the puranas satisfy the panchalakshanas, the five characteristics of their sense. In the course of the last 1500 years they have suffered additions and omissions with the result that none retains its original shape. The puranas glorify hindu gods and goddesses, contain numerous myths, legends and genealogies, describe heaven and hell, mention rewards of visiting holy places, define the duties of different castes and contain a multitude of details of all aspects of Hinduism. There may not be much of history in the puranas, but they help to have an idea of the religious outlook and social customs and manners, but they help to have an age. Apart from the 18 puranas, there were 18 upapuranas also. Among them, the Vishnudharmaottama is said to be worthy of notice. The gupta age also witnessed the composition of a few smriti, otherwise known as Dhmasastras. The smrities of Brihaspai, Narada and Katyayana were compiled in the Gupta age. They deal with law, courts, and judicial procedure. Naradar gives a complete list of court in an ascending order. The judicial procedure was well developed. Brihaspasthi describes the four stages of legal proceedings as the complaints, the reply, producing evidence, and the judgement. Laws were classified under various heads. Succession, stvidhana, abuse and assault, theft, and violence. Six systems of philosophy developed in this period. Nyaya, Vaiseshika, Sankhya, Yoga. Purvamimsa and uttaramimsa.

Check your progress-5

1. Describe the place of Kalidasas in Sanskrit literature.
2. Point out the significance of the Panchatantra
3. State the achievements of the Guptas in science.
4. What do you understand from the Puranas?

8.7. Arts

Arts and architecture developed in the Gupta empire to an extent unknown elsewhere in India. The presence of peace in all the parts of the empire, the prosperity that prevailed everywhere, and the patronage offered by kings who themselves were men of culture led to an unprecedented efflorescence of culture during the 4th, 5th and 6th centuries. Though Pataliputra continued to be the administrative capital of the empire, Ujjaini became its intellectual and culture metropolis. The 'nine gems' who adorned the court Chandragupta Vikramaditya added lust to the empire, and no other court in India could boast of so many eminent men. Most of the temples, sculptures, and paintings of the age have perished due to the ravages of time and foreign invasions like that of the Huns. The few that remain reveal the glories of the Gupta art.

8.7.1 Architecture

The practice of excavating cave temples and monasteries in caves continued in this period as well. Such cave architecture is to be seen in Ajanta, Ellora, Aurangabad, and Bagh. At least 23 out of the 28 caves of Ajanta were excavated during the Gupta period. The caves at Ellora extend for about a mile. The images of the Buddha take a prominent place in one of these caves known as the Viswakarma. The Ellora caves are also known for three storeyed monasteries called Tin Mal. S. K. Saraswati is of the opinion that the Tin Mahal is among the most interesting of its class in the whole of India. Among Brahmanical caves, the Dhunur lena is said to be best and is celebrated for its pillars of massive proportions. The elephant cave near Bombay has been admired for its sculptures.

The practice of building temples with brick and stone started in the Gupta period. The temples at Deogarh and Bhitargaon were well planned and had *sikharas* or towers which have tumbled down. To begin with, such temples had only flat roofs, but in course of time subshrines, *prakaras*, and towers were added and they became elaborate structures.

8.7.2. Sculpture

The temples are only frames, but the sculptures make them fit for gods. Sarnath excelled in making 'countless seated or standing images of the Buddha or Bodhisattvas and also certain Brahmanical images.' The seated Buddha of Sarnath is a masterpiece, a sublime creation. It

shows the Buddha in the Dharmachakra- pravartana- mudra style- turning the wheel of the law. It has been said that 'the Sarnath image is a fine expression in stone of the meditative and compassionate Buddha giving his first message'. The copper statue of the Buddha discovered at Sultanganj is 7.5 feet height and weights a ton. It shows the influence of Mathura school. Hiuen Trang reports to have seen a Buddha's copper image 80 feet in height but its whereabouts are not known. The Delhi iron pillar of Chandra, mentioned earlier show the great progress of metallurgy in those days. V. A. Smith observes that 'even now there are comparatively few (foundries) where a similar mass of metal could be turned out'. The images of Brahma, Vishnu and Siva in the Deogarh temple exude beauty and spiritualism. The Bhitari monolith of Skandagupta crowned with a statue of Vishnu is yet another example of Gupta sculpture. An inscription on the pillar describes a story of the grand deliverance from the Pushyamitra and the term perils.'

8.7.3. Painting

Paintings were more popular than sculptures. Princes, nobles, and common people considered painting a social accomplishment. The Vishnudharmotaram has a whole chapter on painting, and discusses its different aspects. It informs us that religious buildings, palaces, and private residences were covered with paintings. The paintings in the caves of Ajanta show us a world of lively vegetation, of Gods and semi divine beings of apsaras and kinnaras of semi and grotesques, of a rich and varied flora of pageantry and processions of gaiety and love, of grace and charm of sublimity and coarseness, all sophisticated civilization. Paintings like the dying princess, the Apsaras, the Bodhisattva, the mother and the child excite respectful admiration.

The paintings in the Bagh caves are almost as good as the Ajanta paintings. Though they are mostly concerned with Buddhist themes, there is more for worldliness than spiritualisms in them. N.R. Ray suggests that 'all the technical knowledge of the age manifests itself in the scene of the female chauri-bearer'. The paintings at Sigiriya Ceylon which came under the artistic sovereignty of Ajanta' are also worthy of notice. They show women carrying flowers to the Buddhist temple.

8.7.4. Coins

The Gupta coins are noted for their clarity and elegance of design and lettering, regularity of shapes and forms, and precision and refinement of executions. Samudragupta issued eight types of gold coins. The Asvamedha type, the lyrist type, the tiger slayer type, and the bow and arrow type deserve special mention. These coins carry legends 'like the king of kings who performed the Asvamedha sacrifice' 'having the prowess of a tiger', etc. In his battle-axe type of coins, Samudragupta describes himself as 'the unconquered conqueror of the unconquered kings'.

The gold coins of Chandragupta II indicate his power and personality. He is represented in one of his coins killing a lion. This is supposed to say that that he conquered. Gujarat where lions were common. In his rupaakriti coins, the emperor is shown as holding a flower. This is supposed to reveal his aesthetic sense. Another coin contains the portrait of the emperor holding a sword under an umbrella. It may be presumed that this is a declaration of his claims to universal sovereignty.

Kumaragupta introduced the peacock type of coins-a departure from the coins of his father and grandfather. The king feeding a peacock on the obverse and God Kumara riding a peacock on the reverse. Skandagupta's gold coins are rare, the few that are available show a fall in the standard of purity. This is attributed to the depletion of treasury due to wars with formidable enemies like the Huns.

The Gupta coins are said to have been influenced by Saka-Kushana coins. Samudragupta calling himself as Samuda and Chandragupta and Chandra are said to be adopted from Kushan Cons. Later, other rulers like Sashnka of Bengal and the Huna kings. Toramana and Mihirakula imitated the Gupta coins.

Check your progress-6

1. State how architecture developed in the Gupta period
2. Explain the progress of sculpture with examples.
3. Describe the features of the Ajanta Paintings.
4. Mention the artistic excellence of the Gupta Coins.

8.8. Let us sum up

The Gupta rule lasted for 200 years, and there was no field in which the rulers did not leave their stamp. They earned victories in battles. They maintained law and order so that the people could live in peace. There was social harmony which facilitated people living happy. Trade and Commerce brought untold wealth. The emperors followed religious tolerance in spite of their personal preferences. People cultivated their intellect through epics, dramas, poetry, fables, and scientific works. Different kinds of arts like sculpture and painting reached new heights of glory. In short, the age of the Guptas was a Golden age an age of culture efflorescence.

8.9. Answers to check your progress

Check your progress -1

7. See 8.2.1
8. See 8.2.2
9. See 8.2.3
10. See 8.2.4

Check your progress -2

7. See 8.3.1 Paragraph 2
8. See 8.3.3 Paragraph 2
9. See 8.3.5
10. See 8.3.6 Paragraphs 2 and 3

Check your progress -3

7. See 8.4.1
8. See 8.4.2
9. See 8.4.3
10. See 8.4.4

Check your progress -4

8. See 8.5.1

9. See 8.5.2

10. See 8.5.3

11. See 8.5.4

Check your progress -5

8. See 8.6.1 Paragraph 1

9. See 8.6.1 Paragraph 3

10. See 8.6.2

11. See 8.6.3

Check your progress -6

1. See 8.7.1

2. See 8.7.2

3. See 8.7.3 Paragraph

4. See 8.7.4

LESSON - 9

SOCIO - CULTURAL LIFE DURING SULTANATE PERIOD

Learning Objectives

After the learning this lesson you will be able to

- ❖ Explain about the coming of Islam to India.
- ❖ Understand the social and cultural aspects of Delhi Sultanate period
- ❖ Describe the contributions of Islam to India
- ❖ Narrate the impact of Islam on Indian society and culture.

Structure

9.1 Introduction

9.2 Coming of Islam to India

9.3 Society

9.3.1. Muslim Nobles

9.3.2. Indian Muslims

9.3.3. Condition of women

9.3.4. System of Education and Its Motivation

9.3.5. Paper

9.3.6. Medicine

9.4 Economy

9.4.1. Prosperous agriculture

9.4.2. Industry

9.4.3. Trade and commerce

9.5 Religion

9.5.1. Islam

9.5.2. Sufism

9.5.3. Bhakti Movement**9.6. Literature****9.6.1. Persian****9.6.2. Sanskrit****9.6.3. Regional Languages and Growth of Vernacular Literature****9.6.4. Hindi literature****9.6.5. Marathi Literature****9.6.6. Gujarati Literature****9.6.7. Bengali Literature****9.6.8. Growth of Urdu****9.7 Hindu Muslim Unity****9.8 The Gifts of Muslim rule in India****9.9 Indian Contact with the outer world was established by the Mohammedans.****9.10 Other Legacies****9.11 Let us sum up****9.12 Answers to Check Your Progress****9.1 Introduction**

India was ruled by the Turks and Afghans for more than three hundred years. The Turkish Sultans, who ruled over India, debarred the Indians from enjoying power and responsibility of the state.

They had developed the feeling of abhorrence towards the “low born non-Turks”. However, with the advent of Muslim refugees, this state of affairs underwent a change, resulting in the fusion of Muslims of different races and nationalities through matrimonial alliances.

The converted Indian Muslims during the rule of Khilji dynast were given a share in the work of administration.

In the lesson let us learn about the coming of Islam to India and its impact on Indian society and culture.

9.2. Coming of Islam to India

The new Islamic or Muslim culture was introduced in India by the Arabs. The expansion and propagation of the Islamic culture was attempted by Peace and force. The former was followed by the Arab traders and the Muslim saints. The latter was adopted by the Arabs, Turkish and Mughal invaders. The foundation of the Muslim Empire in India was laid by Muhammad of Ghor. After his death his viceroy Qutbuddin Aibak founded the Slave dynasty and ruled India from 1206 to 1210. Other notable rulers of this dynasty were collapse of the Delhi Sultanate India was ruled by Sayyid and Lodi dynasties

During the three hundred years of the rule of the Sultans of Delhi, the interaction between the Hindus and the Islamic culture was mostly confined to the wealthy cities and well to do upper classes. In the Book 'The influence of Islam on Indian Culture' written by Dr. Tharachand 'not only did Hindu religion, Hindu art, Hindu literature and Hindu science absorb Muslim elements but the very spirit of Hindu culture and the very shirt of the Hindu mind were also altered'. Majority of the scholars hold a different view that the spirit of Indian and the character of her culture could never be altered completely by Islam.

9.3. Society

9.3.1. Muslim Nobles

During the Sultanate period, the nobles stood at the apex of the social system. They were mostly of foreign origin. They were the most respected and privileged class in the society. They were appointed in high posts and in lieu of their services, they received jagirs. As they belonged to different nationalities like Persians, the Afghans, the Turks, the Arabs, the Abyssinians etc. they are quite hostile to each other.

9.3.2. Indian Muslims

The other section of the society was that of Indian Muslims. They were either of the converted Hindus or were descendants of such converted Muslims. They were deprived of enjoying social and economic privileges like other Muslims in the society. They were also not given a share in the work of administration. This state of condition of the Indian Muslims continued

till the end of thirteenth century. During fourteenth century the attitude of the Sultans underwent a change when the migration of the Turks from Central Asia to India was stopped.

Sultan Ala-ud-din-Khilji for the first time had appointed Malik Kafur, an Indian Musalman as his general. Khwaja Jahan, a brahmin convert was the Prime Minister of Sultan Firuz Tughlaq. However, the well-placed Indian Muslims always tried to conceal their parentage as they desired to acquire equal footing with their foreign counterparts.

In India the Muslims were divided into two classes namely the Umaras or nobles and the Ulemas or the theologians. The nobles were divided into three groups such as Khaas, Malik and Amirs. They enjoyed high offices in the state. The Ulemas or the theologians were assigned the duties of clergymen, teachers and judges. They exerted commanding influence on the government.

The cultivators, the artisans, the shop-keepers, clerks, petty traders, servants, slaves etc. formed the lowest class of the Muslim society. During that period a very few Muslims lived in villages. Slave System. Slave system was in vogue. They were engaged in domestic works only. Both the Hindu and Muslims used to keep slaves. There were slave markets. The sultans provided them with proper education and training so that a good number of slaves rose to eminence.

9.3.3. Condition of women

Though the Hindu women enjoyed respectable position in the family, participated in the religious ceremonies yet their position had deteriorated in the society. The practice of polygamy was prevalent among the rich. Sati system was in practice among the Hindus. Another social evil namely devadasi system was also prevalent among the Hindus. Widow Remarriage was not allowed. Women could not inherit property.

Muslim women also did not have an honoured position in the society. The system of polygamy was in practice. Muslim women strictly observed purdah system. They were also deprived of education. However, in certain aspects, they were in a better position as compared to Hindu women. Unlike the Hindu women, they could divorce their husbands, remarry again and could claim their share in the paternal property. Sati system was not prevalent among the Muslim women.

Some of the Hindus were vegetarians whereas the Muslims were non- vegetarians. Liquor and opium were consumed both by the Hindus and the Muslims. Clothes made of silk, cotton and wool were used by the people. Various sports like hunting; animal fights, horse-polo etc. were their favourite pastimes. The Hindus and Muslims came in contact with each other and influenced each other in many respects. But during the Sultanate period the moral character of both the Hindus and Muslims had declined.

9.3.4. System of Education and Its Motivation

Sanskrit continued to be a vehicle for higher thought and a medium for literature during the period under review.

In fact, the production of works in Sanskrit in different branches was immense and perhaps greater than in the preceding period.

The speed with which the ideas of philosophers were widely disseminated and discussed in different parts of the country showed the important role which Sanskrit continued to play during the period.

There was a network of specialized schools and academies in different parts of the country, including areas under Muslim domination. These schools and academies were not interfered with and continued to flourish.

In fact, many of them took advantages of the introduction of paper to reproduce and disseminate older texts. Apart from Sanskrit, regional languages were also used as the medium of education and motivation, mostly in south India. Amir Khusrau had noted the existence of regional languages and remarked: "These languages have from ancient times applied in every way to the common purposes of life."

9.3.5. Paper

Paper was introduced by the Mohammedans as the Arabic word Kaghaz proves. Thus, books could be multiplied in a more attractive and durable form than by scratching on Palm leaves.

9.3.6. Medicine

The Greece-Arab system of medicine was practiced by the best medical men of the age who were known as Yunani specialist's yuan Rahim or Muslim Physicians.

Check your Progress -1

1. Summarize about the Muslim nobles and the Indian Muslims during Delhi Sultanate period.
2. Give an account of condition of women during the period of Delhi Sultans
3. Write a note on education during Muslim rule in India.

9.4. Economy

Foreign travellers who visited India during this period have observed that the people used gold, silver, diamonds, pearls and other precious stones profusely in the form of ornaments.

It was India's fabulous wealth which tempted Mahmud of Ghazni to invade India so many times.

Timur also got unimaginable wealth from only one of India's corners. We find several prosperous cities and parts during this period. The Sultans of Delhi, nobles, governors, merchants and elites of the society possessed vast wealth and enjoyed all comforts of material life.

Several beautiful mosques, monuments, palaces, forts and temples were built during this period. All this indicates that there was general economic prosperity in the country. Despite constant warfare of the Sultans of Delhi, affluent agricultural and industrial production and foreign trade had enriched India and maintained its prosperity.

Achievements in various fields of Indian economy were mostly on account of private enterprise. Very little was done by the Sultans and provincial governors towards the direct development of trade and industry. Food in general was not a problem for the common man. People did not suffer from the lack of shelter.

9.4.1. Prosperous agriculture

According to Ibn Batuta, a traveller who came from North Africa in India during the fourteenth century, agriculture was in a state of great progress. The soil was so fertile that it produced two crops every year; rice being sown three times a year.

Sesame, sugar-cane and cotton were grown in abundance and these formed the basis of several village industries. Rice of Sarsauti, sugar-cane of Kanauj, wheat and betel leaf of Malwa, wheat of Gwalior, ginger and spices of Malabar, grapes and pomegranates of Daultabad, betel nuts of the South India and a large variety of oranges were popular in and outside India.

Cereals, pulses, fruits and vegetables etc. were produced in almost all parts of India. The Ganga-Yamuna Doab remained always famous for its fertility and large-scale production. Animal husbandry was in a very advanced stage. Ordinarily there was plenty of food production. However, on account of the failure of rains, there were periods of draught.

Condition of peasants

Peasants formed the overwhelming majority of the population. They had to work hard to eke out bare subsistence. Usually they were required to pay one-third of their produce as land revenue.

9.4.2. Industry

During Sultanate period, Bengal and the towns in Gujarat were famous for their fine quality fabrics. Cloth of fine quality was produced in other towns as well.

Cambay in Gujarat was famous for textiles and for gold and silver work. Sonargaon in Bengal was famous for raw silk and fine cotton cloth (called **muslin** later on).

There were many other handicrafts as well, such as leather work, metal work, carpet weaving, etc. Some of the new crafts introduced by the Turks included the manufacture of paper. The art of manufacturing paper had been discovered by the Chinese in the 2nd century. It was known in the Arab world in the 5th century and travelled to Europe only during the 14th century.

The production of textiles was also improved by the introduction of the spinning-wheel. Cotton could be cleaned faster and better by the use of the cotton carder's bow (dhunia). But there is little doubt that most important was the skill of the Indian craftsmen.

Indian textiles had already established their position in the trade to countries on the Red Sea and the Persian Gulf. During this period, fine Indian textiles were introduced to China as

well where it was valued more than silk. India imported high grade textiles (satin etc.) from West Asia, glassware and, of course, horses. From China it imported raw silk and porcelain.

Textile industry was the primary industry. Cotton, silk and woollen clothes of different varieties was produced in large quantity. The clothes were studded with gold, diamond, pearl, silver and other stones. Indian textiles were in great demand in foreign countries. The skill of Indian craftsmen was of a high order. Indian cotton textiles were introduced in China as well where these were valued more than silk. Bengal and Gujarat were famous for their fine quality fabrics.

Important handicrafts were such as carpet weaving, mat work and leather work. Besides textile industry, sugar industry, paper industry, metal work, stone cutting, pearl driving out of the sea, ivory and sandal wood work were other important industries of India. The Sultans had set up several 'Karkhanas' (workshops).

9.4.3. Trade and commerce

India carried a brisk trade—both internal as well as external. Delhi was the largest city and the most important trading centre. Other important trade centres were: Daultabad, in the south, Lahore and Multan in the north-west, Kara and Lakhnauti in the east and Anhilwara (Patan) and Cambay (Khambayat) in the west.

External trade was very profitable and it was one of the main causes of the wealth of India. India had trade relations with Iran, Arabia, European countries, Africa, China, Malaya, Afghanistan and Central Asia, etc. The Arabs were the dominant partners in trade through Indian ocean. The Gujarati and Tamil traders played an important part in trade.

The main items of India's exports were: cereals, cotton and silken cloth, opium, indigo, sea-pearls, sandal wood, saffron, ginger, sugar and coconuts, etc. India imported horses, salt, rosewater, colour valvets, perfumes, wines etc. The external trade was carried on both by land and sea.

Goa, Diu, Chaula, Cochin and Quilon were the important parts on the western Sea-coast of India. There were several seaports on the eastern coast also. India enjoyed a favourable balance of trade.

Check your progress -2

1. Describe the economic conditions during Delhi Sultan's rule in India

9.5. Religion

9.5.1. Islam

During the entire period of the Delhi Sultanate, Islam remained the religion of the state. The Sultans performed a religious duty along with his political obligation while administering the state. His duty was to convert the non-Muslim territory to a Muslim land. Sultans like Firoz Tughlaq and Sikandar Lodi left no stone unturned to propagate Islam among their subjects. But to rulers like Ala -ud -din Khilji and Muhammad Bin Tughlaq, this was a secondary duty.

All the rulers of the Delhi Sultanate pursued a discriminatory policy between their Muslim and non-Muslim subjects the majority of who were Hindus. In matters of land revenue, the Muslims had to pay less than the Hindus. Even the Hindu traders paid double trade tax as compared to the Muslim traders. Foreign Muslims alone were entitled high offices of the state while the Hindus and even non-Muslims were not considered for them. The Hindus were unfavourably discriminated in the dispensation of justice. They had to pay the religious tax, Jizya. Restrictions were imposed on the religious pilgrimages of the Hindus. Hindu educational institutions, temples and images were destroyed, mosques were raised in their places and the religion of the Hindus was disrespected during the rule of most of the Sultans. Thus, the Hindus were not only referred to as Zimmis and Kafirs but also were treated as such in practice.

The period of the Delhi Sultanate was the period of struggle between the Hindus and the Muslims and they contested fiercely against each other both in politics and religion. The policy of the Sultans was that of religious intolerance. The religious propaganda adopted by the Sultans was mainly to defend their established empire in India. The Sultans acted according to the spirit of their age and that was natural and practical for them. But no Sultan of the Sultanate could realise that it was impossible to convert all Hindus to Islam or to destroy the strength of Hinduism by sheer physical force. This kept them devoid of loyalty and cooperation of the majority of their subjects. Though the religious administration of the Sultans suffered from certain defects yet it fulfilled the need of the time.

Religious condition under the rulers of the Delhi Sultanate went through a significant change. During the initial years of their rule, all ancient religious sects in India like the Vedic religion, Hinduism, Buddhism, Jainism, Vaishnavism, Shaivism etc. existed in different forms. But with time many religions declined or were concentrated only in some parts of India. Among the Muslims, the Sunnis and the Shias constituted the majority. The novelties of this period were the growing popularity of Sufism among the Muslims and Bhakti movement among the Hindus.

9.5.2. Sufism

Sufism is an old religious sect and it had penetrated into India prior to the advent of the Delhi Sultanate. Once the Muslims firmly established themselves in India, Sufism gained prominence. A large number of Sufi saints came into India and settled themselves in different parts of the country. Sufism was influenced by the religious views prevalent among the Indians. Love towards god, non-violence, practice of self-discipline etc. was common values among the Hindus, Buddhist and Jains in India. The philosophy of Sufism believes in one god and regards every individual and everything else as part of him. The Sufis were devout Muslims who moved within the Shariat and believed it as the true way to attain salvation.

The Sufi saints led a simple or rather ascetic life and believed in the renunciation of all worldly possessions and pleasures. They did not believe in image worship of any form. They regarded God as kind and benevolent and therefore they did not fear him but loved him. They regarded Desire as the primary enemy of human and therefore emphasised on giving it up. Music inspired them to remember God and therefore they engaged themselves in music and dance with ecstasy while remembering god. The Sufis believed in Guru (Master) whom they called Peer and thought that no one can approach near God without the assistance of a Guru. The Sufis were divided into different sects, most important of them being the Suravardi sect and the Chisti sect. The influence of Suravardi sect remained limited only to Sindh, Punjab and Multan but the Chisti sect became well accepted all over India including Punjab, Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Bihar, Bengal, **Orissa** and south India. Many Sufi saints became quite popular during the period of the Delhi Sultanate. The most important of them were Shaikh Muin-ud-din Chisti, Baba Farid-ud-din, Nasir-ud-din Mahmud, Nizam-ud-din Auliya, Khwaja Shaikh Taki-ud-din and Malik Muhammad Jaysi.

The Sufis represent the liberal element in Islam. They were responsible for the growth and spread of Islam in India. These Sufis or Muslim mystics were men of deep religious feeling, leading ascetic lives and more concerned with mysteries contained in the Quran than with the observance of the ceremonials. They emphasized qualities of effluence, love, mercy, and generosity and immense of God, his form and attributes.

The Sufi movement afforded a common platform to the more learned and devout minds among the Hindus and Muhammadans. A system could not be followed by the illiterate people. Thus, faith is reserved for the philosophers, authors and mystics free from bigotry.

9.5.3. Bhakti Movement

The Bhakti movement in Hinduism was a remarkable feature during the period of Delhi Sultanate. Hindu saints emphasised on Bhakti as a means to attain salvation and that resulted in the Bhakti movement. Hinduism had to face the challenge of Islam in the medieval period which gave birth to the Bhakti movement. The saints of the Bhakti movement believed in god who could be called by different names such as Rama, Krishna, Shiva or Allah. They were against the caste system or image worship and laid stress on Bhakti as the only means to attain salvation. The Bhakti saints believed that a devotee needed a Guru who could help and guide him to attain salvation, though that could be achieved only by the grace of God while the grace of god itself could be achieved only by one's own effort.

The saints propagated these ideas among the people by means of their teachings in simple languages, poems and prayers. But the most effective way of preaching their thoughts was their personal dedicated lives to God. The saints preached their ideas not in Sanskrit but in other Indian regional languages of the people. The pioneers of the Bhakti movements were Ramanuja, Nimbakara and Madhavacharya. Bhakti movement rose to popularity through Ramananda who flourished in the fourteenth century. Other Bhakti saints like Kabir, Guru Nanak and Chaitanya contributed a lot in the expansion and popularity of Bhakti movement.

Check your progress – 3

1. Assess the religious conditions during the period of Delhi Sultanate

9.6. Literature

9.6.1. Persian

The Turks who came to India were deeply influenced by the Persian language which had become the literary and administrative language of Central Asia from the tenth century onwards. From the beginning, the Turks adopted Persian as the language of literature and administration in the country. Thus, Lahore emerged as the first centre for the cultivation of the Persian language.

In course of time, digests of the Islamic law were prepared in Persian with the help of Indian scholars. The most well-known of these were prepared in the reign of Firuz Tughlaq. There was a resurgence of the Persian language in Iran and Central Asia from the tenth century onwards and some of the greatest poets of the Persian language, such as Firdausi and Sadi, lived and composed their works between the tenth and fourteenth centuries.

Although the works of only a few of these early writers of Persian in India have survived, we find in the writings of some of them, such as Masud Sad Salman, a sense of attachment and love for Lahore. However, the most notable Persian writer of the period was Amir Khusrau. Born in 1252 at Patiali (near Badayun in western Uttar Pradesh), Amir Khusrau took pride in being an Indian. Khusrau wrote a large number of poetical works, including historical romances.

He experimented with all the poetical forms and created a new style of Persian which came to be called the *sabaq-i-hindi* or the style of India. Apart from poetry, a strong school of history writing in Persian developed in India during the period. The most famous historians of this period were Ziauddin Barani, Afif and Isami.

Zia Nakhshabi (d. 1350) was the first to translate into Persian Sanskrit stories which were related by a parrot to a woman whose husband had gone on a journey. The book *Tuti Nama* (Book of the Parrot), written in the time of Muhammad Tughlaq, proved very popular and was translated from Persian into Turkish and into many European languages as well.

Later, in the time of Firuz Shah, Sanskrit books on medicine and music were translated into Persian. Sultan Zain-ul-Abidin of Kashmir had the famous historical work *Rajatarangini*

and the Mahabharata translated into Persian. Sanskrit works on medicine and music were also translated into Persian at his instance.

9.6.2. Sanskrit

This period produced greater works in Sanskrit rather than the previous periods. Following the great Sankara, works in the field of Advaita philosophy by Ramanuja, Madhava, Vallabha, etc., continued to be written in Sanskrit, some of the oldest available text of the Ramayana and the Mahabharata belong to the period from the eleventh or twelfth century onwards.

A large number of commentaries and digests on the Hindu law (Dharmashastras) were prepared between the twelfth and the sixteenth century. The great Mitakshara of Vijnaneshwar, which forms one of the two principal Hindu schools of law, cannot be placed earlier than the twelfth century.

Another famous commentator was Chandeshwar of Bihar who lived in the fourteenth century. Most of the works were produced in the south, followed by Bengal, Mithila and western India under the patronage of Hindu rulers.

The Jains, too, contributed to the growth of Sanskrit. Hemachandra Suri was the most eminent of these. Oddly enough, these work largely" ignored the presence of the Muslims in the country. Little attempt was made to translate Islamic works or Persian literature into Sanskrit. Possibly, the only exception was the translation of the love story of Yusuf and Zulaikha written by the famous Persian poet, Jami.

Parthasarathi wrote many works on the Karma Mimansa and some works which expressed the doctrines of Yoga, Naya and Vaiseshika systems of philosophy.

The saints of the Bhakti movement made valuable contributions to the philosophical literature in Sanskrit. In South India Sanskrit literature did receive sufficient patronage by the rulers. Telugu and Kanarese received much encouragement from Vijayanagar Kings.

9.6.3. Regional Languages and Growth of Vernacular Literature

Literary works of the regional languages were also produced during this period. Many of the languages, such as Hindi, Bengali and Marathi, trace their origin back to the eight century or so. Some others, such as Tamil, were much older.

The rise to maturity of many of these languages and their uses as means for literary works may be considered a striking feature of the medieval period. There were many reasons for this. Perhaps, with the loss of prestige by the brahmanas, Sanskrit also lost some of its prestige. The use of the common language by the Bhakti saints was, undoubtedly, an important factor for the rise of these languages.

In fact, in many parts of the country, these early saints fashioned these languages for literary purposes. It seems that in many regional kingdoms of the pre-Turkish period, regional languages, such as Tamil, Kanada, Marathi, etc., were used for administrative purposes, in addition to Sanskrit. This must have been continued under the Turkish rule, for we hear of Hindi-knowing revenue accountants appointed in the Delhi Sultanate.

Later, when the Delhi Sultana broke up local languages, in addition to Persian, continued to be used for administrative purposes in many of the regional kingdoms. Thus, literature in Telugu developed in south India under the patronage of the Vijayanagara rulers. Marathi was one of the administrative languages in the Bahamani kingdom, and later, at the court of Bijapur.

In course of time, when these languages had reached a certain stage of development, some of the Muslim kings gave them patronage for literary purposes also. For example, Nusrat Shah of Bengal had the Mahabharata and the Ramayana translated into Bengali, Maladhar Basu also translated the Bhagavata into Bengali under his patronage. His patronage of Bengali poets has been mentioned earlier.

The use of Bhakti poems in Hindi by the Sufi saints in their musical gatherings has been mentioned before. In Jaunpur, the Sufi saints, such as Malik Muhammad Jaisi, wrote in Hindi and put forward Sufi concepts in a form which could be easily understood by the common man. They popularized many Persian forms, such as the masnavi.

Turko-Afgan rulers were primarily military persons, some of them took interest in belles-letters and under their patronage literature of high order was produced during this period. The court of Delhi Sultans were well attended by writers, poets, scholars, philosophers, logicians, theologians, lawyers and chroniclers. Amir Khusrau, Mir Hussan Dehlvi, Badruddin Thoneswari, Quazi Abdul and Amil-ul-Mulk etc. were the shining lights of the literary firmament during the period.

Islam gave an immediate filling to the vernacular languages which were in the course of evolution. The religious reformers and saints wrote, spoke and preached in languages which could be easily understood by the masses. The growth of Hindi, Marathi, Bengali, Maithili, Punjabi, Gurumukhi and other provincial literatures took place in this age. Ramananda, Kabir, Surdas and Tulsidas preached in Hindi, Mirabai and some other preachers and saints of Radha-Krishna cult preached in Brij-bhasa.

9.6.4. Hindi literature

The liberal patronage extended by the court of provincial rulers to men of letters has added to the growth of Hindi literature. The poet Chand Bardai wrote Prithviraj-Raso was the earliest Hindi poet. In Rajasthan, a vast literature rich in heroic ballads and poetry connected with the deeds of Rajput Chiefs and warriors grew. Gorakhnath and Namadeva were the first saint to compose the Bhajans and Pads or Verses in Hindi. Kabir's verses possessed the charm and force with the sentiment of Hindu-Muslim unity.

His mysticism has its own prominence in Hindi literature. Nanak has also enriched Hindi literature. Mira bai who was intensely devoted to her deity Lord Krishna expressed her love and devotion in exquisite verses which are famous for their sweet melody and attracted millions of her time Kabir, Nanak, Dharamadas, Daud Dayal, Sunder Das, Maluk Das etc. have created religious literature.

9.6.5. Marathi Literature

Marathi literature began from the medieval age. Chakradhar, Bhaskar, Bhatt, Narendra, and Mukundaray were the early poets and writers of Marathi. Jnaneswar the famous saint poet of Maharashtra in the 13th century composed his commentary on Gita called Janeshwari in Prakrit Marathi. It appealed to the masses most.

9.6.6. Gujarati Literature

The early medieval Gujarati literatures were enriched by the boards and Jain monks. To preach the doctrine of Jainism, the Jain monks had composed many works in poetry called Ras. The Bhakti movement in Gujarat stimulated the growth of religious literature in Gujarati. Mira and Narsingh Mehta occupy prominent position among the saints and poets of Gujarat.

9.6.7. Bengali Literature

The work of Vidyapati and Chandi Das renowned poets of the age provided stimulus to the growth of the Bengali literature. Vidyapati extended his work to Maithili language also. The Muslim rulers of Bengal also patronized Bengali. They engaged scholars to translate Ramayan and Mahabharat from Sanskrit to Bengali.

Chaitanya enriched the Bengali literature with his songs and Bhajans. The elevation of Bengali to a literary status was brought about by several influences of which Mohammedon conquest was undoubtedly one of the foremost causes as marked by Dinesh Chandra Sen.

9.6.8. Growth of Urdu

Another important achievement in the field of literature was the growth of Urdu out of the mingling of Persian, Arabic and Turkish words and ideas with languages and concepts of Sanskrit Origin. It has the words of Arabic, Persian, Turkish languages, Western Hindi dialects of Delhi province.

The grammatical structure of Urdu is essentially that of Hindi. Various necessities forced the Mohammadans and Hindus to meet each other involved the evolution of a common language which came to be known as Urdu that turned to be the medium of expression of many during this period that still continued to be an Indian language, composed and contributed by many poets and literatures. Literature in different regions thus underwent a great change.

Check your progress – 4

1. Highlight the development of languages and literature during Delhi Sultanate period

9.7. Hindu Muslim Unity

The numerous social taboos and restrictions regarding caste, marriage, eating and drinking had become all the more stringent among the Hindus. The unhealthy feature of social life that crept into the Hindu Society. Muhammadan dress, etiquette and ceremonial came into fashion in the Hindu Society under Mohammed an influence. An important result of the advent of Islam was the restoration of India's contact with the outside world. Owing to the Islamic impact, the

birth of a girl among the Hindus was looked upon as an inauspicious event. Consequently, infanticide spread widely among the Hindus. Like Muslim women, the Hindu women started living in speculation. An important result of the advent of Islam was the restoration of India's contact with the outside world.

The growth of the spirit of mutual harmony, co-operation and toleration and the synthesis of Hindu-Muslim cultures constitute other interesting aspects. The contribution made by the Muslims in art and architecture is great. The Muslim conquest of India is fundamentally different from other conquests. The previous conquerors like the Greeks, the Scythians, the Parthians and Mongolians were Hinduized in their dress, customs and manners, ideas and religion. Heliodorus, a Greek became a worshipper of Vishnu and created a column for Vishnu and became a Vaishnavite.

Islam cannot allow any compromise in Polytheism and Islam is Monotheistic religion. The Muslims even today turn their faces towards mecca while they worship.

9.8. The Gifts of Muslim rule in India

- a) There was a restoration of contact with outside world, which included the revival of an Indian Navy and sea-borne trade which had been lost since the decline of Cholas. During the Muslim rule, thousands of foreigners poured into India, while only a part of Muslims went abroad.
- b) Uniformity of social manners and dress prevailed among the upper classes irrespective of their creed.
- c) Indo-Saracenic art emerged in splendour. In this art the medieval Hindu and Chinese schools were blended together. A new style of architecture and the promotion of industries of a refined kind were developed.
- d) Internal peace was established over a large part of India especially North of the Vindhyas.
- e) Rise of our Vernacular literature under the sultanate of Delhi came to be developed. Historical literature developed considerably due to Islamic impact.
- f) A common lingua franca called Rekhta or Hindustani and an official prose style was developed.

- g) Monotheistic religious revival and Sufism were the two other characteristics of Islam which made their impact upon India.
- h) Improvement took place in the art of warfare and in civilization in general.

They also established the Rule of Law everywhere which was in many more humane than the Rule of Law which prevailed in contemporary Europe. The Muslims imposed death punishment for certain crimes. The Muslims observed elaborate court festivals and etiquette (code of conduct) in the court.

9.9. Indian Contact with the outer world was established by the Mohammedans

Only foreigners infiltrated into India and some Indian Muslims went abroad every year. Sea routes were also established. Because of the coming of the Muslims, our contact with the outer world had increased remarkably. The sultans of Delhi left a very good legacy in administration. In case of less weightage of food grains, Ala-Ud-Din-Khilji ordered that the same equal measurement of flesh would be cut off and taken away from the person who was found to be guilty. As a result, there was justice and fair play even in business. Ala-Ud-Din-Khilji did not believe in enhancing the salaries of the officials. On the other hand, he believed in the concept of reducing the prices of the commodities. There is great legacy on his part to the contemporary India. Like him, Muhammed-bin-Thughlaq also left very good legacy in administration.

9.10. Other Legacies

The Muslim influence was naturally most strongly felt on the system of administration, the court ceremonies and dress, the military organization and arm, the lives of the upper classes, the articles of luxury, fine arts, architecture and gardening.

The Muslims were leading generally a more luxurious life than the Hindus and being a predominantly city population encouraged several manufactures and fine arts. They were more tasteful and elegant than the Hindus in their daily life and even in their food habits –which the richer Hindus and particularly the official class copied wherever they had the means. By the agency of the Mohammedans, new articles of food and new styles of cookery were introduced.

Check your progress -5

1. Analyze the impact of Muslim rule on Indian society and culture.

9.11. Let us sum up

In this lesson we have learnt about the advent of Islam to India and its contribution. Moreover, you have studied about the impact of Islam on Indian Society and culture.

9.12. Answers to Check your Progress

Check your Progress – 1

1. See 9.3.1& 9.3.2
2. See 9.3.3.
3. See 9.3.4.

Check your Progress – 2

1. See 9.4.1. – 9.4.3.

Check your Progress – 3

1. See 9.5.1. – 9.5.3.

Check your Progress - 4

1. See 9.6.1-9.6.8

Check your Progress - 5

1. See 9.7. – 9.10.

LESSON - 10

ART AND ARCHITECTURE UNDER DELHI SULTANATE

Learning Objectives

After learning this lesson, you will be able to

- appreciate the splendour of Indo-Islamic architecture
- assess the glory of provincial architecture
- comprehend the beauty of Hindu architecture
- understand the nuances of characteristic features of architecture of this period
- Grasp the importance attained by the Fine Arts

Structure

10.1 Introduction

10.2 Indo-Islamic Architecture

10.3 Provincial Architecture

10.4 Hindu Architecture

10.5 Characteristics of the Architecture During the Sultanate Period

10.6 Fine Arts

10.7 Answers to Check your Progress

10.1 Introduction

During the Sultanate period, architecture made tremendous progress. This period witnessed the growth of Indo-Islamic architecture. This style of architecture was either purely Islamic or purely Hindu, rather it was influenced by both the styles.

Several factors contributed towards the synthesis of Indian and Islamic style. Firstly, the Muslim rulers had to employ Indian 'Craftsmen, architects and sculptors, who had applied the

Indian style of construction into Muslim buildings. Secondly, the Muslim rulers destroyed the Hindu temples and built the mosques, palaces and tombs out of the materials of the destroyed Hindu temple.

Thirdly, the rulers converted the Hindu temples and palaces into their mosques and buildings. Besides, there was a nexus between the two styles with regard to the fact that both the Indian and Islamic art were inherently decorative. The Hindus adorned their buildings with images of different gods and goddesses, whereas the Muslims decorated them with square, triangular, parallel, rectangular lines, teachings of the Korans inscribed in the Persian script. Thus, the Hindu style of architecture greatly influenced Islamic style because of these factors and gave birth to this Indo-Islamic architecture.

10.2. Indo-Islamic Architecture

Qutubuddin Aibak constructed the Quwat-ul-Islam mosque at Delhi and another mosque at Ajmer called the Dhaj Dargah. The first was raised at the site of a destroyed temple and the other at a site of a destroyed college of Sanskrit. Therefore, both these mosques have the imprint of both the Hindu and Muslim art. Sultan Iltutmish and Alauddin Khilji added further to the Quwat-ul-Islam mosque. The construction of Qutub Minar was originally planned by Aibak but it was completed by Iltutmish.

The planning of Qutub Minar was purely Islamic as originally the purpose of this tower was that from it the Muezzin could summon the faithful to prayer, though, afterwards, it became famous as a tower of victory. Iltutmish constructed its four storeys and it rose to a height of 225 feet. During the reign of Firuz Tughlaq lightning caused damage to the fourth storey of this tower and he replaced it by two smaller ones and raised its height to 243 feet (74.12 metres).

According to Percy Brown, "Qutub Minar as a whole is a most impressive conception, the vivid colour of its red sand stone, the changing texture of its fluted stories with their overlay of inscriptional bands, the contrast between the alternating spaces of plain masonry and rich carving, the shimmer of the shadows under the balconies, all combine to produce an effect of marked vitality.

Fergusson regarded it 'as the most perfect example of a tower known to exist anywhere in the world'. Besides completing the Qutab Minar, Iltutmish constructed a tomb on the grave of his eldest son, known as Sultan-Ghori, nearly three miles away from the Qutub-Minar.

He also constructed a chamber near the Qutub Minar which was, probably, the tomb on his own grave and also, Hauz-i-Shamsi-Itdgah, the Jami Masjid at Badaun and the Atar kin-ka-Darwaza at Nagur (Jodhpur). He further made additions to Quwat-ul-Islam and Dhai-din Ka Jhonpra. The mausoleum of Iltutmish was also another famous building of that period.

Balban built his own tomb and the Red palace at Delhi. His own tomb, though in a dilapidated condition now, marked a notable landmark in the development of Indo-Islamic architecture. Alauddin Khilji had better economic resources at his command and therefore, constructed beautiful buildings. His buildings were constructed with perfectly Islamic viewpoint and have been regarded as some best examples of Islamic art in India.

He had a plan to build a minar and a big mosque near the Qutub Minar which he could not pursue because of his death. Yet, he found the city of Siri, constructed a fort, built a beautiful palace of thousands of pillars (Hazar Situn) within it, Jamait Khan Mosque at the shrine of Nizamuddin Auliya and the famous Alai Darwaza at the Qutub Minar. He also built a single compact chamber near the Qutub Minar.

His city and the palace had been destroyed but the Jamait Khan mosque and the Alai Darwaza still exist which have been regarded as beautiful specimens of Islamic art. According to Marshal, 'the Alai Darwaza is one of the most treasured gems of Islamic architecture.' Alauddin also constructed a magnificent tank covering an area of nearly 70 acres, known as Hauz-i-Alai or Hauz-i-Khas near his newly constructed city of Siri in the vicinity of the old city of Delhi.

The Tughlaq-Sultans did not construct beautiful buildings. Probably, the primary cause of it was their economic difficulties. Besides they were puritanical in their taste and therefore, avoided ornamentation in their buildings. Ghiyasuddin constructed the new city of Tughlaqabad east of the Qutub area, his own tomb and a palace.

Ibn Battuta wrote about his palace that 'it was constructed of golden bricks which, when the sun rose, shone so dazzlingly that no one could gaze at it steadily'. However, now his

palace and the city stand destroyed while his tomb constructed of red stone gives the impression of a small strong fort but lacks splendour.

Muhammad Tuglaq constructed the new city of Jahanpanah near the city of old Delhi, the fort of Adilabad and a few other buildings at Daulatabad. But all his buildings have been destroyed.

The remains of only two buildings, the Sathpalah bund and the Bijai Mandal alone are found. Firoz Tughluq constructed many buildings but all of them were just ordinary and weak. Among his notable buildings was the new city of Firuzabad near the old city of Delhi, the palace-fort known as Kotla Firoz Shah within it, a college and his own tomb near Hauz-i-Khas. During his time a noble at the court, Khan-i-Jahan Jauna Shah constructed the tomb of his father, Tilangani, the Kaii Masjid and the Khirki Masjid in the city of Jahanpanah.

A beautiful building known as Lai-Gumbad was constructed by Nasiruddin Muhammad Tughlaq Shah at the grave of Kabir-ud-din Auliya. A few notable structures among the buildings constructed by Lodi and Sayyid Sultans are the tombs of Mubarak Shah Sayyid, Muhammad Shah Sayyid and Sikandar Lodi and a mosque known as Moth-ki-Masjid by the prime minister of Sikandar Lodi at Delhi.

Among buildings raised by Sultan of the Delhi Sultanate cities, palaces and forts have been destroyed. Only a few tombs, mosques and minars have existed so far. The buildings which are left, of course are not marvellous, yet fairly good specimens of early Indo-Islamic architecture in India and the best among them are the Qutub Minar and the Alai-Darwaza.

10.3.Provincial Architecture

A good number of provinces proclaimed their independence during the period of the later Tughlaqs. The rulers of these provinces were also great patrons of architecture. The provincial style was different from imperial style in some respects. The imperial architecture was more splendid than the provincial architecture. This was mainly due to the limited financial resources of the provincial rulers. Secondly, the local style also influenced the provincial style of architecture.

In Bengal the style of architecture which developed was the synthesis of Islamic art and Hindu art. The notable buildings of province are Adina Masjid constructed by Sikandar Shah at

Pandua the Eklakhi Mausoleum at HazratPandua, the Lotan Masjid and the Bari Sona Masjid at Gaur, the Qudam Rasul at Gaur built by Nusrat Shah, the DakhilDarwaza at Gaur and the tomb of Jalaluddin Muhammad at Pandua.

The buildings of Gaur Tribeni and Pandua are made of bricks. Stones were very rarely used. The special features of Bengal style of architecture were the use of pointed arches on pillars, Hindu decorative designs and the application of Hindu architecture to Islamic art.

The rulers of Jaunpur were great patrons of art and architecture. The architecture of Jaunpur contained the features of both Hindu and Islamic architecture. The Atala Masjid constructed by Ibrahim Shah Sharqi, the Jami Masjid built by Hussain Shah, and the Lai Darwaza mosque are some of the beautiful specimens of provincial architecture.

The province of Malwa witnessed the emergence of a distinct style of architecture which had some resemblance with the architecture of Delhi. The domes and pillars of two mosques built out of the materials of Hindu buildings at Dhar were of Hindu form. The fort of Mandu has been considered as the beautiful specimen of provincial architecture. Some of the beautiful buildings of Mandu are the Jami Masjid, the Hindola Mahal, Asharfi Mahal, the Jahaz Mahal, the tomb of Hushang Shah and the palaces of Baz Bahadur and his queen Rupamati.

Before the advent of Turks, the province of Gujarat had developed a beautiful indigenous style. After the Muslim conquest, Gujarat had produced the best combination of Hindu and Muslim architecture. The famous buildings of Gujarat are the Jami masjid at Cambay, the Jami Masjid and tomb of Ahmad Shah at Ahmedabad, the Tin Darwaza, the Ranika Hujra and Dholka Masjid. The city of champagne is adorned with many beautiful buildings and the most famous building among them is the mosque built by Mahmud Begarha.

The Sultans of Bahamani kingdom also constructed magnificent buildings within their territories. Some of the famous buildings are the mosques at Bidar and Gulbrga, the tomb of Muhammad Adil Shah known as Gol Gumbuz and the Chand Minar at Daulatabad.

10.4.Hindu Architecture

In north India particularly in Rajasthan, the Rajput's could maintain their political existence. Hence in Rajasthan, the specimens of Hindu architecture are found. Rana Kumbha of Mewar

had constructed the fort of Kumbhalgarh and the Kirti Stambha or the tower of victory in Chitor. Kirti Stambha has been considered as one of the remarkable towers in the country.

At many places forts and palaces were built by different rulers. Though the forts still exist, the palaces have perished. In the south, the rulers of Vijay Nagar Empire had built many beautiful architectural edifices. Unfortunately, the battle of Talikota devastated the kingdom and most of the beautiful buildings and temples of the kingdom were destroyed.

However, one among them which were survived is the Vithala temple built by Krishnadeva Raya. Fergusson has described this temple as the, “finest building of its kind in South India.” Thus, both the Indian and Islamic art had played pivotal role in the enrichment of Indian architecture. During the period of Delhi Sultanate architecture had made good progress.

Check your progress – 1

1. Give an account of Indo-Islamic Architecture
2. Write a note on Provincial Architecture during the rule of Delhi Sultans

10.5. Characteristics of the Architecture During the Sultanate Period

i. A mixture of Indian (Hindu) and Iranian (Muslim) Style:

The Sultans of Delhi wanted to construct their buildings on the pattern of Iran and Central Asia.

However, their buildings could not be exact copies of these buildings. They had to employ Indian craftsmen who had their own ideas about the form and method of construction.

Thus, though the buildings were designed by Muslim architects to suit the requirements of their religious ideas, yet they were constructed by Hindu craftsmen who formed the finest artistry of the world. Obviously, the buildings had a combination of Indo- Islamic architecture.

ii. Buildings constructed with the material of Hindu temples:

Several buildings were constructed out of the material used in the temples that were destroyed by some of the Muslim rulers. Quwat-ul-Islam Mosque in Delhi is said to have been

built by Qutub-ud-Din Aibak by demolishing a Hindu temple. Likewise, 'Adai-din-ka Jhopra' a mosque in Ajmer, built in 2 ½ days came into being on the ruins of a Hindu building.

iii. Pointed arched in the Muslim structures:

It is noted that the Hindus used square pillars which supported their temple roofs. On the other hand, the Muslims used the arches. Besides arches, they also used domes over their buildings and minarets on sides. The use of arch and dome added charm to the Muslim buildings and also enabled them to dispense with the need of a large number of pillars to support the roof.

iv. Carvings:

The Hindus carved the figures of gods and goddesses on all sides of pillars, walls and ceilings also. They also carved various ornamental things like garlands, flowers and temple bells etc. The Muslims did not allow any representation of living things on their buildings. The Hindu workmen who were skilled in decorating the pillars and walls were allowed the use of flowers and trees in the decoration of Muslim buildings.

v. Use of geometrical designs:

During the Sultanate period, geometrical designs began to be used for decoration purposes.

vi. Quaranic 'Ayats':

The use of Quaranic 'Ayats' in the buildings served two purposes i.e. religious as well as decorative.

vii. Use of stones and lime:

During the Sultanate period several types of coloured stones like red, light black, yellow and white marbles were used. A very good quality of stone was used to make the buildings strong.

10.6. Fine Arts

During this period, trends towards mutual understanding and integration are to be found in the fields of fine arts, particularly music. When the Turks came to India, they inherited the rich Arab tradition of music which had been further developed in Iran and Central Asia. They brought with them a number of new musical instruments, such as the rabab and sarangi, and new musical modes and regulations.

Indian music and Indian musicians at the court of the Caliphs at Baghdad had possibly influenced the development of music there. However, systematic contact between the two began in India under the Sultanate. Amir Khusrau, master of both the theory and practices of music, introduced many Perso-Arabic airs (ragas), such as aiman, ghora, sanam, etc.

He is credited with having invented the Sitar, though we have no evidence of it. The Tabla which is also attributed to him seems, however, to have developed during the late seventeenth or early eighteenth century.

The process of integration in the field of music continued under Firuz. The Indian classical work Ragadarpan was translated into Persian during this reign. Musical gatherings spread from the abodes of the Sufis to the palaces of the nobles. Sultan Husain Sharqi, the ruler of Jaunpur, was a great patron of music.

The Sufi saint, PirBodhan, is supposed to have been the second great musician of the age. Another regional kingdom where music was highly cultivated was the kingdom of Gwalior. Raja Man Singh of Gwalior was a great music lover.

The work Man Kautuhal in which all the new musical modes introduced by the Muslims were included was prepared under his aegis. We do not know at what time the musical modes in north India began to differ from those in the south. But there is little doubt that the differentiation was largely due to the incorporation of Perso-Arabic modes, airs and scales. A distinctive style of music, influenced in considerable measure by Persian music, developed in the kingdom of Kashmir.

After the conquest of Jaunpur, Sikandar Lodi followed its tradition of patronizing music on a lavish scale — a tradition which was adopted by the great Mughals later on.

Check your Progress – 2

1. What are the Characteristics of the Architecture during the Sultanate Period?
2. What do you know about the Fine Arts during Delhi Sultanate period?

10.7. Answers to Check your Progress

Check your progress – 1

1. See 10.2.
2. See 10.3.

Check your Progress – 2

1. see 10.5.
2. See 10.6.

LESSON - 11

SOCIO - CULTURAL LIFE DURING MUGHAL RULE

Learning Objectives

After the learning this lesson you will be able to

- ❖ Explain about the Social divisions in the society during Mughal period.
- ❖ Describe the System of education
- ❖ Narrate the development of literature
- ❖ Focus on the religious conditions, fairs and festivals of Mughal period

Structure

11.1 Introduction

11.2 Social divisions

11.2.1. The king and the princely class

11.2.1. The king and the princely class

11.2.2. Nobility or nobles

11.2.3. The Middle Class

11.2.4. The Lower Class

11.2.5. Position of women

11.2.6. Social evils

11.2.7. Dress, food habits and ornaments

11.2.8. Amusements and sports

11.2.9. Mujra

11.3 System of Education and Its Motivations

11.3.1. Education: A Private Affair

11.3.2. Hindu Education

11.3.3. Muslim Education: Madarsa and Maktabas**11.3.4. The Aim of Education****11.3.5. Course Content and Libraries****11.3.6. Women's Education****11.4 Literature****11.4.1. Persian****11.4.2. Sanskrit****11.4.3. Regional Languages****11.4.4. Growth of Vernacular Literature****11.5 Religious Conditions****11.5.2. Din-i-Ilahi****11.5.3. Festivals, fairs and pilgrimages****11.6 The Gifts of Mughal rule in India****11.6.1. Warfare****11.6.2. Natural beauty****11.6.3. Other Legacies****11.6.4. Diffusing knowledge****11.6.5. The Sufi brotherhood****11.7 Let us sum up****11.8 Answers to check your Progress****11.1 Introduction**

The **Mughals** were a branch of the Timurid dynasty of Turco-Mongol origin from Central Asia. Their power rapidly dwindled during the 18th century and the last of the emperors was deposed in 1857, with the establishment of the British Raj. The Mughal Empire (1526-1761 CE) at its zenith commanded resources unprecedented in Indian history and covered almost the entire subcontinent. From 1556 to 1707, during the heyday of its fabulous wealth and glory, the Mughal Empire was a fairly efficient and centralized organization, with a vast complex of personnel, money, and information dedicated to the service of the emperor and his nobility.

Much of the empire's expansion during that period was attributable to India's growing commercial and cultural contact with the outside world. The 16th and 17th centuries brought the establishment and expansion of European and non-European trading organizations in the subcontinent, principally for the procurement of Indian goods in demand abroad. Indian regions drew close to each other by means of an enhanced over land and coastal trading network, significantly augmenting the internal surplus of precious metals. With expanded connections to the wider world came also new ideologies and technologies to challenge and enrich the imperial edifice.

The empire itself, however, was a purely Indian historical experience. Mughal culture blended Perso-Islamic and regional Indian elements into a distinctive but variegated whole. Although by the early 18th century the regions had begun to reassert their independent positions, Mughal manners and ideals outlasted imperial central authority. The imperial centre, in fact, came to be controlled by the regions. The trajectory of the Mughal Empire over roughly its first two centuries (1526–1748) thus provides a fascinating illustration of premodern state building in the Indian subcontinent.

The individual abilities and achievements of the early Mughals—Bâbur, Humâyûn, and later Akbar—largely charted this course. Bâbur and Humâyûn struggled against heavy odds to create the Mughal domain, whereas Akbar, besides consolidating and expanding its frontiers, provided the theoretical framework for a truly Indian state. Picking up the thread of experimentation from the intervening Sûr dynasty (1540–56), Akbar attacked narrow-mindedness and bigotry, absorbed Hindus in the high ranks of the nobility, and encouraged the tradition of ruling through the local Hindu landed elites. This tradition continued until the very end of the Mughal Empire, despite the fact that some of Akbar's successors, notably Aurangzeb (1658–1707), had to concede to contrary forces.

11.2. Social divisions

Broadly speaking, Indian society was divided into four classes:

- (1) The king and the princes
- (2) The nobles
- (3) The middle class
- (4) The lower class.

11.2.1. The king and the princely class

The king enjoyed the highest social status. He lived in great luxury. Usually he maintained a big 'harem' (wives and concubines in the palace of the emperor). It is said that Akbar had about 500 women in his household. The princely class was quite large on account of a large number of queens the Mughal kings had. The princes followed the life style of the king.

11.2.2. Nobility or nobles

The noble class included descendants of the people who had come from other lands like Central Asia and Persia. It also included high mansabdars and jagirdars. Important Rajput chiefs also came under this category.

The nobles imitated the King and the princes and lived a life of extravagance. They spent lavishly. They lived in palatial buildings. They have scores of servants. They kept several women in their 'harem'. Drinking was very common among them. Generally speaking they indulged in court intrigues and were very corrupt. The nobles patronized art and literature. They also took interest in laying down beautiful gardens and flower beds.

11.2.3. The Middle Class

It included wealthy traders and merchants, small mansabdars, jagirdars and professionals. The merchants and traders did not exhibit their wealth because of the fear that the ruler or a powerful noble might snatch it from them. In general, they enjoyed a simple life.

11.2.4. The Lower Class

A majority of the population belonged to this category. This class lived a life of poverty. They had a few clothes. They lived in thatched mud houses. This class comprised artisans, attendants, cultivators, labourers, peasants, small traders and shop-keepers, etc. There were slaves also. There was a glaring inequality in the lives of other classes and the common people. The peasants lived virtually at the mercy of the mansabdars and jagirdars. They were worst hit during famines.

11.2.5. Position of women

Although the general condition of women was not good, there were several capable and enterprising women like Nur Jahan, Mumtaz Mahal, Jahanara, Roshanara, Rani Karnavati, Rani Durgavati, Rani Rupmati, Chand Bibi, Jijabai and Tarabai. But all these ladies belonged to the higher strata of society. In general women suffered from all sorts of handicaps.

Polygamy was very common among the Muslims. Talaq or divorce was also very common and men could get it very easily. There was no talaq among the Hindus.

Sati was common among the Hindu women.

The emperors, the nobles and the rich people had reduced the position of women to articles of pleasure. They kept a large number of wives, concubines and slave girls in their harems.

The Muslim women had to observe purdah.

11.2.6. Social evils

Sati was common among the Hindus. Child marriage was also prevalent. Purdah system was in vogue. Untouchability was practiced on a large scale.

11.2.7. Dress, food habits and ornaments

Important changes took place in dress, food habits and ornaments etc. People of upper and middle classes both among the Hindus and Muslims wore Qahaf – a long coat coming down to the knees and tight trousers. The common man among the Hindus used Dhoti and the Muslims Kurta and Pajama. Both the Hindus and the Muslims wore turbans though their styles differed.

Men, both Hindus and Muslims used Shawls. Hindu ladies wore Dhoti and Angiya and the Muslim ladies 'Pajama, Ghagra', 'Jacket' dupata etc. Only rich people could afford to wear shoes or chappals.

While the Hindus were mostly vegetarians, the Muslims were generally non-vegetarians. Milk formed an important part of diet in the villages.

Several sections of population used wine, opium and tobacco as intoxicants.

11.2.8. Amusements and sports

Hunting, animal fighting, wrestling, pigeon- flying, were important sources of amusements and sports. Cock-fightings, bull-fightings and ram-fightings were also very common. Chess and chauper were also played.

11.2.9. Mujra

The performance of singers and dancers and Mushaira were also very popular.

Check your progress -1

1. Analyse the divisions in the Mughal society
2. Write a note on the position of women during Mughal period

11.3. System of Education and Its Motivations

All the Mughal emperors were great patrons of learning and gave their full encouragement to the spread of education in their dominions.

Babur was himself a great scholar and public works department (Shuhraat-i-Am) established by him, which, also continued to exist under later Mughal emperors, was on trusted along with other responsibilities to that of building the schools and colleges.

His son, Humayan had great love for study of books especially in astronomy and geography. He constructed a Madarsa at Delhi and converted the pleasure-house built by Sher Shah in Qila Kohana also called Purana Qila into a library.

The reign of Akbar, well known for improvement in various other domains, also constitutes a new epoch in the growth and improvement of education. He established a number of colleges for high learning at Agra and Fatehpur Sikri and also attempted to revise the curriculum of education.

Abul Fazal writes, "All civilized nations have schools for the education of youth; but Hindustan is particularly famous for its seminaries". Akbar also encouraged the Hindus to join the madarsa and learn Persian, the court language.

Jahangir was himself a great scholar of Turki and Persian and had written his memories known as the Tuzuk-i-Jahangiri. It is stated that soon after his sitting on the throne, he got repaired many old madarsa, which had ceased to function for quite a long and filled them with pupils and their teachers.

Towards the close of his reign, he also promulgated an order that if a rich person or traveller died without heirs, his property would escheat to the crown and be spent on the construction and maintenance of madarsa and monasteries, etc.

Shah Jahan had great fascination for study of the Turkish language and had a regular habit of study at night for a short while. He repaired an old institution called Dar-ul-Boqa (Abode of Eternity) and found a new college at Delhi. His son, Dara Soukoh, also patronized every educational activity. Aurangzeb encouraged the education of the Muslims and founded colleges and schools” (Keene).

11.3.1. Education: A Private Affair

Dr. Srivastava writes, “The Mughal government did not consider it to be its duty to educate the people. It had no department of education and did not allocate a portion of the public revenue for the spread of literacy. Education was thus in Mughal India a private affair, a hand-made of religion and if the Mughals took interest in it, it was to earn religious merit and not to advance the welfare of the people.

The public made their own arrangements for the education of their children and considering the age and circumstances of the time, the arrangements were fairly satisfactory.” Both the Hindus and the Muslims had their separate institutions for education of their children.

The Hindus sent their children to the school usually at the age of five but the Muslims performed the maktab ceremony at the auspicious day of the child completing four years, four months and four days. The syllabi and curriculum of studies as well as the medium of instruction used by the communities were different. Obviously, their institutions of higher learning were also located separately and the subjects of their research and higher studies were also different.

11.3.2. Hindu Education

The Hindus had their primary schools attached to the temples. These schools were maintained by grants or endowments and no fee was charged from the pupils. There were no printed books and the children wrote the alphabets on wooden boards or on dust of the ground with fingers.

Classes were usually held under the shade of a tree. The students were taught the religious scriptures after they finished their alphabets and these were usually, according to Bernier, the Puranas. The centers of higher learning or universities were scattered all over the country, largely near the places of pilgrimage. These were Banaras, Nadia, Mithila, Mathura, Tirhut, Paithan, Karhad, Thatte, Sirhind and Multan.

Bernier states, "Banaras is kind of university; but it has no college or regular classes as in our universities, but resembles rather the school of the ancients, the masters being spread over different parts of the town in private houses". Nadia was the second great centre of Hindu learning after Banaras.

Vasudeva Sarvabhauma founded a school of Nyaya there in the sixteenth century which even out rivalled Mithila. The University of Mithila, however, continued to be a prominent centre of learning during the Mughal period. Mathura was another famous centre of learning with its specialization in Hindu philosophy and there were more than ten thousand students.

Thatte was equally important and had, according to Hamilton, four hundred colleges. The subjects of theology, philology and politics were taught there. Multan was well known as a centre of specialization in astronomy, astrology, medicine and mathematics. Sirhind had an important school of medicine.

The subjects of study in all these Hindu centers of study were grammar, logic, philosophy, history, poetry, astronomy, astrology, medicine including veterinary science and mathematics also including study of physics and chemistry.

11.3.3. Muslim Education: Madarsah and Maktab

The Muslims sent their children to Maktab located in the mosque and these schools, according to the Italian traveller Delia Valle, existed in every town and village. The basic course of study at the primary standard was the Quran which every child had to learn by rote. After completing their study of Quran, the pupils were taught Gulistan and Bostan of Sheikh Sadi and poems of Firdausi.

The institutions of Higher learning called Madarsahs were at Agra, Delhi, Lahore, Jaunpur, Gujarat, Sialkot and Ahmedabad. Agra was the biggest centre of learning where there were numerous Madarsahs including the college of Jesuits. Delhi was the second largest centre of education.

It had also a number of madarsah, the prominent being Humayun's madarsah, Maham Anaga's madarsah, called Khair-ul- Manzil and Darul Bana built by Shah Jahan. The Khan-ul- Manzil was big residential college where students lived in the rooms of both the storeys and classes were conducted in the main hall.

Jaunpur as a great centre of learning was known as the 'Shiraz of India', where students came from far and wide. The Madarsah Faiz Safa and Langar-i-Den/vazda Imam (now called Bara Imam ka Kotla) located in Gujarat and Ahmedabad respectively were reputable centers of learning in the Western India.

Lahore as an important centre of education attained its eminence during the reign of Aurangzeb. Kashmir was also a place of attraction for scholars because of its pleasant climate and beautiful environment.

Among other places of education, Gwalior, Sialkot, Ambala and Thaneswar were quite famous. The courses of study in these institutions of learning consisted of grammar, rhetoric, logic, theology, metaphysics, jurisprudence and literature. Mathematics, medicine and astronomy were also studied under the impact of Hindu scholars. The medium of instruction usually was Persian or Arabic.

11.3.4. The Aim of Education

“The aim of education” writes Prof. S.M. Jaffar, “was to bring out the latent faculties of students, to discipline the forces of their intellect and to develop their character, to equip them with all that was required for their material as well as moral improvement. Education was regarded as a preparation for life and for life after death and hence it was that religion was at the root of all study”.

The education thus did not equip a student only to obtain his employment under the state but attempted at the development of his faculties of head and heart. These were no regular examinations for a student to be promoted to the next standard and the teacher was the sole judge to ascertain his suitability for promotion to the higher class.

The educational institutions also did not award certificates or degree and it was enough for a student to have been taught at a reputed school or by a well-known learned teacher. This made the admission to the reputed institutions a big burden and according to Dr. P.N. Chopra, it was with great difficulty that Mullah Shah Badakshi agreed to take Jahan Ara as his pupil.

11.3.5. Course Content and Libraries

It cannot be said with certainty as to whether the duration of the courses in all the educational institutions was fixed according to a standard pattern. It seems that the study for ten to sixteen years was considered enough for education of a person equivalent to the degree examination in our universities.

All those who wanted to adopt teaching profession or otherwise desired to pursue higher studies were placed under the specialists. These students also visited the other centres of learning both in the country and abroad as a part of their curriculum. There were big libraries for use of these students in every madrasa but certain libraries like that Madars Feiz Safa were highly reputed.

The biggest library was, however, the Imperial library containing the Emperor’s collection of books. The Mughal princesses Salima Sultana and Zib-un-Nisa had built their own libraries. The high nobles and other courtiers also attempted to work on the royal work on the royal example. Faizi had a collection of 4,600 books in his library.

Abdur Rahim Khan Khana employed ninety-five persons to take care of his collection of books and rare manuscripts. The library of Maharaja Jai Singh contained all books on astronomy used by the Hindu Scholars. Bernier saw a big hall at Banaras University, which was full of books on philosophy, medicine, religion and history etc.

The impact of Islam could be seen in the development of Libraries. Not only the Mughal Kings and princes but also the noble men build up libraries. Even though Babur was illiterate, he did not fail to educate Humayun, his lovable son. Humayun mastered Arabic, Persian and Turkish and loved reading. He had his famous library at Bibama fort, while climbing down the steps from there he slipped and fell down dead. That is why Lanepoole says 'Humayun tumbled throughout life and tumbled out of life'.

Among the all Mughal princes Dara Shukoh, the first and lovable son of Shah Jahan was a great scholar. He was a man of liberal outlook and possessed scholarly qualities. He was delighted to be in the company of other faiths. The Atherva Veda and Upanishads were translated in to Persion at his instance. For his board religious outlook, he was dislike by the narrow-minded orthodox Muslims. All the libraries built by the Mughal emperors, princes and noblemen were ruined during the sepoy mutiny. Some of the books are preserved in the libraries of Europe. The cultural influence of the six centuries of Muslim rule was necessarily wide-spread. Hunting, hawking and many games became Mohammadanised in the method and terminology. In other fields also Persion, Arabic and Turkish words have entered into Hindi, Bengali and Marathi languages.

11.3.6. Women's Education

Along with the education of men, the education of the women did not obtain proper priority during the Mughal period. Most of the women did not get an opportunity to read beyond the primary standard and it was only the few nobles and rich people who were able to engage private tutors for education of their daughters at home.

The institutions of education of females were, however, absent. According to Dr. Datta, regular training was given to the ladies of the royal household during the reign of Akbar. The ladies of the royal blood thus excelled themselves in education and statecraft.

Gulbadan Begam, Salim Sultana, Zeb-un-Nisa and Zinat-un-Nisa excelled themselves in the literary field where Nur Jahan and Jahanara played an important part in politics.

Check your Progress – 2

1. Assess the contribution of Mughals in the fields of literature and libraries.

11.4. Literature

Islam exerted a great influence on literature. Islam itself came under the influence of both Persian language and literature. India became Persianized. Two classes of Hindus particularly distinguished themselves. The Kashmir Pandits and Kayasthas. It was through the Persian languages; the moral thoughts were learnt by the educated Hindus. The mixture of Persian and Hindi languages brought into being a new language namely Urdu. Urdu literature is particularly rich its poetical literature. Wali of Aurangabad having been the first recognized power of note. But the southern Urdu or Rekhta had produced good poetry a century before Wali. The literary impulse given the peace and prosperity of Akbar's long and successful reign and the close of the 16th and the first half of the 17th centuries. To this period belongs the curious corrupt Sanskrit history of Bengal entitled 'Shaikhsuhoday'. This was written by Chandra Bhan Brahman and diplomat of Shah Jahan.

11.4.1. Persian

During this period Akbar brought Persian at the level of state language, which helped in the growth of its literature. Besides, all Mughal emperors, except Akbar, were well-educated and patronized learning. Babur was a scholar.

He wrote his biography, Tuzuki-i-Babri, in Turki language and it was so beautifully written that it was translated into Persian three times. He also wrote poems both in Turki and Persian and his collection of poems Diwan (Turki) became quite famous. Humayun had good command over both Turki and Persian. Besides, he had sufficient knowledge of philosophy, mathematics and astronomy.

He patronized scholars of all subjects. Akbar himself was not educated but he created those circumstances which helped in the growth of literature during the period of his rule. He

gave encouragement to Persian language and famous works of different languages like Sanskrit, Arabic, Turki, Greek, etc., were translated into it. He established a separate department for this purpose. Many scholars rose to eminence under his patronage. Jahangir was also well-educated.

He wrote his biography, Tuzuk-i-Jahangiri himself by for the first seventeen years of his rule and got prepared the rest of it Mautmid Khan. Not much was done concerning translation work but a few original works of repute were written during the period of his rule. Shah Jahan also gave projection to scholars.

His son Dara Shukoh was also well-educated and arranged for the translation of many Sanskrit texts in Persian. Aurangzeb was also a scholar though he hated writings of verses and books on history. During the period of the later Mughals, Persian remained the court-language till the rule of Muhammad Shah. Afterwards, it was replaced by Urdu. Yet, good works produced by many scholars in Persian even afterwards. Thus, Persian got the maximum incentive to grow during the rule of the Mughals and, therefore, made very good progress.

Largest numbers of good books written in Persian were either autobiographies or books on history. Among writings on history, Tuzuk-i-Babri written by emperor Babur, Humayuna Nama of Gulbadan Begum, Akbarnama and Ain-i-Akbari of Abdul Fazl, Tabkhat-i-Akbari of Nizamuddin Ahmad, Tazkirautal-waqiat of Jauhar, Tauja-i-Akbarshahi alias Tarikh-i-Sher Shah of Abbas Sarwani, Tarikh-i- Alfi which covers nearly one thousand years of history of the Islam and was written by the combined efforts of many scholars.

Muntkhba-ut-Twarikh of Badayuni, Tarikh-i-Salatin-Afghana of Ahmad Yadgar, Tarikh-i-Humayun of Bayaqzid Sultan and Akbarnama of Faizi Sarhindi were written during the period of the rule of Akbar except the first. Jahangir wrote his biography Tuzuk-i-Jahangiri.

Mautmid Khan completed it and also wrote Ikbalanama-i-Jahangiri. Massara Jahangir of Khawja Kamgar Makazzam- i-Afghani of Niamatullah, Tarikh-i-Farishta of Muhammad Kasim Farishta and Massare-i-Rahini of Mulla Nanvandi were also written during the period of Jahangir. Among the famous work written during the period of reign of Shah Jahan were Padshahnama of Aminai Qazvini, Shahjahanama of Inayat Khan and Alam-i-Saleh of Muhammad Saleh. Aurangzeb discouraged writings of history.

Yet a few good works were produced during his rule. Among them, the most famous ones were Muntkhab-ul- Lubab of Khafi Khan, Alamgimama of Mirza Muhammad Qazim, Nuike-Dilkusha of Muhammad Saki, Fatuhat-i-Alamgiri of Iswar Das and Khulasa-ut-Tawarikh of Sujan Rai.

Historical works were written under the patronage of the later Mughals as well as provincial ruler. Among them, the most reputed were Sidrul-Mutkharin of Gulam Hussain, Tawarikh-i-Muzaffari of Muhammad Aliand Tawarikh-Cahar- Gulzar-i-Suzai of Harcharan Das.

Besides original work, books in other languages were translated into Persian. Among the Sanskrit text, Mahabharat was translated by the joint efforts of Naki Khan, Badayni, Abdul Fazal, Faizi etc.

Badayuni translated Ramayana into Persian. He also started translating Atharvaveda while it was completed by Haji Ibrahim Sarhindi. Faizi translated Lilavati, Shah Muhammad Sahabadi translated Rajtarangini, Abul Fazl translated Kaliya Daman, Faizi translated Nal Damyanti and Maulana Sheri translated Hari-Vansha.

All these works were translated during the period of rule of Akbar. During the reign of Shah Jahan, his eldest son, Dara Shukoh provided incentive to this work and got translated Upanishads, Bhagvata Gita and Yogavasistha.

He himself wrote an original treatise titled Manjul- Bahreen in which he described that Islam and Hinduism were simply the two paths to achieve the same God. Many texts written in Arabic, Turki and Greek were also translated into Persian during the rule of the Mughal emperors. Bible was translated in it. Aurangzeb with the help of many Arabic texts got prepared a book of law and justice in Persian which was titled Fatwah-i-Alamgiri.

Poems in Persian were also written during this period though this type of work could not achieve the standard of prose-writing. Humayun wrote a few verses. Abul Fazl named fifty-nine poets at the court of Akbar. Among them Faizi, Gizali and Urfi were quite famous. Hahangir and Nur Jahan were also interested in poetry. Jahan Ara daughter of Shah Jahan and Jebunnisa, daughters of Aurangzeb were also poetesses.

The letters written by the emperors and nobles also occupy important place in the Persian literature of that time. Among them, letter written by Aurangzeb, Abul Fazl, Munir, Raja Jai Singh, Afzal Khan, Sadulla Khan, etc. have been regarded as good literary value.

11.4.2. Sanskrit

Original good works in Sanskrit could not be produced during the rule of the Mughals. Yet as compared to the age of the Delhi sultanate, Sanskrit literature made good progress during the period. Akbar gave recognition to scholars of Sanskrit. Abul Fazal has named many scholars of Sanskrit who received the patronage of the emperor. A dictionary of Persian Sanskrit titled Farsi- Prakash was prepared during his rule.

Besides many Hindu and Jaina scholars wrote their treatises outside the patronage of the court of the emperor. Mahesh Thakur wrote the history of the reign of Akbar; the Jain scholar Padma Sundar wrote Akbarshahi-Srangar-Darpan and the Jain Acharya Siddhachandra Upaddaya wrote Bhanuchandra Charita. Deva Vimal and many other also wrote their treatises in Sanskrit.

Jahangir and Shah Jahan maintained the tradition of Akbar and gave protection to scholars of Sanskrit. Kavindra Acharya Saraswati received patronage of Shah Jahan and Jagannath Pandit who wrote Rasa Gangadhar and Ganga Lahri was also at his court. Aurangzeb stopped court protection to scholars of Sanskrit. Of course, Sanskrit continued to receive patronage from Hindu rulers, yet, its progress was checked later on.

11.4.3. Regional Languages

During this period, regional languages were developed due to the patronage extended to them by local and regional rulers. They acquired stability and maturity and some of the finest lyrical poetry was produced during this period.

The dalliance of Krishna with Radha and the milkmaids, pranks of the child Krishna and stories from Bhagwat figure largely in lyrical poetry in Bengali, Oriya, Hindi, Rajasthani and Gujarati during this period. Many devotional hymns to Rama were also composed and the Ramayana and the Mahabharata translated into the regional languages, especially if they had not been translated earlier.

A few translations and adaptations from Persian were also made. Both Hindus and Muslims contributed in this. Thus, Alaol composed in Bengali and also translated from Persian. In Hindi, the *Padmavat*, the story written by the Sufi saint, Malik Muhammad Jaisi, used the attack of Alauddin Khilji on Chittor as an allegory to expound Sufi ideas on the relations of soul with God, along with Hindu ideas about maya.

Medieval Hindi in the Brij form, that is the dialect spoken in the neighbourhood of Agra, was also patronised by the Mughal emperors and Hindu rulers. From the time of Akbar, Hindi poets began to be attached to the Mughal court.

A leading Mughal noble, Abdur Rahim Khan-i-Khanan, produced a fine blend of Bhakti poetry with Persian ideas of life and human relations. Thus, the Persian and the Hindi literary traditions began to influence each other. But the most influential Hindi poet was Tulsidas whose hero was Rama and who used a dialect of Hindi spoken in the eastern parts of Uttar Pradesh. Pleading for a modified caste system based not on birth but on individual qualities, Tulsi was essentially a humanistic poet who upheld family ideals and complete devotion to Rama as a way of salvation open to all, irrespective of caste.

In south India, Malayalam started its literary career as a separate language in its own right. Marathi reached its apogee at the hands of Eknath and Tukaram. Asserting the importance of Marathi, Eknath exclaims: "If Sanskrit was made by God, was Prakrit born of thieves and knaves? Let these earrings of vanity alone. God is no partisan of tongues. To Him Prakrit and Sanskrit are alike. My language Marathi is worthy of expressing the highest sentiments and is rich, laden with the fruits of divine knowledge."

11.4.4. Growth of Vernacular Literature

From 1200 to 1550 what is popularly called the Pathan period was the Dark age of north Indian History and the Hindu intellect was barren during these three centuries and a half. But by the time Akbar had conquered his enemies and established a broad empire covering all northern India- peace and good administration began to produce natural fruits. With the feeling of security wealth grew and wealth brought leisure and a passion for the things of the mind. There was a sudden growth of Vernacular literature in all the provinces of India. In Bengal a

new impulse was given to creative instinct of the followers of Chaitanya (1485-1553) who wrote the first great works – as direct from folk songs in Modern Bengali. Such were the Saint's biographies, the Chaitanya Bhagarat (1573) the Chaitanya Chararumeta (1582) and the two Chaitanya mangals of Jayandha and Lochan Das (1575) and the biographical and mystical works of the monks and their devotees.

In the Hindi speaking world, the greatest master was Tulasidas who began his immortal and perennially inspiring Rama Charit Manas in 1574. He had been preceded by a Muslim poet, Malik Muhammad Jaisia. He wrote the Padumavat and Mingavat. There was a quite a crop of Hindi poems produced in this age such as Akbaravat Sapanavat, Kandarovat, Madhumalat, Usman's Chitravati, Sura-Sahitya-Lahiri and Purushottam Vaishya's (Dharmashwave) Dharmashwamedh. Kabir, Dadu and Nanak were the great Hindi poets. Many of the Persian poets of the Delhi court down to the middle of the 17th century were emigrants from Persia.

Check your Progress – 3

1. Explain the growth of Sanskrit and Persian literature during Mughal rule
2. Describe the development of regional languages and vernacular literature during Mughal period

11.5. Religious Conditions

Divergent views have been expressed by historians and scholars regarding the religious conditions.

On the one hand there are those who state there was a lot of religious harmony among the people of different faiths and on the other hand it is stated that seeds of the partition of the country were sown by emperors like Aurangzeb and others.

They point out that Hindu-Muslim discord is not the legacy of the British rule but some of the medieval narrow-minded rulers.

11.5.1. Division of society on the basis of religion

The majority of the Indian society consisted of the Hindus. Traditionally they were divided into four classes. Caste system had become very rigid. There were hundreds of sub-castes.

The Sudras were in the lowest cadre of society. The Muslims were divided into Sunnis, the Shias, the Bohras and the Khojas etc. The Sunnis were in majority and also belonged to the privileged class because the emperors were also Sunnis. The Shaikhs and Sayyids also commanded respect in the society.

The foreign Muslims like the Arabs, the Persians, the Turks, the Mongols, the Uzbeks, the Abyssinians and the Armenians regarded themselves socially superior to converted Indian Muslims. They occupied higher position in the society.

The Sufi saints and the Bhakt Saints laid stress on religious harmony, equality in society and devotion to God. Emperor Akbar founded a new religion of 'Din-i-Ilahi' but it could not attract many followers and collapsed with his death. A new faith of Sikhism among the Hindus emerged. Its followers were mostly confined to Punjab. In general, its followers and the Mughal rulers did not enjoy cordial relations.

11.5.2. Din-i-Ilahi

Din-i- Ilahi "the religion of God," was a system of religious beliefs introduced by the Mughal emperor Akbar in 1582 CE. His idea was to combine Islam and Hinduism into one faith, but also to add aspects of Christianity, Zoroastrianism and Jainism. Akbar clearly took a personal interest in religious matters. He founded an academy, the Ibadat Khana, "the House of Worship," in 1575, where representatives of all major faiths could meet to discuss theology. Listening to these debates, Akbar concluded that no single religion captured the whole truth and that they consequently had to be combined.

Din-i- Ilahi emphasized morality, piety and kindness. Just like Sufi Islam it regarded the yearning for God as a key feature of spirituality; just like Catholicism it took celibacy to be a virtue and just like Jainism it condemned the killing of animals. As for its ritual, it borrowed heavily from Zoroastrianism, making fire and the sun objects of divine worship. The new religion had no scriptures and no priests and it never had more than a handful of adherents — mainly the members of Akbar's closest circle of advisors. The most prominent person among them was Abul-Fazl ibn Mubarak, the emperor's vizier, or prime minister. Abul Fazl was the author of the **Akbarnama**, "the Book of Akbar," a history of Akbar's reign written in three volumes, which provide a rich description of India at the height of the Mughal's power.

Din-i-Ilahi is best viewed as a state religion with the emperor himself at its centre. As the single authority on all religious matters, Akbar was not only going to interpret and apply the religious law, but to actually make it. According to rumours, the Muslim call to prayer, “Allahu akbar,” meaning “God is great” was interpreted by him as “God is Akbar.” In the end, the new faith had more to do with politics than with religion. Din-i-Ilahi was his solution to the thorny problem of how a Muslim ruler could govern a predominantly Hindu state. Yet the Din-i-Ilahi was fiercely opposed by many Muslims clerics who declared it as a heretical doctrine. Although the new religion did not survive its founder, it triggered a strong fundamentalist reaction among India’s Muslims.

Islam cannot allow any compromise in Polytheism and Islam is Monotheistic religion. The Muslims even today turn their faces towards mecca while they worship. They even went to the extent of worshipping Akbar, and individual character. The Muslim state in India retained its original military nomadic character. Akbar converted the Police State into welfare state. All Mohammedans have the same sacred language, literature, teacher, saints and shrines throughout the world.

11.5.3. Festivals, fairs and pilgrimages

Important festivals of the Hindus were Basant, Diwali, Dussehra, Holi, Sankranti and Shivaratri. Sankranti and Purnimah were to be considered very auspicious days and a dip in some river on that day were considered to be a pious act. People went to places of pilgrimages such as Kashi, Kurukshetra, Prayag, Puri and Pushkar.

Millions of Hindus attended the Kumbh fair. The Hindus believed in the purity and sacredness of the water of the Ganges and that a dip in the Ganges would purify them of all their sins. The pilgrimage to Mecca was an annual event of great importance for the Muslims. The important festivals of the Muslims were Id-ul-Juha, Id- ul-Fitr, Shab-i-Barat, Muharram and Milad-ud-Nabi.

Check your progress-4

1. Focus on the religious conditions during Mughal period with special reference to Din-i-Ilahi.
2. Briefly write about the Festivals, fairs and pilgrimages during the rule of Mughals

11.6. The Gifts of Mughal rule in India

- a) During the Mughal rule, the Subahs or Provinces were under one uniform administration. Persian language became the common language of official languages.
- b) Imperial oneness was felt under the Mughal rule. The land revenue system of the Mughal was followed by the Britishers. The postal system, the practice of laying roads, erecting irrigational canals, covering the whole land by constructing inns (SARAI, rest houses) etc. Were the contributions of the Mughals. Elaborate court festivals were observed by the Muslims.
- c) They also established the Rule of Law everywhere which was in many more humane than the Rule of Law which prevailed in contemporary Europe. The Muslims imposed death punishment for certain crimes. The Muslims observed elaborate court festivals and etiquette (code of conduct) in the court. This practice continued even after the Mughal rule in India, the durbars during the coronation times were surcharged with the recitation of the poets with Poems, were the legacy of the Muslim rule.
- d) She Shah Sur was the forerunner of Akbar in the field of administration and laid the foundation for the present rupee system. He was also known as the father of High way Roads. There was uniformity of administration and cultured life under the Mughals. The 200 years of Mughal rule gave to the whole of Northern India and most parts of the Deccan also oneness of official languages, administrative system and coinage and also popular lingua-franca for all classes except the Hindu Priest and the Stationary Village folk. The administrative system of the Mughals, official titles, court etiquette and monetary type were borrowed more or less by the neighbouring High Rajas.
- e) The impact of Mughals can also be seen in the field of Fine Arts

11.6.1. Warfare

The art of war was very high developed by the Muslims, partly by borrowing from Europe through Turkey and to a lesser extent through Persia, the imperial Mughal army served as a model which Hindu Rajas early imitated. The Muslims left very good legacy in the system of fortification and artillery. In the art of war, we find the impact of Islam. Babur in his memoirs laid emphasis on forts and the system of fortifications. The gun powder was introduced and cavalry rose to great prominence under the Mughal eclipsing the elephants of the old Hindu days. This animal now ceased to be an arm and continued as a mere transport agency.

11.6.2. Natural beauty

Islam exerted a great impact on the minds of the Hindus in encouraging a great feeling for natural beauty. For example, Akbar is said to have visited Kashmir in order to enjoy the earthly paradise. But he used to take new route to Kashmir every time. His son Jahangir was also a lover of beauty. His wife Nurjahan excelled him not only in enjoying the beauty but also admiring it. The Shalimar gardens which were known for its natural beauty is attributed to her. There were also gardens like Nasin and Nezart which were admired by Nurjahan. One is impressed by the beauty of colour and Majesty in the Mughal gardens. A thing of beauty is a joy for ever is proved by the Mughals. The beauty encouraged poets to write poems in Hindu and Urdu. Birbal and Ikbal were great poets.

11.6.3. Other Legacies

The Muslim influence was naturally most strongly felt on the system of administration, the court ceremonies and dress, the military organization and arm, the lives of the upper classes, the articles of luxury, fine arts, architecture and gardening.

The Muslims were leading generally a more luxurious life than the Hindus and being a predominantly city population encouraged several manufactures and fine arts. They were more tasteful and elegant than the Hindus in their daily life and even in their food habits –which the richer Hindus and particularly the official class copied wherever they had the means. By the agency of the Mohammedans, new articles of food and new styles of cookery were introduced.

11.6.4. Diffusing knowledge

Paper was introduced by the Mohammedans as the Arabic word Kaghaz proves. Thus, books could be multiplied in a more attractive and durable form than by scratching on Palm leaves. The illumination of manuscripts is an art which we owe for the Mughal empire, and from AKBAR'S time onwards Hindi and Sanskrit works were finely copied and illustrated for the sake of the Hindu Rajahs. We owe to the Mohammedan influence the practice of diffusing knowledge by the copying and circulation of books, while the earlier Hindu writers, as a general rule loved to make a secret of their productions.

11.6.5. The Sufi brotherhood

The Sufis represent the liberal element in Islam. They were responsible for the growth and spread of Islam in India. These Sufis or Muslim mystics were men of deep religious feeling, leading ascetic lives and more concerned with mysteries contained in the Quran than with the observance of the ceremonials. They emphasized qualities of effluence, love, mercy, and generosity and immense of God, his form and attributes.

The Sufi movement afforded a common platform to the more learned and devout minds among the Hindus and Muhammadans system could not be followed by the illiterate people. Thus, faith is reserved for the philosophers, authors and mystics free from bigotry. Sufism spread and developed rapidly in India from the time of Akbar's mantle as an ascetic and peace maker in religion fell on his great grandson Dara Shukoh. Dara Shukoh prepared a Persian translation of Upanishads and Atharva Veda.

Another gift of the Muslims to India is historical literature. The chronological sense was very imperfectly developed among the Hindus. Before the Islamic conquest they produced no true history at all. All of their records did not contain a chronological frame work. On the other hand, the historical literatures of the Mohammedans in all countries have been vast and carried and well furnished with dates. We therein get a solid basis for historical study. The Persian chronicles which were written under every Muslim Dynasty in India and in every reign under the Mughals, not only served as materials of study in themselves but furnished an example which Hindu writers and Hindu rulers were not slow to imitate. Thus a few and very useful element was introduced into Indian literature and in the 17th and 18th centuries it formed a magnificent body – if we take all the histories biographies and letters into account.

Check your progress - 5

1. What do you know about the impact of Islam and the Mughals on Indian culture.

11.7. Let us sum up

In this lesson we have learnt about the advent of Islam to India and its contribution. You have studied about the impact of Islam on Indian Society and culture. Like all societies including the present one, there were several inequalities. The majority of the people lived very poorly.

The workmen received low wages. The lofty buildings of the Mughals concealed the hardship of the workmen. They were also forced to work for higher classes without any remuneration. They lived on poor food and took one meal a day sometimes consisting of Khichri made of green pulse mixed with coarse rice. In the period of the Mughals, the people of upper classes were the only beneficiaries while the common people toiled and mostly remained on mere existence level.

Check your progress - 6

s1. Elaborate on what you have studied in the lesson.

11.8. Answers to check your Progress

Check your progress-1

1. See Sections 11.2.1. – 11.2.4.
2. See Section 11.2.5.

Check your progress-2

1. See Sections 11.3. – 11.3.6.

Check your progress-3

1. See Sections 11.4. -11.4.2.
2. See Sections 11.4.3. – 11.4.4.

Check your progress-4

1. See Sections 11.5. – 11.5.2.
2. See Sections 11.5.3.

Check your progress - 5

1. See Sections – 11.6. – 11.6. 5.

Check your progress - 6

1. See All Sections

LESSON – 12

ART AND ARCHITECTURE UNDER THE MUGHALS

Learning Objectives

After learning this lesson, you will be able to

- Grasp the nuances of the Mughal architecture
- Understand the characteristics of Mughal painting
- Admire the mellifluous nature of Mughal Music and exquisite dance
- Appreciate the beauty of Mughal gardens

Structure

12.1 Introduction

12.2 Architecture

12.2.1. Babur

12.2.2. Humayun

12.2.3. Akbar

12.2.4. Jahangir

12.2.5. Shahjahan

12.2.6. Aurangzeb

12.2.7. Successors of Aurangzeb

12.3 Painting

12.3.1. School of Old Tradition

12.3.2. Mughal Painting (School from Persian Influence)

12.3.3. European Painting

12.3.4. Rajasthan School of Painting

12.3.5. Pahari School of Painting

12.4 Music and Dance

12.4.1. Music

12.4.2. Musical Instruments During Mughal Era

12.4.3. Mian Tansen

12.4.4. Dance During Mughal Era

12.4.5. Influence of Mughals on Indian Music & Dance

12.5 Mughal Gardens

12.6 Answers to Check your Progress

12.1 Introduction

Mughal period was the period of glory in the field of architecture. Mughal art and architecture, has a characteristic Indo-Islamic-Persian style that flourished on the Indian subcontinent during the Mughal Empire (1526–1857). This new style combined elements of Islamic art and architecture, which had been introduced to India during the Delhi Sultanate (1192–1398) and had produced great monuments such as the Qutb Minar, with features of Persian art and architecture. Mughal monuments are found chiefly in North India, but there are also many remains in Pakistan. This lesson discusses these distinctive forms of art and architecture as they developed under a succession of Mughal emperors.

In the domain of fine arts, the richest contributions were made by Mughals. They built mosques, forts palaces and tombs. The inland work in lit-Mud Danhalis (father in –law of Jahangir) tomb is outstanding and remarkable in many ways. The Indo-Saracens style of painting and artificial gardening came to be developed. The paintings of animals and human beings were forbidden. At the same time painting was allowed to beauty the domes, mosques and palaces. The artistic genius of both Muslim and native artists received the fullest support from the rulers. Mausoleums (tomb) and mosques became an inspiration to every artist. The Muslim ruler naturally patronized artistic designs they depended very much.

The Indo-Saracenic art was developed in the courts of the Mughal Emperors. Babur took keen interest in art. He is said to have brought to India the finest specimens of paintings from his father's territory. Though some of them were taken by Nadir Shah, they exerted greater

influence on painting. Babur's unfortunate son Humayun accomplished nothing in this field. Akbar, the great, reached the zenith in this field. Akbar was a great patron of art workshops of art and crafts, attached to the royal household and each was like city.

Jahangir carried on his father's love of painting. Shah Jahan also gave encouragement to painting. But this act had declined during the Puritanical reign of Aurangzeb. He dismissed the royal astronomers and astrologers from the court. He asked the dancing girls either to leave the country or to get married immediately.

12.2. Architecture

Mughal architecture is the distinctive Indo-Islamic architectural style that developed in northern and central India under the patronage of Mughal emperors from the 16th to the 18th century. It is a remarkably symmetrical and decorative amalgam of Persian, Turkish, and Indian architecture. The Mughals were also renowned for creating exquisite gardens in the Persian **charbagh** layout, in which the quadrilateral gardens were divided by walkways or flowing water into four smaller parts.

The imperial Mughals were great patrons of art and architecture. They took keen interest in the planning of forts, places, mosques, tombs and even the new townships.

They had their own ideas about the construction of buildings by the free amalgamation of what was called the Mughal architecture which was in fact, the national Indian architecture of that age. In architecture, the Mughal period was not entirely an age of innovation and renaissance, but a continuation and culmination of processes that had their beginning in the later Turko-Afghan Period.

Hindu influence on architectural style lasted throughout the Mughal period and expressed itself in the narrow columns; Pilasters, corbel and other expressed itself in the narrow columns, pilasters, corbel and other ornamental features of Mughal buildings.

The salient features of the Mughal architecture, writes Sarkar' are the pronounced dome, slender turrets and the corners, the bells supported on pillars and the Indo-Savannic gate which takes the form of a huge semi-dome sunk in the front wall and bearing an admirable

proportion to the building while the actual entrance is a small rectangular opening under the arch’.

The history of Mughal architecture can be divided into three phases. The early phase includes Akbar and partially Jahangir, the middle phase which began with Jahangir and covers the periods of Shahjehan and early part of Aurangzeb, and the later phase which began with Aurangzeb and covers later Mughal rulers.

12.2.1. Babur

The history Mughal architecture begins with Babur, who is said to have undertaken many building projects at Agra, Dholpur, Gwalior and other places. The Mughal dynasty was established after the victory of Babur at Panipat in 1526. During his five-year reign, Babur took considerable interest in erecting buildings, though few have survived.

12.2.2. Humayun

His son Humāyūn ascended the throne in 1530. The adverse political circumstances did not afford much opportunity to Humayun to undertake any significant architectural activity. In 1533 he founded a new city, at Delhi called the Din Panah (world Refugee) on the bank of the Yamuna River but no remains are available of this first Mughal city. Shēr Shah, who overthrew Humāyūn in 1540, razed Din Panah to the ground and built his new capital, the Sher Shahi, now known as Purana Qila fort, in south eastern Delhi.

A new impetus to architecture was given by Sher Shah. His famous mausoleum at Sasaram (Bihar) and his mosque in the old fort at Delhi are considered architectural marvels. They form the climax of the pre-Mughal style of architecture, and the starting point for the new.

12.2.3. Akbar

Early Mughal architecture first developed during the reign of Akbar the Great (1556–1605), who commissioned palaces, mosques, gardens, and mausoleums. The architecture was a synthesis of Persian, Turkic, Timurid Iranian, Central Asian, and Indian Hindu and Muslim styles. Akbari architecture is also remarkable for its large-scale use of sandstone, evident both

in the construction of Fatehpur Sikri, Akbar's royal city, and Akbar's own tomb in Sikandra. The mosque at Fatehpur Sikri boasts the Buland Darwaza, the largest gateway of its kind in India. Early Mughal mosques had massive enclosed courtyards and domed shallow prayer halls.

Akbar was the first Mughal ruler who had the time and means to undertake construction on a large scale. He built a series of forts, the most famous of which is the fort at Agra. Built in red sandstone, this massive fort had many magnificent gates. The climax of fort building was reached at Delhi where Shah Jahan built his famous Red Fort.

In 1572, Akbar commenced a palace-cum-fort complex at Fatehpur Sikri, 36 kilometres from Agra, which he completed in eight years. Built atop a hill, along with a large artificial lake, it included many buildings in the style of Gujarat and Bengal. These included deep caves, balconies, and fanciful kiosks.

In the Panch Mahal built for taking the air, all the types of pillars used in various temples were employed to support flat roofs. The Gujarat style of architecture is used most widely in the palace built probably for his Rajput wife or wives. Buildings of a similar type were also built in the fort at Agra, though only a few of them have survived. Akbar took a close personal interest in the work of construction both at Agra and Fatehpur Sikri.

Persian or Central Asian influence can be seen in the glazed blue tiles used for decoration in the walls or for tiling the roofs. But the most magnificent building was the mosque and the gateway to it called the Buland Darwaza or the Lofty Gate, built to commemorate Akbar's victory in Gujarat. The gate is in the style of what is called a half-dome portal.

What was done was to slice a dome into half. The sliced portion provided the massive outward façade of the gate, while smaller doors could be floor meet. This device, borrowed from Iran, became feature in Mughal buildings later.

Tomb of Humayun

One of the most stellar accomplishments of Mughal architecture under Akbar is the tomb of his father Humayun, situated in Delhi. Commissioned in 1562 by Humayun's wife, Hamida Banu Begum, and designed by a Persian architect, Humayun's Tomb was the first garden tomb

on the Indian subcontinent and the first structure to use red sandstone on such a large scale. It is also the first Indian building to use the Persian double dome, with an outer layer supporting a white marble exterior—a material not seen in earlier Mughal architecture—and the inner layer giving shape to the cavernous interior volume. The use of indigenous Rajasthani decorative elements is particularly striking, including the small canopies or **chhatris** (elevated, dome shaped pavilions) surrounding the central dome. It boasts the use of the **pietra dura** technique, with marble and even stone inlay ornamentation in geometrical and arabesque patterns on the facade of the mausoleum, and **jali** or latticed stone carving decoration. This style of decorative facade was an important addition to Mughal architecture and flourished in later Mughal mausolea, including the Taj Mahal. The tomb, which was built in the 1560s, was designed by a Persian architect Mirak Mirza Ghiyas. Set in a garden at Delhi, it has an intricate ground plan with central octagonal chambers, joined by an archway with an elegant facade and surmounted by cupolas, kiosks, and pinnacles.

Agra Fort

At the same time Akbar was building his fortress-palace in his capital, Agra. Native red sandstone was inlaid with white marble, and all the surfaces were ornately carved on the outside and sumptuously painted inside. It was the main residence of the emperors of the Mughal Dynasty until 1638, when the capital was shifted from Agra to Delhi. The Agra fort is a UNESCO World Heritage site. It is situated about 2.5 km northwest of Taj Mahal. The fort can be more accurately described as a walled city. After the First Battle of Panipat in 1526, Babur stayed in the fort, in the palace of Ibrahim Lodi. He later built a baoli (step well) in it. His successor, Humayun, was crowned in the fort in 1530. He was defeated at Bilgram in 1540 by Sher Shah Suri. The fort remained with the Suris till 1555, when Humayun recaptured it. Adil Shah Suri's general, Hemu, recaptured Agra in 1556 and pursued its fleeing governor to Delhi where he met the Mughals in the Battle of Tughlaqabad. Realising the importance of its central situation, Akbar made it his capital and arrived in Agra in 1558. His historian, Abul Fazl, recorded that this was a brick fort known as 'Badalgarh'. It was in a ruined condition and Akbar had it rebuilt with red sandstone from Barauli area Dhaulpur district, in Rajasthan. Architects laid the foundation and it was built with bricks in the inner core with sandstone on external surfaces. Some 4,000 builders worked on it daily for eight years, completing it in 1573.

Fatehpur Sikri

Akbar went on to build the entire city of Fatehpur Sikri (City of Victory) in which extensive use was made of the low arches and bulbous domes that characterize the Mughal style. The site of Sikri reflected Akbar's gratitude to a Muslim saint at Sikri for the birth of his son. Courtiers soon followed suit and built homes surrounding the palace and mosque. The new city became the capital of the empire, but in 1585 it was abandoned.

Speaking in general, the buildings of Akbar's reign combine both Hindu and Muslim features, and therefore, are correctly described as being of Hindu-Muslim style. Fatehpur Sikri which he built around the hermitage of the pious Shaikh Salim Chishti and which was the seat of the imperial court from 1569-84 constitutes perhaps the most remarkable evidence of Akbar's genius.

Perhaps the greatest feature of this city is the Buland Darwaza- the great portal built of marble and sandstone which forms the second gateway of the mosque. An authority described it 'as one of the most perfect architectural achievements in the whole of India.'

Though long abandoned and bearing the scars of time, Fatehpur Sikri forms the most impressive revelation of a mighty personality. Revelation of a mightily personality, in the words of Fergusson: 'It is simply a reflex of the mind of a great man who built it'. The construction of the walled city was started in 1569 and completed in 1574. It contained some of the most beautiful buildings – both religious and secular which testify to the Emperor's aim of achieving social, political and religious integration. The main religious buildings were the huge Jama Masjid and small tomb of Salim Chisti. The tomb, built in 1571 in the corner of the mosque compound, is a square marble chamber with a veranda. The cenotaph has an exquisitely designed lattice screen around it. Buland Darwaza, also known as the Gate of Magnificence, was built by Akbar in 1576 to commemorate his victory over Gujarat and the Deccan. It is 40 metres high and 50 metres from the ground. The total height of the structure is about 54 metres from ground level. Buland Darwaza dominates the landscape. According to Historian 'Abd al-Qadir Bada'uni it was the highest gateway in Hindustan.

The Haramsara, the royal seraglio in Fatehpur Sikri was an area where the royal women lived. The opening to the Haramsara is from the Khwabgah side separated by a row of cloisters.

According to Abul Fazl, in *Ain-i-Akbari*, the inside of Harem was guarded by senior and active women, outside the enclosure the eunuchs were placed, and at a proper distance there were faithful Rajput guards.

Jodha Bai's Palace

This is the largest palace in the Fatehpur Sikri seraglio, connected to the minor haramsara (where the less important harem ladies and maids would have resided) quarters. The main entrance is double storied, projecting out of the facade to create a kind of porch leading into a recessed entrance with a balcony. Inside there is a quadrangle surrounded by rooms. The columns of rooms are ornamented with a variety of Hindu sculptural motifs. The glazed tiles on the roofs from Multan have an eye catching shade of turquoise. The mosque was built in honour of Jodha Bai, mother of Jahangir and wife of Akbar. Her Mughal name was Mariyam Zamani Begum and this being the reason that the mosque was built in her honor in Lahore's walled city. Jahangir built his mother Mariyam Zamani Begum's mosque and is just 1 km away from the tomb of Akbar near Agra at a place called Sikandra.

Akbar built many more edifices besides the master pieces of architecture mentioned above, as for example, the Sikandra, the Akbari Mahal, and the Allahabad Fort. 'Everywhere', writes Abul Fazl'. Sarais have been built which are the comforts of travellers and the asylum of poor strangers.

The new style of architecture (representing the combination of the best features of the indigenous and foreign styles) which may be called by the name of Mughal architecture had produced a profound effect on buildings all over the country, including those of the Rajput rulers of Rajasthan.

The places built during the reign of Akbar at Amber, Jhodhpur, Droha and Dafia indicate unsuitable Mughal influence.

12.2.4. Jahangir

With the consolidation of the empire, the Mughal architecture reached its climax. Towards the end of Jahangir's reign began the practice of putting up building entirely of marble and

decorating the walls with floral designs made of semi-precious stones. This method of decoration, called *pietra-dura*, became even more popular under Shah Jahan who used it on a large scale in the Taj Mahal, justly regarded as a jewel of the builder art.

The number of edifices erected during the Jahangir's reign appears to be poor in comparison to the architectural record of his father. Built of white marble, the Itmad-ud-Daula mausoleum at Agra is decorated with *pietra-dura* work which emulates, if not surpasses, the style of decoration in Shahjahan's reign. Towards the end of Jahangir's reign began the practice of putting up buildings entirely of marble and decorating the walls with floral designs made of semiprecious stones. This method of decoration, called *pietra dura*, became even more popular under Shahjahan who used it on a large scale in the Taj Mahal, justly regarded as a Jewel of the builder's art.

12.2.5. Shahjahan

The style of Shahjahan's principal edifices though based on session heritage is at the same time clearly distinguishable from Persian works by the lavish use of white marble and incomparable decoration. Another salient feature of his structures is the openwork tracery which ornaments the finest buildings, and the 'apt combination of spacious designs with an almost feminine elegance'.

Wazir Khan Mosque

The Wazir Khan Mosque in Lahore was commissioned during the reign of Shah Jahan, and is famous for its rich embellishment which covers almost every interior surface. Rather than building huge monuments like his predecessors to demonstrate their power, Shah Jahan built elegant monuments. The force and originality of this previous building style gave way under Shah Jahan to a delicate elegance and refinement of detail, illustrated in the palaces erected during his reign at Agra, Delhi and Lahore. Some examples include the Taj Mahal at Agra, the tomb of his wife Mumtaz Mahal. The Moti Masjid (Pearl Mosque) in the Lahore Fort and the Jama Masjid at Delhi are imposing buildings of his era, and their position and architecture have been carefully considered so as to produce a pleasing effect and feeling of spacious elegance and well-balanced proportion of parts. Shah Jahan also built sections of the Sheesh

Mahal, and Naulakha pavilion, which are all enclosed in the fort. He also built a mosque named after himself in Thatta called Shahjahan Mosque. Shah Jahan also built the Red Fort in his new capital at Shah Jahanabad, now Delhi. The red sandstone Red Fort is noted for its special buildings-Diwan-i-Aam and Diwan-i-Khas. Another mosque was built during his tenure in Lahore called Wazir Khan Mosque, by Shaikh IIm-ud-din Ansari who was the court physician to the emperor.

Taj Mahal

The Taj Mahal, the pinnacle of Mughal architecture, is certainly one of the unrivalled beauties of the world. This World Heritage Site is described as the “teardrop on the cheek of time” by Rabindranath Tagore. It was built between 1630 and 1649 by the emperor Shah Jahan (1628-1658), grandson of Akbar the great, in the memory of his queen Arjumand Bano Begum, entitled ‘Mumtaz Mahal’. Mumtaz Mahal was a niece of empress Nur Jahan and granddaughter of Mirza Ghias Beg I’timad-ud-Daula, wazir of emperor Jehangir. She was born in 1593 and died in 1631, during the birth of her fourteenth child at Burhanpur. Her mortal remains were temporarily buried in the Zainabad garden. Six months later, her body was transferred to Agra to be finally enshrined in the crypt of the main tomb of the Taj Mahal. The Taj Mahal is the mausoleum of both Mumtaz Mahal and Shah Jahan.

in memory of his wife Mumtaz Mahal.(Mumtaz died after her 14th delivery). It took 17 years for the monument complex to be completed in 1648. The Taj Mahal complex is believed to have been completed in its entirety in 1653. Its construction took 22 years and required 22,000 laborers and 1,000 elephants. Built entirely of white marble at a cost of 32 million rupees, it is one of the New7Wonders of the World. The building’s longest plane of symmetry runs through the entire complex except for the sarcophagus of Shah Jahan, which is placed off centre in the crypt room below the main floor. This symmetry is extended to the building of an entire mirror mosque in red sandstone, to complement the Mecca-facing mosque placed to the west of the main structure. Shah Jahan used “pietra dura”, a method of decoration on a large scale-inlaid work of jewels.

The mausoleum is located on the right bank of the river Yamuna at a point where it takes a sharp turn and flows eastwards. Originally, the land where the Taj Mahal presently stands

belonged to the Kachhwahas of Ajmer (Rajasthan). The land was acquired from them in lieu of four havelis as is testified by a court historian, Abdul Hamid Lahauri, in his work titled the *Badshah-Namah* and the firmans (royal decrees). For construction, a network of wells was laid along the river line to support the huge mausoleum buildings. Masons, stonecutters, inlayers, carvers, painters, calligraphers, dome-builders and other artisans were requisitioned from the whole of the empire and also from Central Asia and Iran. While bricks for internal constructions were locally prepared, white marble for external use in veneering work was obtained from Makrana in Rajasthan. Semi-precious stones for inlay ornamentation were brought from distant regions of India, Ceylon and Afghanistan. Red sandstone of different tints was requisitioned from the neighbouring quarries of Sikri, Dholpur, etc. In all, the Taj Mahal covers an area of 60 bighas, as the terrain gradually sloped from south to north, towards the river, in the form of descending terraces. At the southern point is the forecourt with the main gate in front and tombs of Akbarabadi Begum and Fatehpuri Begum, two other queens of Shah Jahan, on its south-east and south-west corners respectively called Saheli Burj 1 and 2. On the second terrace is a spacious square garden, with side pavilions. It is divided into four quarters by broad shallow canals of water, with wide walkways and cypress avenues on the sides. The water channels and fountains are fed by overhead water tanks. These four quarters are further divided into the smaller quarters by broad causeways, so that the whole scheme is in a perfect char-bagh.

The main tomb of the Taj is basically square with chamfered corners. The minarets here are detached, facing the chamfered angles (corners) of the main tomb on the main plinth. Red sandstone mosque on the western and Mehman-Khana on the eastern side of the tomb provides aesthetically a clear colour contrast. The Taj has some wonderful specimens of polychrome inlay art both in the interior and exterior on the dados, on cenotaphs and on the marble jhajjhari (jali-screen) around them.

The Taj Mahal brought together in a pleasing manner all the architectural forms developed by the Mughals. Humayun's tomb built at Delhi towards the beginning of Akbar's reign, and which had a massive dome of marbles, may be considered a precursor of the Taj. The double dome was another feature of this building.

This devise enabled a bigger dome to be built with a smaller one inside. The chief glory of the Taj is the massive dome and the four slender minarets linking the platform to the main building. The decorations are kept to a minimum, delicate marble screens, pietra dura inlay work and kiosks (chhatris) adding to the effect. The building gains by being placed in the midst of a formal garden.

Mosque-building also reached its climax under Shah Jahan, the two most noteworthy ones being the Moti Masjid in the Agra fort built like the Taj entirely in marble, and the other the Jama Masjid in the Agra fort built like the Taj entirely in marble, and the other the Jama Masjid at Delhi built in red sandstone. A lofty gate, tall, slender minarets, and a series of domes are a feature of the Jama Masjid.

Wazir Khan Masjid

The Wazir Khan Masjid was commissioned during the reign of the Mughal Emperor Shah Jahan in 1634, and completed in 1642. Considered to be the most ornately decorated Mughal-era mosque, Wazir Khan Masjid is renowned for its intricate faience tile work known as kashi-kari, as well as its interior surfaces that are almost entirely embellished with elaborate Mughal-era frescoes. The mosque has been under extensive restoration since 2009 under the direction of the Aga Khan Trust for Culture and the Government of Punjab.

Shah Jahan Mosque

The Shah Jahan Mosque is the central mosque for the city of Thatta, in the Pakistani province of Sindh. The mosque commissioned by Shah Jahan, who bestowed it to the city as a token of gratitude. Its style is heavily influenced by Central Asian Timurid architecture, which was introduced after Shah Jahan's campaigns near Balkh and Samarkand. The mosque is considered to have the most elaborate display of tile work in South Asia, and is also notable for its geometric brick work - a decorative element that is unusual for Mughal-period mosques.

Red Fort

Another important monument built by Shah Jahan in 1639 as the palace of his fortified capital Shahjahanabad is the Red Fort. The Diwan-e-khas in it with its original ceilings of silver

and its decorative scheme of marble gold and precious stones fully justified the Persian inscription which it bears: 'If one the earth be an Eden of Bliss, It is this, it is this, none but this'.

It was the main residence of the emperors of the Mughal dynasty for nearly 200 years, until 1856. It is located in the centre of Delhi and houses a number of museums. In addition to accommodating the emperors and their households, it was the ceremonial and political centre of the Mughal state and the setting for events critically impacting the region.

Red Fort is named for its massive enclosing walls of red sandstone and is adjacent to the older Salimgarh Fort, built by Islam Shah Suri in 1546 AD. The imperial apartments consist of a row of pavilions, connected by a water channel known as the Stream of Paradise (Nahr-i-Bihisht). The fort complex is considered to represent the zenith of Mughal creativity under Shah Jahan, and although the palace was planned according to Islamic prototypes, each pavilion contains architectural elements typical of Mughal buildings that reflect a fusion of Timurid and Persian traditions. The Red Fort's innovative architectural style, including its garden design, influenced later buildings and gardens in Delhi, Rajasthan, Punjab, Kashmir, Braj, Rohilkhand and elsewhere.

It showcases a high level of ornamentation, and the Kohinoor diamond was reportedly part of the furnishings. The fort's artwork synthesises Persian, European and Indian art, resulting in a unique Shahjahani style rich in form, expression and colour. Red Fort is one of the building complexes of India encapsulating a long period of history and its arts. Even before its 1913 commemoration as a monument of national importance, efforts were made to preserve it for posterity. The fort was plundered of its artwork and jewels during Nadir Shah's invasion of the Mughal Empire in 1747. Most of the fort's precious marble structures were subsequently destroyed by the British following the Revolt of 1857. The forts' defensive walls were largely spared, and the fortress was subsequently used as a garrison. The Red Fort was also the site where the British put the last Mughal Emperor on trial before exiling him to Yangon in 1858. Every year on the Independence Day of India (15 August), the Prime Minister hoists the Indian "tricolour flag" at the main gate of the fort and delivers a nationally broadcast speech from its ramparts. It was designated a UNESCO World Heritage Site in 2007 as part of the Red Fort Complex. Its English name Red Fort is a translation of the Hindustani *Lāl Qila*, deriving from its red-sandstone

walls. As the residence of the imperial family, the fort was originally known as the “Blessed Fort” (Qila-i-Mubārak). Agra Fort is also called Lāl Qila.

Moti Masjid

Perhaps the most perfect architectural legacy of Shahjahan’s reign is the Moti Masjid or Pearl Mosque in Agra Fort in which the style of purity and elegance introduced by the great Mughals reached its zenith. Moti Masjid earned the epithet Pearl Mosque for it shone like a pearl. It is held that this mosque was constructed by Shah Jahan for his members of royal court. It stands on ground that slopes from east to west to the north of Diwan-i-Aam complex in Agra Fort. The courtyard of the Moti Masjid has side arcades and arched recessions and the main sanctuary facade beyond. The sanctuary is roofed with three bulbous domes built of light white marble and stand on the red sandstone walls. There are a series of Hindu-style domed kiosks along the parapet. There are seven bays that are divided into aisles which are supported by piers and lobed arches. The Moti Masjid boasts of extensive white marble facing, a typical stylistic feature of architecture during the reign of Shah Jahan. This masjid was constructed at a cost of 2 lakh and 60 thousand rupees and took four years to build.

12.2.6. Aurangzeb

Although not many buildings were put up by Aurangzeb who was economic-minded, the Mughal architectural traditions based on a combination of Hindu and Turk-Iranian forms and decorative designs, continued without a break into the eighteenth and early nineteenth centuries.

In Aurangzeb’s reign (1658–1707) squared stone and marble was replaced by brick or rubble with stucco ornament. Srirangapatna and Lucknow have examples of later Indo-Mughal architecture. He made additions to the Lahore Fort and also built one of the thirteen gates, which was later named after him (Alamgir). The Badshahi Masjid in Lahore, Pakistan was commissioned by the sixth Mughal Emperor Aurangzeb. Constructed between 1671 and 1673, it was the largest mosque in the world upon construction. It is the third largest mosque in Pakistan and the seventh largest mosque in the world. The mosque is adjacent to the Lahore Fort and is the last in the series of congregational mosques in red sandstone. The red sandstone of the walls contrasts with the white marble of the domes and the subtle intarsia decoration.

Aurangzeb's mosque's architectural plan is similar to that of his father, Shah Jahan, the Jama Masjid in Delhi; though it is much larger. It also functions as an idgah. The courtyard which spreads over 276,000 square feet can accommodate one hundred thousand worshippers; ten thousand can be accommodated inside the mosque. The minarets are 196 feet (60 m) tall. The Mosque is one of the most famous Mughal structures, but suffered greatly under the reign of Maharaja Ranjit Singh. In 1993, the Government of Pakistan included the Badshahi Mosque in the tentative list for UNESCO World Heritage Site.

The **Moti Masjid** is a white marble mosque inside the Red Fort complex in Delhi, India. The name translates into English as "Pearl Mosque." Located to the west of the Hammam and close to the Diwan-e-Khas, it was built by the Mughal emperor Aurangzeb from 1659-1660. The mosque was built by the Mughal emperor Aurangzeb at the Red Fort complex in Delhi, India, from 1659-1660 for his 2nd wife Nawab Bai. The mosque was also used by the ladies of the Zenana. The mosque was constructed at a cost of Rs. 160,000.

The Alamgiri Gate, built in 1673, is the main entrance to the Lahore Fort in present-day Lahore. It was constructed to face west towards the Badshahi Mosque in the days of the Mughal Emperor Aurangzeb.

12.2.7. Successors of Aurangzeb

Additional monuments from this period are associated with women from Aurangzeb's imperial family. The construction of the elegant Zinat al-Masjid in Daryaganj was overseen by Aurangzeb's second daughter Zinat-al-Nissa. Aurangzeb's sister Roshan-Ara who died in 1671. The tomb of Roshanara Begum and the garden surrounding it were neglected for a long time and are now in an advanced state of decay.

Bibi Ka Maqbara was a mausoleum built by Prince Azam Shah, son of Emperor Aurangzeb, in the late 17th century as a loving tribute to his mother, Dilras Bano Begam (posthumously known as Rabia-ud-Daurani) in Aurangabad, Maharashtra. It bears a striking resemblance to the famous Taj Mahal. Due to the strong resemblance, it is also called the Dakkhani Taj (Taj of the Deccan). The Bibi Ka Maqbara is the principal monument of Aurangabad and its historic city. An inscription found on the main entrance door mentions that this mausoleum was designed and erected by Ata-ullah, an architect and Hanspat Rai, an

engineer respectively. Ata-ullah was the son of Ustad Ahmad Lahauri, the principal designer of the Taj Mahal. Bibi Ka Maqbara is believed to have been built between 1668 and 1669 C.E. According to the “Tarikh Namah” of Ghulam Mustafa, the cost of construction of the mausoleum was Rs. 668,203-7 (rupees six lakh, sixty-eight thousand, two hundred three and seven annas) – Aurangzeb allocated only Rs. 700,000 for its construction. An inscription found on the main entrance door mentions that this mausoleum was designed and erected by Ata-ullah, an architect and Hanspat Rai, an engineer respectively. The marble for this mausoleum was brought from mines near Jaipur. According to Tavernier, around three hundred carts laden with marble, drawn by at least 12 oxen, were seen by him during his journey from Surat to Golconda. The mausoleum was intended to rival the Taj Mahal, but the decline in architecture and proportions of the structure (both due to the severe budgetary constraints imposed by Aurangzeb) had resulted in a poor copy of the latter.

Another construction of the Mughal era is Lalbagh Fort (also known as “Fort Aurangabad”), a Mughal palace fortress at the Buriganga River in the southwestern part of Dhaka, Bangladesh, whose construction started in 1678 during the reign of Aurangzeb.

A small mosque named Moti Masjid was built for private prayer by Aurangzeb’s son, the Mughal emperor Bahadur Shah I (r. 1707-1712), close to the Ajmere Gate of the Dargah of Sufi saint Qutbuddin Bakhtiar Kaki, which is located in Mehrauli at the Jahaz Mahal. It is an imitation of the one inside the Red Fort.

Mughal traditions influenced the palaces and forts of many provincial and local kingdoms. Even the Harmandir of the Sikhs, called the Golden Temple at Amritsar which was rebuilt several times during the period was built on the arch and dome principle incorporated many features of the Mughal traditions of architecture.

Check your Progress -1

1. Give an account of architecture of early Mughal rulers
2. Summarize about the architecture of Akbar and Jahangir
3. Write a note on the beauty of the monuments of Shahjahan
4. Focus on the buildings of Aurangzeb and his successors

12.3. Painting

Under Akbar, Persian artists directed an academy of local painters. The drawings, costumes, and ornamentation of illuminated manuscripts by the end of the 16th cent. illustrate the influence of Indian tastes and manners in the bright colouring and detailed landscape backgrounds. Modeling and perspective also began to be adapted from Western pictures. Basawan, Lal, and Daswanth were Akbar's most famous painters.

Major Styles of Painting

Mughal period was the golden period for the development of painting in India. This period practiced the arts of different styles of painting which are as follows:

12.3.1. School of Old Tradition

Here old tradition is referred to the ancient style of painting which was flourished in India before sultanate period. After the eighth century, the tradition seems to have decayed, but palm-leaf manuscripts and illustrated Jain texts from the thirteenth century onwards show that the tradition had not died. Apart from the Jains, some of the provincial kingdom, such as Malwa and Gujarat extended their patronage to painting during the fifteenth century.

12.3.2. Mughal Painting (School from Persian Influence)

This school had been developed during the period of Akbar. Jaswantand Dasawan were two of the famous painters of Akbar's court. The school developed centre of production. Apart from illustrating Persian books of fables, the painters were soon assigned the task of illustrating the Persian text of the Mahabharata, the historical work Akbar Nama and others.

Indian themes and Indian scenes and landscapes, thus, came in vogue and helped to free the school from Persian influence. Indian colours, such as peacock blue, the Indian red, etc., began to be used. Above all, the somewhat flat effect of the Persian style began to be replaced by the roundedness of the Indian brush, giving the pictures a three-dimensional effect.

Mughal painting reached a climax under Jahangir who had a very discriminating eye. It was a fashion in the Mughal school for the faces, bodies and feet of the people in a single

picture to be painted by different artists. Jahangir claims that he could distinguish the work of each artist in a picture.

Apart from painting hunting, battle and court scenes, under Jahangir, special progress were made in portrait painting and paintings of animals. Mansur was the great name in this field. Portrait painting also became fashionable.

12.3.3. European Painting

Under Akbar, European painting was introduced at the court by the Portuguese priests. Under their influence, the principles of fore-shortening, whereby near and distant people and things could be placed in perspective was quietly adopted.

12.3.4. Rajasthan School of Painting

The Rajasthan style of painting combined the themes and earlier traditions of western India or Jain school of painting with Mughal forms and styles. Thus, in addition to hunting and court scenes, it had paintings on mythological themes, such as the dalliance of Krishna with Radha, or the Barah-masa, that is, the seasons, Ragas (melodies).

12.3.5. Pahari School of Painting

The Pahari School continued the Rajasthani styles and played an important role in its development.

Check your Progress - 2

1. Write a note on different styles of paintings prevailed during Mughals

12.4. Music and Dance

Music was originally discouraged in Islam. But there came about a change as a result of the contact with the Indians and the Sufis. The Sufis believed in the efficacy of music. Music became customary on all festive occasions. Music became the link between the Hindus and the Muslims. The early Mughal rulers have introduced a number of musical instruments but it saw severe declaim during the time of Aurangzeb. He hated all fine arts. There is an anecdote

that once Aurangzeb was going for a walk in the garden while his courtiers were digging a pit. When Aurangzeb raised the question why and for what reason they were doing so, they replied that fine arts were dead and they were going to bury all the musical instruments under the ground. Aurangzeb walked off but after some time he returned and requested the courtiers to dig the pit a little bit deeper and bury them so that the dead fine arts would not come active again. That much hatred he had towards the fine arts.

12.4.1. Music

During Mughal Period music was the sole medium of Hindu-Muslim unity. Akbar patronized Tansen of Gwalior who is credited with composing many new melodies (ragas). Jahangir and Shah Jahan as well as many Mughal nobles followed this example. There are many apocryphal stories about the burial of music by the orthodox Aurangzeb.

Recent research shows that Aurangzeb banished singing from his court, but not playing of musical instruments. Some scholars believe that Aurangzeb himself was an accomplished Sitar player. Music in all forms continued to be patronized by Aurangzeb's queens in the harem and by the nobles.

That is why the largest number of books on classical Indian music in Persian were written during Aurangzeb's reign. But some of the most important developments in the field of music took place later on in the eighteenth century during the reign of Muhammad Shah (1720-48).

The Mughals appreciated music. Babur is said to have composed songs. Akbar was a lover of music. His court was adorned by famous musicians like Tansen of Gwalior and Baz Bahadur of Malwa. Shah Jahan was fond of vocal and instrumental music. The two great Hindu musicians of his time were Jagannath and Janardhan Bhatta. But Aurangzeb who was a puritan dismissed singing from his court. However, ironically, the largest number of books on classical music were written in his reign.

Music in those days had no notation system and passed on orally. The most famous musician of the period was Tansen. The variety of music most extensively cultivated at Akbar's court was the ancient dhrupad. The same tradition was continued by Bilas Khan, the inventor of bilas todi. Music received great encouragement under Shah Jahan

12.4.2. Musical Instruments During Mughal Era

The string instrument dominant in the Mughal period was the beena, or rudra vina, which is the most ancient stringed instrument in India. The rudra vina is made of two large gourds joined symmetrically by a long, thin wooden neck, with frets traditionally fixed to the neck with beeswax, four main playing strings, and three drone strings. It is characterized by its deep, rich voice. It may be seen in numerous paintings from the Mughal period.

The pakhawaj is the barrel-drum dominant in the Mughal period, and like the rudra vina, it may be seen in numerous Mughal miniature paintings. It is made of a single piece of wood, hollowed out, with goatskin heads on either side and bound together by leather straps running the length of the drum. The surmandal or swaramandala (literally, “temple of notes”) is a zither-like instrument of many strings. Illustrations of this instrument may be found in Mughal miniature painting.

12.4.3. Mian Tansen

Indian classical music history is enriched with numerous musicians who were able to create different effects in seasons, daytimes through ragas. One such musician was the legendary Tansen. He lived during Akbar’s time. Tansen (c. 1500 – 1586), also referred to as Ramtanu, was a prominent figure of North Indian (Hindustani) classical music. Born in a Hindu family, he learned and perfected his art in the northwest region of modern Madhya Pradesh. He was the disciple of Swami Haridas, the legendary composer from Vrindavan and part of the stellar Gwalior court of Raja Man Singh Tomar (1486–1516 AD), specialising in the Dhrupad style of singing. He began his career and spent most of his adult life in the court and patronage of the Hindu king of Rewa (princely state), Raja Ramchandra Singh (1555–1592), where Tansen’s musical abilities and studies gained widespread fame. This reputation brought him to the attention of the Mughal Emperor Akbar, who sent messengers to Raja Ramchandra Singh, requesting Tansen to join the musicians at the Mughal court. Tansen did not want to go, encouraged him to gain wider audience, and sent him along with gifts to Akbar. In 1562, about the age of 60, the Vaishnava musician Tansen joined the Akbar court, and his performances became a subject of many court historians.

Numerous legends have been written about Tansen, mixing facts and fiction, and the historicity of these stories is doubtful. Akbar considered him as a Navaratnas (nine jewels), and gave him the title Mian, an honorific, meaning learned man.

Tansen was a composer, musician and vocalist, to whom a large number of compositions have been attributed in northern regions of the Indian subcontinent. He was also an instrumentalist who popularized and improved musical instruments. He is among the most influential personalities in North Indian tradition of Indian classical music, called Hindustani. His 16th century studies in music and compositions inspired many, and he is considered by numerous North Indian gharana (regional music schools) as their lineage founder.

Tansen is remembered for his epic Dhrupad compositions, creating several new ragas, as well as for writing two classic books on music Sri Ganesh Stotra and Sangita Sara. Tansen's musical compositions covered many themes, and employed Dhrupad. Most of these were derived from the Hindu Puranas, composed in Braj Bhasha, and written in praise of gods and goddesses such as Ganesha, Sarasvati, Surya, Shiva, Vishnu (Narayana and Krishna avatar). He also composed and performed compositions dedicated to eulogizing kings and emperor Akbar.

The bulk of Tansen's biography as found in the Akbar court historian accounts and gharana literature consists of inconsistent and miraculous legends. Among the legends about Tansen are stories of his bringing down the rains with Raga Megh Malhar and lighting lamps by performing Raga Deepak. Raga Megh Malhar is still in the mainstream repertoire, but raga Deepak is no longer known; three different variants exist in the Bilawal, Poorvi and Khamaj thaats. It is not clear which, if any, corresponds to the Deepak of Tansen's time. Other legends tell of his ability to bring wild animals to listen with attention (or to talk their language). Once, a wild white elephant was captured, but it was fierce and could not be tamed. Finally, Tansen sang to the elephant who calmed down and the emperor was able to ride him.

12.4.4. Dance During Mughal Era

Traditional Dance continued in this period both in the north and in the south. Kathak was a new dance that had developed during this period. But the art was not pursued purely from an

aesthetic point of view. Kathak is the only Indian dance form to have been directly and deeply impacted by the arrival and rule of northern and central India by the Mughal, an Islamic dynasty from Persia. Kathak is legitimately both Hindu and Islamic, and unique in having a historical link to a religion that pretty much 'officially' forbids dance and music.

A Tawaif was a courtesan who catered to the nobility of India, particularly during the era of the Mughal Empire. Tawaifs were the influential female elite, were largely a North Indian institution that became prominent during the weakening of the Mughal rule in the mid- 18th century.

12.4.5. Influence of Mughals on Indian Music & Dance

A lot of changes are seen in Kathak dance after the Mughal advent. Though most of them were not nice but the good ones still exist and are followed by Kathak dancers. For example, the Kathak outfit is inspired by the Mughal clothing. In the context of contemporary South Asian music, Dhrupad falls in the tradition of Hindustani music, which is practiced in the northern portion of India, as well as in Pakistan and Bangladesh. Dhrupad music was the result of an extended interaction between two cultures — the Hindu Indian and the Mughal cultures — over a long period of time.

Dance Sufi music also came into existence in India during the Mughal era which is now enjoyed a lot by people over here. Women dancers were integral to Mughal court life and in cloistered women's quarters. They are in the illustrations depicting forts and palaces and fighting expeditions. Although dance was patronized in Mughal Courts, it became a degraded profession as the main body of the performers were dancing girls of bad repute.

As the Mughal Empire came into closer contact with Hindus, especially under Jalal ud-Din Akbar, music and dance also flourished. In particular, the musician Tansen introduced a number of innovations, including ragas and particular compositions. Legend has it that upon his rendition of a night-time raga in the morning, the entire city fell under a hush and clouds gathered in the sky, and that he could light fires by singing the raga "Deepak", which is supposed to be composed of notes in high octaves.

At the royal house of Gwalior, Raja Mansingh Tomar (1486–1516 CE) also participated in the shift from Sanskrit to the local idiom (Hindi) as the language for classical songs. He himself penned several volumes of compositions on religious and secular themes, and was also responsible for the major compilation, the *Mankutuhā* (“Book of Curiosity”), which outlined the major forms of music prevalent at the time. In particular, the musical form known as *dhrupad* saw considerable development in his court and remained a strong point of the Gwalior *gharana* for many centuries.

After the dissolution of the Mughal empire, the patronage of music continued in smaller princely kingdoms like Awadh, Patiala, and Banaras, giving rise to the diversity of styles that is today known as *gharanas*. Many musician families obtained large grants of land which made them self-sufficient, at least for a few generations (e.g. the Sham Chaurasia *gharana*). Meanwhile, the Bhakti and Sufi traditions continued to develop and interact with the different *gharanas* and groups.

Check your Progress – 3

1. Summarize about the development of music and musical instruments under Mughals
2. Write a note on Mian Tansen
3. Explain about dance forms during Mughal period
4. Describe about the Influence of Mughals on Indian Music & Dance

12.5. Mughal Gardens

Mughal period was the period of glory in the field of laying out the gardens. They laid out many formal gardens with running water. In fact, use of running water even in their palaces and pleasure resorts was a special feature of the Mughals. Babur was very fond of gardens and laid out a few in the neighbourhood of Agra and Lahore. Some of the Mughal gardens, such as the Nishal Bagh in Kashmir, the Shalimar at Lahore, the Pinjore garden in the Punjab foothills, etc., have survived to this day. The Shalimar Gardens (1641–1642) built on the orders of Bahadur Shah Zafar in Lahore, Pakistan, is also on the UNESCO world heritage list.

Mughal gardens are a group of gardens built by the Mughals in the Persian style of architecture. This style was heavily influenced by the Persian gardens particularly

the Charbagh structure. Significant use of rectilinear layouts is made within the walled enclosures. Some of the typical features include pools, fountains and canals inside the gardens.

The founder of the Mughal empire, Babur, described his favourite type of garden as a charbagh. They use the term *bâgh*, *baug*, *bageecha* or *bagicha* for garden. This word developed a new meaning in India, as Babur explains; India lacked the fast-flowing streams required for the Central Asian charbagh. The Agra garden, which was renamed after Partition of India as the Ram Bagh, since it lied in Hindu majority portion is thought to have been the first charbagh. India, Bangladesh and Pakistan have a number of Mughal gardens which differ from their Central Asian predecessors with respect to “the highly disciplined geometry”. The early textual references about Mughal gardens are found in the memoirs and biographies of the Mughal emperors, including those of Babur, Humayun and Akbar. Later references are found from “the accounts of India” written by various European travellers (Bernier for example). The first serious historical study of Mughal gardens was written by Constance Villiers-Stuart, with the title *Gardens of the Great Mughals* (1913). Her husband was a Colonel in Britain’s Indian army. This gave her a good network of contacts and an opportunity to travel. During their residence at Pinjore Gardens, Mrs. Villiers-Stuart also had an opportunity to direct the maintenance of an important Mughal garden. Her book makes reference to the forthcoming design of a garden in the Government House at New Delhi (now known as Rashtrapati Bhavan). She was consulted by Edwin Lutyens, and this may have influenced his choice of Mughal style for this project. Recent scholarly work on the history of Mughal gardens has been carried out under the auspicious guidance of Dumbarton Oaks (including *Mughal Gardens: Sources, Places, Representations, and Prospects* edited by James L. Wescoat, Jr. and Joachim Wolschke-Bulmahn) and the Smithsonian Institution. Some examples of Mughal gardens are Shalimar Gardens (Lahore), Lalbagh Fort at Dhaka, and Shalimar Bagh (Srinagar).

From the beginnings of the Mughal Empire, the construction of gardens was a beloved imperial pastime. Babur, the first Mughal conqueror-king, had gardens built in Lahore and Dholpur. Humayun, his son, does not seem to have had much time for building—he was busy reclaiming and increasing the realm—but he is known to have spent a great deal of time at his father’s gardens. Akbar built several gardens first in Delhi, then in Agra, Akbar’s new capital. These tended to be riverfront gardens rather than the fortress gardens that his predecessors built. Building riverfront rather than fortress gardens influenced later Mughal garden architecture considerably.

Akbar's son, Jahangir, did not build as much, but he helped to lay out the famous Shalimar garden and was known for his great love for flowers. Indeed, his trips to Kashmir are believed to have begun a fashion for naturalistic and abundant floral design.

Jahangir's son, Shah Jahan, marks the apex of Mughal garden architecture and floral design. He is famous for the construction of the Taj Mahal, a sprawling funereal paradise in memory of his favourite wife, Mumtaz Mahal. He is also responsible for the Red Fort at Delhi which contains the Mahtab Bagh, a night garden that was filled with night-blooming jasmine and other pale flowers. The pavilions within are faced with white marble to glow in the moonlight. This and the marble of the Taj Mahal are inlaid with semiprecious stone depicting scrolling naturalistic floral motifs, the most important being the tulip, which Shah Jahan adopted as a personal symbol.

Mughal gardens design derives primarily from the medieval Islamic garden, although there are nomadic influences that come from the Mughals' Turkish-Mongolian ancestry. Julie Scott Meisami describes the medieval Islamic garden as "a hortus conclusus (enclosed garden), walled off and protected from the outside world; within, its design was rigidly formal, and its inner space was filled with those elements that man finds most pleasing in nature. Its essential features included running water (perhaps the most important element) and a pool to reflect the beauties of sky and garden; trees of various sorts, some to provide shade merely, and others to produce fruits; flowers, colourful and sweet-smelling; grass, usually growing wild under the trees; birds to fill the garden with song; the whole is cooled by a pleasant breeze. The garden might include a raised hillock at the centre, reminiscent of the mountain at the centre of the universe in cosmological descriptions, and often surmounted by a pavilion or palace." The Turkish-Mongolian elements of the Mughal garden are primarily related to the inclusion of tents, carpets and canopies reflecting nomadic roots. Tents indicated status in these societies, so wealth and power were displayed through the richness of the fabrics as well as by size and number.

The Mughals were obsessed with symbol and incorporated it into their gardens in many ways. The standard Quranic references to paradise were in the architecture, layout, and in the choice of plant life; but more secular references, including numerological and zodiacal significances connected to family history or other cultural significance, were often juxtaposed.

The numbers eight and nine were considered auspicious by the Mughals and can be found in the number of terraces or in garden architecture such as octagonal pools.

The most important Mughal gardens can be seen at

Afghanistan

- Bagh-e Babur (Kabul)

India

- Humayun's Tomb, Nizamuddin East, Delhi
- Taj Mahal, Agra
- Aarm Bagh, Agra
- Mehtab Bagh, Agra
- Safdarjung's Tomb
- Shalimar Bagh (Srinagar), Jammu and Kashmir
- Nishat Gardens, Jammu and Kashmir
- Yadavindra Gardens, Pinjore
- Khusro Bagh, Allahabad
- Roshanara Bagh
- Rashtrapati Bhavan, New Delhi (1911-1931)
- Vernag
- Chashma Shahi
- Pari Mahal
- Achabal Gardens
- Qudsia Bagh
- Pune-Okayama Friendship Garden-Phase_II

Pakistan

- Chauburji
- Lahore Fort
- Shahdara Bagh
- Shalimar Gardens (Lahore)
- Tomb of Jahangir, Lahore
- Hazuri Bagh
- Hiran Minar (Sheikhupura)
- Mughal Garden Wah

Bangladesh

- Lalbagh Fort

The garden at Humayun's Tomb is a 'Charbagh' garden. Humayun's Tomb is situated in Nizamuddin East, Delhi. Being the first garden tomb of India, it surrounds the tomb of Mughal emperor, Humayun. This Mughal garden represents Persian gardens as well as ideal Mughal architecture. The garden has quadrilateral layout and paved pathways in between them.

Taj Mahal - The mausoleum of love is encircled by gardens which were completed five years after the completion of the monument. The Moonlight Garden is at the north of Yamuna river while the rest is constructed as 'Charbagh'. This Mughal garden has pathways with large marble tank in between. Trees and fountains are found all through this beautiful garden. The tomb here is at the end of the garden while generally, tombs remain at the centre.

Khusro Bagh - Situated in Allahabad, this Mughal garden is large walled and surround the tombs of Khusrau Mirza, Shah Begum, and Khusrau's sister. Khusrau was Jahangir's first son and Shah Begum was the emperor's first wife. Khusrau was imprisoned in the garden by his father for rebelling against him. Presently the area around the garden is an upcoming township.

Ram Bagh - India's oldest Mughal garden was constructed by Babur and is 5km from Taj Mahal. Pathways and canals in the garden are typical representative of the Persian style. Fountains and water courses lend a picturesque view to this captivating garden. It is also known by different names and is historically renowned as Akbar proposed his third wife at Ram Bagh. It was later redesigned by Nur Jahan.

Pinjore Gardens - One of the fascinating gardens in India, Pinjore Gardens is situated at Panchkula in Haryana. This Mughal garden is also known as Yadavindra Garden.

Mehtab Bagh - Also famous as Moonlight garden of Taj Mahal, this Mughal Garden also represents 'Charbagh' design. This square shape garden is ideally situated opposite to River Yamuna. Babur was probably the builder of this garden which comprises spacious pavilions, plaster pathways, fountains and pools. It was ruined due to flood but was later reconstructed again.

Nishat Bagh - This Mughal garden is located at the eastern side of the Dal Lake. This terraced garden is the second largest in Kashmir Valley. The magnificent view of Pir Panjal mesmerises the visitors. It has twelve terraces and is divided into two sections. Both the sections are watered by Gopi Thirst, which is a spring. It is said that Shah Jahan was so jealous of the spellbinding view that he closed the garden until it was left deserted.

Safdarjung's Tomb - This Mughal garden is second garden tomb after Humayun's tomb. Situated in New Delhi this monumental tomb garden is also designed as 'Charbagh'. The garden is designed with four squares and wide pathways and water tanks around it. It is almost a replica of the garden at Humayun's tomb. Various water channels enhance the beauty of the garden.

Shalimar Bagh - Situated at Srinagar, Shalimar Bagh is one of the most enticing gardens in India. This Mughal garden is also known as Shalimar Garden and was built by emperor Jahangir. This royal garden was transformed and renamed by various rulers. But Shalimar garden is the name that remained etched all through. It also has three terraces and fountains within its premises.

Roshanara Bagh This Mughal garden was constructed by Roshanara Begum. She was emperor Shah Jahan's second daughter whose mausoleum is located here. It is located by the University of Delhi and nestles variety of plants, some being originally from Japan. Bird enthusiasts have good time during winter as the lake here attracts many migratory birds. There are many flowering plants too which are planted beside the canal.

Verinag - Verinag Spring in Anantnag district of Jammu Kashmir is highly renowned for its spellbinding beauty. It was built by emperor Shah Jahan while the Mughal garden by the spring was laid down by Shah Jahan. Here lies an octagonal tank where reminiscent of Hindu idols along with an old temple is also traced. Facilities for hot and cold bath is also found at this garden.

Check your progress – 5

1. Write an essay on Mughal Gardens.

12.6 sAnswers to Check your Progress

Check your Progress -1

1. See 12.2.1 and 12.2.2
2. See 12.2.3. and 12.3.4.
3. See 12.2.5.
4. See 12.2.6 and 12.2.7

Check your Progress – 2

1. See 12.3.1. – 12.3.5

Check your Progress – 3

1. See 12.4.1 and 12.4.2.
2. See 12.4.3.
3. See 12.4.4.
4. See 12.4.5.

Check your Progress – 4

1. See 12.5.

LESSON – 13

INDIAN SOCIETY IN TRANSITION – THE 19TH CENTURY RENNAISSANCE HINDU AND MUSLIM REFORM MOVEMENTS

Learning Objectives

After learning this lesson, you will be able to

- ❖ Comprehend about the reforms initiated and implemented by Raja Ram Mohan Roy
- ❖ Understand the role of Henry Vivian Derozio in the young Bengal movement
- ❖ Estimate the part played by the several reformists and their organizations
- ❖ Assess the role of Muslim, Sikh and Parsi reformers
- ❖ Evaluate the work of women social reformers
- ❖ Appreciate the role of Literature and Press as a powerful weapon for spreading social awareness

Structure

13.1 Introduction

13.2 Hindu Reform Movements

13.2.1. Raja Rammohan Roy and BrahamoSamaj

13.2.2. Henry Vivian Derozio and the young Bengal movement

13.2.3. Debendranath Tagore

13.2.4. Keshab Chandra Sen

13.2.5. Iswar Chandra Vidyasagar

13.2.6. Sri Ramakrishna Paramahansa

13.2.7. Swami Vivekananda

13.2.8. The Ramakrishna Mission

13.2.9. Dayanand Saraswati and the Arya Samaj

13.2.10. JyotiraoGovindrao Phule

13.2.11. The PrarthanaSamaj

13.2.12. The Theosophical Society and Annie Besant

13.3 Reform movements among the Muslims

13.3.1. Syed Ahmad Khan

13.4 Reform movements among the Parsis and the Sikhs

13.5 Women Reformers

13.5.1. Pandita Ramabai

13.5.2. Sarojini Naidu

13.6 Literature and the Press

13.7 Characteristics of the Reform Movements

13.8 Contribution of the reform movements

13.9 Answers to Check your Progress

13.1 Introduction

The urgent need for social and religious reform that began to manifest itself from the early decades of the 19th century arose in response to the contact with Western culture and education.

The weakness and decay of Indian society was evident to educated Indians who started to work systematically for their removal.

They were no longer willing to accept the traditions, beliefs and practices of Hindu society simply because they had been observed for centuries.

The impact of Western ideas gave birth to new awakening. The change that took place in the Indian social scenario is popularly known as the Renaissance.

13.2. Hindu Reform Movements

13.2.1. Raja Rammohan Roy and Brahmo Samaj

The central figure of this cultural awakening was Raja Rammohan Roy. Known as the “father of the Indian Renaissance”, Rammohan Roy was a great patriot, scholar and humanist. He was moved by deep love for the country and worked throughout his life for the social, religious, intellectual and political regeneration of the Indians.

Rammohan Roy was born in 1772 in Radhanagar, a small village in Bengal. As a young man he had studied Sanskrit literature and Hindu philosophy in Varanasi and Persian, Arabic and Koran in Patna. He was a great scholar Roy who mastered several languages including English, Latin, Greek and Hebrew.

Social Reforms:

In 1814, Rammohan Roy settled in Calcutta and dedicated his life to the cause of social and religious reform. As a social reformer, Rammohan Roy fought relentlessly against social evils like sati, polygamy, child marriage, female infanticide and caste discrimination. He organised a movement against the inhuman custom of sati and helped William Bentinck to pass a law banning the practice (1829). It was the first successful social movement against an age-old social evil.

Rammohan Roy was one of the earliest propagators of modern Western education. He looked upon it as a major instrument for the spread of modern ideas in the country. He was associated with the foundation the Hindu College in Calcutta (which later came to be known as the Presidency College). He also maintained at his own cost an English school in Calcutta. In addition, he established a Vedanta College where both Indian learning and Western social and physical science courses were offered.

He sent petitions to the government to adopt a wider system of public education in English. He also recognised the importance of vernaculars for spreading new ideas. He compiled a Bengali grammar and developed an easy and modern style of Bengali prose.

Journalism:

Rammohan Roy was a pioneer of Indian journalism. He himself published journals in Bengali, Persian, Hindi and English to educate the public on various current issues. SamvadKaumudi was the most important journal brought out by him.

Rammohan Roy and Internationalism:

Rammohan Roy was a firm believer in internationalism. He held that the suffering and happiness of one nation should affect the rest of the world. He took a keen interest in international

events and always supported the cause of liberty and nationalism. He celebrated the success of the revolution in Spain in 1823 by hosting a public dinner.

Religious Reforms:

Rammohan Roy struggled persistently against social evils. He argued that ancient Hindu texts the Vedas and the Upanishads upheld the doctrine of monotheism. To prove his point, he translated the Vedas and five Upanishads into Bengali.

In 1849 he wrote *Gift to Monotheism* in Persian. Rammohan Roy was a staunch believer in the philosophy of Vedanta (Upanishads) and vigorously defended the Hindu religion and Hindu philosophy from the attack of the missionaries. He only wanted to mould Hinduism into a new cast to suit the requirements of the age.

In 1829 Rammohan Roy founded a new religious society known as the Atmiya Sabha which later on came to be known as the **Brahmo Samaj**. This religious society was based on the twin pillars of rationalism and the philosophy of the Vedas. The Brahmo Samaj emphasised human dignity, criticised idolatry and denounced social evils like sati.

Rammohan Roy represented the first glimmerings of the rise of national consciousness in India. He opposed the rigidity of the caste system because it destroyed the unity of the country. The poet Rabindranath Tagore has rightly remarked: "Rammohan was the only person in his time, in the whole world of men, to realise completely the significance of the Modern Age."

13.2.2. Henry Vivian Derozio and the young Bengal movement

The establishment of the Hindu College in 1817 was a major event in the history of Bengal. It played an important role in carrying forward the reformist movement that had already emerged in the province. A radical movement for the reform of Hindu Society, known as the Young Bengal Movement, started in the college.

Its leader was Henry Vivian Derozio, a teacher of the Hindu College. Derozio was born in 1809. He was of mixed parentage his father was Portuguese and his mother was Indian. In 1826, at the age of 17, he joined the Hindu College as a teacher and taught there till 1831.

Derozio was deeply influenced by the revolutionary ideas of liberty, equality and fraternity. He was a brilliant teacher and within a short period of time, he drew around him a group of intelligent boys in the college.

He inspired his students to think rationally and freely, to question authority, to love liberty, equality and freedom and to worship truth. By organising an association for debates and discussions on literature, philosophy, history and science, he spread radical ideas.

The movement started by Derozio was called the Young Bengal Movement and his followers were known as the Derozians. They condemned religious rites and the rituals, and pleaded for eradication of social evils, female education and improvement in the condition of women.

Derozio was a poet, teacher, reformer and a fiery journalist. He was perhaps the first nationalist poet of modern India. He was removed from the Hindu College because of his radicalism and died soon after at the age of 22.

The Derozians could not lead a very successful movement because social conditions were not yet ripe for their ideas to flourish. Yet they carried forward Rammohan's tradition of educating the people on social, economic and political questions.

13.2.3. Debendranath Tagore

Debendranath Tagore, the father of Rabindranath Tagore, was responsible for revitalising the Brahmo Samaj. Under him the first step was taken to convert the Brahmo Samaj into a separate religious and social community. He represented the best in traditional Indian learning and the new thought of the West.

In 1839, he founded the Tatvabodhini Sabha to propagate Rammohan Roy's ideas. He promoted a magazine to do a systematic study of India's past in Bengali language. The Samaj actively Debendranath Tagore supported the movements for widow remarriage, the abolition of polygamy, women's education and the improvement in the condition of the peasantry.

13.2.4. Keshab Chandra Sen

Keshab Chandra Sen carried on an intensive programme of social reform. He set up schools, organised famine relief and propagated widow remarriage. In 1872 the Government passed the Native (Civil) Marriages Act legalising marriages performed according to Brahmo Samaj rites.

13.2.5. Iswar Chandra Vidyasagar

Iswar Chandra Vidyasagar, a towering personality of the mid- nineteenth century, was born in a poor Brahmin family of Bengal in 1820. He was a renowned Sanskrit scholar and became the Principal of the Sanskrit College in 1851. The Sanskrit College conferred on him the title of 'Vidyasagar' because of his profound knowledge of Sanskrit.

Pandit Iswar Chandra Vidyasagar was both a scholar and a reformer. He was a great humanist and had deep sympathy for the poor and the oppressed. He dedicated his entire life to the cause of social reform which he thought was necessary for modernising India. By admitting non-Brahmin students to the Sanskrit College, he dealt a severe blow to the prevalent caste system.

Vidyasagar was a staunch supporter of women's education and helped Drinkwater Bethune to establish the Bethune School, the first Indian school for girls, in 1849. As Inspector of Schools, Vidyasagar opened a number of schools for girls in the districts under his charge.

Vidyasagar's greatest contribution lies in the improvement of the condition of widows. Despite opposition, Vidyasagar openly advocated widow remarriage. Soon a powerful movement in favour of widow remarriage was started. At last, after prolonged struggle the Widow Remarriage Act was passed in 1856. Through his efforts, twenty-five widow remarriages took place. He also spoke vehemently against child marriage and polygamy.

Vidyasagar contributed enormously to the growth of the Bengali language and contributed to the evolution of the modern prose style in Bengali. He wrote a Bengali primer, 'Varna Parichay', which is used even today. Through his writings, Vidyasagar made the people aware of the social problems and thus helped the growth of nationalism in India.

Check your Progress – 1

1. Summarize about the reforms of Raja Rammohan Roy.
2. Write about Henry Vivian Derozio and the young Bengal movement
3. Assess the role played by Debendranath Tagore, Keshab Chandra Sen, Iswar Chandra Vidya Sagar

13.2.6. Sri Ramakrishna Paramahansa

Sri Ramakrishna Paramhansa was one of the greatest saints of modern India. Ramakrishna was born in a poor Brahmin family of Bengal. He showed a religious bent of mind from his childhood. He had no formal education but his discourses were full of wisdom. He was the chief priest of the Kali temple at Dakshineswar near Calcutta. People from all walks of life visited Dakshineswar to listen to his discourses.

Ramakrishna Paramhansa was a man with a liberal outlook. He firmly believed that there was an underlying unity among all religions and that only the methods of worship were different. God could be approached by any form of worship as long as it was done with single-minded devotion.

Different religions were all different roads to reach the same God. He believed that service to man was service to God, for man was the embodiment of God on earth. As man was the creation of God, man-made divisions made no sense to him.

Ramakrishna Paramhansa was a great teacher who could express complicated philosophical ideas in a simple language for everyone to understand. He believed that religious salvation could be attained through renunciation, meditation and devotion.

13.2.7. Swami Vivekananda

Narendra Nath Dutta, better known as Swami Vivekananda, was the most illustrious disciple of Sri Ramakrishna. He was born in Calcutta in January, 1863. He graduated from the Scottish Church College and was well-versed in Western philosophy. Vivekananda was a man of great intellect and possessed a critical and analytical mind. At the age of eighteen, Vivekananda met Sri Ramakrishna. This meeting transformed his life completely. After the

death of Sri Ramakrishna, he became a 'sanyasi' and devoted his life to preaching and spreading Ramakrishna's message to the people. His religious message was put in a form that would suit the needs of contemporary Indian society.

Vivekananda proclaimed the essential oneness of all religions. He condemned the caste-system, religious rituals, ceremonies and superstitions. He had a deep understanding of Hindu philosophy and travelled far and wide to spread its message. At the Parliament of World Religions in Chicago (1893), Vivekananda spoke about Hindu religion at length.

His brilliant speech on Hindu philosophy was well received. American newspapers described him as an 'Orator by Divine Right'. He delivered a series of lectures in the U.S.A., England and in several other countries of Europe. Through his speeches, Vivekananda explained Hindu philosophy and clarified the wrong notions that prevailed in Western countries about the Hindu religion and Indian culture.

In India, however, Vivekananda's main role was that of a social reformer rather than a religious leader. He propagated Ramakrishna's message of peace and brotherhood and emphasized the need for religious tolerance which would lead to the establishment of peace and harmony in the country.

He believed that it was the social responsibility of the better placed people to take care of the downtrodden, or the 'daridranarayan'. With his clarity of thought, deep understanding of the social problems of India, Vivekananda undoubtedly left a deep mark on the Indian intelligentsia as well as on the masses. At a time when the nation was in despair, he preached the gospel of strength and self-reliance. Vivekananda died at the age of 39.

13.2.8. The Ramakrishna Mission

In 1896, Vivekananda founded the Ramakrishna Mission to propagate social welfare. It laid emphasis not on personal salvation but on social good and social service. The Ramakrishna Mission stood for religious and social reform based on the ancient culture of India. Emphasis was put on the essential spirit of Hinduism and not on rituals.

Rendering social service was the primary aim of the Ramakrishna Mission. It believed that serving a human being was the same as worshipping God. The Mission opened a chain of

schools, hospitals, orphanages and libraries throughout the country. It provided relief during famines, earthquakes and epidemics. A math or monastery was established in Belur near Calcutta. The Belur Math took care of the religious developments of the people.

13.2.9. Dayanand Saraswati and the Arya Samaj

Another organisation in northern India which aimed to strengthen Hinduism through reform was the Arya Samaj. Dayanand Saraswati, the founder of the Arya Samaj in Rajkot, was born into a Brahmin family in Kathiawar, Gujarat, in 1824. At the early age of 14, he rebelled against the practice of idol worship. He ran away from home at the age of twenty. For the next fifteen years, he wandered all over India meditating and studying the ancient Hindu scriptures.

In 1863 Swami Dayanand started preaching his doctrine of one God. He questioned the meaningless rituals, decried polytheism and image worship and denounced the caste system. He wanted to purify Hinduism and attacked the evils that had crept into Hindu society.

Dayanand Saraswati believed that the Vedas contained the knowledge imparted to men by God, and hence its study alone could solve all social problems. So, he propagated the motto "Back to the Vedas." Asserting that the Vedas made no mention of untouchability, child marriage and the subjugation of women, Swami Dayanand attacked these practices vehemently.

Dayanand began the suddhi movement which enabled the Hindus who had accepted Islam or Christianity to return to Hinduism, their original faith. Dayanand published his religious commentaries in Hindi so as to make the common people understand his preachings. The Satyarth Prakash was his most important work.

The Swami worked actively for the regeneration of India. In 1875, Swami Dayanand founded the Arya Samaj in Bombay. The Arya Samaj made significant contributions to the fields of education and social and religious reforms. After his death, his followers had established the Dayanand Anglo Vedic Schools first in Lahore and then in other parts of India. Gurukuls were also established to propagate traditional ideals of education. A network of schools and colleges both for boys and girls were also established by the Arya Samaj.

The Arya Samaj influenced mostly the people of northern India, specially Uttar Pradesh, Rajasthan, Gujarat and Punjab. Although it was not a political organisation, the Arya Samaj played a positive role in creating a nationalist pride in Indian tradition and culture.

Check your Progress – 2

1. Explain the part played by Ramakrishna Paramahansa, Vivekananda and Ramakrishna Mission in social and religious reform movement in India
2. What do you know about Arya Samaj

Reform movements in Western India:

13.2.10. JyotiraoGovindrao Phule

JyotiraoGovindrao Phule prominent role in bringing about, reforms in Maharashtra. He fought for improving the condition of women, the poor and the untouchables. He started a school for the education of girls of the lower castes and founded an association called the SatyasodhakSamaj.

People from all castes and religions were allowed to join the association. He was opposed to the domination of the Brahmins and started the practice of conducting marriages without Brahmin priests.

13.2.11. The PrarthanaSamaj

In 1867, the PrarthanaSamaj was started in Maharashtra with the aim of reforming Hinduism and preaching the worship of one God. Mahadev Govind Ranade and R.G. Bhandarkar were the two great leaders of the Samaj. The PrarthanaSamaj did in Maharashtra what the Brahmo Samaj did in Bengal.

It attacked the caste system and the predominance of the Brahmins, campaigned against child marriage and the purdah system, preached widow remarriage and emphasised female education. In order to reform Hinduism, Ranade started the Widow Remarriage Association and the Deccan Education Society. In 1887, Ranade founded the National Social Conference with the aim of introducing social reforms throughout the country. Ranade was also one of the founders of the Indian National Congress.

Reform Movements in South India:

13.2.12. The Theosophical Society and Annie Besant

Many Europeans were attracted towards Hindu philosophy. In 1875, a Russian spiritualist named Madame Blavatsky and an American called Colonel Olcott founded the Theosophical Society in America. The society was greatly influenced by the Indian doctrine of karma. In 1886 they founded the Theosophical Society at Adyar near Madras.

Annie Besant, an Irish woman who came to India in 1893, helped the Theosophist movement to gain strength. She propagated Vedic philosophy and urged Indians to take pride in their culture. The Theosophists stood for the revival of the ancient Indian religion and universal brotherhood.

The uniqueness of the movement lay in the fact that it was spearheaded by foreigners who glorified Indian religious and philosophical traditions. Annie Besant was the founder of the Central Hindu College in Banaras, which later developed into the Banaras Hindu University. Annie Besant herself made India her permanent home and played a prominent role in Indian politics. In 1917, she was elected President of the Indian National Congress.

13.3. Reforms movements among the Muslims

Movements for socio-religious reforms among the Muslims emerged late. Most Muslims feared that Western education would endanger their religion as it was un-Islamic in character. During the first half of the 19th century only a handful of Muslims had accepted English education.

The Muhammadan Literary Society, established by Nawab Abdul Latif in 1863, was one of the earliest institutions that attempted to spread modern education. Abdul Latif also tried to remove social abuses and promote Hindu- Muslim unity.

13.3.1. Syed Ahmad Khan

The most important socio-religious movement among the Muslims came to be known as the Aligarh Movement. It was organised by Syed Ahmad Khan (1817-1899), a man described as the most outstanding figure among the Muslims.

Syed Ahmad Khan was born in 1817 into a Muslim noble family and had joined the service of the Company as a judicial officer. He realised that the Muslims had to adapt themselves to British rule. So, Syed Ahmad advised Muslims to embrace Western education and take up government service.

In 1862, he founded the Scientific Society to translate English books on science and other subjects into Urdu. He also started an English- Urdu journal through which he spread the ideas of social reform. Through his initiative was established the Mohammedan Oriental College which later developed into the Aligarh Muslim University. It helped to develop a modern outlook among its students. This intellectual movement is called the Aligarh Movement.

As a social reformer, Syed Ahmad Khan campaigned against the purdah system, polygamy and the Muslim system of divorce. He emphasised the need for removing irrational social customs while retaining the essence of Islam and encouraging a rational interpretation of the Koran.

Syed Ahmad Khan believed that the interest of the Muslims would be best served through cooperation with the British Government. It was only through the guidance of the British that India could mature into a full-fledged nation. So, he opposed the participation of the Muslims in the activities of the Indian National Congress.

13.4. Reform movements among the Parsis and the Sikhs

The Parsi Religious Reform Association was started in 1851. It campaigned against orthodoxy in religion. Religious and social movements among the Sikhs were undertaken by various gurus who tried to bring about positive changes in the Sikh religion. Baba Dayal Das propagated the nirankar (formless) idea of God. By the end of the 19th century a new reform movement called the Akali Movement was launched to reform the corrupt management of Gurdwaras.

13.5. Women Reformers

13.5.1. Pandita Ramabai

The British Government did not take substantial steps to educate women. Still, by the end of the 19th century, there were several women who had become aware of the need for

social reform. Pandita Rama bai had been educated in United States and in England. She wrote about the unequal treatment meted out to the women of India. She founded the Arya Mahila Sabha in Pune and opened the Sarda Sadan for helping destitute widows.

13.5.2. Sarojini Naidu

Sarojini Naidu was a renowned poet and social worker. She inspired the masses with the spirit of nationalism through her patriotic poems. She stood for voting rights for women, and took an active interest in the political situation in the country. She also helped to set up the All India Women's Conference.

13.6. Literature and the Press

Literature was used as a powerful weapon for spreading social awareness among the people. It was also used for promoting social reforms. The social reformers made valuable contributions to literature. Bharatendu Harish Chandra, Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay and Rabindranath Tagore spread the ideas of social reform and condemned social injustice in Hindi and Bengali.

Poets like Iqbal and Subramania Bharati inspired the masses. Premchand wrote about the sufferings of the poor and thus made the people aware of social injustice. Rabindranath Tagore composed the National Anthem. Bankim Chandra and Iqbal composed two other national songs Bande Mataram and Saare Jahan Se Achcha.

Growth of the Press:

Most reformers started journals of their own. Through these journals and newspapers, they put forward their demands for social, economic and political changes. Thus, the press acted as a vehicle for disseminating ideas of social transformation.

13.7. Characteristics of the Reform Movements

An analysis of the reform movements of the 19th century brings out several common features:

- (1) All the reformers propagated the idea of one God and the basic unity of all religions. Thus, they tried to bridge the gulf between different religious beliefs.
- (2) All the reformers attacked priesthood, rituals, idolatry and polytheism. The humanitarian aspect of these reform movements was expressed in their attack on the caste system and the custom of child marriage.
- (3) The reformers attempted to improve the status of girls and women in society. They all emphasised the need for female education.
- (4) By attacking the caste system and untouchability, the reformers helped to unify the people of India into one nation.
- (5) The reform movements fostered feelings of self-respect, self-reliance and patriotism among the Indians.

13.8. Contribution of the reform movements

Many reformers like Dayanand Saraswati and Vivekananda upheld Indian philosophy and culture. This instilled in Indians a sense of pride and faith in their own culture. Female education was promoted. Schools for girls were set up. Even medical colleges were established for women. This led to the development, though slow, of girls' education. The cultural and ideological struggle taken up by the socio-religious movements helped to build up national consciousness. They, thus, paved the way for the growth of nationalism.

Check your Progress – 3

1. Highlight the Reform movements in Western India
2. Describe the Reform Movements in South India.
3. Explain about the Reform movements among the Muslims, Sikhs and Parsis.
4. Assess the role of Women reformers
5. Write a note on the role of Literature and Press in propagating reform movement in India

13.9. Answers to Check your Progress

Check your Progress – 1

1. See 13.2.1.
2. See 13.2.2.
3. See 13.2.3. – 13.2.5.

Check your Progress – 2

1. See 13.2.6. – 13.2.8.
2. See 13.2.9.

Check your Progress – 3

1. See 13.2.10. and 13.2. 11.
2. See 13.2.12.
3. See 13.3. – 13.4.
4. See 13.5.1. and 13.5.2.
5. See 13.6.

LESSON – 14

THE BRITISH RULE: MISSIONARY ACTIVITIES

SPREAD OF CHRISTIANITY

IMPACT OF CHRISTIANITY ON THE SOCIETY

Learning Objectives

After studying this lesson you will be able to

- Understand the policy of non-interference of East India Company
- Learn the Charter Act of 1813 and its provisions on Christianity
- Comprehend the Charter Act of 1833 and its features regarding Christianity
- Grasp the distinctive features of the activities of the Missionary Societies
- Acquire knowledge on different phases of Missionary Activities of British in India
- Gain information about the impact of Christianity on Indian Society

Structure

14.1 Introduction

14.2 Policy of Non-Interference

14.3 Charter Act of 1813

14.4 Charter Act of 1833

14.5 The Distinctive Features of the Activities of the Missionary Societies

14.6 Different Phases of Missionary Activities of British in India

14.6.1. First Phase of Missionary Activities of British in India

14.6.2. Second Phase of Missionary Activities of British in India

14.6.3. Third Phase of Missionary Activities of British in India

14.6.4. Fourth Phase of Missionary Activities of British in India

14.7 Impact of Christianity on Indian Society

14.7.1. Education

14.7.2. Language and Literature

14.7.3. Social Reform

14.8 Answers to Check your Progress

14.1 Introduction

In India the British government had three roles to play, the first role is to trade, second to rule, and the third role is to propagate Christianity. Initially the East India company followed the policy of non-interference with the customs and traditions of the natives and lack of support for missionary work to propagate Christianity in India. Till the renewal of the Charter Act of 1813, the British East India Company had blocked the entry of missionaries into India.

14.2. Policy of Non-Interference

In the early years of its rule the East India Company had taken a position of neutrality with regard to the religious and social affairs of the people of India. The Company decided not to interfere with the traditional cultures of the people by supporting missionary work. The company's policy of non-interference, probably, was based on fear that missionaries through English education expecting to aid conversions might offend the Hindu subjects of the company and create unrest. They felt that the missionaries would encourage the religious sentiments among the people in India and that would affect the business policy and diplomatic role of the East India Company.

The Company and some influential people in England made an attempt to stop the promotion of missionary movement in India as they feared that it would lead to the awakening of the Indian Hindu, and ultimately it would be the Company's interest that would suffer. Thus, it created an agitation against the East India Company that the Company was opposed to the teachings of Christ and neglected to provide education for the Indians.

In 1813 the Company's Charter came once again for renewal. By this time the missionaries prepared the ground through agitation in England for proselytizing activities in India.

There was great unrest in the British Parliament, in 1813, when the issue of permission to start missionary movement in India was asked. Several officials of the Company argued that

the restrictions on the missionaries should continue, because the Indians are civilized enough and do not need the missionaries. But the missionaries and their political supporters argued that the Indians are in the darkest plight, the conversion of India to Christianity will spell temporal benefits to the heathens and the conversion of heathens to Christianity will further consolidate the empire.

Finally, the missionary clause was attached to the Charter Act of 1813 passed by the British Parliament. It permitted the missionaries to go to India and propagate English and preach Christianity.

14.3. Charter Act of 1813

The Charter Act of 1813 brought to an end the era of agitation started by Charles Grant, Wilberforce and others. **"It allowed the missionaries to land in India in large numbers and establish modern English schools and thereby they laid the foundation of the well-organised modern educational system"**.

The Charter Act of 1813 was the first parliamentary approval for propagation of Christianity in India. The policy of modernizing Indian society and culture was also encouraged by the Christian missionaries and religious minded persons such as William Wilberforce and Charles Grant, the Chairman of the Court of Directors of the East India Company, who wanted to spread Christianity in India. They too adopted a critical attitude towards Indian society but on religious grounds. They passionately believed that Christianity alone was true.

As the shores of India were thrown open to missionaries, they poured into India not only from England but all also from other parts of the world, particularly from Scotland, Germany and America. In fact, missionaries from outside Great Britain came to India only after 1833. The Charter Act created an era of controversies with regard to the content of education, the aim of education, the medium of education and the agency of education.

The Charter Act opened the shores of India to missionary societies. As a result, the period from 1813 to 1833 was one of great mission activity in different parts of the Company's possessions. The earlier missionary societies expanded their activities and new societies entered the field. Of these latter societies special mention may be made of the General Baptist Missionary

Society, the London Missionary Society, the Church Missionary Society, the Wesleyan Mission and the Scotch Mission-ary Society.

14.4. Charter Act of 1833

The Charter Act of 1833 laid down regulation of permanent presence of missionaries in India and the number of Bishops were made three. The Charter Act of 1833 made provision for Anglican hierarchy at Calcutta. Finally, in 1833, the policy of the company was changed under pressure from the Evangelicals in England. This marked the first decisive step of missionary work in India. With the expansion of British Empire missionaries began to arrive and Christianity began to spread by establishing dioceses at Madras and Bombay. Ever since there existed a renewed cooperation between the missionaries and the colonial power in helping one another in their missions.

Check your Progress – 1

1. What do you know about the policy of non-interference of the East India Company?
2. How far the Charter Acts of 1813 and 1833 helped the missionaries in India?

14.5 The Distinctive Features of the Activities of the Missionary Societies

1. The main object of the missionaries was proselytization and not education. Education was regarded by them as a means to an end. It was the secondary object and not the principal one. Their sole aim was to propagate Christian doctrines.

They mainly aimed at religious conversion. They took up educational work in order to meet the needs of the converted Indian. Further, they intended to train up Indian assistants for their proselytizing activities. It is, however, true that their activities greatly helped to the educational progress of the country.

2. The early missionaries attached importance to the use and development of the modern Indian languages. They employed the local Indian languages (mother-tongue of the pupils) as the media of instruction. But the latter missionaries attached importance to the English language as the medium of instruction.

3. The early missions had to work among the lowest classes of the society who knew their own languages only. But the latter missions chiefly worked among the upper classes of the society who knew the English language to a certain extent. The latter believed that Christianity would filtrate from the upper classes to the lowest classes. They practically invented the Downward Filtration Theory in the field of religion. This is especially applicable to Alexander Duff of the Scottish Mission.
4. The earlier missions were mostly Catholic, but the missionaries who came after 1813 were mostly Protestants.
5. The missionaries before 1813 mainly worked in the South-Western region of India, but the missionaries who came later primarily worked in the North-Eastern belt of India.
6. The missionaries who poured into Indian soil in between 1813 -1833 belonged chiefly to Great Britain. But the missionaries who came to India after 1833 mostly belonged to Germany and America. These missions included The Basle Mission Society, The Protestant Lutheran Society, and Women's Association of Education of Females in the Orient (founded in Berlin), The American Baptist Union, The American Board and the American Presbyterian Mission Board.
7. Another important feature of the missionary enterprise after 1813 was that the relations between the Company and the missionaries were cordial and cooperative. The earlier strained relations between them from 1793 to 1813 improved slowly and steadily. Each tolerated the other and each co-operated with the other.

As a result, missionary enterprise was greatly facilitated by the cordial relations that existed in this period between the officials of the Company and the missionaries. This was due to changed social and political relations in the country and introduction of a number of social reforms and liberal ideas.

8. The largest amount of mission activity took place in Madras in comparison to Bombay and Bengal and other provinces.
9. Missionary activities received a new momentum and direction in the hands of Alexander Duff, the vigorous and the greatest Scottish missionary of the period. His indomitable spirit and tireless efforts resulted in the spread of English education in Bengal. He was

thrice in India. 1830 – 35, 1840 – 50 and 1856 – 63. He came to Calcutta as the first missionary of the Church of Scotland in 1830.

Duff was thinking of preaching salvation to India. According to him salvation of India depended on what the West and particularly the Bible gave her. He was an energetic educationist. He advocated the promotion of English education combined with Christian faith as its animating spirit. In 1835 he observed that “every branch of western Knowledge would destroy some corresponding part of the Hindu system, and so one stone after another would be thrown down from the huge and hideous fabric of Hinduism”.

The “spirit and faith of Duff soon infected almost all the missionaries working in the field of Indian education and English schools conducted by the missionaries began to multiply very rapidly after 1830. The period from 1830 to 1857 can rightly be regarded as “the age of the mission school” in India.

Duff led a full-fledged missionary movement. He initiated a new missionary policy in India. He considered Western education as the soundest weapon for conversion into Christianity. He aimed at bringing the upper classes into contact with missionaries and imparting Western education “inseparable from the Christian faith and its doctrines”.

Duff hoped that English education would secure converts from the upper classes and Christianity would percolate from them to the masses. (Thus, Duff invented the Downward Filtration Theory in the field of religion which Macaulay applied to education later). With this objective in view Duff founded the General Assembly’s Institution (the present Scottish Church College) in Calcutta in 1830.

10. It is evident that the missionaries employed education as a subservient means to propagate their Christian doctrines.
11. But the aggressiveness of the missionaries contained the germs of their ultimate failure. The disillusionment came by about 1870. Only a small section of the Indian upper classes embraced Christianity. The bulk of the Indian masses, particularly the middle class, remained outside the orbit of Christianity. Most of them welcomed western education minus Christianity.

12. With a clear vision, the Evangelicals now had access to India and could begin spreading the Gospel to the 'idolatrous', 'heathen' Indians. The Church Missionary Society and the London Missionary Society joined the Baptist Missionary Society in the initial missionary efforts of translations of the Scriptures and the establishment of schools. Their efforts were built on the prior legendary work of the Reverend William Carey and the Baptist Missionary Society at Serampore. Vigorous efforts in evangelising and bazaar preaching brought only modest results, but enough to be seen as threatening to the Hindu culture and thus a contributing cause of the Indian [Sepoy Mutiny](#) of 1857. Following the Mutiny, the missionary focus rested on the use of educational and medical missions as vehicles for conversion. At the turn of the twentieth century, the fulfilment theory reigned for a time with the vision of Christianity as the next step, or as the fulfilment of Hinduism. Following the First World War, the established church separated from its British roots to become the Church of India and slowly its hierarchy became Indianized. In the end, Christianity held its greatest appeal among India's untouchables. To sum up, British missionary and religious activities in India can be broadly classified and differentiated into four distinct phases, with separate facets, objectives and condition and status of Britishers in the nascent stage of capturing India.

Check your Progress – 2

1. Write a note on the distinctive features of the activities of the Missionary Societies

14.6 Different Phases of Missionary Activities of British in India

14.6.1. First Phase of Missionary Activities of British in India

The first phase of British missionaries in India falls within the time-period of 16th century to 18th century. This was the era, when the British East India Company was making its very initial voyages to broaden trade prospects with East. As such, to establish British colony in an alien country, it was necessary to know the countrymen primarily. Thus, Christian preachers and clergymen were sent to make Christianity a homely faith amongst the 'heathens'. Englishmen were at times accompanied by French and Dutch missionary activists, who were later ousted in a warlike manner.

14.6.2. Second Phase of Missionary Activities of British in India

With the already established notion of Christianity in the first phase, second phase of British religious and missionary activities falls within the era from late 18th century to mid-19th century. The time witnessed the tremendous rise of Christian faith as a leading religion in India. Church was the foremost organisation, which became successful to achieve such a task. The British Crown from England had laid down certain rules also, for such earnest endeavours. The Presidency towns of Calcutta, Madras and Bombay were the key places, from where operations took place. The Holy Bible was also a religious initiator in this phase.

14.6.3. Third Phase of Missionary Activities of British in India

The third phase of British religious missionary activities in India comprised the years falling within mid-19th century till late-19th century to early 20th century. This was the period of the rise of the Indian intellectual and the middle-class educative class. They were also termed as reformists or nationalists. Armed with educative values, they understood the value of Christian faith, beliefs and conversion. Women were also noticed to have come up in such a socialist movement. Societies, schools, hospitals, churches and specialised homes were established by the still broad-hearted English. Then came the incredible resisting force of [Sepoy Mutiny](#) of 1857, hampering religious activities to the maximum. After the Mutiny, things took a dramatic turn, never to remain the same again.

14.6.4. Fourth Phase of Missionary Activities of British in India

Fourth phase of the missionary and religious activities in India by the Britons lasted within the period of early 20th century till Indian Independence. The corrosive, resisting and rebellious era had set in. British presence in India was no longer considered a boon, tremendously hindering religious activities in the way. Though Her Highness in England had formulated regulations to make Indians calmer towards English rule, yet, it was impossible under severe oppression. As such, Christianity was targeted as the foremost instigator to such motions. Churches were separated from the Government of India into a separate organisation; schools in the Westernised mode of education functioned violently, however without much result. Though in the times of Independence India was declared a secular country, yet missionaries of the 16th century failed to keep their notion strong in 1947.

Check your Progress – 3

1. Give an account of different phases of Missionary activities in India

14.7. Impact of Christianity on Indian Society

It is widely believed that St. Thomas, the disciple of Jesus, first introduced the Christian faith to India nearly two thousand years ago. The subcontinent would not experience the influence of Christianity, however, until the much later arrival of the Europeans. The Portuguese began to settle in Goa from 1498. In 1542 the Jesuit Francis Xavier, a papal ambassador, arrived, and the work of the Roman Catholics began in earnest. Protestant ministry in India was first established in Tranquebar by two German pietists, Bartholomew Ziegenbalg and Henry Plutschau.

14.7.1. Education

Christian missionary activity in India generally involved the establishment of high-quality schools. Obviously, the Christian community's impact does not end there. Accompanying the schools came printing presses, which were helpful in the dissemination of literature of all kinds. In fact, the early overseas missionaries were responsible for pioneering English and modern vernacular education. R. L. Rawat, in his *History of Indian Education*, suggests that India will forever be indebted to the missionaries for the production of textbooks, dictionaries, and grammars, and for their zealous pursuit of educational advancement.

The works carried out by missionaries and Christians have always been understood to be an expression of their love and obedience to Jesus. The underlying motivation, of course, was their obligation to proclaim the salvation of God through the Christian faith.

In the sixteenth century it was the Jesuits who first established Christian institutions of learning. They were followed by the German Tranquebar missionaries. Later the renowned Friedrich Schwartz began Christian schools in both vernacular languages and in English. William Carey and the British Baptists who arrived in Calcutta in the late eighteenth century pioneered modern education in North India. By 1818 there were 111 schools located as far away from Calcutta as Shimla and Delhi in the north, and Rajputna in the south.

With the renewal of the British East India Company's charter in 1813 and the arrival of a host of British mission societies, there was a proliferation of schools and printing presses across the country. The first Western-type postsecondary school, Serampore College, was organized in 1818. The American Mission opened schools for boys in Bombay from 1815 and in 1829. John Wilson saw to it that a school was also set up in Bombay for girls.

The arrival in Calcutta of Alexander Duff in 1830 marked the beginning of a new approach to learning, namely, English-language education. Duff's idea to set up an English-language school was, at first, controversial. There was significant opposition, but soon Duff's modest experiment began to catch the imagination of the upper classes and those who possessed aspirations for their children. Duff's work was a great success and resulted in the expansion of English-language educational institutions throughout British India in the nineteenth and twentieth centuries, at the primary, secondary, and university levels; in time English became the veritable lingua franca of India. The widespread and popular adoption of English by people of all language groups and classes has certainly given India an advantage in today's global economy, as well as in diplomacy, politics, and technology.

Christians were the pioneers in the field of female education. Much of this work was taken up by the wives of early missionaries, and by single women missionaries, of whom there were many. In the nineteenth century the commonly accepted view in India was that formal education was not for women of any kind, much less for those from respectable families. In 1834 it was reported that only 1 percent of Indian women could read and write.

Yet by 1900 an impressive number of schools and colleges had been opened in major cities, towns, and even villages throughout India for both men and women. Christians also went to live and work among both the tribal groups and the downtrodden. The former were animists who lived outside the Hindu fold, while the latter were from the "untouchable" caste and were therefore excluded from the orthodox Hindu social structure. Toward the end of the nineteenth century Christian missionaries began to take more seriously the needs of these people and went to minister to them. The missionaries began schools and created written forms for many of the languages. In response, people from these groups converted to Christianity in great numbers. This was particularly so in the Northeast and in the mass movements of Andhra Pradesh and Tamil Nadu.

14.7.2. Language and Literature

Christians have also made a significant contribution in India in the fields of languages, literature, and journalism. Constanzio Beschi (1680–1747) reformed Tamil alphabetical characters, making them more suitable for the printing press. He also produced a fourfold Tamil dictionary, which was divided according to words, synonyms, classes, and rhymes. Bishop Robert Caldwell's (1815–1891) *Comparative Grammar of the Dravidian Languages* and G. U. Pope's (1820–1908) translations of classics of Tamil literature into English are noteworthy. Vedanayagam Pillai (1824–1889) and H. A. Krishna Pillai (1827–1900) are two other Christian writers who produced some of the first Tamil novels.

The French priest Francis Mary of Toure began work on Hindustani as early as 1680, composing a massive dictionary titled *Thesaurus Linguae Indiae*. Modern Hindi, the national language, developed out of Hindustani. Henry Martyn and a Dr. Gilchrist, a professor of Hindustani and an American Presbyterian missionary, and the Reverend S. H. Kellogg all contributed to the formation and popularization of Hindustani. Kellogg, in fact, drew more than a dozen dialects together to assist in creating what is today known as Hindi. He produced in 1893 *A Grammar of the Hindi Language*, which is still in circulation. William Carey and his Baptist colleagues, beginning in 1818, were the first to produce periodicals, journals, and a newspaper. Their publication, the *Friends of India*, lived on and is now an English daily, the *Statesman*, published from Calcutta and New Delhi.

Jawaharlal Nehru in his *Discovery of India* acknowledges the contribution of the early missionaries, especially the Baptists of Serampore, concerning the shift from the dominating influence of both Sanskrit and Persian. The printing of books and newspapers by the missionaries, together with English-language education, no doubt broke the hold of the classics, says Nehru, and allowed regional languages to emerge and blossom. While Nehru saw no difficulty in missionaries dealing with the major languages, he notes that they, “even laboured at the dialects of the primitive hill and forest tribes... The desire of the Christian missionaries to translate the Bible into every possible language thus resulted in the development of many Indian languages. Christian mission work in India has not always been admirable or praiseworthy . . . but in this respect, as well as in the collection of folklore, it has undoubtedly been of great service to India”.

14.7.3. Social Reform

From the very first, missionaries were shocked at the social evils that persisted in India, including the practice of sati (the immolation of widows on their husbands' funeral pyres), the killing of lepers, and the sacrifice of children.

William Carey was active from his arrival in 1793 in any issue that he felt needed change or reform. Within a year, near Malda, he reported having found the remains of an infant that had first been offered to a god as a sacrifice and then abandoned to be eaten by white ants. Moreover, children were thrown into the Ganges in fulfilment of vows taken for answers to prayer. Carey used his connections to those in authority and power to campaign for the outlawing of such practices. Governor-General Lord Wellesley asked him to submit a report on the matter and subsequently, in 1802, declared infanticide to be an act of murder; those who performed such horrible deeds, if caught, would themselves be put to death.

Carey employed his publications to educate public opinion on matters of humanitarian concern. The first issue of the *Friend of India* carried an exhaustive report of an actual sati. Subsequently he kept the practice before the public eye and did all he could to see sati abolished. By 1814 Ram Mohan Roy joined Carey in the campaign against sati. Armed with accounts of 438 widow burnings, Carey and his Serampore colleagues implored the government to forbid the rite by law. At first very little progress was made, due to strong opposition from high caste Hindu leaders. The Christians kept up the pressure, and eventually public opinion turned against the orthodox Hindus. In 1829 Lord William Bentinck finally signed an order prohibiting sati in the occupancies of the East India Company.

The field of medicine is another area in which Christians have made a significant contribution to the welfare and the common good of India. Jesuits in the late sixteenth century opened infirmaries attached to their living accommodations. John Thomas, an associate of William Carey, began his work in 1799. In the nineteenth century medical establishments of various kinds were created throughout India, set up by almost every missionary society. Two have been internationally recognized. The first, the Christian Medical College Hospital, Ludhiana, was founded by Dr. Edith Brown in 1893; the other, the Christian Medical College Hospital, Vellore, grew out of Dr. Ida Scudder's roadside clinics, first begun in 1895. In time both of these

hospitals added to their facilities, becoming the first government-recognized medical colleges for women and subsequently for men.

There have also been programs set up for the mentally challenged and the disabled. The first institution for the deaf was organized by an order of nuns in Bombay in 1884. Since then, Catholic and Protestant Christians have established numerous homes throughout India for the abandoned, the abused, and the exploited. Two of the most impressive of these centers are the Mukti Mission in Kedegoan, near Pune founded by Pandita Ramabai in 1898 for orphaned girls and abused women. The other, the Dohnavur Fellowship, was first organized in 1901 by Amy Carmichael in South India. Its object was to rescue girls who had been forced into temple prostitution.

Another matter of concern among Christians over the years has been the practice of child marriage, whereby alliances are made among Hindus between children as young as five years of age. Carey's solution was to promote female education. Child marriage was legislatively banned in 1929. Christians since then have made a concerted effort to promote the approval of widow remarriage.

Christian reform efforts also included establishing sanatoriums for tuberculosis patients and for those who had contracted leprosy. The Schefflin Research and Training Centre in Karigiri, near Vellore, has carried out much original creative work in the area of leprosy reconstruction and rehabilitation.

While most of the early expressions of Christian social initiatives were pioneered by foreign missionaries, Indian Christians have carried on and even multiplied the legacy handed down to them. This has been so much the case that well into the late twentieth century a preponderance of doctors and nurses in any area of health care and medicine were Indian Christians. Moreover, many Hindus and Muslims still prefer to go to Christian hospitals.

Christians were also involved in rural development. Typical had been the Allahabad Agricultural College, organized in 1910. Their aims were to assist and improve the productivity of farmers.

There were a number of Christians involved in the freedom movement, including K. T. Paul, V. Chakkarai and his colleagues, Bishop Paul Appaswamy, Bishop Waskom Pickett, E. Stanley Jones, and to a lesser extent Bishop V. Z. Azariah. In addition, several Christians played an important role in framing the Indian Constitution. There were six appointed to the Minority Advisory Committee by the [Constituent Assembly](#): Raj Kumari Amrit Kaur, Elbar D' Souza, P. K. Salvry, H. C. Mukherji, J. J. M. Nichols Roy, and J. N. P. Roch Victoria. The committee met under the leadership of Sardar [Vallabhbhai Patel](#) in late 1947.

At the center of India's struggle for freedom from the British was the towering figure of Mahatma Gandhi. He was well acquainted with Christianity. However, it was Jesus Christ, more than Christians, that touched his heart. In 1920 he wrote "I revere the Bible. Christ's sermon on the mount fills me with bliss even today. Its sweet verses have even today the power to quench my agony of the soul." Writing in the Harijan in January 1939 he said, "Though I cannot claim to be a Christian in the sectarian sense, the example of Jesus' suffering is a factor in the composition of my undying faith in non-violence which rules all my actions, worldly and temporal."

Check your Progress – 4

1. What is the impact of Christianity on Indian Society

14.8. Answers to Check your Progress

Check your Progress – 1

1. See 14.2.
2. See 14.3. and 14.4.

Check your Progress – 2

1. See 14.5.

Check your Progress – 3

1. 14.6.1. – 14.6.4.

Check your Progress – 4

1. 14.7. – 14.7.3.

LESSON – 15

WESTERN EDUCATION AND ITS IMPACT ON INDIAN SOCIETY

Learning Objectives

- After learning this lesson, you will be able to
- Describe the indigenous education
- Mention the early the efforts made by the English to promote education in India.
- Narrate the role of Christian Missionaries in spreading education
- Differentiate between the Orientalists and Anglicists.
- Give an estimate of Macaulay's Minute
- Highlight the importance of Wood's Despatch of 1854
- List out the various education commissions with their recommendations.
- Distinguish between the various educational schemes
- Mention about the new education policy
- Give a critical estimate of the impact of education on the Indian Society.

Structure

15.1 Introduction

15.2 Indigenous education

15.3 Early English efforts

15.4 Role of Christian Missionaries

15.4.1. Missionary work in Bengal

15.4.2. Response of the native people

15.4.3. Missionary work in South India

15.4.4. Other contributions of the Missionaries for the cause of education

15.5 East India Company and education**15.6 Charter Act of 1813****15.7 Charter Act of 1833****15.8 Macaulay's Minute 1835****15.9 Woods despatch 1854****15.10 The Hunter Commission 1882****15.11 Lord Curzon and Indian Education****15.12 Indian Universities Act 1904****15.13 The Sadler Commission 1917-1919****15.14. Education under Dyarchy 1921- 37****15.15. The Hartog Committee 1929****15.16. Wardha Scheme of Basic education****15.17. Sargent Plan of Education 1944****15.18. Radhakrishnan Commission on University Education 1948-49****15.19. Secondary Education Commission 1953****15.20. Acharya Narendradev Commission 1953****15.21. Kothari Commission 1964- 66****15.22. National Education Policy****15.23. Education and its impact on society****7.23.1. Impact on Society****7.23.2. Birth of Socio- religious reform movement****7.23.3. Rule of Law****7.23.4. Democracy****7.23.5. Awakening****7.23.6. Development of Vernacular language****15.24. Impact of Westernisation****15.25. Let us sum up****15.26. Answers to check your progress**

15.1 Introduction

Pre-colonial India is well known for its system of indigenous education. There existed Gurukulas and Pathshalas to promote education of the caste Hindus and Madarasas and Maktabas to promote the education of the Muslim community in India. This indigenous education gave more stress to scholarship of languages rather than science and technology and by the time the British came to India as traders, Persian was the court language and irrespective of religious faith, both Hindus and Muslims learnt Persian to obtain jobs under the rulers of pre-colonial India. Besides Madarsas and Patashalas, there too existed advanced centres of learning in languages along with ordinary schools teaching language proficiency based on oral tradition and memorization of the texts. The British who acquired territorial control and became political masters did not interfere in the educational field till 1813. After 1813, with the cooperation of a limited number of Indians, the British colonial rulers introduced the western system of education in India.

Since education is considered as one of the best means of bringing change and progress in a society it is essential to know about its growth in the past. You will learn in this lesson the growth of education in India during the modern period and its impact on the society. Education is one of the social aspects for your study.

15.2. Indigenous education

There were various stages in the growth of education in India. We had the traditional system of learning during the ancient period. Sanskrit learning was once most popular. Education in ancient India mostly centered round religion. It was once mainly literary, philosophical and religious. Secular learning occupied only secondary position and practical education was offered at the elementary stage. The system of education was old and it was mostly confined to the privileged sections of the society. Nalanda, Taxila in North India. Vallabhi in Western India and Kanchi in South India were the famous centres of learning in India during the ancient period. After the conquest of India by the Muslims. Sanskrit learning lost the sympathy of the rulers. Royal patronage declined to religious as well as secular learning except here and there.

Persian language became popular under the Muslim rulers during the medieval period. It was the official language for many years. The Hindus learnt it as a matter of practical necessity.

A Persian school or a Maktab was attached to almost every mosque and such schools were located at other places also. Students were taught from manuscripts on elementary grammatical works, form of correspondence, tales, medicines, theology and popular poems. When the Europeans came to India, there were simple village schools generally accommodated in thatched houses or under the shadow of the tree. They taught the rudiments of learning, working and arithmetic. The loss of political power led to the neglect of education in India during the 18th century.

15.3 Early English efforts

There was a great debate among Indians and the British, known as 'Orientalists' and 'Anglicists' about the type of education needed by the Indians. For nearly more than half a century, the British followed a policy of neutrality or non-intervention in the matters of religion and culture of the indigenous people.

But due to constant pressure from different sections – the Christian missionaries, the liberals, the utilitarians, and the Anglicists – the British yielded and agreed to take up the responsibility of promoting Western education. There is also a view that the educational policy was designed to legitimize the domination of the British colonial needs.

No doubt, there also existed certain people among the British, who were genuinely interested in the promotion of oriental learning, like Warren Hastings who started Calcutta Madarasa in 1781, Jonathan Duncan who founded the Benaras Sanskrit College in 1791 and William James, who founded The Asiatic Society of Bengal in 1784. In this great debate, finally Anglicists, succeeded in introducing the western system of education in India. A general committee of public instruction was set up in 1823 to look after the development of education in India.

The English East India Company became a ruling power in Bengal in 1765. But the company did not recognize the promotion of education among the natives of India as a part of its duty. They followed the policy of non- interference in such matters. They considered interference would affect their political and commercial fortunes. Therefore, they left the education of the people of India to private effort. However, some officials of the east India

Company showed some interest on the declining state of education among the Indians. They obliged the company's court of directors to do something for the promotion of learning among them. But the Christian missionaries were the first to come forward to do some service for the cause of Indian education.

Warren Hastings set up the Culcutta Madrasa in 1781 for the study and learning of Persian and Arabic. He wrote to the court of directors in 1784 about the bad condition of schools in every Capital town and city of Northern India and the Deccan. In 1787 John Sullivan, the company's president at Tanjore assisted Rev. Swartz in establishing some schools there. Rev. Swartz got the help of the Raja of Tanjore in establishing schools for teaching English at Tanjore. Ramanathapuram and Sivaganga. Jonathan Duncan, another British Resident at Banaras did some help in establishing a Sanskrit College at Banaras in 1781. It stood for the cultivation of the laws, literature and religion of the Hindus. The Christian missionaries decried such attempts to revive an out of date system of education. They advocated the teaching of Western literature and Christian religion through the medium of English. Lord Wellesley set up in 1800 the Fort William College at Calcutta for the training of the Civil Servants of the company in the languages and customs of India. But the court of directors ordered the closure in 1802. Thus, the east India company followed a policy of neutrality till 1813 on educational and social matters of the Indians.

15.4. Role of Christian Missionaries

The role of Christian missionaries in the field of education is really commendable. They were the first to establish modern type of educational institutions in this country. As the Hindu educational institution served the upper castes, the backward and lower caste pupils were attached towards the new Christian missionary educational institutional institutions. They were organized on the basis of Western concept of middle-class education whose object was to promote the extension, not the monopoly of learning, to rouse the mind and elevate the character of the whole people and not to keep them in a state of slavish submission to a particular sect.

The society for the propagation of Christian knowledge, the Danish Mission, the London Missionary Society, the church missionary society, the Wesleyan mission, the free church mission of Scotland and a host of other missions started schools in different parts of India from the beginning of the 18th century.

15.4.1. Missionary work in Bengal

The first missionary school in Bengal was of J.N. Kiernader which was opened on 1 December 1758. It provided education to Bengal students along with the others of foreign origin. The famous Baptist missionary was established in 1792. William Carey of the Baptist mission came to Bengal in 1793 and opened a school at Mandabatty in the Dinajpur District in 1794. It was meant mainly for the education of Bengal children. The Baptist missionary society made Serampore in Bengal as their headquarters in 1799. They started a vernacular school for Bengal boys on June 1800. Soon it became popular. They also assisted in the establishment of the benevolent institution at Calcutta in 1810 for the study of the poor children, pupils of different age, groups, religions and nationalities like Europeans, native Portuguese, Armenian, Chinese, Hindu, Muslim and Abyssinians were admitted into that institution. Branches of that institution were also opened at Serampore, Dacca and Chittagong. In 1822 there were about 500 students staying in such institutions. The Baptist mission society had more than one hundred schools by 1879 and about 7000 students were enrolled in them.

The Serampore mission also established in 1816 an institution for the encouragement of native schools in India. It was guided by Carey, Marshman and Ward. They also established a college at Serampore in 1818 for higher education. The missionaries were directed by Hastings to extend their services to Rajasthan. Therefore Jabez, Carvey and W.B. Martin were sent Ajmer to start schools and train teachers there.

Captain James Stewart of Calcutta Committee of church missionary society (established in 1817) set up schools at Calcutta, Burdwan, and Krishnanagar in Bengal and at Agra, Chunar and Meerut. The London missionary society set up schools for vernacular education at Chin Sura with the help of the government.

The Calcutta Diocesan Committee of the Society for promoting Christian knowledge started some schools in Calcutta with the help of Bishop Middleton. He also laid the foundation of the famous Bishop College in Calcutta in 1820. Though the main object of that college was to train the Christian youth of Bengal as school masters of Missionaries, pupils of other communities also got admission for liberal education.

15.4.2. Response of the native people

There was good response from the people of Bengal for the educational activities of the churches. The Bengali parents did not hesitate in sending their wards to missionary schools. They did not object to the Bible being read in the schools so long as their children were not compelled to eat something against their caste restrictions and convert to Christianity. Some Indians actually assisted the missionaries in setting up educational institutions. For example, Raja Kali Shankar Ghosal donated land in 1817 for constructing the church missionary society's schools at Kidderpore. Similarly, Jainarain Ghosal donated money to the same society to start a school at Banaras in 1818 for teaching English, Bengali, Persian and Hindustani. Ram Mohan Roy helped Alexander Duff of the Scottish mission to establish his first school in Calcutta in 1830.

15.4.3. Missionary work in South India

The Danish mission from Denmark took the lead in doing some educational service in South India. Barthilomew Ziegenbalg and Henry Plutschow came to Tranquebar (Tarangambadi) in 1705. Ziegenbalg translated the New Testament and a part of the Old Testament into Tamil. rev. Frederick Swartz came to Tanjore in 1750. The Danish missionaries gained some influence in the court of Tanjore and set up schools at Cuddalore, Tirunelveli and other places in the Tamil region.

The English missions had to work in the south under certain restrictions. Lady Campbell wife of the governor of Fort St. George started in 1787 a female orphan asylum at Madras. Within a few years more than 150 girls received education in that institution. A male asylum was also set up to educate and maintain orphan boys, mostly sons of soldiers in the Company's service. There were 200 students in that institution in 1792.

15.4.4. Other contributions of the Missionaries for the cause of education

The Christian missionaries rendered valuable services by printing and publishing many text books and reference books for use in Primary and High Schools. They also compiled and published dictionaries and grammars of the different languages of India. Ziegenbalg and Rhenius wrote Tamil grammar. A Malayalam dictionary and a book on grammar were written by Bailey of Kottayam and Carey Yates wrote on Bengali Grammar.

A large Bengali dictionary was produced by Carey and a small one by Pearson Thomson of Delhi and Adam of Banaras compiled a Hindi Dictionary. Sanskrit grammar and dictionaries were produced by Yates and Carey. The Bible was translated into several Indian languages. The missionaries also established Printing Presses in India. By the middle of the 19th century there were about 25 presses owned by the missionaries and about 50 owned by the Indians in the Presidencies of Bengal and Agra. They published a large number of books and tracts in them for the instruction of the students.

By the close of 1850 there were 1345 Vernacular schools run by the missionaries with 83,700 boys. They had 73 boarding schools for Christian children with 992 boys. for spiritual education through English medium there were 128 boys' schools with 1400 boys. For female education there were 354 Vernacular day schools with 11,500 girls and 91 boarding schools with 2450 boys. Thus, the Christian missionaries did a yeoman service for the cause of Indian education before the east India Company could do something for it.

Check your progress-1

1. Assess the contribution of Christian missionaries for the progress of education in India.

15.5. East India Company and Education

Charles Grant who served in India from 1768 to 1790 wrote a treatise in 1792 entitled observations on the state of society among the Asiatic subjects of Great Britain. It was presented to the court of Directors in 1797. He advanced the needs for the introduction of English languages among the Indians. Lord Minto was also in favour of such a step in his Minutes of 1811.

15.6. Charter Act of 1813

When the time for the renewal of the Charter of 1793 came before the British Parliament for consideration in 1813 Grant and Wilberforce strongly urged the introduction of English education in India. Due to their presence a clause was added in the charter act of 1813 which authorized the Governor General of Bengal to set apart a sum of one lakh of rupees but it was allowed to accumulate.

Committee on Public Instruction – Orientalists – Anglicists Controversy

Hastings's temporary successor John Adams made efforts for formation of Committees of Public Instruction on the three Presidencies of Bengal, Bombay and Madras. They were formed in 1813. H.H. Wilson was appointed as its Secretary of Bengal to supervise the expenditure of the sum set apart according to the Act of 1813. Soon a controversy appeared as to the medium of instruction when a proposal to open a Sanskrit college in Calcutta came before the company's government in 1813. A Sanskrit college was opened at Calcutta in 1824 and another at Delhi which was opposed by Raja Ram Mohan Roy. He advocated the promotion of English education.

Wilson, H.T. Prinsep and the governor –general lord Amherst were in favour of the promotion of orientalised education. They were known as orientalises. W. W. Hunter, Sir Charles Trevelyan and Raja Ram Mohan Roy favoured English education and they were known as Anglicists. At that time the literacy rate in Bengal and Bihar was 7.75%. Munro a population of 12,850,941. In Bombay there were 1705 schools with 35,143 students in 1830 for a population of 46,89,755.

Although English education held its ground in Bengal, the Bengal government did not neglect vernacular education altogether. Moreover, in Bombay (Mumbai), Madras (Chennai), and the North-Western Provinces there was as yet little effective demand for English, and the tendency was to lay the main stress on Indian languages. Bombay adopted the policy of encouraging primary education and spreading Western science and knowledge through the mother tongue. This was done under the able guidance of Mount Stuart Elphinstone, then the governor, even though the government also conducted an English school in almost every district in the province. Between 1845 and 1848 a bitter controversy arose regarding the language of instruction, but the issue was between the mother tongue and English, and not between a Classical language and English as it was in Bengal. The controversy gathered strength every day, and, in those days of centralization, the matter had to be referred to the Bengal government, which advised the Bombay government to concentrate its attention on English education alone, thus throttling the growth of education through the mother tongue in Bombay. Meanwhile, the Madras government was biding its time, leaving the field of positive effort open to Christian

missionaries; as a result of this missionary initiative, English education in the Madras presidency was more extensively imparted than in Bombay.

A laudable experiment in the field of vernacular education was carried out by Lieutenant Governor James Thomason in the North-Western Provinces. Thomason's %alqabandī system attempted to bring primary education within easy reach of the common people. In each %alqah(circuit) of villages, a school was established in the most central village so that all the villagers within a radius of two miles might avail themselves of it. For the maintenance of these schools the village landholders agreed to contribute at the rate of 1 percent of their land income. The experiment proved successful, and in 10 years Thomason opened 897 schools and provided elementary education for 23,688 children.

15.7. Charter Act of 1833

When William Bentinck was the governor-general of Bengal the third charter act passed in 1833. According to the charter act of 1813, one lakh of rupees was set apart but it was allowed to accumulate. By the charter act of 1833 it was clearly laid down that the allotted amount should be spent only for the spread of English education. Lord Macaulay was appointed as the Law member of the governor general's council. He came to India in 1834 and supported the views of English education group in the committee of public instruction. His resolution of 1835 ended the Orientalists and Anglicists controversy in India Lord William Bentick supported Macaulay's efforts.

William Bentinck announced in 1835 that English replaced Persian as the court language, books in English were made available at low prices and more funds were allotted to support the English education, and fund for the support of oriental learning was curtailed. Lord Auckland, who succeeded Bentnick as the Governor General also continued encouragement for the promotion of English learning by opening English colleges in Dacca, Patna, Benaras, Allahabad, Agra, Delhi and Barielly.

15.8 Macaulay's Minute 1835

As a member of the governor-general's executive Macaulay wrote on 2 February 1835 his famous minute on the educational policy of the company's administration. It aimed to create

a class of persons who should be Indians in blood and colour but English in taste, in opinion, in morals and in intellect. Bentinck's government accepted it on 7 March 1835. Thus, the object of Indian education under the company became the promotion of European literatures and sciences through the medium of English. Macaulay, the president of the General Committee of Public Instruction and Lord Bentinck overrode the orientalist view point and declared, "the great object of the British government in India is henceforth to be the promotion of European literature and science among natives of India and that all the funds appropriated for the purpose of education would be best employed on English education alone". Besides Macaulay and William Bentinck, the efforts of Charles Grant and William Wilberforce deserve to be remembered in this aspect.

15.9 Woods despatch 1854

In 1841, the General Committee of Public Instruction was abolished and in its place a council of education was established. Another landmark in the development of Western education was Wood's Despatch of 1854. Sir Charles Wood was the president of the board of control in English during the governor-generalship of Lord Dalhousie. He drafted a despatch in 1854 to India which had many recommendations. It enumerated the aim of education as the diffusion of arts, science, philosophy and the literature of Europe. The study of Indian languages was to be encouraged. The English language was to be taught whenever there was a demand for it. Both the English language and the Indian languages were to be regarded as the media for the diffusion of European knowledge. It was felt that the time had come for the establishment of university. Each university was to consist of a chancellor, vice-chancellor and a senate. It was laid down that the affiliated institutions would be periodically visited by government inspectors.

The Despatch categorically states "the education that we desire to see extended in India is that which has for its object the diffusion of the improved arts, science, and philosophy and literature of Europe, in short, of European knowledge.

Charles Wood also recommended for the starting of universities at Calcutta, Bombay and Madras, for the establishment of a network of graded schools, high schools, middle schools and the elementary schools, promotion of vernacular schools and the establishment of teacher training institutions and the introduction of grant-in-aid system to non-government schools

opened by charitable bodies and individuals. As per the recommendation of Wood, in 1857 three universities were established at Madras, Bombay and Calcutta.

The Woods Despatch acted as a model for further development of education in India. Besides government support for Western learning in India, Christian missionaries and others took keen interest. The founding of Hindu College, which in later times was called Presidency College in Calcutta by David Hare and others helped the promotion of secular learning among the Hindus. Along with Western learning, woman's education also received wide patronage. The same pattern of promotion of education can be witnessed in Bombay and Madras presidencies too.

We notice a slow and gradual promotion of Western learning in India which ultimately led to a new spirit of rationalism and a new critical outlook in the Indians which finally led to the emergence of a spirit of nationalism; championing of self-rule and self-reliance. It does not mean that Western learning was primarily responsible for the above narrated process, but it acted as a catalyst in fostering the awareness of the colonial economic exploitation.

As the consequence of the spread of Western educational system, new notions of reason, justice and utilitarian concerns of welfare began to mould the minds of the educated Indians in search of an answer to the problems of poverty and impoverishment that plagued Indian society of the later 19th century. An interesting offshoot of the spread of Western education and transformation of British East India Company from that of trader-conqueror to that of rulers was the emergence of a middle-class professional group to serve the interests of the British colonial and imperial interests.

Check your progress -2

1. What was the status of Indian education under the East India Company?

15.10 The Hunter Commission 1882

In 1882 Lord Ripon appointed a commission to enquire into the manner in which effect had been given to the principles of the Despatch of 1854 and to suggest such measures as it may think desirable in order to the further carry out of the policy therein laid down. The commission collected a lot of useful information and made the following recommendations.

1. Development of primary education through the local bodies with government aid.
2. Encouragement of private efforts in secondary education with grants –in-aid.
3. Government to establish a model school in every district and
4. To offer moral training and religious training in the colleges.

The twenty years following the report of the commission saw an unprecedented growth and expansion of secondary and collegiate education in India. The number of secondary schools increased from 3916 in 1882 to 5,124 in 1902 with 214,077 students to 590,129. A number of arts and professional colleges also increased from 72 in 1882 to 191 in 1902. The Punjab University and the Allahabad university were established in 1882 and 1887 respectively.

15.11. Lord Curzon and Indian Education

Lord Curzon was the Viceroy of India from 1899-1905. He wanted to established government control over education also. He summed a conference at Shimla in 1901 to review the system of education in India. It passed 150 resolutions and suggested the reform of university education. Therefore, Curzon appointed a commission in 1902 headed by Sir Thomas Raleigh. Raleigh commission's recommendations aided mainly at reorganizing the functioning of the universities and laying stringent conditions for affiliation of colleges. Based on this, Curzon's government passed the Indian universities act in 1904.

15.12 Indian Universities Act 1904

The Indian universities act passed during the time of Curzon in 1904 aimed at bringing the following changes.

1. Universities were to promote study and research, appoint professors and lecturers and set up laboratories and libraries and not to be mere examining bodies.
2. The number of students of a university shall not be less than 50 and not more than 100 of which the elective element was 20 for each of the university (Calcutta, Madras and Bombay). They were to hold office for 6 years.
3. Government had the power to veto the regulations passed by the Senate.

4. Universities to have more control over private colleges by laying down strict conditions of affiliation. Periodical inspection by the syndicate and maintain the standard of efficiency. Government approval was necessary for grant of affiliation or disaffiliation of colleges.

One immediate effect of the act was the decrease in the total number of colleges. The Indian nationalists opposed Curzon's measures as they increased the government's control over the universities. G.K. Gokhale described the bill as a retrograde measure. He urged in the imperial legislative council during 1910-13 the government to accept the responsibility for compulsory primary education. Two new universities were started at BENARES and PATNA in 1916 and 1917 respectively.

15.13 The Sadler Commission 1917-1919

In 1916 the Calcutta University under the leadership of Sir Ashothosh Mookerjee decided to bring post-graduation teaching directly under its control. It appointed some professors and lecturers for that purpose. Lord Chelmsford, the governor-general of India immediately appointed a commission with Dr. (late sir) Michal Sadler as its chairman. It was to conduct a comprehensive and searching enquiry about the working of the Calcutta University and its need. It submitted a report in August 1919 and made certain recommendations. They were not only applicable to Calcutta university but also to other universities in India. The main recommendations were:

- a) Government to create intermediate colleges, independently or with selected high schools
- b) Secondary and intermediate education was to be controlled a board of secondary education and not by the university.
- c) The government of Indi should not deal with the Calcutta university and the government of Bengal to take its pace.
- d) The creation of the degree course after the intermediate was limited to 3 years and provision was made for Honors courses for bright students.
- e) Special attention was to be paid too WOMENS education and a board constituted for the purpose.
- f) Vocational and professional training of teachers, lawyer, medical men and engineers was to be seriously taken by the universities.

Seven new universities came into existence during 1916-21 namely, Mysore, Patna, Benares, Aligarh, Dacca, Lucknow and Osmania. In 1920, the government of India recommended the Sadler report to provincial government.

15.14 Education under Dyarchy 1921- 37

Montague – Chelmsford reforms was passed in 1919 and it introduced in 1921 Dyarchy at provincial level and education became a transferred subject under the control of popular ministers in the provinces. Central special grants for education were liberally given to the provinces since 1902 were discontinued. In spite of some financial difficulties there was considerable expansion of education in India and Philanthropic contribution increased with national effort. The Visvabharathi University was started by Rabindranath Tagore at Santhiniketan. The Delhi University and the Nagpur University were set up in 1922 and 1923 respectively. The Andhra University was set up in 1926 and the Annamalai university was set up in 1929.

15.15 The Hartog Committee 1929

The increase in educational institutions led to the fall of quality and standard. Therefore, the Simon Commission appointed an auxiliary committee headed by Sir Philip Hartog to report on the development of education in India. Its report stressed.

1. The national importance of primary education but not the immediate introduction of compulsion in education.
2. Recommended the policy of consolidation and improvement
3. Recommended a selective system for admission
4. Wanted the introduction of diversified courses leading to industrial and commercial careers after the middle stage and
5. Recommended that all efforts to be made in improving the university work in confining the university to its proper function of giving good advanced education to students who were fit to receive it and in fact making the university a more fruitful and less disappointing agency in the life of the community.

15.16 Wardha Scheme of Basic education 1937

The government of India act 1935 was put into operation in 1937 which introduced provincial Autonomy. Elections were held and the congress party came to power in nine provinces. The Haripura Congress Session gave the work of evolving a national scheme of education to Zakir Hussain. A scheme of education called basic education or Wardha Scheme was prepared. It contained a detailed syllabus for a number of crafts to be introduced in the schools with the main principles of learning through activity and manual productive work. It had plans for teachers training supervision, examination and from the implementation till India became independent. Between 1937 and 1949 ten new universities were set up at Travancore, Utkal, Sagar, Rajasthan, East Punjab, Gujarat, Poona, Roorkee, Kashmir And Baroda. There was a phenomenal increase in the number of colleges during 1940 and 1950. The number of colleges rose from 425 in 1940 -41 to 593 in 1945-46 and to 1949-50. The total student population in them during 1949-50 was 380,837.

15.17 Sargent Plan of Education 1944

In 1944 the central advisory board of education drew up a national scheme of education. It was generally known as The Sargent Plan. Sir John Sargent was the educational adviser to the government of India. The plan aimed at setting up junior and senior basic schools for elementary and high school education, introduction of free and compulsory education for children between the ages 6 and 11. It recommended to abolition of intermediate courses and a school course of 6 years for pupils between the ages 11 and 17. It emphasized the diversification of school courses into a academic and technical and vocational. In another four years the independent government of India appointed a commission to report on Indian universities education.

Check your progress -3

1. Give an account of Indian education under British Rule.

15.18 Radhakrishnan Commission on University Education 1948-49

The Indian University education commission was appointed on 4 November 1948 and it was inaugurated by Maulana Abul Kalam Azad, minister for education, on 6 Dec. 1948., Dr. S.

Radhakrishnan was the Chairman of the Commission. The Commission submitted its report in 1949 and made the following recommendations.

- a) Rural universities should be established on the model of Santhiniketan and Jamia Millia.
- b) Government should allocate more funds for education.
- c) More scholarships and stipends should be given to the students.
- d) A college should not be allowed to admit more than one thousand students.
- e) Where the mother tongue was not the same as the regional language the federal language was to be medium of instruction. If the mother tongue and the federal language were the same, the students had to take another Indian classical or modern language.
- f) There should be no attempt at the hasty replacement of English as the medium of instruction for higher classes. The commission did not suggest any time limit.
- g) There should be no denominational or sectarian considerations.
- h) Co-education should be adopted in the secondary stage and then again in the college level.
- i) The standard of teaching profession should be raised. There were to be four classes of teachers for teaching college classes i.e. Instructors, Lecturers, Readers and Professors). Promotion from one category to another was to be solely on merit.

Thus, the post-independence period witness national building activity. Educational plans were executed carefully. There was qualitative and quantitative expansion of education in India.

15.19. Secondary Education Commission 1953

in order to reorganize secondary education in India, a commission was appointed on 23 September 1953 under the Chairmanship of Dr. A. Lakshmanaswamy Mudaliar which submitted its report on 29th August 1953. It ran to 250 pages. Its recommendations occupy a very important place in the history of secondary education in free India. The following were the strong points of its recommendations.

- a) It laid down that the aim of secondary education should be the inculcation of demo critic qualities among the students and moral and religious instruction should be imparted in the schools to build their character and disciplines.

- b) It suggested that the period of secondary education should be 7 years which may start at the age of 11 and finish at 17 or 18
- c) It suggested diversification of courses at the secondary stage and the establishment of multi-purpose schools.
- d) It recommended one year of pre-university course after the high school stage and the abolition of intermediate classes.
- e) Care of physical welfare of students, improvements in the salary scales and conditions of service of the teachers were the other recommendations.

The central government showed interest in higher education during the Nehru Era. There was a large extension of technical education, and establishment of the Indian institutes of technology at 5 places in India and setting up of Research centres ranging from food grain and fertilizers to atomic research spread widely and became popular. Science and technology were given importance. General universities also grew in numbers. There was surplus of graduates by 1964 despite more job opportunities generated by the growth of industry and commerce. The literacy rate which was 15 percent in 1947 rose to about 25 to 30 percent by the end of Nehru Era.

15.20 Acharya Narendradev Commission 1953

It is necessary here to mention about the Narendra Dev Commission of Uttar Pradesh in 1953. It laid emphasis on the discipline of the students and gave importance to administration of educational institutions and the syllabus and the reforms which were to be introduced at various stages. It also laid stress upon the discipline and religious education.

15.21 Kothari Commission 1964- 66

The government of India appointed on 14th July 1964 an education commission under the president ship of Dr. D. S. Kothari. He was to advise government on the national pattern of education and on the general principles and policies for the development of education at all stages and in all aspects (except legal and medical education)

The commission observed in its report that education has to be used as a powerful instrument of social, economic and political change. It also stressed the need for a revolution

in education which in turn will set in motion the much desired social economic and Cultural Revolution. Its recommendations were many and the important ones among them are:

- a) Introduction of work experience and social service as integral parts of general education.
- b) Emphasis to be given on moral education and on the inculcation of a sense of social responsibility.
- c) Vocationalisation of secondary education;
- d) Strengthening of centres of advanced study and universities which aim to achieve highest international standard;
- e) Stress on the training and quality of teachers for school;
- f) Education for agricultural and research in agriculture and allied sciences should be given a high priority in the scheme of educational reconstruction.

15.22 National Education Policy

The government of India adopted a resolution on education in 1968. It was based upon the recommendations of the Kothari commission. The resolution emphasized a. Free and compulsory education up to the age 14. b. Improve the status of teachers and their emoluments. c. Adoption of the three-language formula and development of regional languages. d. Equalization of education of science and research. e. Development of education for agriculture and industry. f. Improvement of quality and production of inexpensive text books and g. Investment of 6 percent of national income on education.

Check your progress-4

1. Write an essay on the growth of education after independence?

15.23 Education and its impact on society

Westernisation is a process whereby traditional long-established societies come under the influence of western (European and somewhat American) culture in such matters as industry, technology, economics, lifestyle, food and moral and cultural values. It has been a pervasive and accelerating influence across the world in the last few centuries. Imperialism and colonization over the centuries culminated in the two world wars of the 20th century. Many smaller states,

created by former colonial powers (mainly European) gained independence and adopted some aspects of western culture. Even before that the impact of western education had resulted in westernisation of India. Modern western education had exercised profound influence on Indian society and culture.

15.23.1. Impact of Society

Growth of education in India brought several changes in the society. it set in new forces which weakened the traditional order. The spread of western education broke the intellectual monopoly of upper castes in India. Equality of man came to be recognized. The western concept of liberalism found support among the educated Indians. It led to the demand for reform in administration and policy. Thus, the contribution of western education lay mainly in three things. First, it broke intellectual monopoly of the Brahmins by opening the doors of education to all classes. Secondly, it led to the emergence of professional classes who championed the cause of liberal reforms. Thirdly, equality of opportunity enabled the technically qualified persons of artisan community and the Brahmin community to enter into different avocations. It set in an unprecedented degree of occupational mobility which helped to increase social mobility. Growth of education also brought changes in the style of dressing manners, attitudes and relationship.

15.23.2. Birth of Socio- religious reform movement

Study of European sciences and literature broadened the knowledge of the Indians. English language broke the linguistic barrier that prevented the coming together of the Indians. Educated Indians were influenced by the rationalistic ideas of the west. It paved the way for the birth of the social and religious reform movements in India. Researches into the culture past of India brought Hindu revivalists' movement.

15.23.3. Rule of Law

The influence of the modern legal and judicial systems went deeper still. Those who studied law became legal practitioners. They not only acted as protectors of persons and property but also the watch dogs of civil liberty. They served their clients regardless of caste or religious persuasion. Rule of law replaced customs and conventions in the society.

15.23.4. Democracy

Growth of modern education opened the great treasure of democratic idealism of the modern west to the Indians. Almost all the leaders of Indian nationalism came from the educated classes of the Indian society. The nationalist movement fought for widening of franchise, freedom of press, speech and association, representative government and executive responsible for the people. The need for social, cultural and political unity in India was felt by the educated intelligentsia and they preached for it.

15.23.5. Awakening

Educated Indians began to develop broad outlook and perspective. It enabled them to understand the world developments. They began to compare the economic developments in the other parts of the world and the Indian situation. Economic writers demanded the promotion of technical education, agricultural improvement and rapid industrialization. Thus an awakening dawned upon the Indians to the reality of the situation.

15.23.6. Development of Vernacular language

Vernacular literature began to develop as a result of the growth of education in India. The introduction of printing presses assisted their further growth. Books in vernaculars embodying western thought and scientific information were written by the Indian intellectuals. It helped the non-English knowing literary section of the people to gather wide knowledge of the world. Some of them spread new ideas and information among the illiterate. It helped the broadening of the vision and enriching of the knowledge of the common people.

Check your progress-5

1. Analyse the impact of education on Indian society.

15.24. Impact of Westernisation

Westernisation which was one of the results of modern western education had its profound influence in all walks of life.

Society

It altered the very structure of the society. It broke the traditional joint family system and nuclear family system came into existence. Moreover, it paved way for inter-caste marriage.

There developed a broad outlook instead of narrow mindedness, birthday celebrations and celebrations of marriage anniversary are nothing but the results of westernization. People who lived in thatched huts and baked brick houses started living in concrete houses with modern amenities like bath attached bed room.

Position of Women

Women who were kept in obscurity are advancing in all walks of life. Nowadays we are witnessing the progress of women on par with men folk. Importance is given to the female education. Illiteracy, ignorance and superstition were the legacies of womenfolk. But gone are the dark days. Then improvement of women is tremendous for which Kalpana Chawla was a fitting example. Divorce has become the order of the day. The institution of marriage is losing its importance.

Food

The impact of westernization on food habits is worth mentioning. People started taking tea, coffee, etc. As soon as they get up from the bed. There is a mushroom growth of fast food restaurants. Pizzas have become the order of the day. Drinking liquor is one of the worst effects of westernization. Tinned food is very common and popular. Bread, bun, butter and jam dominate every day's life almost all sections of the people.

Dress

Copying western style, men are wearing pants, shirts, jeans and tie. They also wear shoes and they have hair cutting. Women are also influenced in recent times. They wear jeans, tops and tights. On top of everything the wearing of safari has become the status symbol, which is unsuitable to our tropical country.

Habits

The important impact of westernization is seen in the habits. The usage of brush and paste, applying powder, lipstick, perfumes, etc. Are some of them. While seeing one another we used to greet them with hello and while departing we say bye.

Entertainment

As a result of westernization valorous games like cockfight, bullfight, and archery were replaced by Tennis, Golf, Ball Badminton and squash. The old games are no more heard of and seen. On European model we see so many clubs, recreation clubs, card playing, chess, gambling, etc.

Check your progress-6

1. Analyse the impact of westernization on Indian society.

15.25 Let us sum up

In this lesson we have studied the development and growth of western modern education at different stages and westernization. Added to it the impact of education and westernization on Indian society and culture is also studied.

15.26 Answers to check your progress

Check your progress-1

See from 15.4 to 15.4.4

Check your progress-2

See section 15.5 to 15.9

Check your progress-3

See section 15.10 to 15.17

Check your progress-4

See from 15.18 to 15.21

Check your progress-5

See from 15.23

Check your progress-6

See from 15.24.

LESSON – 16

DEVELOPMENT OF ART, ARCHITECTURE, MUSIC AND DANCE

Learning Objectives

After learning this lesson, you will be able to

- Explain the development of art under the British rule
- Narrate the changes and development in the architecture
- Discuss about the music and dance under the British rule.

Structure

16.1 Introduction

16.2 Indian culture under the British rule

16.3 Painting

16.3.1. Ravi Varma

16.3.2. Havell

16.3.3. Abanindra Nath Tagore

16.3.4. Nandalal Bose

16.3.5. Sarada Charan Ukil

16.3.6. Mohammed Abdul Rahman

16.3.7. Recent Trends in Indian Painting

16.4 Architecture

16.4.1. The development of a new phase –Victorian style

16.5 Music

16.6 Dance

16.6.1. Bharathanatyam

16.6.2. Kuchipudi

16.6.3. Kathakali

16.6.4. Kathak**16.6.5. Manipuri****16.6.6. Odissi****16.6.7. Miscellaneous Dance****16.7 Let us sum up****16.8 Answers to check your progress****16.1 Introduction**

In this lesson let us learn about the art, architecture, music and dance under the British rule.

16.2 Indian culture under the British rule

The culture of India is rich and varied. In different epochs of her ancient and medieval history. India saw magnificent achievements of her people in the spheres of art, architecture, music and dance and all other allied branches of aesthetic creations. These contributions constituted the artistic heritage of our land. During the eighteenth century, an age of political decay and dissolution, the country witnessed stagnation in its cultural growth. No great buildings were erected as the rulers were unstable, weak and financially incapable of undertaking great plans of construction. The creative urges were lost in the politico-economic confusion. The new power which began to rise after Plessey remained busy in conquests and commerce. Its attitude towards Indian culture was alien and indifferent. The class of nobility which it created was superficially aristocratic, without having any vital role to play in the sphere of culture.

After the political conditions settled into stability, the traditional cultural life began to reassert and re-establish itself. But in the meantime, the influence of the west had been felt in many spheres of life. Throughout the 19th century Indian and western systems came nearer to each other in the fields of art and music. The new influences were neither an unmixed blessing nor unwelcome. In the tide of time, they came in, like many external influences of the past and ultimately became merged with the indigenous systems.

16.3 Painting

When British were busy conquering eastern India, the art of the Kangra valley was yet in a thriving state. In the hill area of the Punjab and Jammu, the artisans remained and developed Mughal style of painting with Hindu themes as their subject matter. In many other areas of northern India too, the art of painting flourished during the latter half of the 18th century. But, on the whole an atmosphere of decadence spread over the whole country because of political uncertain. That was the time, when the western influence began to penetrate into the field of art.

The English traders were attracted by the paintings of Indian artists and the Indian artists were interested attached by the pictures brought into India by the foreigners. The company's merchants began to procure items of Indian arts and crafts. Simultaneously the interested persons among them drew the attention of the Indian artists to the technique of water –colour-painting. Gradually the company's servants created a demand for Indian paintings, painted according to their choice. Artists were required to depict Indian life and scenes but in a medium to the foreigners liking. In such circumstances, artists were required to imitate the English style of painting. Art critics found their tendency dangerous and to them it was the beginning of the degradation of Indian art since any imitation was suicidal. The company painters worked to satisfy the needs of their new masters for some economic gain.

When combined the western technique and Indian form brought about a synthetic style of a raw standard. To that school, no artist of genius belonged. Therefore, worthy works of art did not appear. In spite of the realistic approaches in art, which the new influence brought at, the process of its assimilation into Indian miniature painting did not work well. But the new trend continued to assert itself for a century. During that period the British power was consolidated and English education was introduced. In the general educational policy of western learning the government established 'Art School at Bombay, Calcutta, Madras and Lahore about the middle of the 19th century. In these schools, the western methods of art remained the basic subjects of study and were paid greater attention. To the schools did not improve art in any real sense but on the other hand, they institutionalized art in a commercial way. Traditional Indian paintings began to decline rapidly.

Westernization paved the way for a radical change of artistic taste, and a style emerged that represented the adjustment of traditional artists to new fashions and demands. British colonial rule had a great impact on Indian art. As a whole, the European advent was marked by a relative insensitivity to native art traditions; former Indian patrons of art became less wealthy and influential, and Western art became more ubiquitous as the British Empire established schools of art in major cities, such as the Bombay Art Society in 1888. The Company style of paintings, for example, became common, created by Indian artists working for European patrons of the East India Company. By 1858, the British government took over the task of administration of India under the British Raj. The fusion of Indian traditions with European style at this time became evident in architectural styles. Toward the end of the 19th century, rising nationalism attempted a conscious revival of Indian art.

16.3.1. Ravi Varma

Towards the end of the 19th century one notable Indian artist Ravi Varma tried to re-establish Indian art through western methods of technique of oil painting from the famous European portrait painter Theodore Jensen, who visited Ravi Varma's palace in Travancore. The artist's chief concern was to re reproduce Indian life and scenes as well as the traditional mythological subject matter in oil painting in the western style. Ravi Varma, no doubt made a great venture which attained considerable success but to critics, the Europeanization of Indian art could not be of any lasting value. After Ravi Varma, his innovations and examples did not inspire other artists to follow the line or develop the trend.

16.3.2. Havell

E.B. Havell, a teacher of the Madras school of arts, came to the inevitable conclusion that the artistic heritage of the country should be revived and that India should be given the benefits of her own art system, resting on traditional foundation. He started experimenting his ideas at Calcutta. It was due to his noble endeavours that the seeds were sown for a new art movement for the revival of the lost values and for the revitalization of the indigenous system. The movement reminded the Indian artists of the styles of their ancestors and inspired them to look ahead with confidence.

The old and new could be developed together. Another achievement of Havell was to bring to the notice of the world the rich heritage of Indian art and architecture. His three-great works - Indian sculpture and painting, Indian architecture and ideals of Indian art - served the purpose.

16.3.3. Abanindra Nath Tagore

The pioneer of the new and distinct school of Indian painters was Abanindranath Tagore. His work was twofold-to rediscover the best in the Indian art of the ancient and medieval eras, and to- regenerate art in its modern setting. From the early age, he developed a devotion to art with nature as the theme for his drawings. European artists, an Italian artist, a Norwegian artist and an English artist inspired him. A look to the inner and emotional themes in his country's artistic past. Here was his originality and boldness of character. He depicted Krishnalila in a series of excellent pictures. During the 20th century he came into contact with Havell and was made the Vice- Principal of the government school of art at Calcutta. In reviving the spirit of the lost art, Abanindra decided to use the ancient artist's supreme mental weapons- emotional feeling. His paintings narrated a philosophy and an impulse. His famous picture 'Shah Jahan Looking at Tae Taj' depicted the very depth of the artists emotion in lines and colour. Among other masterpieces of him were Buddha and Sujata, Tear Drops on a Lotus Leaf and Queen of the forest. A new school of artists began to emerge to represent Indianness in all its vivid meaning to their creations.

The new school contained a number of distinguished artists like Nandalal Bose, Surendranath Gangooly, Sarada Saran Ukil, Hakim Khan, K. Venkatappa, Asit Kumar Halia, Abdul Rehman Chaghtai, Mukul Chandra Dey and others.

16.3.4. Nandalal Bose

Nandalal Bose was a man of deep spiritual convictions and the artist to him was moulded by spiritual instincts. Historical themes were reoriented with meaningful originality and also painted pictures of the real life around. The traditional mode of Indian painting as represented at Ajanta. His art was remarkable for its bold lines and simple colour work. His masterpieces include Uma's Tapasya, Natir Puja. The Buddha carrying a lame goat, Krishna and Arjuna,

Pranam. Spring Shiva and Parvati and Gopi Nandalala's experiments with sketches were most successful.

16.3.5. Sarada Charan Ukil

Sarada Charan Ukil ventured to open up new horizons for Indian painting while trying to revive past traditions. In depicting the human form, he depended on idealistic conception rather than on natural features. To him art possessed limitless horizons for new approaches both in themes and in techniques. He depicted the life of the Buddha in a series of pictures. These pictures manifested the idealism and mysticism of artist's mind. To the modern school of art, Sarada's contributions were original, appealing and valuable.

16.3.6. Mohammed Abdul Rahman

Muhammed Abdul Rehman's art contained romantic themes in pleasant colour schemes. Kshitindranath Majumdar achieved considerable success in giving art newness in the context of Indian themes. Among other artists of the new school Ravindranath Tagore tried to innovate new experiments in painting in an original way but the influence of western art on his works was evident. Art like poetry is the creation of the individual, springing from the depth of his emotion. It was art for the sake of art.

16.3.7. Recent Trends in Indian Painting

Indian art in more recent times have assumed a more complex character. The old themes themselves can be given a new orientation. The art of today speaks a language of its own, conveys a new philosophy and reveals new thoughts. Thus, art is becoming simplistic in sense, rather than merely representative of an object.

In the wide and diverse aspects of art such as idealism, realism naturalism and impressionism, the artists of modern India have kept pace with the trends of modern times while the heritage of the land cannot be abandoned. Indian art has shown nevertheless a synthesized spirit in representing world phenomena in the broader perspective of human civilization.

Check your progress -1

1. What do you know about the developments of art during the British period?
2. Write a short note on Ravi Varma.
3. Write a short note on Havell.
4. Write a short note on Nandalal Bose.

16.4 Architecture

The establishment of the British Empire greatly influenced the architecture and culture of India and led to a fusion of styles and techniques. As with the Mughals, architecture under European colonial rule became an emblem of power designed to endorse the occupying power. Numerous European countries invaded India and created architectural styles reflective of their ancestral and adopted homes. The European colonizers created architecture that symbolized their mission of conquest, dedicated to the state or religion. Among the key British architects of this time were Robert Fellowes Chisholm, Charles Mant, Henry Irwin, William Emerson, George Wittet, and Frederick Stevens.

The Indo-Saracenic Revival

The Indo-Saracenic Revival (also known as Indo-Gothic, Mughal-Gothic, Neo-Mughal, or Hindu-Gothic) was an architectural style and movement by British architects in the late 19th century. It drew elements from native Indo-Islamic and Indian architecture and combined them with Gothic revival and Neo-Classical styles favoured in Britain. Public and government buildings, such as clock towers, courthouses, municipal buildings, colleges, and town halls, were often rendered on an intentionally grand scale, reflecting and promoting a notion of an invincible British Empire. Infrastructure was composed of iron, steel, and poured concrete and included domes, overhanging eaves, pointed arches, vaulted roofs, pinnacles, open pavilions, and pierced open arcading.

Every age conceived its architecture according to its need. The stupas, temples, palaces, ports, mosques, minarets and mausoleums which were built in great numbers in different epochs of ancient and medieval history, served the purpose of those times. The religious and devotional

urges of man were manifested in the building activities of the great monarchs who spent unlimited resources in constructing stupendous temples like Konark or great mosque like Jama Masjid. On the secular side the rulers of all times built their palaces, capitals and fortresses. India is one of the few countries in the world, famous for superb monuments in countless number, belonging almost to every epoch in history. The architectural heritage of the country is outstanding. Modern systems of government call for high courts and secretariats, parliaments and Universities. As the needs have changed, so too have the techniques of construction and the building materials employed different materials have in turn necessitated new designs in architecture.

Modern architecture has tried to relate itself to the life of the community in a purposive sense. It has become need-oriented. Beauty in simplicity has emerged as an appealing concept. The so-called functionalism has become a new doctrine in architecture. Science and technology with modern engineering skill has given modern architecture an absolutely new shape. In sheer size and height of modern structures can inspire awe. Most modern buildings being public institutions, they have assumed appearances of a practical nature. Above all, there has been benefit of planned construction.

Modern architecture is still in a process of evolution. In India today, the pace of construction is rapid. The Indian architects and engineers have tried to inculcate a new phase in the history of India's architecture.

16.4.1. The development of a new phase –Victorian style

A change in the traditional style of architecture in India was first initiated by the Europeans, who came to India for trade and established their settlements at various places. In these settlements they built European style houses beside the factories. When their foothold become strong and the number of residents increased, they began the construction of more durable structures, such as strong fortresses and imposing churches. The forts had no architectural significance but the churches had.

In the 18th century European type houses were built at many places. Official buildings were built by the Englishmen in their private capacity. They failed to achieve anything spectacular in their attempt to establish a new style.

With the rise of the British Empire and with the introduction of many things, there began to develop in India the Victorian type of architecture. Throughout the length and breadth of India, public and private buildings, offices and churches were constructed. But the Victorian style itself being imitative. The Victorian architects in India further debased themselves by attempting to copy oriental styles while trying to construct public buildings. Big brick work building with iron support and cloned roofs represented Victorian architecture.

Among the edifices of the Victorian era, the churches of Calcutta and Madras, the free hall in Karachi, the cathedrals at Shimla and Lahore, the Lahore high court and the Calcutta high court are noteworthy. But some of these edifices can be regarded as a great piece of architectures.

In the 20th century the Indo- British style in general did not show any qualitative improvement even though the number of structures increased rapidly. At the end of the Victorian era, India entered into the era of national awakening and movement. The architecture represented the character of the time, a combination of the imperial needs and the national urges.

The British wanted to perpetrate the memory of Queen Victoria in India by erecting a Memorial Hall in her name. But the style of that massive structure was to be oriental enough to satisfy the Indian mind. This again was an unsound step based on a wrong artistic hypothecation. The architects of the Victoria memorial hall could not make it a superb piece of Indo-British style. The Indian characteristics which were superimposed on the edifice did not make it look like the Taj Mahal nor even a poor replica. Similar attempts to imitate oriental features, while constructing the Prince of Wales Museum at Bombay did not prove successful.

A great opportunity came to the British ruler for the construction of grand building in India when it was decided in 1911 to transfer the capital from Calcutta to Delhi. The chief architect Sir Edwin Lutyens and his colleagues Sir Edward Baker at first prepared designs in the Neo-Roman style. But it was considered as unsuitable and inappropriate to the Indian background. Suggestions were advanced to give to India a capital representing the traditional architectural styles of the land. Then the British architects set themselves to study the Buddhist, Hindu and

Islamic features while redrawing their plan for Delhi. A curious mixture emerged out with a huge dome on the lines of a Buddhist Stupa and most buildings represented some elements of Hindu ornamentation or Islamic symmetry. It was a unique experiment to synthesize the different styles of Indian architecture within a broad European fabric – that simplicity, modernity and utility were compromised considerably for the purpose of so-called beauty and structural majesty.

Most of the structures appeared massive, heavy and strong but also congested, close and even medieval. Thus, experiment neither revived in India the lost values of her architectural glory nor did it introduce radically new edifices for the purpose of newer times.

The structures of Delhi are the finest specimens of the architecture of the imperial period. The vice regal palace and the secretariats, among other edifices showed grand and majestic appearance, thanks are due to Sir John Marshall for designing beautiful gardens in order to revive the spirit of the Mughal days. (the capital was constructed mainly during the 30's of this century).

The people of India were conscious of the need for a national style of architecture against the background of national needs. Big universities and other public institution were being constructed by the endeavours of the people themselves. There was a need to shape their structures in the light of the artistic traditions of the country keeping in view the purpose they were intended to serve. The desire for revivalism was praiseworthy but mere superimpositions of certain designs such as arches, brackets, columns and ornamented doors or windows on modern buildings did not really revive the spirit of the architectural heritage. No adequate thought was paid as to how best the old Indian styles could be incorporated into modern buildings. As such, attempts at revivalism only ended in making a caricature of the old artistic features.

When the independence of India, the history of architecture entered in to a new phase. New state capitals, like Bhubaneswar and Chandigarh, had to be constructed. The coming of Ferro Concrete not merely revolutionised existing architectural concepts all over the world but forced upon the different countries a uniform pattern of super constructions. It was only the climate of the different regions which called for some necessary local variations. In the light of these new developments, Indian architecture began to assume a new shape.

Architecture during early British rule in India comprised colossal stone and wood structures, erected during the 17th century. In the emerging stages, British viceroy-generals like Robert Clive managed huge efforts to build such architectural wonders in the essential port cities of India. Early British architectural design composed of charts and outlined plans already erected successfully back in England. This period witnessed the shipping of skilled British architects and young men, equipped with clever motives to make Indian artistic design much like western modes. Indian educated class or the comparatively poorer class did not possess the amount of talent that their English masters were looking for. As such, architectures were planned by the already utilised British structural wonders.

British Architecture in Kolkata

Architectural developments of **Kolkata**, formerly Calcutta, during British rule in India were overwhelming in every aspect of daily existence. Reconstruction of Kolkata during British rule can be called a mandatory affair, which the British had to accomplish in their rule of colonialism. Kolkata was the erstwhile capital city under English administration, paving the way for architectural renovations and reconstructions. To suit the taste of passing years, several monuments were demolished to be rebuilt. Such was the impact that natives even tried to change their architectural tastes to a British one. **Lord Wellesley** and **Lord Curzon** can be called the harbingers of architectural overhauling in this extremely momentous city. Kolkata was perhaps the most eventful city, which was turned into a complete colonial and westernised place, just to suit the tastes of British masters. The government house falls into this category, as well as the historical building up of St. Paul's Cathedral, Kolkata.

British Architecture in Mumbai

Architectural developments of Mumbai, formerly Bombay, during British rule in India were significant, standing tall in their regal and neo-classical look. Churches, town halls and several other structures, bearing semblance with England counterparts paved a fresh way for Mumbai. Mumbai completely metamorphosed into a polished city, much to intimidate Kolkata.

British Architecture in New Delhi

Architectural developments of New Delhi during British rule in India were tremendous still to this day, if one leaves aside the Mughal architectures. The pace and momentum with

which British generals took up the task to reconstruct Delhi was indeed praiseworthy. As New Delhi was declared the capital city after Kolkata, the imperial city was never the same again, adopting a perfect colonial appearance. War memorials were built up in honour; churches of gothic architecture came into being. Architects were called from England for this sole purpose of supreme importance to generals.

British Architecture in Chennai

Architectural developments of **Chennai**, formerly Madras, during British rule in India comprised a massive overhaul in every Christian architectural creation that was present in the port city. Churches were primarily taken into account, giving them a clean English look, deriving inspiration from their London counterpart. Even bungalows were rebuilt in certain areas to suit the high-flying style. Massive banquet halls came into being for official evening functions, every nook emoting out a classical feel.

Later Development of British Architecture of India

During 19th century, Architectural developments in India by British consisted of the rise of bungalow styled architecture from a plain native styled common thatched hut. 19th century was a significant advancement in British Empire, making way for such improvisations. The classical, the gothic look was heavily witnessed in every English creation. As such, hill stations started gaining momentum as admired outings. British military monuments in India were predominated with a lone guiding factor, that being the sublime increase in military monuments. The churches of Kolkata and Chennai were the foremost cities where such buildings took place. Exquisite etchings of slain soldiers and officers still do commemorate these churches erected by the British.

Indian art and craft during British rule were extremely praiseworthy in the attempts made by both British talents and later by educated natives. The overwhelming participation and amount of interest shown by British rulers in Indian art and craft was surprising in its inaugural issues. The British even displayed such enthusiasm as to build up schools precisely for the specified purpose. Schools and exhibitions were established in the primary cities of Chennai, Kolkata and even Lahore. The oriental look had much appealed the western tastes of the British, taking pride place in British museums.

Check your progress -2

1. Give an account of the development of architecture during the British rule.

16.5 Music

Music has been a vital part of Indian culture. From times immemorial it developed many traditions of permanent value. Whether India has retained all the musical formations in Ragas and Talas or whether many of these creations have been lost in the course of time is a matter of conjecture. The extent and nature of foreign influences on Indian music is another matter of considerable importance which needs research.

One has to remember the darker days of the post Aurangzeb's period. He himself discouraged music. The disintegration of the Mughal Empire dispersed the musicians from the capital but in another sense, it was good for music that they found a place in the provincial capitals where independent Nawabs began to hold their courts.

In the latter half of the 18th century it was in South India that music found an opportunity to flourish and develop. King Tuljaji (1763-1787) the Maratha ruler of Tanjore offered his patronages to musicians from all parts of India and made his court a renowned centre of musical culture. The northern and southern systems found a synthesizing atmosphere.

Tyagaraja (1759-1847), Muthuswami Dikshitar (1776-1835) and Shyama Sastri (1762–1827) are regarded as Musical trinity of South Indian Music. The Trinity of Carnatic music, also known as The Three Jewels of Carnatic music, refer to the outstanding trio of these composer-musicians of Carnatic music in the 18th century. Prolific in composition, the Trinity of Carnatic music are known for creating a new era in the history of Carnatic music by bringing about a noticeable change in what was the existing Carnatic music tradition. Compositions of the Trinity of Carnatic music are recognized as being distinct in style, and original in handling ragas. All three composers were born in Thiruvarur, formerly part of Thanjavur District in Tamil Nadu. Along with Purandaradasa, the Pitamaha or Grandfather of Carnatic music, the trinity are considered in a way the greatest musicians and composers of the tradition. Muthuswami Dikshitar mainly composed in Sanskrit, while Tyagaraja and Syama Sastri mainly composed in Telugu. The Trinity of Carnatic music composed new ragas and talas, and had a remarkable ability to introduce innovations within the same raga.

Compositions of Syama Sastri in 'apoorva' ragas like Chinthamani, and Kalagada evidence his originality and genius in discovering new forms in Carnatic music. The creative ability of Syama Sastri is possibly best example in his concert-contest against Kesavvaya, a great Carnatic musician from Bobbili. During this contest which took place at the court of the king of Thanjavur, although Kesavayya sang a rare raga followed by a tana in different jathis and gathis, Syama Sastri reproduced similar tana varieties, and to the delight of the audience, went further to introduce other varieties which were not known to Kesavvaya

The height of musical attainments at Tanjore was marked with the great singer Tyagaraja (1759-1847) who gave a lead to Indian music. He was a poet of remarkable originality. The melodious Kirtanas which he sang had a lasting impact on the musicians and music lovers of his time and long after him. In the story of music, he could claim a period of his own and it is said that the Adhunikā or the modern Sangita attained its full stature during that period.

Thyagaraja sang devotional songs and made music emotional in a deeper sense. To the development of music his contribution was the introduction of a kind of Sangati. Thyagaraja left a school of disciples who developed and spread the art of the master in succeeding generations.

Tyagaraja, who was totally immersed in his devotion to Rama and led the most spartan way of life without bothering in the least for the comforts of the world, did not take any steps to systematically codify his vast musical output. Rangaramanuja Iyengar, a leading researcher on Carnatic music, in his work *Kṛitī Manimalai*, has described the situation prevailing at the time of death of Tyagaraja. It is said that a major portion of his incomparable musical work was lost to the world due to natural and man-made calamities. Usually Tyagaraja used to sing his compositions sitting before deity manifestations of Lord Rama, and his disciples noted down the details of his compositions on palm leaves. After his death, these were in the hands of his disciples, then families descending from the disciples. There was not a definitive edition of Tyagaraja's songs.

The songs he composed in chaste Telugu, were widespread in their popularity, because of the ease with which they could be sung in those days. Musical experts such as Kancheepuram Nayana Pillai, Simizhi Sundaram Iyer and Veenai Dhanammal saw the infinite possibilities for

imaginative music inherent in his compositions and they systematically notated the songs available to them. Subsequently, indefatigable researchers like K. V. Srinivasa Iyengar and Rangaramanuja Iyengar made an enormous effort to contact various teachers and families who possessed the palm leaves. K. V. Srinivasa Iyengar brought out *Adi Sangita Ratnavali* and *Adi Tyagaraja Hridhayam* (in three volumes). Rangaramanuja Iyengar published *Kriti Mani Malai* in two volumes. Out of 24,000 songs said to have been composed by him, about 700 songs remain now but scholars are skeptical about numbers like 24,000 since there is no biographical evidence to support such claims. Tyagaraja also composed two musical plays in Telugu, the *Prahalada Bhakti Vijayam* and the *Nauka Charitam*. He also composed a number of simple devotional pieces appropriate for choral singing.

The impact of Western Music on Tyagaraja Kritis

It is extremely unlikely that Tyagaraja could have been oblivious to the instruments used in western music or to tunes of that genre. By the time the Tyagaraja was in his thirties, Western Music was an art form to which patronage was being extended from the highest quarter. According to Dr. S Seetha's *Tanjore as a Seat of Music*, as early as 1775, when Tyagaraja was just seven, notebooks containing western staff notation and theory of music were being filled in for the benefit of 'His Majesty the Raja of Tanjore.' That was when Tulaja II was the ruler. Under his son Sarabhoji, this was to rise to greater heights. He set up the Tanjore Palace Band and to quote from Seetha again, "collected western musical instruments like violin, clarinet, dulcimer, piano, German flute, tambourine and harpsichord."

The king composed music for the band and also entered into extensive correspondence with foreigners on theory as well as practical aspects. The Darbar Bakshi, Varahappa Dikshita Pandita, became an expert of sorts on western music, going to the extent of giving full-fledged violin performances in that style, for the benefit of audiences in Madras. He was also proficient on the piano. Not surprisingly, he was appointed the superintendent of all the palace musicians.

Influence of new music

Tyagaraja, of course, had little to do with the court. But considering that the ruler and his entourage spent much of the summer months in Tiruvaiyaru, it is quite likely that the composer

had the opportunity to listen to some of the new music that was performed. And he could not have remained uninfluenced. At least three pieces of Tyagaraja demonstrate the impact of Western Music.

One of these songs has a martial gait, conjuring up visions of an army on the move. All three songs have flat notes dominating, with minimum of gamakas or graces, a strong characteristic of orchestral western music.

The fiddle, as the violin was known in the 19th century, could also not have been unknown to Tyagaraja. At least one of his disciples Walajahpet Krishnaswami Bhagavatar became proficient in it, though it is not clear if he trained on it while learning from the composer. Krishnaswami Bhagavatar's familiarity with the instrument would come in useful in the closing years of the 19th century. That was when A.M. Chinnaswami Mudaliar, retired Budget Manager of the Madras Secretariat, embarked on notating Carnatic music in staff or western notation. Tyagaraja's songs were the first to be so written. It was left to Krishnaswami Bhagavatar to check if the notations were correct and some of the proofs so corrected have survived intact in the Walajahpet manuscripts, now with the Saurashtra Sabha.

Later, when cinema came about, the first songs were based on Tyagaraja's tunes, with lyrics by Papanasam Sivan. And they had western style orchestration.

Muthuswami Dikshitar (1776-1835) and Shyama Sastri (1762–1827), were two other great musicians of South India. The fame of Muthuswami lay in venturing a new form of Indian notation which makes use of the different vowel syllables to indicate the various Vikrits of each Svaram.

A famous contemporary of Thyagaraja was Govinda Marar of Travancore. His originality and reputation lay in singing a song in Shatkala.

Western Music of Mutthuswami Dikshitar

A repertoire of "lesser-known" compositions based on western musical ideas attributed to the orthodox composer Dikshitar. A set of 39 compositions—all based on colonial tunes that came to India with the British East India Company written by Dikshitar. **While the Dikshitar's family lived in Manali, a Zamindari near Madras, the family enjoyed the patronage of the**

Zamindar Muddukrishna Mudaliyar and his son Venkatakrishna Mudaliar (sometimes referred to as Chinnaswami). The Zamindars were closely connected with the East India Company as its Dubash (interpreters); and in that capacity they often called on Fort St. George the seat of the Company in South India. Since the Zamindars were reputed art connoisseurs, they were regularly invited to Fort St. George to listen to the European Airs played by the Irish bands. The bands played simple Celtic marching tunes, lilting melodies, easy on the drums and bagpipes and flutes.

The zamindars would sometimes take along with them the Dikshitar brothers, who were in their teens, to listen to the “English” bands. That was how Muthuswami Dikshitar and his younger brother Baluswami came to gain familiarity with the Western music. During this association, it is said, that at the suggestion of Col. Browne who was in the service of the East India Company, Muthuswami Dikshitar composed the text in Sanskrit and Telugu for well-known Western tunes. He also composed other songs in Sanskrit and Telugu based on Western notes. The collection of these compositions numbering about forty later came to be known as “Nottuswara Sahithya”. Nottu is Telugu/Tamil transformation of the word Note. It is a unique genre of music. The way the composer took western music tunes and set Sanskrit lyrics for them is a fascinating study. Two stalwarts of the Diskhitar lineage — Vadivelu and Baluswami Dikshitar — are accredited with transforming the violin into a Carnatic instrument and it is likely that the nottuswaras must have helped.

The most famous Prince singer was Maharaja Swathi Thirunal who composed his songs in as many as six Indian languages- Sanskrit, Marathi, Hindustan, Tamil, and Telugu and Malayalam. A new touch was given to the musical system during the beginning of the 19th century in North India at Patna, Muhammed Rezza, a gifted critic of music brought out a book in 1813, it had a profound lasting effect on Hindustani music.

In Rajasthan, Maharaja Pratap Singh of Jaipur (1779-1804) was great patron of music. A valuable work entitled Sangita Sara was brought out by him.

During the 19th century in different parts of India, the traditional musical systems continued to survive with or without patronage.

At Lucknow which was a traditional centre of musicians. Singers and dancer lived. The art of music continued to thrive at Banaras due to the religious character of the place which

kept the temple music going from generation to generation. A novel feature was the playing of the Nanbat (a typical Islamic instrument played at the courts of the Muslim Kings) in front of the Hindu sacred places notably the temple of Visweswar and the Dasaaswamedha ghat, there were hereditary temple musicians in places like Mathura and Vrindavan. Even the beggars of Vrindavan sang melodious songs in a professional way. Benares and Lucknow were reputed for light music too. When the Europeans came to these centres, they liked the light music of the type of Taza-Ba-Taza and Hilli-Milipatna. The musicians at Vrindavan also sang Thumri song.

In the latter half of the 19th century Baroda produced remarkable musician in Mowha Buksh who acquired all India recognition. He was a master in playing the Veena and Jaltarang. In Gujarat a new type of emotional song on spiritual themes called a Zicree became immensely popular and gradually spread to other parts of the country.

In madras presidency, the music of southern style retained its vitality more vigorously than elsewhere. Neither the Mohammadan music nor the western styles could influence the Carnatic Music. The Carnatic Music retained what is called then elaborate system of solemnization and rhythmic arrangements. Madras also abounded with folk songs of different kinds. It was said of the southern people that they had songs for every event in life. The Tamil, Malayalam and Telugu languages are rich with ballads, devotional songs and love songs.

In Orissa, Puri was a place of sacred music from early medieval days, being a great centre of Hinduism. The Devadasis sang melodious songs and maintained their skill in musical performances in a rigid manner. The Kirtans in the streets of Puri were performed as a matter of daily routine. In rural Orissa the Jatras and Palas were highly popular. In the Sambalpur area a new type of music called Sambalpuri was gradually taking shape with elements of adhurak songs mixed with simple folk music.

Amritsar being the religious centre of the Sikhs perpetrated the traditional devotional songs and even perfected the old styles in a more appealing manner. The Tappa songs were very popular.

The European impact on Indian music could not be in any way deep and meaningful. They did not touch the fundamentals of music. Towards the second half of the 19th century, in

the presidency cities of India the existence of a mixture of Indian and European music was felt, but these assimilative trends did not achieve maturity or perfection. The western type of stage drama required stage singing by the actors and actresses. The Christian churches which sang western hymns, confined their music to limited circles. The Indian Christians sang their hymns in the musical forms of their birth place. The European style could not penetrate that sphere either. The laws of western music are totally different from the laws of Indian music. The two could seldom unite. European musical instruments gradually entered into India. And found a market. Attempts were made to utilize them for the purpose of Indian music. But while they could be used for light music they could not be adjusted to the forms and styles of Indian classical music.

The impact of western music on Indian music and vice versa remained a remote possibility. Apart from the styles, modes and forms of music, the two systems differed in their very spirit. For us music has above all a transcendental significance. It disengages the spiritual from the happenings of life. It sings of the relationship of the human soul with the soul of things beyond. The world by day is like European music; a flowing concourse of vast harmony.

Music in India entered into a new place of consolidation as well as expansion. Rabindranath Tagore founded a great musical style –the Rabindra Sangeet. It was made universal but it retained Indian sentiments as its foundation.

All India music conference was organized in 1916 by the initiative of the Maharaja of Baroda. An immediate outcome of it was the establishment of all India music academies in 1919. Attempts were made to systematize the Hindustani ragas. It encouraged the establishment of musical institutions and organisations in different parts of India; a music academy was founded at Madras in 1928. It organizes annual music conferences.

The study of music was gradually introduced into the Indian universities. A number of universities such as Annamalai, Andhra, Allahabad, Benares, Lucknow, Nagpur and Punjab introduced courses in music.

Music has become a part and parcel of the day-to-day entertainment. The Radio and Television play music of light and classical varieties from numerous stations day and night. The

musicians and their music no longer belong to the Darbars of the Maharajas and Nawabs, but to the society at large.

Check your progress-3

1. Write about the status of Music under the British

16.6. Dance

Dance is one of the most ancient arts of Indian culture. At the beginning of the British period, the dances of India, like many other aspects of Indian culture such as art and architecture were in a state of decline. The Indian aristocracy had turned towards the west for new sources of entertainment. The dancers who performed a religious duty in the temples, felt shy in their profession. The temple dancers or the Devadasis came to be disliked. Western education and the disappearance of the medieval devotion gave a death blow to devotional dances. By the latter of the 19th century everywhere in India, all forms of classical dance were in a sad state of affairs and seemed to be on the verge of collapse.

16.6.1. Bharathanatyam

Bharata Natyam is one of the oldest dance forms of India. It was nurtured in the temples and courts of southern India since ancient times. Later it was codified and documented as a performing art in the 19th century by four brothers known as the Tanjore Quartet whose musical compositions for dance form the bulk of the Bharata Natyam repertoire even today. The art was handed down as a living tradition from generation to generation under the Devadasi system under which women were dedicated to temples to serve the deity as dancers and musicians forming part of the elaborate rituals. These highly talented artists and the male gurus (nattuvanars) were the sole repository of the art until the early 20th century when a renewal of interest in India's cultural heritage prompted the educated elite to discover its beauty. By this time the Devadasis had fallen upon evil days due to lack of state patronage and changed social mores. The revival of Bharata Natyam by pioneers such as E Krishna Iyer and Rukmini Devi Arundale brought the dance out of the temple precincts and onto the proscenium stage though it retained its essentially devotional character.

It flourished in Tamil Nadu and its influence extended over a wide area of the South. It is one of the most ancient forms of dance art. During the 18th century the rulers of Tanjore became interested in Bharatha Natyam and patronized Mahadeve Annavi. Bharatha Natyam entered a new phase of vigour and refinement. When the celebrated Thayagaraja was inaugurating a new era in the history of Carnatic music King Swathi Thirunal of Travancore patronizes one of the four Tanjore brothers Vadivelu in his court, given enough encouragement to him to train many disciples. Chinnayya received the help of the Tanjore court to train his disciples there.

During the second half of the 17th and 19th century when the British sway and the western influence over Tamil Nadu were complete, Bharatanatyam passed through its most critical period. It was about to be lost and forgotten. But not allow the art to die. He maintained the art tradition in their pure form and bequeathed them to the future.

In the 20th century when the dances of India were received everywhere Bharathanatyam too came to its former forms and quickly established its reputations as one of the most attractive artistic legacies of the land. It emerged as a dance art of the whole of India with classical traditions surcharged with religious emotions and philosophical significance. It became popular everywhere and came to be practiced at many places.

Check your progress-4

1. Write a short note on Bharathanatyam.

16.6.2. Kuchipudi

Among the old forms of the South Indian dance Kuchipudi has attracted wide attention. Kuchelapuram came to be known as Kuchipudi and the specialized of that place possessed that name. The Kuchipudi singers who accompany the dancers know Sanskrit and Telugu. The music of the dance is Carnatic. In its modern development, the Kuchipudi dance drama has been changing its character with a greater tendency towards solo items. From the temple premises it has come to open air theatres and the modern stage. Sidhendra Yogi, an exceptionally gifted scholar and artiste, who lived in the 16th century gave a definite format and purified this ancient art. Sidhendra abstained from training women fearing that they might exaggerate the sentiments expressed and dispel it of its spiritual tone. Kuchipudi became an all-male domain.

The female roles were also impersonated by men. All the families residing in Kuchipudi were devoted to either in teaching or performing this austere dance style. Dance was their one and only source of living. Kuchipudi remained confined to the narrow limits of an obscure village with little exposure.

The emergence of rule of colonial officials of East India Company during the 18th century and establishment of the British colonial rule in the 19th century saw decline of various classical dance forms which were subjected to contemptuous fun and discouragement including Kuchipudi. Eventually the social stigma associated with nautch girls of north India and Devadasis of South India added with highly critical and despicable attitude from the Christian missionaries and British officials, who held them as harlots, disgraced such systems. Furthermore, the Christian missionaries launched anti-dance movement in 1892 to stop such practice. The Madras Presidency under the British colonial government banned the custom of dancing in Hindu temples in 1910. With this Kuchipudi that was performed conventionally during night time on a stage associated with a Hindu temple also saw its decline.

The Indian community disapproved such ban worrying that the rich and ancient custom of Hindu temple dancing was being persecuted on the pretext of social reform. As the Indian freedom movement progressed steadily during the early 20th century, an effort to revive Indian culture and tradition seethed with excitement among Indians. Many classical art revivalists questioned against such discrimination and joined hands between 1920 and 1950 in reviving the ancient classical dance forms. Among them Vedantam Lakshminarayana Sastri played an instrumental role in reviving and reconstructing Kuchipudi and also inspired women to tread this dance form. His guru Vempati Venkatanarayana Sastri also remained a central figure in preserving Kuchipudi. Chinta Venkataramayya, another stalwart popularised the dance form through public performances. Many Western artists who came to learn Indian classical dance forms became a part of the revival movement. Kuchipudi acquired a wholly new dimension under Padmabushan Dr. Vempati Chinna Satyam is a recognized Guru of Kuchipudi Dance all over the world. He refined Kuchipudi, bringing it completely within the boundaries of Natya Sastra and gave it wholly new perspective. Guru Vempati Chinna Satyam enlarged and enriched the repertoire both in solo items and dance-dramas most of them being composed by Kalaimamani P. Sangeetha Rao. Compositions of eminent poets in all regional languages were set to the dance. Apart from mythological themes, Social themes also formed the main subject of dance-dramas. Kuchipudi, which is known only in and around Andhra Pradesh, spread all

over India and abroad under Guru Vempati's efforts. Gone were the days when men donned even the female roles. Guru Vempat Chinna Satyam 's ballets showed a complete cycle where women not only performed but even adorned male roles.

Indrani Bajpai (Indrani Rahman), daughter of Ragini Devi, and Yamini Krishnamurti expanded this art through public performances outside Andhra that not only garnered new students in the art form but also made it widely popular both at national and international platforms. Other eminent Kuchipudi dancers include internationally famed dancing couple, Raja and Radha Reddy, their daughter Yamini Reddy; Kaushalya Reddy; Bhavana Reddy, daughter of Raja and Kaushalya Reddy; Lakshmi Narayn Shastri; and Swapana Sundari among others.

16.6.3. Kathakali

Kathakali is the classical dance of Kerala. It means the story-play. There was a time when Kathakali passed through a crisis arising out of negligence, lack of patronage and general public indifference. From the middle of the 19th century to the first quarter of the 20th century, the growth of this dangerous phenomenon was distinctly marked. When the decline was almost complete it was the famous Malayalee poet Vallathol Narayana Menon, who struggled on to revive the art at all costs. In 1930 he established an institute named Kerala Kala Mandalam. Kathakali is an art form which can be distinguished by the elaborately colourful make-up, costumes and facemasks that the traditionally male actor-dancers wear. Similar to other Indian classical dance arts, the story in 'Kathakali' is also communicated to audience through excellent footwork and impressive gestures of face and hands complimented with music and vocal performance. It can be distinguished from their style and movements that reflect the age-old martial arts and athletic conventions prevalent in Kerala and surrounding regions. Traditionally performed by male dancers, it developed in courts and theatres of Hindu regions contrary to other Indian classical dances which predominantly developed in Hindu temples and monastic schools. Although not clearly traceable, this classical dance form is considered to have originated from temple and folk arts that trace back to 1st millennium CE or before.

Although 'Kathakali' incorporates and reflects several elements of different Hindu temple art forms, its uniqueness lies in its performance where the actor-dancers concentrate exclusively

on emoting the scene through acting and dancing while the voice artist delivers the lines very much contrary to the ancient forms where vocal part was also delivered by the actor-dancers. Traditionally the themes of 'Kathakali' were based on religious sagas, legends, mythologies, folklores and spiritual concepts taken from the 'Puranas' and the Hindu epics. Apart from such themes, the modern day 'Kathakali' troupes of India have also adapted themes based on legends on Christianity as also Western plays and stories of renowned authors like William Shakespeare. Another development of present day 'Kathakali' is inclusion of women in the troupe which traditionally had been an all-men ensemble. The voice part as per tradition continues to be Sanskritised Malayalam.

Kavungal Chathunni Panicker, a celebrated and veteran performer of this field, is a scion of the famous Kavungal family associated with 'Kathakali' for six generations. Kalamandalam Gopi, a renowned name in 'Kathakali' with a career of over 30 years, is one of the most eminent representatives of the Kalluvazhi School of Kerala. Another famed 'Kathakali' actor Kottakkal Sivaraman, who portrays feminine characters emotes different nayika bhavas such as lasya nayika and vasakasajjika with great élan. Kalamandalam Ramankutty Nair is a seasoned 'Kathakali' performer who not only earned fame for portraying negative characters like Ravana and Duryodhana but also proved his mettle in characterising Lord Hanuman.

16.6.4. Kathak

It's an interesting dance art of India. It had undergone evolutionary development through the ages by keeping its doors wide open to various external influences. Kathak means 'the story teller' through the 19th century the art lingered on in a precarious condition, through some Rajput families tried their best to retain it in its purer shape. During the 1st quarter of the 20th century there were attempts to revive the lost artistic values associated with the original Kathak.

Kathak is one of the main genres of ancient Indian classical dance and is traditionally regarded to have originated from the travelling bards of North India referred as Kathakars or storytellers. These Kathakars wandered around and communicated legendary stories via music, dance and songs quite like the early Greek theatre. The genre developed during the Bhakti movement, the trend of theistic devotion which evolved in medieval Hinduism. The Kathakars communicate stories through rhythmic foot movements, hand gestures, facial expressions

and eye work. This performing art that incorporates legends from ancient mythology and great Indian epics, especially from the life of Lord Krishna became quite popular in the courts of North Indian kingdoms. Three specific forms of this genre that is three gharanas (schools), which mostly differ in emphasis given to footwork versus acting, are more famous namely, the Jaipur gharana, the Benaras gharana and the Lucknow gharana. This ancient classical dance form that was majorly associated with Hindu epics was well acknowledged by the courts and nobles of the Mughal period. The dance performed in Mughal courts however adapted a more erotic form without having much reference to particular themes applied earlier that communicated religious or spiritual concepts. Improvisations were made by the dancers predominantly to entertain the Muslim audience with sensuous and sexual performances which although were different from the age-old dancing concept but contained a subtle message in it like the love of Radha-Krishna. Eventually Central Asian and Persian themes became a part of its repertoire.

Emergence of colonial rule in the 18th century followed by the establishment of the colonial rule in the 19th century saw decline of various classical dance forms which were subjected to contemptuous fun and discouragement including Kathak. Eventually the social stigma associated with nautch girls added with highly critical and despicable attitude from the Christian missionaries and British officials, who held them and the Devadasis of South India as harlots, disgraced such systems. The Anglican missionaries were critical about Hinduism manifested from the proposition of Reverend James Long who suggested that Kathak artists should embrace European legends and tales associated with Christianity and do away with the Indian and Hindu legends. The Christian missionaries launched anti-dance movement in 1892 to stop such practice.

The book 'The Wrongs of Indian Womanhood' by Marcus B. Fuller published in 1900 caricatured the facial expressions and sensuous gestures emoted during Kathak performances in Hindu temples and family functions. The nautch girls were not only disgraced by the newspapers and officials of colonial rule but were also suppressed economically by pressurising their patrons to cease financial support. The Madras Presidency under the British colonial rule banned the custom of dancing in Hindu temples in 1910. The Indian community disapproved such ban apprehending persecution of such rich and ancient Hindu custom on the pretext of social reform. Many classical art revivalists questioned against such discrimination.

In the midst of such upheaval, the families made effort in keeping this ancient dance form from dying out and continued teaching the form including training boys. The progress of the Indian freedom movement in the early 20th century saw an effort among Indians to revive national culture and tradition and rediscover the rich history of India in order to resurrect the very essence of the nation. The revival movement of Kathak developed both in the Hindu and Muslim gharanas simultaneously, especially in the Kathak-Mishra community. Kalkaprasad Maharaj played an instrumental role in drawing international viewership of Kathak in the early 20th century.

Imminent personalities associated with Kathak include among others the founders of the different gharanas or schools of this form of classical dance namely Bhanuji of the Jaipur Gharana; Janaki Prasad of the Benaras Gharana; Ishwari Prasad of the Lucknow Gharana; and Raja Chakradhar Singh of the Raigarh Gharana. Shambhu Maharaj was a renowned guru of the Lucknow Gharana. His brothers Lachhu Maharaj and Acchan Maharaj were also stalwarts in the art of Kathak. One name that has almost become synonymous with modern day Kathak dance is Pandit Birju Maharaj, a scion of the legendary Maharaj family and son of Acchan Maharaj. He is considered the leading advocate of the Lucknow Kalka-Bindadin gharana. Sitara Devi was another star of this dance form described as Nritya Samragini that is the empress of dance by Rabindranath Tagore and she continues to retain her Kathak Queen title even after death. Other eminent Kathak artists include Roshan Kumari, Shovana Narayan, Maya Rao and Kumudini Lakhia to name a few.

16.6.5. Manipuri

The indigenous dance style of the North –Eastern region Manipuri dance, also known as Jagoi is one of the major Indian classical dance forms, named after the region of its origin – Manipur, a state in north eastern India. With the British annexation of Manipur in 1891, the dance art suffered from neglect. The royal patronage which for generation had kept the art in a thriving condition did not exist anymore. The Manipur dance would have died out once and for all had not the temples of the area preserved it for the sake of religious ceremonies.

It was Rabindranath Tagore who in his Santhiniketan initiated the study and performance of Manipuri till the art was restored to its original value.

It is particularly known for its Hindu Vaishnavism themes, and exquisite performances of love-inspired dance drama of Radha-Krishna called Raslila. However, the dance is also

performed to themes related to Shaivism, Shaktism and regional deities such as Umang Lai during Lai Haraoba.

The roots of Manipuri dance, as with all classical Indian dances, is the ancient Hindu Sanskrit text *Natya Shastra*, with influences and the culture fusion between various local folk-dance forms. According to the traditional legend, the indigenous people of the Manipur valley were the dance-experts revered as Gandharvas in the Hindu epics (*Ramayana* and *Mahabharata*), suggesting a dance tradition has existed in Manipur since antiquity. With evidence of Vishnu temples in the medieval era, the dance arts have been passed down verbally from generation to generation as an oral tradition. The first reliably dated written texts describing the art of Manipuri dance are from the early 18th-century.

The Manipuri dance is a team performance, with its own unique costumes, aesthetics, conventions and repertoire. The Manipuri dance drama is, for most part, marked by a performance that is graceful, fluid, sinuous with greater emphasis on hand and upper body gestures. It is accompanied with devotional music created with many instruments, with the beat set by cymbals (*kartal* or *manjira*) and double-headed drum (*pung* or Manipuri *mrdanga*) of *sankirtan*.

Manipuri dance is a religious art and its aim is the expression of spiritual values. Aspects of this performance art is celebrated during Hindu festivals and major rites of passage such as weddings among the Manipuri people, particularly in the ethnic majority of Meitei people. The dance drama choreography shares the plays and stories of 'Vaishnavite Padavalis', that also inspired the major Gaudiya Vaishnava-related performance arts found in Assam and West Bengal.

16.6.6. Odissi

Odissi is the classical dance of Orissa. Orissa was the meeting ground of southern and northern cultures, the Dravidian and the Aryan ways of life from Proto-historic times.

During the British period the culture of the land passed through difficult days. The only place where the culture flickered on precariously was Puri. The dance art remained in its living form though degenerated to a great extent. There was lack of patronage, encouragement and appreciation at that time. That it survived at all through those dark and dangerous days is a matter of surprise.

Odissi also referred to as Orissi in older literature, is a major ancient Indian classical dance that originated in the Hindu temples of Odisha – an eastern coastal state of India. Odissi, in its history, was performed predominantly by women, and expressed religious stories and spiritual ideas, particularly of Vaishnavism (Vishnu as Jagannath). Odissi performances have also expressed ideas of other traditions such as those related to Hindu gods Shiva and Surya, as well as Hindu goddesses (Shaktism).

Modern Odissi is performed by children and adults, in solo or as group. Above is the Tribhanga posture of Odissi.

The theoretical foundations of Odissi trace to the ancient Sanskrit text *Natya Shastra*, its existence in antiquity evidenced by the dance poses in the sculptures of Odissi Hindu temples, and archeological sites related to Hinduism, Buddhism and Jainism. The Odissi dance tradition declined during the Islamic rule era, and was suppressed under the British Rule. The suppression was protested by the Indians, followed by its revival, reconstruction and expansion since India gained independence from the colonial rule.

Odissi is traditionally a dance-drama genre of performance art, where the artist(s) and musicians play out a mythical story, a spiritual message or devotional poem from the Hindu texts, using symbolic costumes, body movement, *abhinaya* (expressions) and *mudras* (gestures and sign language) set out in ancient Sanskrit literature. Odissi is learnt and performed as a composite of basic dance motif called the *Bhargas* (symmetric body bends, stance). It involves lower (footwork), mid (torso) and upper (hand and head) as three sources of perfecting expression and audience engagement with geometric symmetry and rhythmic musical resonance. An Odissi performance repertoire includes invocation, *nritta* (pure dance), *nritya* (expressive dance), *natya* (dance drama) and *moksha* (dance climax connoting freedom of the soul and spiritual release).

According to Alexandra Carter, Odissi presumably developed further in the 17th century under the patronage of King Ramachandradeva. Athletics and *Akhanda* (martial arts) were included and boys or youths were trained in this dance form, which traditionally was performed by women. This development led the boys and youths of Odissi called *Gotipuas* get an opportunity to train since early age and prepare for military to combat foreign invasions. Ragini Devi states that according to historical records, the 14th century Raja of Khurda promoted the *gotipuas* tradition.

The 18th century saw emergence of rule of colonial followed by the establishment of British colonial rule in the 19th century. Such developments saw decline of various classical dance forms which were subjected to contemptuous fun and discouragement including Odissi. Eventually, social and economic conditions associated with Devadasi culture added with contempt and despicable attitude from the Christian missionaries and British officials. Furthermore, the Christian missionaries launched anti-dance movement in 1892 to stop such practice. The Madras Presidency under the British colonial government even banned the custom of dancing in Hindu temples in 1910. The dancers were not only subjected to disgrace but were also suppressed economically by pressurising their patrons to cease financial support. The Indian community disapproved such ban and as the Indian freedom movement progressed steadily during the early 20th century, an effort to revive Indian culture and tradition became strong among Indians. Many classical art revivalists joined hands in reviving the ancient classical dance forms including Odissi. Oriya poet, researcher and dramatist Kavichandra Kalicharan Pattanayak was one such revivalist who not only made effort to revive the dance form but is also accredited for naming it as 'Odissi'.

Traditional Odissi exists in two major styles, the first perfected by women and focused on solemn, spiritual temple dance (maharis); the second perfected by boys dressed as girls (gotipuas which diversified to include athletic and acrobatic moves, and were performed from festive occasions in temples to general folksy entertainment. Modern Odissi productions by Indian artists have presented a diverse range of experimental ideas, culture fusion, themes and plays. The Odissi maestros who revived the art form in the late 1940s include Kelucharan Mohapatra, Raghunath Dutta, Deba Prasad Das, Pankaj Charan Das and Gangadhar Pradhan. The instrumental role played by Guru Mayadhar Raut saw the dance form achieving classical status. Other famous exponents include disciples of Kelucharan Mohapatra namely Sanjukta Panigrahi, Sonal Mansingh and Kumkum Mohanty; Aruna Mohanty, Anita Babu and Aadya Kaktikar to mention a few.

16.6.7. Miscellaneous Dance forms

Chhau Dance famous as masked dance, is of ancient origin. The various other traditional dance styles such as Kuravanchi, Mohiniattam, Ottamthullal, Rasalila Of Brajsattrra, Rasa Lila

of Manipur, and Choloms prevail in different parts of India. But they were not influenced by the western culture. They represent the dance heritage of India. Apart from the classical dances mentioned above there are various folk dance forms from each state of India.

Special mention should be made for folk dance. It is the art in its simplest form, spontaneously performed and naturally enjoyed. They represent the values of the religions, so well aesthetic and even the material traditions of by one time. They continue to be a source of enjoyment both to the performers and the observers and add pageant and beauty to the cultural life of the country.

Check your progress -4

1. Give an account of the development of dance under the British Rule.

16.7. Let us sum up

Though the art, architecture, dance and music were subjected to many influences under the British Rule, the foregoing account tells about their survival in contemporary India.

16.8. Answers to check your progress

Check your progress -1

1. See in 16.3.
2. See in 16.3.1
3. See in 16.3.2
4. See in 16.3.4

Check your progress -2

See in 16.4

Check your progress -3

See in 16.5

Check your progress -4

See in 16.6.1. – 16.6.7.

M.A DEGREE EXAMINATION
HISTORY
MODEL QUESTION PAPER
PAPER – I
CULTURAL HERITAGE OF INDIA
(EXCLUDING TAMIL NADU)

Time: 3 Hours

Maximum: 80 marks

SECTION A

(10 X 2 = 20 Marks)

Answer any TEN questions.

Each answer should not exceed 30 words

1. Bharatavarsha
2. “Priest King” of Harappa
3. Four Vedas
4. Tripitakas
5. Asvaghosha
6. Fahien
7. Karkhana
8. Abul Fazl
9. Bi-bi-ka Maqbara
10. Nandalal Bose
11. Madrasa & Makhtab
12. Punch Marked Coins

SECTION B**(5X 6 = 30 Marks)****Answer any FIVE questions.****Each answer should not exceed 200 words**

13. Briefly mention about the Indus seals
14. Summarize about the position of women during early and later Vedic periods
15. Write short notes on the causes for the rise of Jainism and Buddhism.
16. Briefly review about the Kushana Coins
17. Examine main principles of Sufism
18. Assess the social divisions during Mughal period
19. Give a precise note on Ramakrishna Mission

SECTION C**(3X 10 = 30 Marks)****Answer any THREE questions.****Each answer should not exceed 500 words**

20. India is a land of unity in diversity – Discuss
 21. Describe the significant features of Indus Civilization
 22. Analyze the rise and growth of non-Brahmanical religions of 6th century B.C.
 23. Explain the characteristic features of Gandhara and Mathura Art
 24. Estimate the role played by Asoka and Kanishka in the development of Buddhism
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